

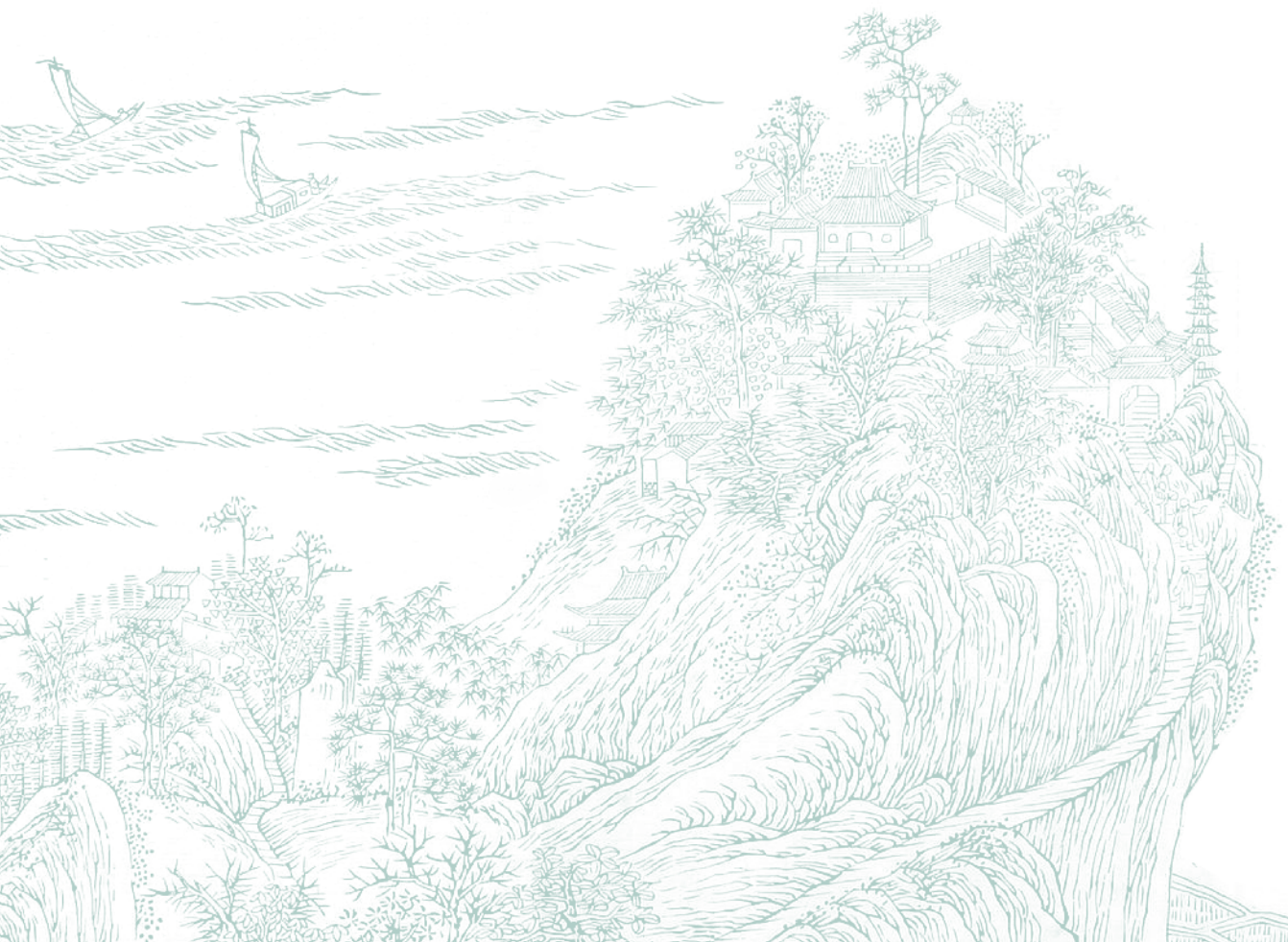
Countless Sands

*Medieval Buddhists and
Their Environments*



Edited by JEFFREY MOSER *and* JASON PROTASS

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Medieval Buddhists and Their Environments

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Contents

<i>Acknowledgments</i>	vii
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Part I Introductions

CHAPTER 1	Medieval Buddhists and Their Environments	3
	<i>Jason Protass and Jeffrey Moser</i>	
CHAPTER 2	Contextualizing the Relationship between Nature and Culture in East Asian Buddhism	14
	<i>James Robson</i>	

Part II Matters of Scale and the Environment

CHAPTER 3	Flesh Mountain: Human Bodies on a Nonhuman Scale	55
	<i>Reiko Ohnuma</i>	
CHAPTER 4	Movements and Patterns in Embodied Landscapes for Art	70
	<i>Eric Huntington</i>	
CHAPTER 5	Geomorphism at “The Peak That Flew in from Afar”	90
	<i>Jeffrey Moser</i>	
CHAPTER 6	The Japanese Image of the Buddhist Earth: Geography, Cosmology, and the Culture of Vision	113
	<i>D. Max Moerman</i>	

Part III Environments in the Shaping of Medieval Buddhism

CHAPTER 7	Human Places and Cosmic Spaces: Ecological Engagements at Ellora	133
	<i>Tamara Sears</i>	

CHAPTER 8	Riverine Buddhism at Changlu Monastery <i>Jason Protass</i>	163
CHAPTER 9	Masculine Mountains: Gendered Affordances at Dali's Stone Treasure Grottoes <i>Megan Bryson</i>	195
CHAPTER 10	The Geoaesthetics of Ritual in the Chinese Buddhist Sanctuary of Shizhuanshan <i>Phillip E. Bloom</i>	219
Part IV	Environments as Mediums of Practice	
CHAPTER 11	"Occasions Both Worldly and Transcendent": Sacred Trees in Buddha's India <i>Maria Heim</i>	245
CHAPTER 12	<i>Vidyārājas</i> and the Articulation of Ecological Interdependence at Cave Temples <i>Sonya S. Lee</i>	260
CHAPTER 13	Mountains, Waters, and Dharmakāya: Kūkai's Irrigation Projects <i>Ryūichi Abé</i>	281
	<i>Glossary</i>	307
	<i>Contributors</i>	311
	<i>Index</i>	313

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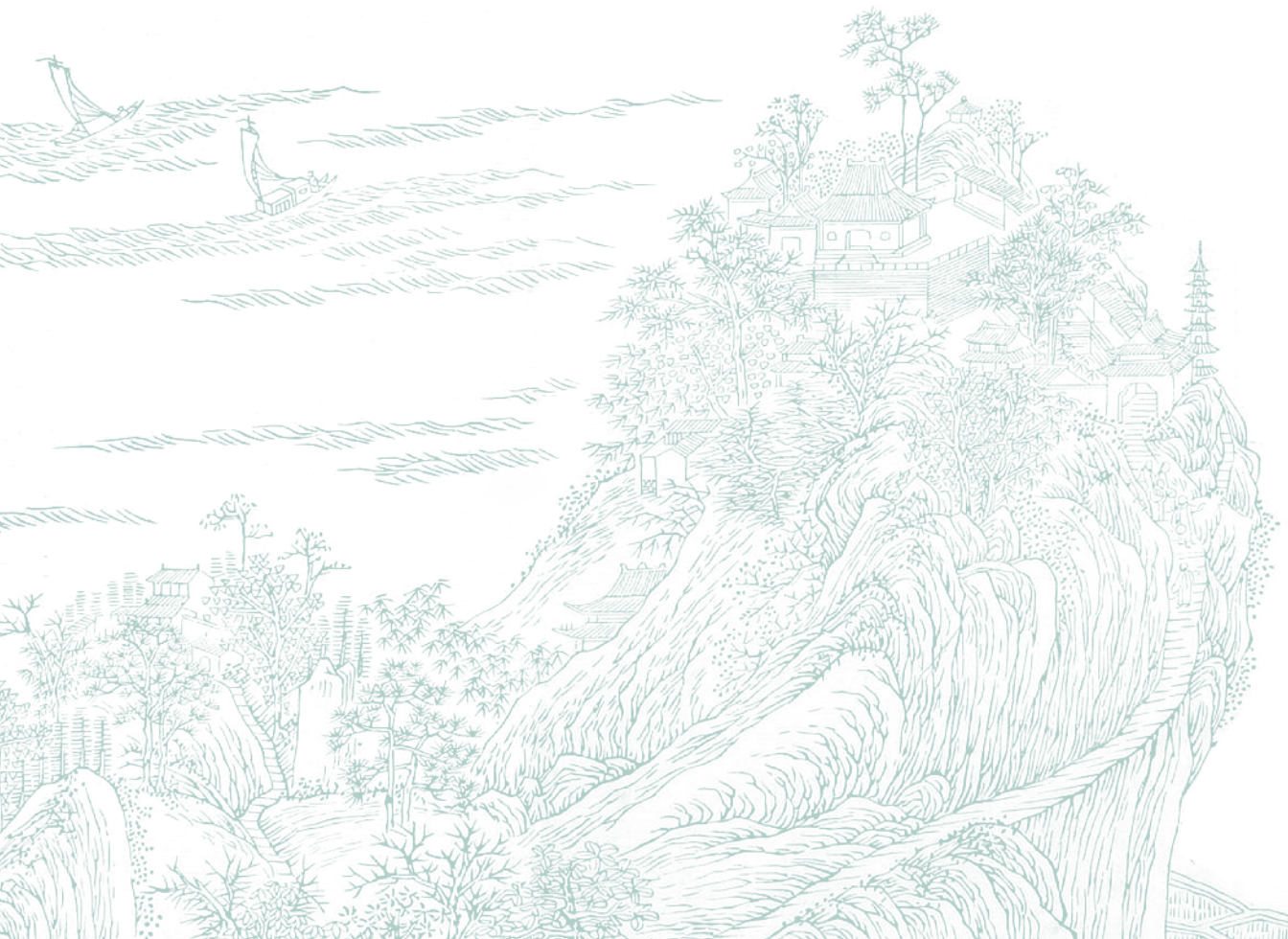
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JM & JP
Providence, RI
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PART I

Introductions





CHAPTER 1

Medieval Buddhists and Their Environments

Jason Protass and Jeffrey Moser

The Buddhists of medieval Asia inhabited many worlds, some dusty and some rarefied. They dwelled in a cosmos made up of countless Buddha-worlds and enumerated time in epochs marked by the destruction and recreation of the universe. Across lifetimes, they inhabited multiple planes of existence in which they were born as gods, animals, and hungry ghosts. They lived with all other humans on the great world-continent of Jambudvīpa, the southernmost of the vast islands encircling the cosmic axis of Mount Meru.

They also lived on a continent that is now called Asia, along the Ganges, Mekong, and Yangtze Rivers, in the fertile valleys of the Korean peninsula and the Japanese archipelago, on the high plateaus of Tibet, and around the coasts of the Indian Ocean and South China Sea. The scale of this vast continent, and the perilous mountains and deserts that crisscrossed it, meant that only a small number of Buddhists could ever make the pilgrimage to the parks and mountains in northern India where, they understood, the historical Buddha Śākyamuni had preached the dharma. Those who never made the journey nonetheless witnessed the presence of the Buddha in the hills and rocks around them. For them, this was at times more conceptual, and at times more concrete. Buddhists recreated in their temples and gardens the places where the Buddha taught. They retraced the steps of famous pilgrims in maps and paintings. They discovered that sacred Indian mountains had transported themselves, miraculously, into the hills around their own local settlements. These more intimate worlds were the local spaces in which Buddhists developed their affective connections to wider worlds beyond the range of their immediate sensory experience.

These worlds were not exclusively Buddhist. The large-scale, cosmic worlds were shared with the Hindu and Jain communities of South and Southeast Asia. Others were cohabited by the Daoist and other religious communities of East Asia. The most immediate worlds of mountains, lakes, and forests were shared by all human and nonhuman beings who inhabited the continent.¹ At the same time, all these worlds were shared, in one sense or another, with the innumerable ecological processes that collectively constitute what we moderns call “the environment.” These processes were the substance of Asia itself—its terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems, the geomorphology of its mountains and plains, and the hydrological and atmospheric forces that determined its weather. In some cases, they shaped (and were in turn transformed by) the ritual, devotional, and artistic practices that organized the lives of Buddhists on Jambudvīpa. Trees supplied shade for meditators and timber for temples. Mountains afforded rock-cut sculpture and endangered travelers. Rivers sustained monasteries (with provisions and pilgrims) and inundated them in floods.

This volume was born from an interest in the relationships between these worlds. In particular, we are interested in the relationship between the karmic, cosmological, and social systems by which these worlds were Buddhist, and the ecological, geological, and atmospheric systems by which they were environmental. This interest in the intersections between Buddhists and their environments was encouraged by the wider ecocritical and environmental turn of the humanities over the past two decades. Recent years have witnessed a surge in publications on themes of the environment, climate change, and the Anthropocene.² Many of these publications have advanced powerful ethical and political arguments to account for the human failure to respond effectively to global climate change, and have encouraged examinations of non-Western histories and alternative ways of being in the world. This book illustrates the complexity of those calls. While the chapters in our book emerged from our shared awareness of these challenges and critiques, none of them presents an explicitly political argument. Nor are we seeking to identify and prescribe alternative ways of being in the world as correctives to the ecological problems of the present. Instead, our volume constitutes a more subtle and fundamental effort to historicize the environment as a site and subject of local Buddhist practices.

We think this less overtly political and more rigorously historical effort can help those attentive to contemporary environmental problems avoid the ahistorical, Orientalizing tropes and binaries that have long informed the invocation of Buddhism in Euro-American environmental discourses. As James Robson’s detailed introductory essay in this volume demonstrates, these tropes have a deep history stretching back to the nineteenth-century Romantics and transcendentalists who laid the conceptual foundations for the modern environmentalist movement. Many of the most influential voices in that tradition

subjected Buddhism to a totalizing Orientalist gaze in their search for alternatives to Western modernity. Others, as Robson shows, adopted more nuanced perspectives, taking inspiration in certain aspects of Buddhism while simultaneously recognizing that Buddhist thought encouraged practices that had destructive impacts on the nonhuman world. Our goal is to deepen such nuance and move beyond binary questions of whether Buddhism is or is not “good” for the environment.

We have taken as a starting point for this volume the assumption that there was no singular consistently “Buddhist” understanding of the natural world. When we look closely at the evidence our authors have gathered, we see varied ecological entanglements preserved in discrete texts, images, and artifacts. We believe our starting assumption can also be extended to encompass numerous other examples, and that a diversity of ecological attitudes was manifest within Buddhism. Individual Buddhists and communities of Buddhists had varied, richly imaginative ways of thinking in environmental terms; learned to live within the possibilities (and dangers) that their environments provided; and generally understood the construction of Buddhist infrastructure as a manifestation of the dharma. Nuance, therefore, occurred as Buddhists lived their tradition at the local level—and does not refer only to our recognizing that there was a multiplicity of Buddhisms in lieu of one monolithic Buddhist tradition. Buddhists were the recipients and creators of Buddhist ideas, texts, and objects. Buddhists put their tradition into practice as they negotiated their immediate contexts, their everyday material and environmental conditions, as well as their visions of planetary- and cosmic- scaled worlds. Seeking to recover such complexity as it existed in medieval Buddhism, each of the authors in this volume focuses on a case study, a set of relationships between particular Buddhists and their environments.

Recognizing that the sources for these understandings are fragmentary and complex, we concluded that the project was best suited to a collaboration between scholars with expertise in both textual and art historical evidence. We also brought together scholars with different kinds of questions and methodologies, including those advancing interpretations supported by extensive documentary evidence, as well as those whose materials and questions called for more abstract and speculative arguments. Because the sources that we wish to consult are diverse, scholarly perspectives must be as well. The result is an explicitly pluralistic inquiry into the multiple relations between *Buddhists* and *their environments* rather than the totalizing relationship between *Buddhism* and *the environment*.

This attention to plurality also explains our decision to frame our discussion in terms of “environments” rather than “ecology.” As editors, we recognize that this may seem like a strange choice to readers attuned to recent developments in ecocritical theory. The myriad theoretical positions and critical voices that

scholars today associate with the label “environmental humanities” address a wide variety of conceptual issues; however, they are largely united in their critique of the traditional anthropocentrism of the humanities.³ The essence of this critique is that classical humanism is premised on a fundamental distinction between Man and Nature that is essentially exploitative. Even when—as in the case of such figures as Emerson, Audubon, and Muir—the Nature writer aimed to exalt and celebrate the nonhuman world, ecocriticism has shown us that a vision of nature as separate from human society necessarily subordinates that world to the gaze of the human subject. The term “environment” is frequently cited in such critiques as signifying one of the foundations of anthropocentrism: the notion that entities (e.g., humans) are ontologically separable from their surroundings (e.g., environments). Contemporary ecocriticism prefers “ecological” frameworks, in which humans are understood to be ontologically entangled with the nonhuman.⁴ To generalize, both the Cartesian mind-body distinction and an Enlightenment distinction between nature and culture are supplanted by *sympoiesis*—which emphasizes that the “all that is human” (our bodies, thoughts, and works) and the nonhuman are inseparable and mutually generative.⁵ However, in light of the particular history of Euro-American writing about Buddhism, we have decided here to follow a different tack.

We, too, are interested in how Buddhist worlds were mutually constructed by human and nonhuman forces. But our interest is not limited to the resonances between the contemporary theoretical developments of ecological *sympoiesis* and certain modes of Buddhist philosophy, especially Huayan theories of mutual interpenetration. Despite interesting similarities, such Buddhist notions existed part and parcel with other Buddhist notions and practices that made explicitly anthropocentric distinctions between human and nonhuman beings and between sentient and insentient entities. Buddhism, as a lived religion, is not adequately understood by a selective reading of philosophical texts. Such an approach often, intentionally or not, reproduces the Orientalizing gazes elucidated in Robson’s chapter. If we are to account for the anthropocentrism that also existed in the thinking of Buddhists in medieval Asia, we must not make our subject sound more ecological than it was. Here we are particularly attuned to the cautions of Ian Harris, Johan Elverskog, and other skeptics of “eco-Buddhism.”⁶ To our minds, sticking with the older, more troubled term “environment” is a better way to capture the historical spectrum of Buddhist voices: those that are more anthropocentric, those that are more ecological, and those that would not recognize such a distinction in the first place.

Additionally, the authors in this volume do not aim to speak on behalf of practitioner communities nor in the voice of the tradition itself.⁷ Our concerns are more foundational: What evidentiary resources are available for understanding the environment in premodern Buddhism? In what ways

can the environment be discerned in different kinds of texts, artworks, and locales? What analytical approaches are needed to call it forth, and how might these approaches be calibrated to the limits of our sources? By exploring these questions across a range of studies drawn from the traditions of Chinese, Indian, Tibetan, and Japanese Buddhism, we aim to make the archive of medieval Asia more accessible to all who endeavor to find contemporary environmental significance in the traces of the past. We also hope that our editorial approach, one that we think accommodates a range of methods, is generative for further scholarship on this subject. Given the scale of the topic of Buddhists and their environments, the limited number of chapters we selected for inclusion here can merely delineate major contours in the intellectual terrain, and cannot exhaust the important topics that deserve study.

Temporally speaking, the chapters in these pages focus on the period between the fifth and sixteenth centuries CE, which we construe broadly as “medieval” for convenience’s sake. The term “medieval” possesses different connotations in the historiographies of different areas of Asia, and there are porous boundaries in any such designations. Nonetheless, our main chapters are focused on a Buddhist Asia that is neither ancient nor modern—belonging literally to a middle era—and we wish to draw attention to the fact that due to the nature of our sources, our work necessarily differs from that of scholars who work on the early modern and modern periods. Our broad periodization is the result of reflecting on the nature of historical sources across diverse Asian cultures. We focus on these centuries for two primary reasons: The first is that the middle of the first millennium CE marks the point at which it is possible to describe Buddhism as a pan-Asian phenomenon, reaching from Sri Lanka to Japan. The second is that the sixteenth century marks a shift in the historiography of Asian environments as well as an implicit boundary in the current literature of the environmental humanities.⁸ Scholars of Asia are well aware of the long *durée* of environmental change across the region; however, they must grapple with the qualitative change in the nature of the sources available for exploring this history that occurs around the sixteenth century. One witnesses this shift in works such as Mark Elvin’s magisterial *The Retreat of the Elephants: An Environmental History of China*, which alternates between a speculative, deep history of environmental awareness recorded in preimperial and early medieval poetry, and a more explicitly evidenced but shorter history of the environmental exploitation preserved especially in Qing-era (1644–1911) gazetteers, court archives, and other sources.⁹ This vacillation within Elvin’s work demonstrates that moving back in time requires thinking in different ways about the sources that evince the environment in quieter, more implicit terms. A methodological goal for our volume is to explore how we can attune our ears to that earlier, softer patter.

Formation and Structure of the Volume

Countless Sands: Medieval Buddhists and Their Environments began as a conference at Brown University titled “Buddhist Geoaesthetics.” Participants were invited to reflect on Buddhist histories of environmental, ecological, and planetary thinking. As the organizers, we presented participants with such questions as: How did medieval Buddhists understand the temporal and spatial scale of the earth? How were their understandings implicated in what they said and did with rocks, rivers, and plants? How might we endeavor to reconstruct those understandings? What sources are available, and what questions should we ask of them? To what extent can we meaningfully conclude that the relevant understandings were “Buddhist”? In order to connect participants with existing work in our academic discipline, we invoked recent scholarship on Buddhist cave shrines and sacred mountains that reckoned with climatological and geological actants in the formation of ritual environments. Our invitation to participants was to think about the dynamic interplay between Buddhist understandings of the earth and its forces, and the actual impact of these forces on the history of Buddhism.

For our symposium, we used the term “geoaesthetics” as an evocative prompt for thinking about the connections between these questions. Our principal inspiration was the recent deployment of the term by Sugata Ray in *Climate Change and the Art of Devotion: Geoaesthetics in the Land of Krishna, 1550–1850*. Ray adopted the word from Gary Shapiro, who first used it to highlight the “zones of indeterminacy” between the earth and the artwork that characterized the land art and environmental art of the 1970s.¹⁰ For Ray, the term operates as a means to call forth the role that planetary changes, specifically climate change, played in encouraging new forms of artistic practice in South Asia during the Little Ice Age (ca. 1550–1850). We used “geoaesthetics” in a closely related yet broader sense to highlight the ways in which the vast presence of the earth, as an assemblage of ontological forces and epistemological subjects, registered in specific, local practices. For us, the “aesthetics” of the term was intended not to convey a focus on classical eighteenth-century questions of beauty and artistic judgment, but to draw our participants’ attention to the values and judgments implicated in all anthropogenic things—be they texts, gardens, or works of sculpture. Overall, we found “geoaesthetics” a useful heuristic exactly because it was a novel term, an underdetermined concept that most of our contributors had not yet thought through. To our minds, this was an ideal provocation, as it created a suggestive but unbounded space that each author could define in the terms of their respective sources.

As the conversation between authors developed during and after the conference, it became clear the while geoaesthetics had served as a productive

prompt for conversation between scholars with diverse interests and expertise, it did not do the work of binding these studies together into a shared theoretical project. Some authors, such as Eric Huntington, found the term very productive but gave it a valence rather different from those we initially imagined. Others used it primarily as a bridge to other concepts, as with James Gibson's "affordances" or Timothy Morton's "hyperobject."¹¹ Still others found it usefully evocative but unnecessary. Despite the absence of agreement about what geoaesthetics signifies, the conversation between authors resulted in a shared focus on developing new histories of Buddhists and their environments based on the close reading of a local case study. These case studies coalesced around themes that correspond to broader topics in the environmental humanities.

The resulting book begins with an introductory chapter by James Robson, which provides the theoretical critiques and intellectual justifications that necessitate our approaches to the topic of Buddhism and the environment. Robson traces the history of the invocation of Buddhism in late twentieth and early twenty-first century Euro-American environmental discourses and offers a thorough introduction to the historical emergence of the East-West, modern-premodern binaries that this book is endeavoring to undo. The subsequent chapters are composed of case studies organized around one of three common themes. Each of these three sections proceeds roughly chronologically as well as geographically, from west to east, beginning in South Asia and ending in China or Japan. While a substantial portion of the volume is made up of examples from medieval China, each section also includes studies of Indo-Tibetan and Japanese materials. Still, the contributions gathered here also have geographic limitations, and Buddhist worlds from Korea and Southeast Asia are not represented. Although the scale of the topic meant that we could not aim for both in-depth studies and geographical comprehensiveness, it is our conviction that broadly pan-Asian coverage remains a critical component for understanding the history of particular Buddhists in their local contexts. Each section thus brings together thematically related materials or methods that scholars working across areas and subfields of Buddhist studies and Asian art history are using in their effort to articulate "the environment" as a historical subject.

The chapters in part II, "Matters of Scale and the Environment," were inspired by recent theoretical attention to the role that scale plays in the human conceptualization of exceptionally large things such as global climate.¹² Each author considers the way in which Buddhists grappled with the scale of the immeasurable qualities of the dharma as well as with the broad geography of the known Buddhist world. Reiko Ohnuma focuses on all-too-human corporeal metaphors to convey the great enormity of a bodhisattva's compassion in the *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka Sūtra*, a Mahāyāna text that exists in

Sanskrit, Tibetan, and Chinese. Jeffrey Moser examines how Chinese sculptors took advantage of the peculiar geology of “the peak that flew in from afar” in Hangzhou to transcend the physical distance between China and India. Eric Huntington’s and Max Moerman’s respective chapters analyze the layered corporeal, geographic, and sacred topologies interwoven in Tibetan landscapes, and the scales of planetary and local knowledge encoded in representations of Xuanzang’s famous continent-spanning pilgrimage from China to India and back.

Part III, “Environments in the Shaping of Medieval Buddhism,” focuses on how local environments encouraged specific adaptations and interpretations of wider (or “translocal”) religious practices and iconography. These chapters respond to the broader scholarly interest in revisiting human responses to environmental determinants and the nonhuman “agency” of environments.¹³ Tamara Sears analyzes the relationship between seasonal monsoons and the iconography at the rock-cut site of Ellora. Her chapter does the important service of placing Buddhism in dialogue with the other Indian religions present at the site. Jason Protass examines the lower Yangtze River as a historical force in the shaping of Buddhist practice through the complex history of destruction and reconstruction at Changlu Chan Monastery. Megan Bryson and Phillip Bloom each examine a different medieval rock-cut shrine in China, one in Yunnan and one in Sichuan. Interestingly, the evidence from each site leads them to distinct conclusions regarding the “agency” of the environment. Taken together, these chapters demonstrate how it is fallacious to speak of a singular “Buddhist view” in response to questions about the environment.

Part IV, “Environments as Mediums of Practice,” focuses on how Buddhists conceptualized their uses of their environments as expressions of the dharma. Maria Heim considers the arboreal imagination and the presence of charismatic heritage trees in fifth-century Theravada commentaries by Buddhaghosa. Sonya S. Lee examines how medieval Chinese sculptors at the Baodingshan complex used their local environment to create a “therapeutic devotional ground” that is strikingly analogous to those envisioned by modern practitioners of “ecohealth.” Ryūichi Abé concludes our book with a trenchant reexamination of Kukai’s famous reservoir engineering projects that created the enormous man-made Mannōike and Masudagaike lakes that still exist today. Whereas other scholars have argued that these were primarily “public works” with limited Buddhist significance, Abé demonstrates that these dam projects, including their environmental impacts, were understood as explicitly “Buddhist works” in their own historical context. Each of these chapters shows the intellectual importance of analyzing what we might call instances of the Buddhist environmental *imaginaire* within their specific and immediate contexts.

NOTES

1. Important studies of the Buddhist imagination of these worlds, and the nonhuman beings they contained, include Levine, “Tree-Buddhas”; Ohnuma, *Unfortunate Destiny*; Rambelli, “Cultural Imagination of Trees and the Environment,” in *Buddhist Materiality*, 129–171; Rambelli, *Vegetal Buddhas*; Ohnuma and Ambros, “Buddhist Beasts”; and Sørensen, “Didactic Use.”
2. This literature is too vast to even begin to summarize. Some of the work that has most influenced our thinking includes Chakrabarty, “Climate and Capital”; Ghosh, *Great Derangement*; Latour, *Facing Gaia*; and Morton, *Hyperobjects*.
3. The sixty-plus volumes that currently make up the Posthumanities series from the University of Minnesota Press demonstrate the range of arguments that scholars are building on the critique of anthropocentrism, including work that explicitly engages contemporary discourses of environmental concern and work that addresses cybernetics, monstrosity, and other less explicitly “environmental” topics.
4. Morton, *Ecology*.
5. “If humans are clearly part of evolution ‘then it follows that all of our vaunted cultural constructions are, in a sense, natural constructions.’” Patrizio, *Ecological Eye*, 10, citing Garrard, *Ecocriticism*, 11. Originally proposed by M. Beth Dempster, “sympoiesis” has been most influentially deployed by Donna Haraway. For an introduction to the origins and significance of the term, see Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble*, 58–98.
6. Harris, “Buddhism and the Discourse”; Harris, “Buddhist Environmental Ethics”; Elverskog, *Buddha’s Footprint*.
7. We would distinguish ourselves, in this sense, from a book such as David Loy’s *Ecodharma: Buddhist Teachings for the Ecological Crisis*.
8. Ray, *Climate Change*, 18.
9. Elvin, *Retreat*.
10. Ray, *Climate Change*, 20–22.
11. Gibson, “Theory”; Morton, *Hyperobjects*.
12. Issues of scale are central to Dipesh Chakrabarty’s effort to disaggregate climate and capital, Amitav Ghosh’s articulation of the limits of the novel, Ursula Heise’s effort to “sense” the planet, Bruno Latour’s approach to “facing Gaia,” Timothy Morton’s theory of the hyper-object, and David Wood’s eco-phenomenology, to name just a few influential examples. Derek Woods has even gone so far as to give this tendency a name: *scale critique*. See Chakrabarty, “Climate and Capital”; Ghosh, *Great Derangement*, 3–84; Heise, *Sense of Place*; Latour, *Facing Gaia*, especially 111–145; Morton, *Hyperobjects*; Wood, “What Is Eco-Phenomenology?”; and Woods, “Scale Critique.” Clark (“Scale”) usefully extends Woods’s term.
13. Recent books focused on Asia that shaped our thinking include Amrith, *Unruly Waters*; Courtney, *The Nature of Disaster in China*; L. Zhang, *The River, The Plain*; J. Zhang, *Coping with Calamity*; and Edgerton-Tarpley, *Tears from Iron*.

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CHAPTER 2

Contextualizing the Relationship between Nature and Culture in East Asian Buddhism

James Robson

Asia in the Anthropocene

In 2008, Dipesh Chakrabarty wrote that the “current planetary crisis of climate change or global warming elicits a variety of responses in individuals, groups, and governments, ranging from denial, disconnect, and indifference to a spirit of engagement and activism of varying kinds and degrees.”¹ Those responses generated, among other things, deep thinking about climate change and the ecological impact of humans on the environment. In order to capture the magnitude of the impact of humans on the environment, Paul J. Crutzen and Eugene F. Stoermer had earlier proposed that we are living in a new epoch that they named the “Anthropocene.”² They suggested that the Anthropocene began with the large-scale globalization of industrialization that can be dated to the late eighteenth century. There is little doubt that industrialization had a major impact on the scale and speed of the transformation of the environment, but other scientists, such as William Ruddiman, proposed that “important anthropogenic effects on the environment and on global climate began thousands of years ago and grew to substantial size long before the industrial era.”³ Ruddiman’s early anthropogenic hypothesis should have poured cold water on overly romanticized views that claimed in the premodern period

humans lived harmoniously with the natural world and that the destruction of the environment was an exclusively modern phenomenon. We can accept the reality that the human impact on the natural world accelerated rapidly with the onset of industrialization, but that does not allow one to conclude that our predecessors lived lighter on the land. I do not intend to wade into the scientific debates about when the anthropogenic effects on the environment began or the related issue of periodization, except to say that Mike Davis seems to have been right on the mark with his comment that “in geology, as in biology or history, periodization is a complex, controversial art” and that there is still a place for the consideration of the past in relation to environmental history.⁴ Therefore, the first part of this chapter seeks to track the place of premodern East Asian religious traditions within the discourse on environmental history, which became particularly prominent in the 1960s.

The term “Anthropocene” has gained widespread acceptance—and generated debate—among scientists, social scientists, and humanists; but those who claimed a deeper history to anthropogenic effects on the environment had long preceded Ruddiman and have continued into the present day. It is not possible to review that full history here, but the interested reader can refer to J. R. McNeill’s comprehensive, if somewhat dated, “Observations on the Nature and Culture of Environmental History.”⁵ In that survey of the field, McNeill introduces and assesses research done in different domains within environmental history, which he divides into three categories: material, cultural/intellectual, and political. The category that primarily concerns us in this chapter is the second: cultural/intellectual environmental history. McNeill notes that the “largest-scale debate within this wing of environmental history has concerned the relative environmental impact, and perhaps by implication relative wickedness, of various religio-cultural traditions.”⁶ McNeill is, of course, gesturing back to a seminal chapter by Lynn White Jr., “The Historic Roots of Our Ecological Crisis,” in which White laid the blame for the growing environmental crisis at the feet of the Western Judeo-Christian ethos.⁷ In that chapter, White famously claimed that “what people do about their ecology depends on what they think about themselves in relation to things around them. Human ecology is deeply conditioned by beliefs about our nature and destiny—that is, by religion.”⁸ In his view, the Judeo-Christian tradition supplanted the animistic paganism of antiquity and “made it possible to exploit nature in a mood of indifference to the feelings of natural objects.”⁹ This form of Western exploitation of nature (grounded in Christian anthropocentrism) was opposed to Asian religions (especially Zen Buddhism), which are presented as the “mirror image of the Christian view” due to their more harmonious relationship with the natural world. This polarization of East and West is far too stark of an opposition, since, as we will see below, premodern Asia was not immune to environmentally rapacious practices, and the Western tradition itself contains views that

could be considered as propounding a view of the relationship between humans and nature that White himself found to have potential (such as Saint Francis). After introducing the East-versus-West distinction, however, White concluded that Asian traditions, such as Zen, were not viable alternatives for the cultures of the West. White's ideas would not stand for long, despite being joined with fears about the undermining of Western science-based civilization by mystical Eastern influences and other quasiracist sentiments.¹⁰ This was, after all, a period that was not only the dawning of the "Age of Aquarius," inspired by the transcultural appeal of East Asian religious philosophies, German idealism, and American transcendentalism, but also the dawning of an age of environmental awareness.

Amitav Ghosh may have been generally correct when he noted how the "discourse around the Anthropocene, and climate matters generally, remains largely Eurocentric"; but Asian religious traditions had long been an appealing place to look for alternatives to Western approaches to the environmental crisis.¹¹ In the same year that White's article appeared, for instance, Roderick Nash published his formative *Wilderness and the American Mind*, which is a good example of the ways Asian religions were being looked to as an antidote to the rapacious West in the 1960s. "In the Far East," he writes, "the man-nature relationship was marked by respect, bordering on love, absent in the West. India's early religions, especially Jainism, Buddhism and Hinduism, emphasized compassion for all living things. Man was understood to be a part of nature. . . . In linking God and the wilderness, instead of contrasting them as did the Western faiths, Shinto and Taoism fostered love of wilderness rather than hatred. . . . Freed from the combined weight of Classicism, Judaism, and Christianity, Eastern cultures did not fear and abhor wilderness."¹² Arnold Toynbee, writing a few years later than White and Nash, echoed many of the claims made in "The Historic Roots of Our Ecological Crisis," but, like Nash, he was explicit in drawing on the opposition between Eastern and Western religions.¹³ Toynbee forcefully asserted that the causes of the current ecological crisis could be traced back to the monotheistic religions of the West, while the hope for the future lay with the respect for nature found in Buddhism, Confucianism, Daoism, and Shinto as well as in pre-Christian Greek cults.

In his survey, McNeill demonstrated that Asia, China in particular, has played an important role in environmental history and—despite White's protestations—interest in Asian religious traditions (often conflated into the problematic category "Eastern wisdom") and their approaches to the natural world came to have a significant impact.¹⁴ Indeed, the two streams of science and the budding interest in Asian religiocultural traditions eventually came together and threatened to flood the discourse on environmental history with vague Romanticist notions of an Asian love of nature and other Orientalist fantasies.¹⁵ Western writers, artists, and those interested Asian

religions often looked to Asian painting, poetry, and indigenous religions as a resource to counteract Western modes of thinking that they denounced as being based in materialism, capitalism, anthropocentrism, and a related sense of human dominion over the natural world that were all seen to be leading to an impending environmental crisis. Those vague ideas developed through the 1970s, 1980s, and 1990s and joined with a variety of other nascent movements connected with a movement that came to be called “deep ecology” and with other environmental philosophies that sought to draw on the perceived resources found in Asian religious traditions, including Buddhism and Daoism, to help address growing concerns about environmental destruction in the modern period.

White’s brief invocation of Zen Buddhism’s radically different way of conceiving the “man-nature relationship” was—as he says himself—filtered through the lens of “beatniks and hippies” (who remain unnamed). The early “beatniks and hippies,” and their predecessors, had been introduced to Zen at first through the writings of Anesaki Masaharu (1873–1949) and, to a much greater extent, D. T. Suzuki (1870–1966). In 1933, Anesaki published his *Art, Life, and Nature in Japan*, which was based on lectures presented at the Fogg Museum of Art at Harvard University, in which he famously claimed that “the Japanese lives too close to nature for him to antagonize her, the benign mother of mankind.”¹⁶ In 1959, D. T. Suzuki published his widely influential *Zen and Japanese Culture* (based on essays originally published in 1938 as *Zen Buddhism and Its Influence on Japanese Culture*) that included a chapter titled “Love of Nature” that is related to his earlier “The Role of Nature in Zen Buddhism,” which was presented as a talk in 1953 to the Eranos Conference organized by Carl Jung in Ascona, Switzerland.¹⁷ In those works, Suzuki presented a clear distinction between East and West, describing the West as based on a fundamental alienation from nature, leading to environmental destruction, and the East as based on a harmonious relationship that situates man within nature, a perspective inspired from his reading of the writing of Romantics and transcendentalists.

In 1974, Watanabe Masao published “The Conception of Nature in Japanese Culture” in *Science*, which explicitly extended White’s invocation of Zen in his earlier essay that appeared in the same journal.¹⁸ Watanabe begins with the bald claim that “nature for the Japanese has not traditionally been an object of man’s investigation or of exploitation, as it has been for Westerners. For the Japanese and for other Oriental peoples, man was considered part of nature, and the art of living in harmony with nature was their wisdom.”¹⁹ In their writings, Anesaki, Suzuki, and Watanabe all speak the same language of *nihonjinron* (the theory of Japanese uniqueness), which, among other things, asserts that the “Japanese are racially and/or culturally inclined to experience the world more directly than are the peoples of other nations,” except perhaps a few other “Oriental peoples.”²⁰

Deep Ecology, Asian Religions, and Their Critics

Some environmental historians, as noted above, tried to avoid polluting Western science with the ideas found in mystical Asian traditions, but others saw the possibilities and potential value of extending the essentialized versions of an Asian worldview into the West. During the 1970s, references to Asian religious traditions began to inundate writings associated with deep ecology. It may be true that Arne Naess—who is usually credited as being the founder of deep ecology, though many also recognize the inspiration drawn from Aldo Leopold’s *A Sand County Almanac* (1948)—made no explicit reference to Buddhism or Asia in his earliest publications, but he certainly knew about those traditions since he mentioned them in a later essay and also integrated Buddhist ideas about dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) into his work on Spinoza.²¹ Naess initially drew a distinction between “shallow ecology” and “deep ecology.” The former, he says, has been significant due to the way it addressed pollution and resource depletion, but he thought it retained an anthropocentric standpoint that separated humans from nature. “Deep ecology,” by contrast, was to be a trenchant critique of modern industrialism that sought to reorient human consciousness, bringing about an internal transformation by returning humans to nature in order to recognize nature’s intrinsic value. Deep ecology seeks to bring about that transformation by drawing on new religious and philosophical perspectives retrieved from primal peoples who, its proponents claim, lived in a state of innocence and harmony with nature. Deep ecology, according to another early advocate of the movement, Michael Tobias, concerns “personal moods, values, [and] aesthetic and philosophical convictions which serve no necessarily utilitarian, nor rational end. By definition their sole justification rests upon the goodness, balance, truth and beauty of the natural world, and of a human being’s biological and psychological need to be fully integrated into it.”²² Enter Asian religions, which took on a particularly important role within deep ecology.

If the connections between Asian religions and deep ecology were not made explicit by Naess, they did become clear in Tobias’ *Deep Ecology* (1984), in Bill Devall and George Sessions’s popular *Deep Ecology: Living as if Nature Mattered* (1985), and in J. Baird Callicott’s widely read *Earth’s Insights: A Multicultural Survey of Ecological Ethics from the Mediterranean Basin to the Australian Outback* (1997).²³ In the preface to their *Deep Ecology* volume, Devall and Sessions wrote that “we may not need something new, but need to reawaken something very old.”²⁴ The chapter “Some Sources of the Deep Ecology Perspective” includes a section titled “Eastern Spiritual Process Traditions,” located between discussions of Martin Heidegger and Robinson Jeffers, that discusses the “old” ideas in Daoism (the *Daode jing*) and Buddhism (Dōgen, as read through the lens of poets such as Gary Snyder and Allen Ginsberg), with other references to Asian religious texts being excerpted throughout the volume.²⁵ In the years

following those early collections, the connections between Asian religions and deep ecology became even more pronounced. The literature is vast, but a few representative works include *Deep Ecology and World Religions: New Essays on Sacred Ground* (2001), *A Manual for Buddhism and Deep Ecology* (2002), and *Zen Buddhism and Environmental Ethics* (2017).²⁶

The writings of deep ecologists did not, however, go unchecked, and there have been significant challenges to the vague claims they make about the need to look to the East for answers. The critiques have come from multiple directions, including philosophers, environmental historians, and scholars of Buddhism and other Asian religious traditions.²⁷ By the late 1980s, many critical voices were being raised about the appropriation of Asian religions by the proponents of deep ecology. Tim Luke, who locates the roots of deep ecology in, among other things, Daoism and Buddhism—based on the ways that links to those traditions are included in the influential reader published by Devall and Sessions—noted that certain aspects of the movement are laudatory, such as the need to “adopt new codes of ethical responsibility,” but that other arguments concerning the “dreams of deep ecology often take on nightmarish qualities.”²⁸ The most penetrating analysis and critique of deep ecology was, however, just around the corner.

In 1992, the French philosopher Luc Ferry published his *Le nouvel ordre écologique: L'arbe, l'animal et l'homme* (translated into English in 1995 as *The New Ecological Order*), which provided an all-out assault on certain trends in the ecological movement. Ferry begins by cutting down the premises of Christopher D. Stone's famous “Should Trees Have Standing? Toward Legal Rights for Natural Objects,” concerning a 1970's court case between the Sierra Club and Walt Disney Enterprises over the protection of Mineral King—which argued for the granting of legal rights to natural objects of the environment—that the Sierra Club ultimately lost. In addition to his critique of the ideological roots of deep ecology and its excesses, Ferry agreed with earlier scholars who identified the sources of deep ecology as “outside of Western civilization.” “We find jumbled together,” Ferry says, “a strong reference to the misunderstood values of the East, which young Americans discovered in the 1950s and 1960s through ‘marginal’ books like those on Zen Buddhism by Alan Watts or Daisetz Suzuki.”²⁹ Ferry clearly had no truck with the romanticized form of Asian religions (of the “hippies and beatniks”) or what he saw as the irrational and overblown claims of deep ecology. I will comment further on Ferry's larger arguments below, but it is important to note that not all of the romanticizing and essentializing of Asian religious traditions and their views about nature was taking place within publications connected to deep ecology, and not all deep ecology was mired in romanticism.

Beyond the writings of those active in the deep ecology movement, there existed a vibrant discourse that also sought answers to the problems of

environmental degradation in Asian philosophical and religious traditions. Early representative articles in this genre were published in the journal *Environmental Ethics* during the 1980s, including Russell Goodman's "Taoism and Ecology" (1980) and Po-Keung Ip's "Taoism and the Foundation of Environmental Ethics" (1986), which both argued for how the ideas of Laozi and Zhuangzi—which are presented as a form of "naturalism"—can contribute to the establishment of a different environmental ethic. One of the key Daoist ideas discussed by Goodman and Ip is the Daoist notion of *wuwei* (or "nonintervention"), which they suggested would be a salutary attitude to adopt in aiming to act in accordance with nature. Others looked to Buddhism, which is often referenced as perhaps the best example of a religion whose doctrines and practices supported a harmonious relationship between humans and nature and therefore particularly useful in charting out a new environmental ethic. Over the next thirty years there appeared a veritable flood of similar volumes of collected essays and anthologies of primary sources that all sought insights from Asia to reappraise and reorient our relationship with the natural world in the face of the environmental crisis that was seen as an increasing threat to the planet.³⁰

Following the initial attempts by deep ecologists and others to mine the primordial traditions of the Asian past during the 1980s, Holmes Rolston III asked a question that served as the title of his often-cited essay "Can the East Help the West Value Nature?" He concluded that there is little that Daoism or Buddhism have to offer, and that the "East needs considerable reformulation of its sources before it can preach much to the West."³¹ That form of critique was picked up by later scholars who urged the same type of caution about trying to find answers to our contemporary problems by drawing on ideas found in premodern Asian religious traditions.³²

During the early 1990s, Ian Harris established himself as a leading critical voice in questioning attempts by the deep ecology and eco-Buddhist movements to ground their ideas in the early Buddhist tradition's teachings. He pointed out the methodological flaws of searching for solutions to current ecological problems in the past, particularly the past of a fundamentally world-denying tradition that sees the natural world—and all its plants and creatures—as conditioned by the doctrine of dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*), and as intrinsically unsatisfactory.³³ After pointing out the doctrinal problems associated with espousing a Buddhist environmental ethic based on retrieving it from the past, he concluded that the best "Buddhism can offer at the moment is an endorsement of those aspects of the contemporary environmentalist agenda that do not conflict with its philosophical core."³⁴ Modern Buddhists have, in other words, adapted their message to fit with positive ecological messages.

Later, Harris developed a useful four-part scale for sorting the continuum of different writers on Buddhism and the environment: (1) those who endorse Buddhist environmental ethics (such as the Dalai Lama), (2) those who claim

Buddhism has resources necessary for addressing the current environmental crisis (such as the work of Noritoshi Aramaki, Joanna Macy, and Brian Brown), (3) those who employ a critical approach but are optimistic about being able to provide a Buddhist response to environmental problems (such as the work of Lambert Schmithausen), and (4) those who explicitly reject the possibility of Buddhist environmental ethics due to its “otherworldliness” and negation of the natural world (such as the work of Noriaki Hakamaya).³⁵ Harris found his heart aligning with position number three, but his mind and scholarship with number four. The main challenge that his work forces us to confront is how one might extract ecological practices out of philosophical traditions such as Buddhism.

Among scholars of Daoism, Jordan Paper was the first to acknowledge the prominence of references to Daoism in deep ecology and to critically review the ways that they drew from so-called Daoist materials.³⁶ Like Harris, Paper finds it difficult to understand how romantic interpretations of ideas extracted from those texts and their original religious contexts—to say nothing of their profoundly mistaken ideas about Daoism—can “contribute anything meaningful to resolving our urgent environmental problems.”³⁷ Paper describes the Daoism of deep ecology to be a new Western form of Daoism, which resonates well with the view Harris presented of modern eco-Buddhists. Nonetheless, Paper’s critical attitude is tempered with an optimistic view that other pre-modern Chinese sources may in fact be useful for reconceptualizing attitudes to the natural world (his position here is like Schmithausen’s perspective on Buddhism). Paul R. Goldin expanded on Paper’s work to provide an equally critical voice to those who have sought solutions to the current ecological crisis in East Asian religions, and especially from the ideas found in the *Daode jing* and *Zhuangzi*.³⁸ “The idea that Buddhism or Confucianism or Daoism might offer some kind of answer to a current problem,” Goldin suggests, “may be part of a more general contemporary trend—namely, the notion that ‘Eastern wisdom’ may teach us certain mysterious truths about the universe, truths that ‘Western philosophy,’ in its rigidity (and indeed its very Western-ness), has been unable to unlock.”³⁹ We will return to consider deep ecology further later in this chapter, but it is important to stay with our history of the place of Asian religions in environmental history in order to better appreciate how romanticized views of their potential contributions spread despite voices from some quarters urging caution.

Asian Environmental History and Asian Religions

While historians of Asian religions were plumbing the depths of premodern Asian philosophical and religious texts for ideas that might assist with solutions to the environmental crisis, there was a parallel body of sober-minded

scholarship being undertaken by geographers, social historians, and literary historians who had not become intoxicated by drinking at the well of “Eastern wisdom” or the “Asian love of nature.” In that scholarship, which actually precedes the advent of the deep ecology movement, one finds that most of the key positions on the topic had already been addressed, making it all the more surprising that so much ink has been spilled on these issues over the last sixty or so years.

In 1962, for example, Edward H. Schafer published one of his lesser-known articles, “The Conservation of Nature under the T’ang Dynasty,” which explored the complexities of dealing with premodern relations between humans and the environment.⁴⁰ Schafer’s work is directed at a Sinological audience and does not reference any works on environmental history, which may account for the fact that it had limited impact and is rarely cited. After noting that during the Tang dynasty (618–907), “religious attitudes were very important in producing a climate of opinion conducive to explicit plans for conservation,” he reviews how religious and other motivations helped to preserve imperial tombs, sacred mountains, famous rivers, royal preserves, plants, and trees.⁴¹ The religious motivations for preserving certain natural areas were backed up by strict laws and cultural ideals. Schafer cites, for instance, Li Shangyin’s ninth-century account of desecrations, where he “condemns such graceless deeds as spreading a mat over living moss and cutting down a weeping poplar, or erecting a building with its back to a mountain view, as harmful to natural scenery and so to be avoided by cultivated men.” In this way, Schafer notes, “conceptions of beauty led to acts of conservation.”⁴² Indeed, the proper motivations for a “sound policy for the protection of nature, both as an economic and esthetic resource, were present in T’ang times,” especially during the long reign of Xuanzong (r. 713–756). And yet, Schafer concludes that “though enlightened monarchs issued edicts, conformable to the best morality of their times, these were ignored by their successors. In short, there was no permanent embodiment of these advanced ideas in constitutional forms. And so they were ultimately ineffective.”⁴³ He points, for example, to the large-scale impact on the natural environment caused by the growing need for timber for building construction and the need for soot from pines to make carbon for black ink, which sources say led to large-scale deforestation in some areas.

Schafer’s critical assessment of the historical sources was extended and expanded by the geographer Yi-Fu Tuan—who knew of Schafer’s work—a few years later in his well-known and often-cited repudiation of overly romantic views of the Chinese relationship to nature in the premodern period.⁴⁴ Tuan picked up where Lynn White Jr. left off to explore suggestions about the connection between environmental ethics and religion. In his challenge to White, Tuan emphasized, as the title of the essay suggests, the difference between “attitudes” and “behaviors.” Tuan took on the classic opposition between Western attitudes

to nature, where nature is subordinate to man, and Chinese attitudes to nature, where man is part of nature, by explicitly setting his work off from scholars of Buddhism, Daoism, Confucianism, and art. “Unlike the Western man of letters,” Tuan wrote, “the geographer is usually aware of China’s frequent mistreatment of nature. He perceives the country, not through the refined sentiments of Taoist philosophy, Neo-Confucianism, and Oswald Siren, but through the bleak reports of [geographers like] Mallory, Lowdermilk, and Thorp.”⁴⁵ Continuing this line of thinking, he states that in regard to China, “Western humanists commonly show bias in favour of that country’s Taoist and Buddhist traditions. They like to point out the virtues of the Oriental’s quiescent and adaptive approach towards nature in contrast to the aggressive masculinity of Western man. Support for the quiescent view is easily found in the Taoist classics. . . . It is easy to see how these words might appeal to the modern man, who finds in his own environment the all-too-evident consequences of human action ‘contrary to nature.’”⁴⁶ Tuan does not wax romantic and is also quick to point out that many of China’s celebrated natural scenic sites were not in fact “natural” or “wild” but rather the product of human intervention. He discussed, as an example, West Lake in Hangzhou, which is an artificial lake with man-made islands. Many “natural” sites were products of culture and akin to gardens, constituting something like what Michael Pollan has called “second nature.”⁴⁷ They were aesthetic sites to be sure, but they were not wilderness sites that were the product of preservation or conservation. Rather, they were the product of sustained human intervention and manipulation.

Tuan, like Schafer, was attentive to the “glaring contradictions of professed ideal and actual practice” and to certain unsuspected ironies, or those things that “derive from the fact that the benign institutions of a complex society, no less than the exploitive, are not always able to foresee the consequences of their inherent character and action.”⁴⁸ He was well aware, for instance, of Schafer’s example of how the need for black ink used to write nature poetry and brush famous landscape paintings was the cause of deforestation. Such gaps between attitudes and behaviors have been noted by others who have written on the complex relationship between humans and the natural environment in premodern Asia and has not escaped the attention of environmental historians. I. G. Simmons, for instance, noted in his general introduction to environmental history that “Chinese Taoism . . . envisages a quietistic, non-interventionist role in the natural world, but that did not prevent the Chinese of the time from making enormous changes to the land and water around them.”⁴⁹ That will strike some as an understatement, but the overall point is that what people say about nature is not necessarily how they behave toward it, and we should be careful about trying to equate ecological practices with what is espoused in the texts of this or that philosophical tradition.⁵⁰

Some would like to rescue Asia from this conundrum by arguing that the harmonious relationship between humans and nature in the premodern period was fractured upon the arrival of Western ideas. Yet that is a difficult position to maintain in the face of the sophisticated research published by Mark Elvin, and others, over the last thirty years. In a series of influential articles and edited books, Elvin has shown how the “effects of human activities on the environment in China can be seen almost as far back as recorded history in this part of the world. They are not intrinsically a modern phenomenon.”⁵¹ Elvin may have not been explicitly weighing in on the debates over the periodization of the Anthropocene (the word does not appear in his writing as far as I know), but he has noted that “China’s environmental crisis did not begin yesterday. Its roots are multimillennial. They reach back to that time when an archaic wisdom, sensitive to the need for careful stewardship of the natural world, began to be abandoned in the pursuit of state military power built on a pre-modern economic development whose foundations were intensive agriculture and water control.”⁵² Elvin does not define what he means by “archaic wisdom,” but his larger point about something having been lost seems to suggest that at some point the relationship was more balanced.

Elvin, like Schafer and Tuan before him, looks back to a variety of archaic Chinese sources—such as the *Zhouli* (*Rites of Zhou*), *Guoyu* (*Tales of Various States*), *Yueling* (*Monthly Ordinances*), *Tianlü* (*Statutes on Fields*), and *Guanzi* (*Book of Master Guan*)—which are commonly cited as examples of early Chinese regulation of the human relationship to nature. Tuan had already described how the *Zhouli* included descriptions of two classes of officials known as the Shanyu (Inspector of Mountains) and the Linheng (Inspector of Forests) who “saw to it that certain species were preserved, and in other ways enforced conservation practices.”⁵³ Elvin buttresses Tuan’s work by presenting a rich range of textual passages that “put at the centre of its conceptions the conservation of a well-ordered nature.”⁵⁴ Take, for example, the following passage from the *Statutes on Fields*: “In the spring, during the second month, they will not dare cut wood for building or in the mountain forests, or retain water behind dykes. Before the summer they will not dare to take armfuls of hay to make ashes [to put on the soil], nor gather the *li*-grass that is sprouting, nor take the young of animals, eggs, or fledglings . . . , nor poison fish or turtles, nor emplace pitfalls, traps, or nets.”⁵⁵ While these texts are clear enough as far as their explicit regulations go, it is also necessary to ask what the motives were for these restrictions. Were they intended to express an ecological ethic about conservation? Elvin does allude to an early spirit of conservation but says that it gave way to policies aimed at “limiting access for commoners to non-agricultural land, partly to create some degree of state monopoly that could be exploited to fiscal advantage, and partly to force the population to settle down to the pursuit of farming,

the primary source of taxes and conscripts.”⁵⁶ So much for the articulation of an environmental ethic in those early sources. Or so it seemed.

More recently, Charles Sanft has acknowledged the difficulty of discerning ecological motivations in early Chinese sources, but based on the discovery of some new evidence from “Hanging Spring Post” (*Xuanquanzhi*)—located in Gansu Province, near Dunhuang, and perhaps best known for the personal hygiene sticks found in a latrine there—makes a strong case that the people of the time were aware of environmental concerns.⁵⁷ According to Sanft, the most important part of the find was an inscription brushed on a whitewashed wall that included a set of laws (with commentaries) keyed to the seasons titled “Edict of Monthly Ordinances for the Four Seasons in Fifty Articles” (*Zhaoshu sishi yueling wushitiao*). It is the commentaries to these “monthly ordinances” that Sanft argues provide evidence for conservationist thinking in the first century CE. The statutes and commentaries concern the protection of fish, birds, animals, and forests and seem aimed at promoting sustainability. Sanft, like Elvin, explores parallels with early philosophical writings, such as the often-cited passages in the *Mencius* and *Xunzi*.⁵⁸ Yet, like Donald Hughes in his “Mencius, Ecologist,” and the preceding work of Schafer, Tuan, and Elvin, he ultimately concludes that despite having the support of philosophical texts that expressed a conservationist intent and the sanction of legal statutes, “China early on faced serious environmental problems, including widespread deforestation and extinction of animal species. Although the concept of conservation existed and steps were taken as a result, these did not result in effective, long-term protection.”⁵⁹ It is little wonder, then, why Elvin titled the subsection of his own article containing many references in support of conservationist sentiments and laws to enforce them “Powerless Wisdom: The Ecological Economy of Archaic China.”⁶⁰ The wisdom of the ancients was indeed powerless in the face of the forces of destruction of the natural environment to extract resources.

What about the role of Buddhism, which is after all the main focus of this volume? Buddhism is often treated as somehow exceptional in its environmental ethic, as we saw the ways it was appropriated by the deep ecology movement. Advocates of the potential role Buddhism might play in building a new environmental ethic often point back to early Buddhism and, for example, the role of sacred trees and animals in the Buddha’s biography or doctrinal teachings related to not killing sentient beings, which includes animals (though plants were the subject of debate).⁶¹ Buddhism, therefore, seemed to be a natural place to look for such an ethic, and it attracted attention early on from environmental historians, such as Tuan and Elvin, who noted its positive contributions. There is also evidence from East Asia that suggests some ecological practices were put into place. Tuan, for example, claimed that “Buddhism in China [was] at least partly responsible for the preservation of trees around temple compounds, for the islands of green in an otherwise

denuded landscape.”⁶² Elvin, who does not say much about Buddhism, nonetheless also noted that “the most important single factor controlling what happens to the environment is the *social structure of the power* that makes the key decisions affecting the economic and other activities that impact on the environment. To give one simple example: unlike almost all private proprietors, tenants, and even governments (when the latter were under pressure, as for example to build ships), Buddhists and Daoist monasteries looked after their trees. Their goals and their structure of decision-making, and, above all, their time-horizons, were different from those on the basis of which the others worked.”⁶³ It is difficult to discern what the Buddhist or Daoist motivations were for such practices, but Elvin suggests that they may have been to simply protect the long-term profits of the religious institutions.

Regardless of what the motivations may have been, there are many examples of the instituting of environmental protections found throughout the Chinese historical record. The examples that Elvin cites are drawn almost exclusively from Yuan Qinglin’s *Zhongguo huanjing baohu shihua* (*Historical Tales about Environmental Protection in China*), which contains a wealth of pertinent data.⁶⁴ Yuan discusses in detail the environmental protections put into place for sacred places and scenic sites, including Buddhist and Daoist temples and monasteries. Yuan is not naïve, however, and realizes that what is found in the premodern period is not the same as the concerns of modern environmental movements, but they do serve to express some sense of a conservation ethic.⁶⁵ Most of the examples that are discussed are localized and specific. Yuan discusses some of the attempts to protect sites such as the Five Sacred Peaks (*Wuyue*) and other famous mountains. What he presents does not add up to an overall environmental ethic but rather are specific choices to protect certain scenic sites or features (specific old trees, etc.) and general rules for delineated domains. The types of examples he cites will be familiar to many readers and could be multiplied many times over through citations found in a variety of other Buddhist and Daoist sources that concern prohibitions against felling trees within the precincts of a temple or monastery. For instance, as part of a longer set of prohibitions, the Chan Buddhist regulations in the *Chixiu Baizhang qinggui* include a line that says that “no vegetation should be harmed.”⁶⁶ Another passage from the *Nanyue zongsheng ji* (*Record of the Collected Wonders of Nanyue*) states that “in the second year of the Hongdao reign period (683–844) of Tang emperor Gaozong (r. 650–83), the Celestial Master and thaumaturge Ye Fashan (631–720) was ordered to bestow honors on the Five Sacred Peaks by setting aside forty *li* of land on each side of the sacred peak abbeys as spaces for extending life (*changsheng zhi di*) where it was prohibited to gather firewood or hunt game.”⁶⁷

Another area of East Asian religious history that has also attracted some attention among environmental historians is geomancy (*fengshui*). Geomancy

generally concerns a mixture of beliefs related to yin and yang, five phases (*wuxing*), and the flow of *qi* in relation to the features of the natural landscape. Certain topographic features were to be read and decoded for their deeper meanings. “The earth and its formations,” Henrik K. Sørensen explains, “are believed to be ‘alive’ and crisscrossed by subterranean energy flows (*qi*) that tend to accumulate in certain spots of power (‘high energy zones’) depending on the lay-out of the terrain. . . . Because of this, human interaction with this dynamic earthly energy has to be precise and correct on multiple levels . . . [and] any relation with the natural world must be guided by strict laws.”⁶⁸ It is not possible to detail the rich history of *fengshui* here, but—despite the protestations of some scholars of Buddhism who try to insulate the tradition from “magical” thinking—it played a significant role in Buddhist conceptions and practices related to the natural world.⁶⁹ The siting of buildings, such as monasteries and pagodas, was determined in part by the morphology of the landscape and the nodes along which the *qi* of a place was perceived to flow or accumulate. Paul Wheatley has also noted that “these local influences (*xing-shi*), the dynamic powers of the genius loci, were modified from place to place by the morphology of terrain and from hour to hour by the dispositions and conjunctions of heavenly bodies.”⁷⁰ Macrocosm and microcosm are seen here in the relationship between heaven and earth. Concerns about *fengshui* led to sophisticated conceptions about how to read signs in the natural world and the morphology of the landscape in order to realize harmony and benefit and to ward off the dangers that would come from violating *fengshui* principles. Yet if a site was deemed deficient according to *fengshui* principles, it could be supplemented through an alteration of the landscape, such as the addition of a temple or pagoda.⁷¹

The examples drawn from East Asian sources are numerous (if localized), but difficulties are encountered in finding similar sources for South Asia, despite the general claims that have been made for a long time by eco-Buddhists about early Buddhism in South Asia. Ian Harris has noted the need to separate out vague ideas drawn from Buddhist doctrines that have been appropriated by contemporary environmental movements from what is found in early Buddhist texts themselves. For Harris the main issue is the difficulty of squaring modern environmental concerns with early Buddhist teachings, especially those that saw the natural world as a source of danger (expressing a fear of the uncultivated world) and guarding against taking delight in nature due to the ways it can lead to desire and attachment. Harris subscribed to a view that said that it is less that Buddhism has an environmental ethic to be drawn on and more that contemporary Buddhists have found a set of secular concerns in the environmental movement that they can assent to.⁷² One of his main interlocutors, Lambert Schmithausen, has, however, noted that there were early Buddhist restrictions on harming plants and that there was a widespread “belief that

plants (especially large trees) as well as earth, lakes, rivers, etc., are inhabited by spirits of deities who might become irritated if their abode or domain is destroyed or polluted.”⁷³ Although Harris has expressed differences between his and Schmithausen’s views, I fail to see how their positions differ too much, except to say that while both criticize modern eco-Buddhists’ claims about early Buddhism, Schmithausen is more optimistic about the potential use of Buddhist ideas in the present, and Harris is less sanguine about that possibility.

It is important to recognize that the situation in East Asia is rather different from that of early Buddhism in South Asia due to the presence in China of pre-Buddhist ideas that led to significant doctrinal innovations related to Yogācāra and *tathāgatagarbha* ideas of inherent Buddha nature. Yet even with those potentially more charitable and explicit views about the preservation of the natural world, one must also face the reality that this did not diminish acts of environmental destruction, as Schafer and Tuan demonstrated long ago.⁷⁴ More recently Ian Harris, Henrik Sørensen, and Johan Elverskog have discussed acts of destruction perpetuated by Buddhists. After discussing the establishment of release of life ponds (*fangsheng chi*) under the Tang (759) and how some monasteries were veritable nature reserves, Harris concedes that not all the evidence points in one direction. Drawing on the work of Denis Twitchett, he notes that during the Tang dynasty, Buddhist monasteries “‘engaged in multifarious commercial and financial activities’ that may very well have had adverse influence on the natural environment. So, a monastery near Ningbo, having fallen on hard times around 836, was able to recoup its losses by large-scale deforestation of the surrounding hillsides, while a few years later, in 841, another monastery connived with commercial fuel-gatherers to exploit timber and other forest resources for financial advantage.”⁷⁵

In a recent—and balanced—study of Buddhist perspectives on nature and the environment in East Asia, Sørensen follows the critical line of thinking laid out by Harris to strip away some of the contemporary reductionism and assess what primary sources say on the issue. Although he does well to point out that soteriological concepts in East Asia are different from those in South Asia—such as the idea of the “insentient discoursing on the Buddhist teaching” or “plants and trees being endowed with Buddha-nature”—he still finds little concern for nature as such. Rather, in East Asian sources the emphasis is on what nature is thought to represent, mixed with concerns for its practical and economic value (along the lines articulated by Elvin).⁷⁶ Sørensen focuses primarily on Chan Buddhism, due to its monasteries being located in the countryside and mountains, which required “the clearing of forests with the resulting destruction of the habitats of wildlife.”⁷⁷ He also cites the *Baizhang qinggui*, quoted above, and other sources from later in Chinese Buddhist history—such as the late Ming dynasty figure Zhuhong (1535–1615)—concluding that the passages on protecting plants and not killing animals “are contextualized as part

of Buddhist piety and protection of life, not as actual expressions of love of nature or as signs of conservationism.”⁷⁸ If one takes seriously the conclusions drawn in Elvin’s work, however, one might be tempted to challenge Sørensen’s view that a concern for the natural environment was not present since there was no industrialization as a catalyst for its development. Either way, one can grant his larger point that it is difficult to discern an environmental ethic in East Asian Buddhist and Daoist sources and that the presence of both, which had some practices that protected the natural world, was still insufficient to fend off the large-scale destruction of the environment that began in the pre-modern period.⁷⁹

Environmental historians have looked to the past and to other cultures for those societies that managed their relations with the environment in more sustainable ways than those of the present. Those studies have often been marred by obfuscations caused by romanticized views, and whether of India, China, Korea, or Japan, they have not held up well under critical analysis.⁸⁰ Let’s take premodern Japan as an example. Japan is celebrated by popular writers for its love of nature and—more circumspectly—by scholars such as William LaFleur as having a rich record of attributing religious meaning and value to nature. Yet even with the reading of religious meaning into the natural world as reflected, for example, in the poetry of the Buddhist monk Saigyō (1118–1190), the Japanese landscape was not saved from depredation.⁸¹ Environmental historians working on Japan, historians interested in ecological frontiers, and anthropologists interested in human interactions with the environment have revealed the pronounced impact humans had on the environment in premodern Japan.⁸² In describing the rise and success of Edo-period forest preservation, Totman noted, however, that “foreigners, and some Japanese as well, often speak fondly of a special Japanese ‘love of nature’ that can be credited with this early modern forest recovery. To so argue, however, invites the tart query: did they love nature so much less during the ancient and early modern predations?” Totman goes on to note: “Just as we do not find woodland regulators and tree growers justifying their own actions, or urging action by others, in the name of ‘nature,’ so we do not find any themes of Buddhist reverence for sentient beings showing up as reasons or a rationale for forest policy. . . . Nor do the religious doctrines, such as Shintō or Shugendō, show up as motivators in the actions of forest preservers.”⁸³ On the issue of deforestation Walker remarks that “even in early-modern Japan, the environmental context was not fixed but was, as Conrad Totman insists, ‘shaping and being shaped by human activities.’”⁸⁴ Kalland, who has written extensively on the depletion of marine resources, has attempted to “show that the ‘nature loving Japanese’ is to a great extent a misconception” and that “the Japanese try to control nature, or ‘conquer’ it, by processes of taming.”⁸⁵ These studies should have been sufficient to dispel the popular romanticized

views about an inherent Japanese love of nature, but they have been difficult to overturn.

There is ample evidence to show that premodern philosophical and religious-cultural ideas that appeared to advance an environmental ethic in Asia did not inhibit environmental destruction.⁸⁶ We must, therefore, be careful about trying to equate natural philosophy with environmental practices.⁸⁷ What makes these conclusions all the more surprising, however, is that in addition to the ideas one finds in premodern religio-philosophical texts about the proper relationship between humans and the environment, there were also strict laws that had been instituted to protect the natural environment. Neither was effective. Scholars, therefore, seem to have hit a limit about what can be claimed about the past as a possible resource for the present. What now? One of the major contributions of this volume is that it asks a new set of questions and looks to the past and the ways Buddhists in Asia have imagined and engaged with the natural world to inspire us to view that relationship differently and to focus on actions and practices over a myopic focus on vague ideas and philosophies.

Geoaesthetics: Asian Religions, Landscaping, and Mindscaping

Climate change and the ongoing degradation of the environment are perhaps the most significant existential threats to life on the planet, as we know all too well from the reports published by the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (1992), the Kyoto Protocol (1997), the United Nations Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (2007 and 2014), and other recent reports. Those concerns have driven the types of questions asked among environmentalists hoping to provide some way to address contemporary problems by looking to the past. Yet those are not the only possible questions that can be posed by those interested in the relationship between humans and the natural world. Indeed, the close linkage between nature and environmentalism—which now seems so natural to many—is a product of mid-twentieth-century concerns. Julia Adeney Thomas has pointed out that “nature over the centuries has shifted among disciplines, considered at different times the special preserve of religion, philosophy, politics, and the arts, as well as agriculture, industry, medicine, and the sciences.”⁸⁸ There are many other questions to ask that are rather different from those focused on climate change and environmental degradation (such as eco-Buddhism). How, for instance, have premodern Buddhists envisioned and put into practice various ways of interacting with the natural world? Our concerns do not merely have to be about mining the past for an environmental ethic (Buddhist, Daoist, or otherwise) or looking for evidence of climate change as reflected in earlier history (art, religion, literature),

but rather in probing some of the ways that humans have entered into profoundly interesting relationships with the natural world as they transformed it with their bodies as well as their minds. This shift in focus might be described as taking us from a “geoethics” to what is here called “geoaesthetics.” Rather than just look to the past to find those who managed their relations with the environment more successfully or sustainably, which, as we have seen, was more of an ideal than a reality, it is nonetheless possible to look into the past to study the ways humans have interacted with the natural world. It is not just an ecological question; it is also an aesthetic one. We can now return to a consideration of deep ecology, which I argue can, in a qualified sense, be considered a precursor to “geoaesthetics.”

To be sure, much of the writing associated with the deep ecology movement was larded with romantic ideas about Asian religious traditions, yet even from its earliest days there were also those who resisted that temptation. Indeed, tucked away in the same volumes that contain some of the most egregious expressions of romanticized views are articles focused not on the Asian love of nature or environmentalism but on topics that could be described as concerned with “geoaesthetics.” From this perspective then, the critique of the excesses of deep ecology mounted by Luc Ferry—which discusses a limited range of some of the more outlandish claims of some advocates of deep ecology and Asian religions—can be viewed itself as a form of intellectual clearcutting. For example, in 1984, well before Luc Ferry published his critique, Tobias’s *Deep Ecology* included an essay by Allan G. Grapard titled “Nature and Culture in Japan” that eschewed the Asian love of nature rhetoric being peddled by many.⁸⁹ Grapard asserted that his article was an attempt to “suggest that the Japanese cultural tradition hides in its deepest recesses a vast storehouse of notions and practices which may be helpful in establishing a culturally-grounded ecophilosophy.”⁹⁰ I will return to Grapard’s work below, but since we are entering into a rich field of “geo”-neologisms that lead directly to the new “geoaesthetics,” I would like to pause momentarily on his choice of the term “ecophilosophy,” since it is a term that was used by Arne Naess in the 1970s to refer to an examination of our relationship to nature. Grapard was using the language of deep ecology, but I will suggest his work also prefigures the type of work associated with “geoaesthetics.”

The term “ecophilosophy” preceded the use of the similar term “geophilosophy,” which was coined in 1991 by Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari in *Qu’est-ce que la philosophie?* to describe how “thought realizes itself in the relationship between territory and the earth.”⁹¹ Deleuze and Guattari looked back to Friedrich Nietzsche (1844–1900) as the primogenitor of “geophilosophy.” In 2004, the philosopher Gary Shapiro, who has described Nietzsche’s aesthetics as being “the way in which fully embodied agents affectively respond to and alter their environments,” brought these streams of thought together in his use

of the neologism “geoaesthetics,” by which he tried make “aesthetic sense of nature through designed environments or landscape architecture.”⁹² Shapiro focused on land art—such as Robert Smithson’s iconic *Spiral Jetty*—and gardens, but the term was later picked up by art historians. Sugata Ray’s *Climate Change and the Art of Devotion: Geoaesthetics in the Land of Krishna, 1550–1850* is the most recent example of the tethering of geoaesthetics to issues of environmental change and art, or what he calls eco art history in the premodern period. Ray shifted his focus to an earlier period of history since most work explored how the physical features of the earth have shaped and continue to be shaped by humans since the late eighteenth century to the present. The chapters collected in this volume on Buddhist geoaesthetics, which also focus on the premodern period, do not discuss the kinds of land art discussed by Shapiro, but when he writes that “the history of thought and the history of what we call aesthetics are also fragmentary and ruined collections of texts; thought itself includes, as Derrida and Deleuze join in reminding us, those markings and tracings of the earth, that figurative language that is available to us now only in the form of mute monuments and topographical interventions, whether those of the Nambikwara’s paths through the Amazon jungle, the Celtic monoliths, or the hexagrams and mandalas of the Chinese and the Hindus,” we are dealing with a similar use of the term “geoaesthetics.” Indeed, the way the term is deployed in this volume is not altogether something new but is closer to the original sense. The term may be a neologism, but I would like to suggest that what it aims to capture about the relationship between humans and the landscape is not too dissimilar to ideas that have been expressed by a range of thinkers interested in the intersection between humans and landscape (especially in the focus on the ways they “respond to and alter their environments”). Indeed, the history of premodern ways of reading the landscape and establishing connections to religious meanings through various sophisticated means of resemblances was captured well in the work of Michel Foucault, which was published around the time that environmental history was gaining momentum.

In 1966, Michel Foucault, in a chapter titled “The Prose of the World” in *Les mots et les choses (The Order of Things)*, wrote how “up to the end of the sixteenth century, resemblance played a constructive role in the knowledge of Western culture. It was resemblance that largely guided exegesis and the interpretation of texts; it was resemblance that organized the play of symbols, made possible knowledge of things visible and invisible, and controlled the art of representing them. The universe was folded in upon itself: the earth echoing the sky, faces seeing themselves reflected in the stars, and plants holding within their stems the secrets that were of use to man.”⁹³ Foucault discussed four key forms of resemblance—*convenientia*, *aemulatio*, analogy, and sympathy—which allowed for connections to be established between the natural world and the cultural world. Yet beyond the types of resemblances afforded

by these forms of similitude, there were also ways to imagine and connect things at different scales based on microcosmic and macrocosmic relationships. There exists a “greater world, and that its perimeter defines the limit of all created things; that at the far extremity of this great world there exists a privileged creation which reproduces, within its restricted dimensions, the immense order of the heavens, the stars, the mountains, rivers, and storms.”⁹⁴ Those relationships led to the further sense that the “world is covered with signs that must be deciphered, and those signs, which reveal resemblances and affinities, are themselves no more than forms of similitude.”⁹⁵ Expressions of these types of thinking are found in abundance in pre-Renaissance Europe, extending from Saint Augustine in the fourth to fifth century up through Paracelsus in the sixteenth century. In *The City of God*, Augustine wrote, for example, that Plotinus the Platonist proves by “the beauty of flowers and leaves, that providence extends from the supreme God, whose beauty is intelligible and ineffable, as far as those lowly things of earth.”⁹⁶ Paracelsus later wrote that humans “discover all that is hidden in the mountains by signs and outward correspondences; and it is thus that we find out all the properties of herbs and all that is in stones. . . . There is no mountain so vast that it can hide from the gaze of man what is within; it is revealed to him by corresponding signs.”⁹⁷ Nature, in other words, was perceived to be filled with meaning and replete with signs that are to be decoded and read (much like what we described earlier in regard to *fengshui*).

A year after Foucault’s work was first published in French, the geographer Clarence Glacken published his seminal reflection on nature and culture, *Traces on the Rhodian Shore*. Glacken opens the book by claiming that in the premodern period there was a “yearning for purpose and order” in the conception of nature, which was generally found through connections with religious ideas, resulting in what he refers to as a theory of a “designed earth” that was based on order and harmony.⁹⁸ The discovery of meaning in the natural world rested on interpretation, and one of the primary forms of interpretation was the discovery of patterns. While Foucault may have been focused on carrying out an archaeology of human sciences in the West and Glacken was focused on Greek and Christian views of the environment, there is much in what they discuss that will be familiar to scholars of Asia. In the case of Glacken, those similarities may not be incidental. As Ole Bruun has noted, Glacken had close connections to East Asia since he “had a background as an American army specialist in Japanese language and culture, had served in Korea and had later done ethnographic studies in Okinawa.”⁹⁹ While at the University of California, Berkeley, Glacken interacted regularly with the Sinologist Wolfram Eberhard, coadvised a dissertation on geomancy (*fengshui*), and “several of his former students noticed that he kept a geomantic compass (*luopan*) in his office.”¹⁰⁰ It is perhaps not coincidental that the

language of some of the writing on the interplay between nature and culture resonates well with East Asian concepts.

What Glacken called “designed earth” is similar to what Gregory Bateson later referred to as “ultimate unity,” whereby the natural world is sanctified by patterns that connect things or allow them to be unified, which he describes as being concerned with *aesthetics*.¹⁰¹ Yet we still must ask how the design or unified order is to be perceived—or, to use Foucault’s terminology, “read.” Bateson’s *Mind and Nature* came out in the same year (1979) as the psychologist James J. Gibson’s *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception*, in which Gibson introduced the notion of “affordances.” An affordance is that which the environment provides or furnishes to humans (and animals). Gibson gives the following as an example: “If a terrestrial surface is nearly horizontal (instead of slanted), nearly flat (instead of convex or concave), and sufficiently extended (relative to the size of the animal) and if its substance is rigid (relative to the weight of the animal), then the surface *affords support*.”¹⁰² The use of the affordance is, however, based on perception and interpretation. Affordances can be related to practical utility—which may invite humans to modify the environment further in order to alter the affordances to suit them better (as we saw with *fengshui*)—or to the construction of meaning based on the perception of features of the natural landscape that allow them to be connected to reliiocultural ideas. For our concerns here, I am interested in how landscape morphology has affordances that allow for the connection of a site to Buddhist ideas and practices, and how other sites can be modified by humans to alter the affordances to bring out meaning or serve as adornment.

Gibson’s concept of “affordances” is compelling and opens up new terrain for inquiry into the relationship between humans and the natural world, but Tim Ingold has pointed out some potential dangers in the way Gibson’s theory might be misconstrued. The key issue for Ingold is the aporia between the way anthropologists and cultural ecologists view humans as imposing their “symbolically constituted designs upon the external world” and the long-held anthropological view that culture “is *the* human mode of adaptation.”¹⁰³ “If all meaning is thus culturally constructed,” Ingold writes, “then the environment on which it is imposed must originally be empty of significance. But if we hold that culture is man’s means of adaptation to the environment, and if the environment—prior to its ordering through cultural categories—is mere flux, devoid of form and meaning, it follows that culture is an adaptation to nothing at all, and to say that it is adapted is no more than to affirm that culture exists. We cannot, apparently, have it both ways.”¹⁰⁴ Ingold was, therefore, concerned on the one hand with countering cognitivist accounts of environmental perception based on cultural representations and, on the other hand, with countering views based on a theory of human accommodation to the imperatives of nature.¹⁰⁵ What is particularly appealing about Ingold’s engagement with Gibson’s work is that it

provides a way out of that dilemma by proposing that “persons endure through a continuous intercourse with their environments.”¹⁰⁶ By combining Gibson’s approach with the theories of Jakob von Uexküll, Ingold was able to move away from a cognitivist view—which says that the natural environment is entirely shaped by subjective ideas of humans—toward one that aims to understand how humans engage with the natural landscape based on their perception of its natural features—its affordances—and discover an imagined world of meaning. The result of this process is the assigning of significance to that reality. Ingold does not discuss the discovery of religious meanings in the natural world in particular, since he is primarily interested in the larger category of “culture,” but he provides us with a useful ecological approach that allows for a nuanced view of the ways that humans discover religious meanings in the natural world through their perception and interaction with it, a process that I am arguing is a form of “geoaesthetics.”¹⁰⁷

An intriguing early study of this type that combines perception of landscape morphology (affordances) and connections with religious ideas is Tadahiko Higuchi’s *The Visual and Spatial Structure of Landscapes*, originally published in Japanese in 1975. In part 2 of the book, he discusses seven landscape types and their religiocultural associations. The natural shape of the forms in the landscape provide affordances for the creation of larger meanings. The type most pertinent to the discussion here is the “Eight-Petal Lotus Blossom Type,” which connects the shapes of mountain peaks with the eight petals of a lotus blossom, a shape often used for the pedestal of Buddha images. Higuchi describes places such as Mount Kōya and Murō-ji as examples of “a symbolic meaning read into an actual landscape configuration.”¹⁰⁸ Higuchi’s analysis remains brief, but more sophisticated studies were to quickly follow.

I will focus on the work of one scholar of Japanese Buddhism, Allan G. Grapard, as an example of someone who has been particularly attentive to the connections between religious ideas and practices and landscape morphology. Grapard wrote a series of essays that fit in well with the topic of geoaesthetics (though he used terms such as “geosophia,” “geognosis,” and “geopiety” to discuss the different relationships between humans and natural landscapes). It is not possible to review his entire oeuvre here, but Grapard has been particularly effective in detailing the profound impact that Esoteric Buddhism, particularly Shingon Esoteric Buddhism as developed by Kūkai (774–835), had on forging resemblances between natural landscapes and Buddhist ideas in Japan. He described (in ways evocative of Foucault’s discussion of pre-Renaissance Europe), for example, how the landscape was perceived to speak “in a natural language what people conceived of as a supernatural discourse. Thus, waves, pebbles, winds, and birds were the elementary and unconscious performers of the cosmic speech of buddhas and bodhisattvas; and mountains, springs, lakes, trees, flowers, stars, and vistas were morphological manifestations

of the body of those divine entities that revealed to the trained eye the very essence which was thought to pervade the realm of natural forms.”¹⁰⁹ This notion of the natural world preaching the Dharma was not a Japanese innovation but is already found in the writings of the Chinese Buddhist Huiyuan (334–416). “The Buddha,” Huiyuan wrote, “has an inconceivable, divinely powerful, and transformative teaching. He is able to cause plants and trees to discourse on the teaching (*caomu shuofa*) while going and coming.”¹¹⁰ As Sørensen has shown, this concept is also related to the ideas of “Insentient (Things) Preaching the Dharma” (*wuqing shuofa*) and “The Sound of Birds Chirping as Preaching the Dharma” (*tianniao shuofa zhi yin*).¹¹¹ For those interested in Buddhist geoaesthetics, the main questions of interest are those concerned with how Buddhists understood and engaged with an environment that was perceived to be filled with potential meaning.

In his seminal 1982 article “Flying Mountains and Walkers of Emptiness: Toward a Definition of Sacred Space in Japanese Religions,” Grapard proposed three successive phases in the process of sacralization of sites in Japan. His research anticipates well this volume’s goal of taking up Amitav Ghosh’s challenge to “rethink the scale of our commitments by investigating premodern, non-Western ways of grasping the nonhuman scales of the earth and broader cosmos” through a consideration of examples drawn from the Buddhist tradition.¹¹² Grapard described, for example, a gradual “expansion of sacred space” in Japan, since a “development can be observed over time from a small and limited conception of sacred space to one which includes not only the entirety of Japan but also the entirety of space and temporal possibilities.”¹¹³ He tracked the evolution from the identification of “sacred sites” to the establishment of “sacred areas”—pilgrimage areas and mandalized sites conceived under the influence of Esoteric Buddhist ideas that proposed that Buddhahood could be realized at specific sites—and finally the “sacred nation,” which included the sacralization of all of Japan but, as Grapard notes, “could be expanded to include the universe itself.”¹¹⁴

In his 1985 essay “Nature and Culture in Japan” published in *Deep Ecology*—a more general treatment of his detailed 1982 essay “Flying Mountains and Walkers of Emptiness”—Grapard discussed two key concepts: “mindscapes” and “mandalization,” which he developed further in a series of later essays.¹¹⁵ “Mindscapes” he described as “the various geographical areas chosen by the Japanese in the course of their history to either project onto them particular mental structures of representations of reality, or to infer from them particular representations helping them to establish meaning in experience.”¹¹⁶ Grapard’s work avoids the constructivist problem and prefigures Ingold’s dual concern for the ways humans discover meaning in the natural world through their interactions with it. He further notes that these “mindscapes are generally located in landscapes of great natural beauty which happen to have been

protected over the centuries and many of which form today the National Parks of Japan.”¹¹⁷ That is an intriguing detail that may reinforce the claims of those who aver that inhabiting a sacred world or domain that has significance gives good reason to not want to defile it—the movement, in other words, from ideas to actions.

One particularly compelling example of a mindscape that Grapard discussed was Mount Futagoyama on the volcanic Kunisaki Peninsula in north-eastern Kyushu, which came to be understood as the “natural form” of the *Lotus Sūtra*. As explained by Grapard, “mountain practitioners of the classical period who specialized in this scripture noticed that there were as many natural valleys on the volcanic cone as there were chapters in the scripture: twenty-eight. They thus decided that each valley corresponded naturally to a chapter.”¹¹⁸ The topography provided the affordances for making connections to the *Lotus Sūtra*, but humans also altered the landscape by sculpting over sixty-thousand stone statues that represented each ideogram in the text and placing them along the trails traversed by the practitioners, so that walking the trails was also a reading of the text.¹¹⁹ I have encountered other sites where a perception of eight peaks provided the affordance that allowed for a connection to be made to the *Lotus Sūtra*. In one text, a Buddhist temple associated with Tiantai Buddhist practitioners, for whom the *Lotus Sūtra* is of course central, says that the Fangguang Temple is located beneath Lotus Peak: “Eight peaks and four streams encircle it.” A poem for the site says in part: “The monastery is within a lotus flower./The collection of peaks is like flower petals.”¹²⁰ A similar case in Japan of connecting a natural affordance of the topography to a religious conception is Mount Hiko, a complex site also located in northern Kyushu. Buddhist practitioners there perceived the mountain’s forty-nine natural caves as a way to connect the site to the Inner Palace of Maitreya, the bodhisattva residing in the Tusita Heaven who will become the next Buddha.¹²¹

One of the most striking examples of the concept of “mandalization” that I am aware of is the large-scale projection of the Diamond and Womb *maṇḍalas* onto the vast geographical area of Yoshino and Kumano on the Kii Peninsula in Japan. “It is,” Grapard explains, “as if each *maṇḍala* were spread over the earth as a transparency, and the sun—like a projector—sent the image onto the surface of the earth. Each divinity represented in the *maṇḍala* transparency then found itself as if seated on a mountain peak, on a rock near a waterfall, or in a cavern along the various ranges of summits.”¹²² Just as a practitioner would move through a *maṇḍala* in a specific way in meditation, mountain ascetics in Yoshino and Kumano literally walked through the *maṇḍalas* that were correlated with that natural area. Similar processes of *maṇḍalization* were carried out at numerous other mountain sites throughout Japan and in other parts of Asia, with extensive research also having been done by scholars of Tibetan Buddhism.¹²³

Concluding Thoughts: Geoaesthetics and Imagining a Deeper Environmental Humanities

This chapter has attempted to reveal how—and why—discussions concerning the relationship between humans and the natural world, including recent work on geoaesthetics, have primarily focused on ecological concerns. Some of the earliest publications in the humanities on this topic engaged with the place of religion, decrying Western religions and celebrating Eastern religions. That polarization of East and West we now know to be too simplistic and based on romanticized views of Asian religions. A prodigious amount of literature accrued that was based on questions about whether or not early Buddhism or Daoism had an environmental ethic or—in the deep ecology movement—if there might be some lessons to be learned by looking to the past. Many scholars have, however, pointed out the methodological problems of searching for answers to contemporary environmental problems in the past and the fact that even those cultures that had religio-philosophical views that supported a more harmonious relationship between humans and the environment were themselves unable to fend off the forces of environmental depredation.

The science behind the current ecological crisis is incontrovertible. The Anthropocene is an era in which the human impact on the planet has attained a new order of magnitude and environmentalists have come to realize that nature is indelibly shaped by humans. It is equally true, however, that science alone is not going to rescue us from this dire situation. We are not going to be able to geoengineer our way out of this problem. We need a change of values; we need new belief systems. This sentiment, which aligns well with part of the earlier deep ecology platform, is evident in many of the writers discussed above. Schmithausen, despite being critical of the ways the early Buddhist tradition has been invoked by those in environmental movements, nonetheless aims to contribute to “a change of attitude and behaviour towards nature.”¹²⁴ While certain segments of the deep ecology movement may have been compromised by their overly romanticized views of the possibilities of drawing on Asian religious traditions in the present, one important contribution they made, which is something that many thinkers—particularly those active in the environmental humanities—are now proposing, is precisely the need for a change of values.

This volume might be seen as contributing to ongoing work in the environmental humanities—which is a broad multidisciplinary movement—by bringing various approaches to environmental scholarship into conversation with each other. One objective of the environmental humanities is to foster the cultural transformations necessary for reducing environmental destruction and charting a way to a better future. The editors of this volume have followed a prominent intellectual trajectory that sees our current predicament as partially due to a failure of imagination (Ghosh). The rich cases discussed

in the chapters in this volume provide us not with solutions drawn from the past—that was not the goal of this volume—but with some evocative ways of imagining or reimagining the relationship between humans and the natural world. This is one of the reasons why the past should still matter for the environmental humanities. The myriad ways that humans have interacted with the natural world over time can provide much needed inspiration in the present. What is distinctive about this volume, however, is that the chapters are not limited to discussions of ideas, as one finds in works such as *Nature in Asian Traditions of Thought: Essays in Environmental Philosophy*; instead they provide detailed descriptions and analysis of practices that reveal the variety of creative ways that humans in the premodern period engaged with the natural world.

Nonetheless, if inspiration is not enough to provide us with hope for the future, then perhaps the focus on religious institutions such as Buddhism will. I have found it particularly interesting that at least two of the major voices grappling with environmental issues in recent years, namely Amitav Ghosh and Prasenjit Duara, both look to the possible—perhaps even necessary—role to be played by religious institutions such as Buddhism (not that the institutions were effective in the past). Ghosh sums up the reasons for this well in the final pages of his *Great Derangement*:

Bleak though the terrain of climate change may be, there are a few features in it that stand out in relief as signs of hope: a spreading sense of urgency among governments and the public; the emergence of realistic alternative energy solutions; widening activism around the world; and even a few signal victories for environmental movements. But the most promising development, in my view, is the increasing involvement of religious groups and leaders in the politics of climate change. Pope Francis is, of course, the most prominent example, but some Hindu, Muslim, Buddhist, and other groups and organizations have also recently voiced their concern.¹²⁵

What makes religious organizations particularly well suited to assisting in this effort is the fact that they “possess the ability to mobilize people in far greater numbers than any” other newly formed movements.¹²⁶

Prasenjit Duara expressed similar ideas in his recent *The Crisis of Global Modernity: Asian Traditions and a Sustainable Future*, where he writes that the “goal of this work is to identify traditions in Asia that have been consonant with global imperatives in the Anthropocene—when humans have begun to significantly affect nature and the environment—not only by revealing different attitudes and ideals regarding nature (and other subjugated entities) but also by showing us different methods and techniques of self-formation that can link the personal to the social, natural and the universal to counter the consumerism and nationalism of our times.”¹²⁷ These new approaches are not the old-time romanticism of earlier writers, seduced by the idea of the Asian

love of nature, but they have not jettisoned religion either. Rather, a variety of Asian religions are understood as having “played a significant role in framing, empowering and enhancing the solidarity of local environmental movements since the 1980s.”¹²⁸ Although Duara’s work is focused on modernity and issues of sustainability, one of the reasons I invoke it in particular here is that we share a perspective about the possibilities of drawing on the useful parts of the deep ecology movement. For Duara—drawing on the work of Roger Gottlieb—what is important is the way that religious and philosophical ideas can work hand in hand with social and political ideas to bring about change.¹²⁹ Duara proceeds to detail some of the ways that religious groups—such as Buddhist monks in Cambodia and Thailand or Daoists in China—have worked effectively with popular movements in Asia to combat environmental degradation.¹³⁰ One such example is the protection of “feng shui forests” (*fengshui lin*). Scholars have shown how these old-growth forests are not only related to traditional religio-cultural ideas but also play a role in contemporary ecological practices related to forest management and biodiversity.¹³¹ Local movements in Asia inspired by indigenous religious traditions such as Buddhism and Daoism—and some in the West, such as Extinction Rebellion, which has drawn many Buddhist supporters—have had an effect (regardless of their fidelity to earlier traditions and the inability of those traditions to forestall environmental destruction in the past) on inspiring environmental movements and bringing about changes in practice in the present.¹³² Religious traditions, like certain modern Buddhist movements, may help us to imagine alternative scenarios that inspire us to implement changes in our practices based on new convictions. The chapters included in this volume, with their focus on premodern Buddhist case studies, provide suggestive material that will, I hope, lead to further research and discussion of geoaesthetic issues concerning the relationship between humans and the natural environment.

NOTES

1. Chakrabarty, “Climate,” 197.
2. Crutzen and Stoermer, “Anthropocene,” 12–14. The dates for the first usage of that term are not entirely clear.
3. Ruddiman, “Atmospheric”; and Ruddiman, “Anthopocene.”
4. Mike Davis, “Living on the Ice Shelf: Humanity’s Meltdown,” June 26, 2008, <https://tomdispatch.com/post/174949>, as cited in Chakrabarty, “Climate,” 209.
5. McNeill, “Observations.”
6. *Ibid.*, 7.
7. White, “Historic Roots.”

8. Ibid., 1205.
9. Ibid.
10. On the potential dangers of Eastern thought for Western scientific and technological approaches to nature, see Passmore, *Man's Responsibility*. A good discussion of the quasiracist attitudes expressed by Passmore and others who followed after Lynn White can be found in Hargrove ("Forword," xiii–xxi).
11. Ghosh, *Great Derangement*, 87. For an assessment of the place of the "Anthropocene" in Asian studies, see Elverskog, "(Asian Studies + Anthropocene)."
12. Nash, *Wilderness*, 20–21.
13. Toynbee, "Religious Background."
14. McNeill, "Observations," 15–30.
15. See, for instance, Badiner, *Dharma Gaia*. For insightful critiques of such views, see Clarke, *Oriental Enlightenment*; Harris, "Buddhist Environmental Ethics"; and Harris, "American Appropriation."
16. Anesaki, *Art, Life, and Nature*, 6. A year later, Coomaraswamy published his *Transformation of Nature in Art*, wherein he was even more direct in pointing to the relationship between Buddhism and nature. He asserted that "Ch'an-Zen art, seeking realization of the divine being in man, proceeds by way of opening his eyes to a like spiritual essence in the world of Nature external to himself," and he then proceeded to cite passages from the twelfth-century Sōtō Zen master Dōgen to illustrate his point (40–41).
17. D. T. Suzuki, "The Role of Nature."
18. Watanabe, "Conception of Nature." Watanabe extended these thoughts in chapter 6 of his book, "Modern Science and the Japanese Conception of Nature" (99–114), translated as *The Japanese and Western Science*. In that chapter he also describes how the essay in *Science* was explicitly directed at Lynn White, who was in the audience when the talk on which the essay was based was delivered.
19. Watanabe, "Conception of Nature," 188.
20. Sharf, "Zen of Japanese Nationalism," 124. For a perceptive analysis of the connection between Japanese conceptions of nature and political ideology and the "Japanese love of nature," see Thomas, *Reconfiguring Modernity*, 8–10. See also Kalland, "Culture in Japanese Nature"; and Harris, "Landscape Aesthetics," 159–160.
21. See Naess, "Shallow"; Naess, "Encouraging Richness"; and Harris, "Buddhist Environmental Ethics," 204.
22. Tobias, *Deep Ecology*, vii.
23. Tobias, *Deep Ecology*; Devall and Sessions, *Deep Ecology*; and Callicott, *Earth's Insights*, 67–86 (on Daoism and deep ecology), 87–108 (on East Asian Buddhism).
24. Devall and Sessions, *Deep Ecology*, ix.
25. Ibid., 100–101. On the role of Zen and deep ecology, see also Kalland, "Culture in Japanese Nature," 243.
26. Works cited, respectively, are Barnhill and Gottlieb, *Deep Ecology and World Religions*; Henning, *Manual for Buddhism and Deep Ecology*; and James, *Zen Buddhism and Environmental Ethics*.
27. Elverskog, *Buddha's Footprint*.
28. Luke, "Dreams."
29. Ferry, *New Ecological Order*, 70.

30. Callicott and Ames, *Nature in Asian Traditions*; Badiner, *Dharma Gaia*; Barnes, *Ecology of Spirit*; Tucker and Grim, *Worldviews and Ecology*; Kaza and Kraft, *Dharma Rain*; Tucker and Williams, *Buddhism and Ecology*; Tucker and Berthrong, *Confucianism and Ecology*; and Girardot et al., *Daoism and Ecology*.
31. Rolston, "Can the East Help?"
32. For a useful summary of the critiques of attempts to draw from Daoist sources—including by those within deep ecology—see Clarke, *Oriental Enlightenment*, 172–178; Clarke, *Tao of the West*, 81–89; and most recently Yang, *Chinese Environmental Ethics*.
33. Harris, "How Environmentalist Is Buddhism?" 103–104; Harris, "Causation and 'Telos'"; Harris, "Buddhism"; Harris, "Buddhist Environmental Ethics"; Harris, "American Appropriation"; Harris, "Buddhism and the Discourse of Environmental Concern."
34. Harris, "Causation and 'Telos,'" 126.
35. *Ibid.*, 117.
36. Paper published two related papers with different titles in 2001. See Paper, "'Daoism' and 'Deep Ecology'"; and Paper, "Chinese Religion."
37. Paper, "Chinese Religion," 109.
38. Goldin, "Why Daoism."
39. *Ibid.*, 76.
40. Schafer, "Conservation."
41. *Ibid.*, 279–293.
42. *Ibid.*, 292.
43. *Ibid.*, 308.
44. Tuan, "Discrepancies." Cobb (*Is It Too Late?*) also noted that Daoist ideas did not inhibit rampant deforestation.
45. Tuan, "Discrepancies," 184
46. *Ibid.*, 181–182.
47. Pollan, *Second Nature*.
48. Tuan, "Discrepancies," 188.
49. I. G. Simmons, *Environmental History: A Concise Introduction* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1993), 157, as cited in Goldin, "Why Daoism," 76.
50. This caution is also expressed well in Callicott and Ames, *Nature in Asian Traditions*, "Epilogue," 279–289.
51. Elvin, "Three Thousand Years," 45. See also Elvin and Liu, *Sediments of Time*; and Elvin, *Retreat of Elephants*. Important new research on the history of forest management in China can be found in Miller, *Fir and Empire*.
52. Elvin, "Introduction," in Elvin and Liu, *Sediments of Time*, 3.
53. Tuan, "Discrepancies," 183. Elvin discusses various other titles used in other sources in his "Three Thousand Years," 18n55.
54. Elvin, "Three Thousand Years," 16.
55. *Ibid.*, 20. I have converted Elvin's romanizations to Pinyin.
56. *Ibid.*, 18.
57. Sanft, "Environment and Law."
58. *Ibid.*, 713–714.
59. *Ibid.*, 713–715; and Hughes, "Mencius, Ecologist."
60. Elvin, "Three Thousand Years," 16.

61. On this topic in early Buddhism, see Schmithausen, *Problem of the Sentience*; and Schmithausen, *Plants in Early Buddhism*. On the notion of the Buddhahood of plants in East Asian Buddhism, see, for instance, Shively, “Buddhahood for the Nonsentient”; Grosnick, “Buddhahood of Grasses”; LaFleur, “Saigyō”; Rambelli, *Vegetal Buddhas*; and Sørensen, “Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots.”
62. Tuan, “Discrepancies,” 188.
63. Elvin, “Three Thousand Years,” 11.
64. Yuan Qinglin, *Zhongguo huanjing*, see especially 234–251.
65. *Ibid.*, 234.
66. T. 2025.48.1138a10ff. For further discussion of this text, see Sørensen, “Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots,” 90.
67. T. 2097.51.1068c22.
68. Sørensen, “Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots,” 99.
69. On geomancy (*fengshui*) in general, see also Feuchtwang, *Anthropological Analysis*; and Needham, *Science and Civilization*. On Chinese Buddhism and geomancy, see Robson, “Monastic Spaces”; and Sørensen, “Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots,” 98–100.
70. Wheatley, *Pivot*, 459.
71. See the discussions in Feuchtwang, *Anthropological Analysis*, 2; and Sørensen, “Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots,” 98–99.
72. Harris, “How Environmentalist Is Buddhism?,” 110.
73. Schmithausen, “Buddhism and the Ethics of Nature,” 55. See also Viennot, *Le culte de l’arbe*.
74. Tuan, “Discrepancies,” 188.
75. Harris, “Buddhism and the Discourse of Environmental Concern,” 386.
76. Sørensen (“Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots,” 92–98) conveys the particularly East Asian views of the relationship between Buddhism and the natural environment.
77. *Ibid.*, 90.
78. *Ibid.*, 91.
79. Elverskog, *Buddha’s Footprint*.
80. I have focused my comments on China, for which we have a preponderance of evidence, but the results, according to J. R. McNeill, are broadly applicable. McNeill (“Observations,” 15–16) concluded his survey of environmental history by noting that “over time, the weight of environmental history investigation showed that preindustrial societies often had broad environmental consequences.” See also comments on India (21), on China (28), and on Japan (29). While Gadgil and Guha (*This Fissured Land*) posited that pre-British India was a period of ecological harmony, other scholars have challenged that claim, suggesting that it was a less benign story. See, for instance, Eaton, *Rise of Islam*, 194–227. Schmithausen has expressed reservations about there being an ecological ethic in early Indian Buddhism, as has Elverskog (*The Buddha’s Footprint*), while Meera Baindur, (*Nature in Indian Philosophy*) has argued that such an ecological ethic did exist in early India in Advaita, Sāṃkhya-Yoga, and Jain traditions; but she does not discuss Buddhism or the relationship of those philosophies to actual environmental practices. See also Larson, “Conceptual Resources.”
81. LaFleur, “Saigyō.”

82. Totman, *Green Archipelago*; Walker, *Conquest of Ainu Lands*; and Kalland, "Culture in Japanese Nature." There is also much to be learned about laws regulating the land in Farris, *Population, Disease, and Land*.
83. Totman, *Green Archipelago*, 179.
84. Walker, *Conquest of Ainu Lands*, 13. The citation is to Conrad Totman, *The Lumber Industry in Early Modern Japan* (Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 1995), 5.
85. Kalland, "Culture in Japanese Nature," 243.
86. Korean environmental history is still developing, but based on what we presently know, it seems that there is a similar narrative to that described for China and Japan. See Lee, "Editor's Introduction"; Lee, "Protect the Pines"; and Gant, "Taking Refuge in the Law."
87. See Bruun and Kalland, *Asian Perceptions of Nature*.
88. Thomas, *Reconfiguring Modernity*, 5.
89. Grapard, "Nature and Culture." It is pertinent to note that Tobias had earlier (in 1979) published a collection of essays titled *The Mountain Spirit* (which was originally going to be called *A Mountain Aesthetic*) that included an essay by Arne Naess and no fewer than six essays and translations concerning religious texts on sacred mountains in China and Japan. See especially the contributions by Carl Bielefeldt, Allan Grapard, Byron Earhart, and William Doub.
90. Grapard, "Nature and Culture," 241.
91. Deleuze and Guattari, *Qu'est-ce que la philosophie?*, 85–114.
92. Shapiro, "Territory, Landscape, Garden," 103. See also Shapiro, "Nietzsche," 480.
93. Foucault, *Order of Things*, 17.
94. *Ibid.*, 31.
95. *Ibid.*, 32.
96. Augustine, *City of God*, 392.
97. Foucault, *Order of Things*, 32.
98. Glacken, *Traces*, 3.
99. Bruun, *Introduction*, 147.
100. *Ibid.*, 147.
101. Bateson, *Mind and Nature*, 19.
102. Gibson, *Ecological Approach*, 119.
103. Ingold, "Culture and Perception," 39.
104. *Ibid.*, 39.
105. *Ibid.*, 40.
106. *Ibid.*, 40.
107. A related theory is proposed by Roy Rapport, *Ritual and Religion*, 8.
108. Higuchi, *Visual and Spatial*, 116.
109. Grapard, "Geosophia," 383.
110. T. 1856.45.134a. Cited and translated in Sørensen, "Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots," 93.
111. Sørensen, "Eco-Buddhas and Dharma-Roots," 92–93.
112. Citing our conference's public announcement.
113. Grapard, "Flying Mountains," 195–196.
114. *Ibid.*, 196.

115. Ibid., 195–221, and Grapard, “Nature and Culture.” See also Grapard, “Geosophia”; and Grapard, *Mountain Mandalas*.
116. Grapard, “Nature and Culture,” 244.
117. Ibid., 244.
118. Ibid., 246.
119. For a more detailed discussion, see Grapard, “Textualized Mountain.”
120. Robson, *Power of Place*, 240. See T. 2097.51.1061b.25–29.
121. Grapard, “Geotyping Sacred Space,” 225.
122. Grapard, “Geosophia,” 389–390.
123. On Japan, see Grapard, *Mountain Mandalas*. See also Mammitzsch, “Maṇḍala and Landscape in Japan.” On Tibet, see a number of the essays in Macdonald, *Mandala and Landscape*; Toni Huber, *The Cult of Pure Crystal Mountain: Popular Pilgrimage and Visionary Landscape in Southeast Tibet* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999), especially chapter 4, “Cosmodrama and Architectonics of Landscape,” 39–57, which includes a rich discussion of reading meaning into or from the landscape; Elisabeth Stutchbury, “Perceptions of Landscape in Karzha: ‘Sacred’ Geography and the Tibetan System of ‘Geomancy,’” in Toni Huber, ed., *Sacred Spaces and Powerful Places in Tibetan Culture: A Collection of Essays* (Dharamsala, India: Library of Tibetan Works and Archives, 1999), 154–186, which discusses how the placing of chortens on landscape could modify the quality of a site, which is a practice also found in China.
124. Schmithausen, *Buddhism and Nature*, 2. See also Schmithausen, “Early Buddhist Tradition.”
125. Ghosh, *Great Derangement*, 159. See also Duara, *Crisis of Global Modernity*.
126. Ghosh, *Great Derangement*, 160.
127. Duara, *Crisis of Global Modernity*, 10.
128. Ibid., 42. See also Weller, *Discovering Nature*.
129. Duara, *Crisis of Global Modernity*, 29–30. See also Gottlieb, “Transcendence of Justice.”
130. Duara, *Crisis of Global Modernity*, 42–43.
131. Coggins, *Tiger and the Pangolin*; Coggins, “When the Land Is Excellent”; and Brown, “Veins.”
132. See the examples discussed in Duara, *Crisis of Global Modernity*, 43. Yamabe Nobuyoshi (“Internal Desire”) also discussed the attempt by Zen Buddhists at the Shōgoji in Japan who have tried to live an ecologically conscious lifestyle. Finally, David Loy, a Buddhist activist working within the Extinction Rebellion movement (which has attracted many Western Buddhists due to its commitment to nonviolent protest), has noted in *Ecodharma* (11) that “Buddhist teachings don’t tell us *what* to do, but they tell us a lot about *how* to do it.”

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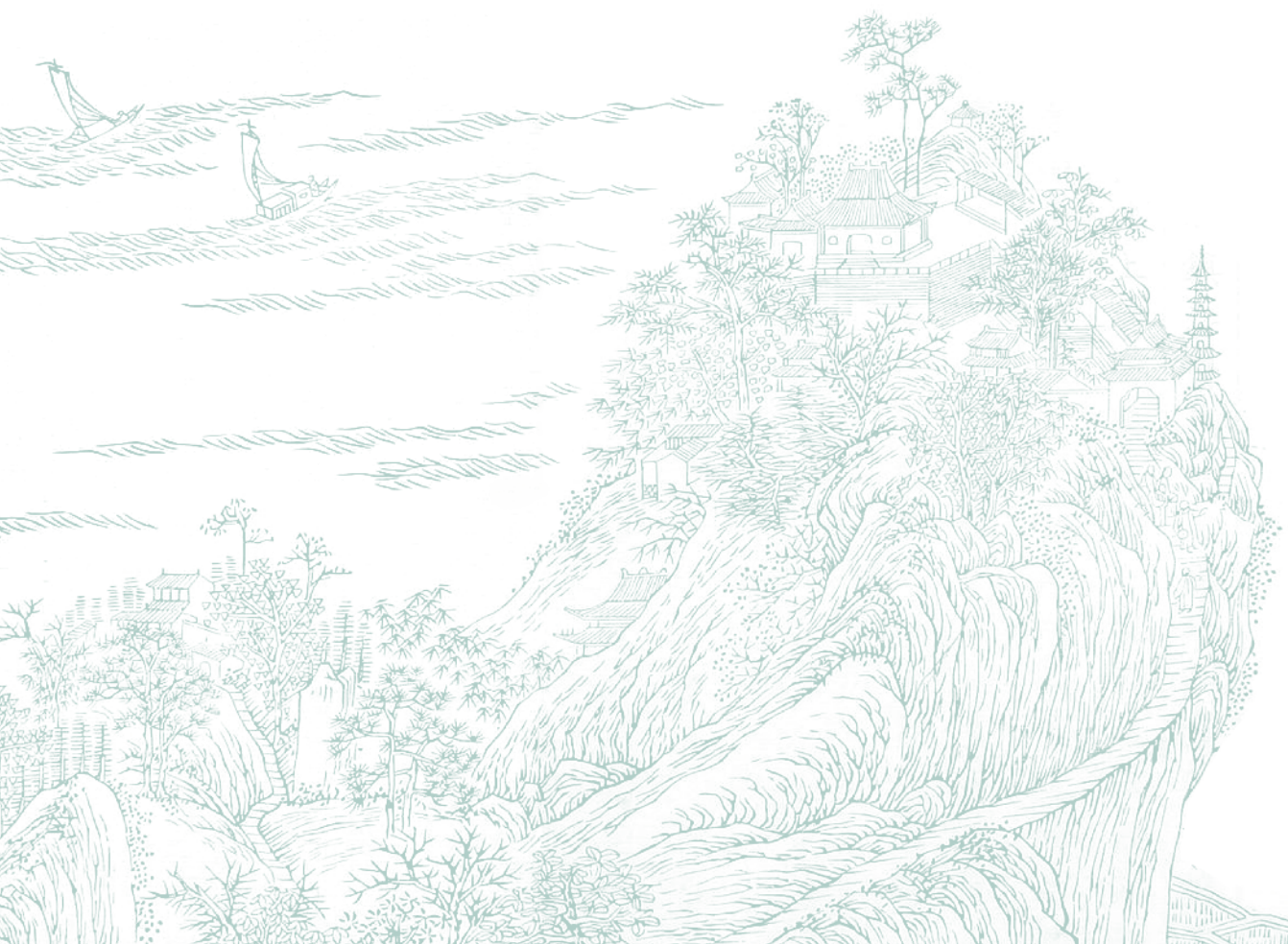
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PART II

Matters of Scale and the Environment





CHAPTER 3

Flesh Mountain

Human Bodies on a Nonhuman Scale

Reiko Ohnuma

How do human beings imagine things that lie utterly beyond the human scale? Constrained as we are by space, time, and physicality, how do we conceive of entities that are infinite, transcendent, or wholly immaterial? Let me begin to propose one possible answer by invoking a piece that I read many years ago but continue to find quite thought-provoking. The piece is called “Dim Body, Dazzling Body” and was written by Jean-Pierre Vernant,¹ a French scholar of ancient Greece who was interested in exploring the question of how the pre-Socratic Greek philosophers imagined the divine. How did human beings in ancient Greece imagine something that was divine, transcendent, and utterly beyond the human realm? According to Vernant, they did not do so by making the gods noncorporeal, immaterial, or pure “spirit” as opposed to “matter.” Instead, they did so by investing the gods with a highly unusual and illogical *body*, a body that makes use of the same basic code as the ordinary human body and yet constitutes its very opposite. In Vernant’s words:

Roughly, the problem consists of deciphering all the signs that mark the human body with the seal of limitation, deficiency, incompleteness, and that make it a sub-body. This sub-body cannot be understood except in reference to what it presupposes: corporeal plenitude, a super-body, the body of the gods. . . . By pushing to an extreme all the qualities and bodily values that are present in an always diminished, derivative, faltering, and precarious form in man, one is led to endow the divinities with a set of traits which . . . locates them in an inaccessible beyond and causes them to transgress the corporeal code by means of which they are represented.²

Thus, human beings imagine things that lie beyond themselves by making use of what they do know—which is the ordinary human body, the “corporeal code”—and yet the body they describe by means of this code is so illogical and so exaggerated that it finally transcends the code itself and suggests something wholly immaterial—but without ever taking that final step. As Vernant puts it: “The divine super-body evokes and touches upon the non-body. It points to it; it never merges with it.”³

Though Vernant is speaking here about ancient Greece, the same ideas seem equally applicable to a South Asian context and the traditions of both Hinduism and Buddhism, which are full of highly unusual bodies. To give just one example: I have always wondered why it is the case that certain lists commonly found on the Internet—such as “Top 10 Tallest Statues in the World,”⁴ “The 15 Tallest Statues in the World,”⁵ or “Top 20 Tallest Statues in the World”⁶—feature such a large preponderance of buddhas and bodhisattvas (including, in these three lists, seven of the top ten, twelve of the top fifteen, and fourteen of the top twenty).⁷ Why have Buddhists all over the world been so interested in constructing absolutely gargantuan images of buddhas and bodhisattvas? What could the sheer size of such figures possibly indicate?

One possible answer is provided by a rather old documentary that I’m somewhat embarrassed to say I still have my students watch, even though it is now quite outdated. *Buddhism: Footprint of the Buddha* was produced by the BBC back in 1977 as part of a documentary series called *The Long Search*, which followed the British theater director Ronald Eyre as he traveled the world to learn about various world religions.⁸ In the scene in question, Mr. Eyre goes into a temple in Sri Lanka, where he sees a regular-size image of the Buddha’s son Rāhula standing next to an enormous image of the Buddha that reaches all the way up to the ceiling. When he asks the monk accompanying him why the Buddha image is so tall, the monk answers by saying that the human form of the image shows us what the Buddha looked like, while the *height* of the image illustrates the Buddha’s “heightless virtues, his infinite virtues.”⁹ Thus we see that an image’s physically exaggerated *height* might be one way of pointing toward the “heightless”—the infinite—and now we have a way to wrap our minds around the very idea of “infinite virtue.” We cannot physically see something that is infinite, nor can we estimate the size of infinity. But we can look upward at a Buddha image and wonder why it is so tall.

Another example that works on a slightly different principle: The bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara is well known in Mahāyāna Buddhism for being the very embodiment of perfect compassion (Skt. *karuṇā*), one who constantly looks down upon the world with great compassion and is always ever-ready to reach out and save sentient beings in their time of need. But since compassion is an abstract quality and not something we can physically grasp, how can we understand just how extensive his compassion really is? Perhaps one way of

conveying its enormous reach is through the *multiplication of body parts*. By giving Avalokiteśvara eleven heads or one thousand arms (and often both, as we find in many fantastic images from the Chinese, Japanese, and Tibetan traditions),¹⁰ the suggestion is made that Avalokiteśvara's ability to look down and reach out is an almost grotesque multiplication of our own. Again, we cannot see the multiple universes through which his compassion extends, but we can gaze in wonder at his freakish body with its one thousand arms.¹¹ Or, if we want to go even further, by multiplying what has already been multiplied, we can take a single image of one-thousand-armed Avalokiteśvara, multiply that image one thousand times, and line all one thousand images up in one of the longest wooden buildings in the world, such as we find at Sanjūsangen-dō, the famous twelfth-century CE temple in Kyoto.¹² By giving one thousand arms to each image and then multiplying these images by one thousand, the creators of this highly impressive temple seem to convey a message that is almost *mathematical* in its intent—giving visual expression to an exponential function whose value increases very rapidly and shoots upward toward infinity. And yet this mathematical formula for infinite compassion is conveyed not through the medium of numbers but through a “corporeal code”—a code constituted by ordinary and lifelike heads, arms, and bodies.

Since all the images I have mentioned so far are actual physical objects, there is, of course, a certain limit to what they are able to achieve. Once we move to the realm of written texts, however, the body can be imagined on an even grander scale and conceived of in an even more inconceivable way. Not only can you make the body very large or endow it with multiple body parts but you can also describe a body that extends through space until it fills up the entire universe—or, alternatively, you can place the entire universe inside of a single body. By making the body coterminous with the universe, you have, in effect, eradicated any distinction at all between that which is *body* and that which is *nonbody*, and therefore, even while it remains a body, it can stand for that which is nonbody—in other words, something immaterial, inconceivable, or otherwise hard to grasp. In his recent study of the role of “cosmological thinking” in Himalayan Buddhism, for example, Eric Huntington discusses the use of “cosmic scale as a measure of spiritual attainment” in certain literary and artistic depictions of the Buddha.¹³ In a story from *The Wise and the Foolish*, for example, the grandeur of the Buddha's attainment is indicated “by having him literally extend himself to the height of the heavens and the size of the universe.”¹⁴ Making the Buddha's physical body coterminous with the entire cosmos thus conveys a sense of the enormity of the Buddha's awakening. In order to depict such an image in a two-dimensional format, Huntington notes, the Buddha is sometimes depicted seated or standing directly in front of Mount Meru—the enormous mountain that marks the very center of our cosmos—and as being roughly equivalent in height. The inconceivable nature of

the Buddha's awakening is thus conveyed through the equation of the Buddha's body, Mount Meru, and the cosmos.

We find several of these strategies coming together in a Hindu context in the famous theophany in chapter 11 of the *Bhagavad Gita*, where the god Krishna grants to the warrior Arjuna a physical vision of his supernal form as God. Earlier in their encounter, Krishna has already revealed his divine and transcendent nature to Arjuna in all sorts of different ways, describing himself, for example, as “the life-force that sustains the universe”;¹⁵ “the source of all the universe”;¹⁶ “the unborn, beginningless great lord of the worlds”;¹⁷ “the source of everything”;¹⁸ “eternal, divine, the primordial god, unborn, omnipotent”¹⁹—and finally concluding his speech by saying, “Endless are my divine powers—of my power's extent I have barely hinted! . . . I stand sustaining this entire world with a fragment of my being.”²⁰ Thus, over and over again, he has told Arjuna that, as God, he is infinite, transcendent, and supreme. And yet none of this is enough for Arjuna—the stubborn human being—who replies to this description of God by saying, “Just as you have described yourself, I wish to see your form in all its majesty, Krishna.”²¹ So Krishna grants to Arjuna a physical vision of his body as God. This divine epiphany is referred to as Krishna's *viśvarūpa*, or “universal form,” and it combines several of the strategies mentioned above. Krishna's body clearly fills up the entire universe, for Arjuna says to him, “You alone fill the space between heaven and earth and all the directions.”²² But even while filling up the entire universe, this body also contains the entire universe, for we are told that in this vision, “Arjuna saw all the universe in its many ways and parts, standing as one in the body of the god of gods”²³—a vision that many foolhardy artists throughout South Asian art history have attempted to portray.

How, then, does one come to grasp the absolute omnipresence of God? By trying to imagine a body that both *fills* the universe but also *contains* the universe, which suggests a complete interpenetrability of space that could only be divine in nature. This, too, is a common feature of the divine superbody that distinguishes it from the ordinary human body, as described by Vernant: “One of the functions of the human body is that it precisely positions every individual, assigning him one and only one location in space. A god's body escapes this limitation. . . . The gods are here and there at the same time . . . the constraints imposed by the externality of the divisions of space are child's play to them.”²⁴ As if all of this were not enough, we also have, in this vision, the theme of multiple body parts, for Arjuna says to Krishna, “I see your boundless form everywhere, the countless arms, bellies, mouths, and eyes. . . . Seeing the many mouths and eyes of your great form, its many arms, thighs, feet, bellies, and fangs, the worlds tremble and so do I.”²⁵

“The worlds tremble.” Clearly, this is a vision that is terrifying for Arjuna, so terrifying that no mortal human being can bear to see it with his ordinary

human eyes. In fact, before the vision is granted, Krishna says to Arjuna, “But you cannot see me with your own eye; I will give you a divine eye to see the majesty of my discipline.”²⁶ As Vernant notes, before any divine epiphany can occur, one usually has to be provided with some kind of supernatural vision, for “to see a god face-to-face, as he is authentically in his uncovered body, is far more than human strength can bear.”²⁷ Here, we encounter a paradox that speaks poignantly to our nature as human beings: On the one hand, we can grasp the divine body only by imagining the human body on an utterly nonhuman scale. But on the other hand, the resulting body is so ridiculously beyond the human scale that we implicitly realize that our ordinary vision will no longer suffice, and we have to be granted the eyes of God himself. Only God can see God. And yet we persist in trying to describe God’s body.



How is this discussion related to the notion of a Buddhist geoaesthetics? As I understand it, *geoaesthetics* is an approach that considers human conceptualizations of the earth in constant interaction with the agency of the earth itself—or, in place of “agency,” the natural “affordances” for human interaction provided by geological phenomena such as rocks, mountains, rivers, features of climate and topography, and the implacable presence of the earth itself. Inasmuch as geoaesthetics foregrounds the interaction between human and nonhuman forms of agency, it can be seen as part of the posthumanist turn. Yet among the varieties of posthumanism, geoaesthetics is perhaps particularly useful for foregrounding questions of *scale*: How do human beings conceptualize and interact with geological phenomena that vastly exceed the scale of ordinary human embodiment and experience? How do they conceptualize what Timothy Morton has referred to as the *hyperobject*—that is, “things that are massively distributed in time and space relative to humans”²⁸—things that confound human systems of reckoning, such as black holes, climate change, or the Himalayan mountain range? Just as we might wonder how global humanity, at the present moment, might grapple with the enormity of climate change, we can also ask how human beings in the past (Buddhists, in particular) have measured the size of Mount Meru, calculated the number of years in a *kalpa*, or counted the “grains of sand in the Ganges River.”

While Morton’s notion of the hyperobject pertains to actual geophenomena (such as the number of fish in the Pacific Ocean), the strategy I am interested in here adds another dimension: How did Buddhists use large-scale phenomena such as mountains to point toward even-larger-scale notions of the immaterial, the divine, or the transcendent? And why did they rely upon the mundane human body as a necessary code for enacting this leap toward infinity? What happens when the human body itself is imagined on a nonhuman scale—the

cosmic scale of a mountain, the earth, or the entire universe? If the human body itself serves to chart that which is unfathomably beyond the human, then the human/nonhuman boundary itself is troubled and thrown into question.

Thus, while many of the contributions to this volume focus on specific physical sites and the agency exercised (or “affordances” provided) by the geological features of those sites, I see my own contribution as a more informal reflection that is meant only to foreground the particular geoaesthetic issue of *scale* and the practice of imagining the human body on a nonhuman scale as a way of charting that which is unfathomable, unknowable, and beyond the human ken. More specifically, I will do this by focusing on the image of the “flesh mountain” (*māṃsa-parvata*) as it appears in the *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka Sūtra*, a Mahāyāna *sūtra* that exists in Sanskrit, Tibetan, and Chinese.²⁹ My argument is simply that the move that I’ve been discussing—that is, imagining human bodies on a nonhuman scale, and more specifically, on the scale of unimaginably large mountains—might be seen as one of the organizing principles of this text and constitutes the text’s major strategy for pursuing its basic argument.

The essential argument of the *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka Sūtra* is one that we find in several other Mahāyāna *sūtras* as well. It is the argument that our buddha, the Buddha Śākyamuni, was by no means inferior to other buddhas simply because he presided over this impure Sahā world full of suffering. In fact, exactly the opposite is the case: our buddha is the *best* buddha because he had the greatest compassion and thus chose for himself an extremely impure buddha-field, so that he could save the very lowliest of beings (namely, us). Historically, this argument was necessitated by the fact that, as the Mahāyāna tradition developed, the growing notion of other buddhas, endowed with unimaginably long life spans and fantastic, paradisiacal buddha-fields, increasingly threatened to make our own buddha, Śākyamuni, seem rather shabby and inferior by comparison. By emphasizing our buddha’s great compassion in *choosing* to establish the dharma in the most unfortunate land of all, the argument for Śākyamuni’s superiority to all other buddhas could defensibly be made.

While the first two chapters of the *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka Sūtra* are somewhat unrelated to the rest of the text, this argument is made clear at the very beginning of chapter 3, when the bodhisattva Śāntimati asks the Buddha the following questions:

Blessed One, why do other lord buddhas have buddha-fields that are pure—buddha-fields that are free of impurities, free of the five defects, and full of good qualities, and where the bodhisattva-mahāsattvas are full of many excellent qualities and provided with all kinds of pleasures, and where even the names of Śrāvakas and Pratyekabuddhas do not exist, let alone the real thing? Why, Blessed One, did the Blessed One appear in a buddha-field with

the five defects (*pañca-kaṣāya*)? Why did you awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, full awakening when the defects of lifespan, eon, beings, views, and afflictions all existed? . . . Why did the Blessed One not adopt a pure buddha-field free of the five defects?³⁰

The Buddha's reply makes it clear that this is a result of his "great compassion":

Through the power of their vows, Son of Good Family, do bodhisattvas adopt pure buddha-fields, and through the power of their vows do they adopt impure buddha-fields. Son of Good Family, it is because they possess great compassion (*mahākaruṇā*) that bodhisattva-mahāsattvas adopt impure buddha-fields. How is that? It is because of the vow that I made that I have now appeared in such an inferior buddha-field characterized by the five defects. Listen well and take it to heart, Śāntimati, and I will explain.³¹

The remainder of the text then sets out to demonstrate the superiority of Śākyamuni's "great compassion" (*mahākaruṇa*) to the great compassion of other buddhas, including such well-known figures of the Mahāyāna pantheon as Amitābha and Akṣobhya. The *sūtra* derives its title from the fact that Śākyamuni's great compassion is compared to a white lotus (*puṇḍarīka*), which is perceived to be superior to all other kinds of flowers.

Here, however, it would seem that we have something of a problem: The *mahākaruṇa*, or great compassion of a fully awakened buddha, is, by definition, *universal*—it extends equally to all sentient beings alike and suffers no limitations in its object. But if great compassion is universal by definition, then how are we to demonstrate that one buddha's universal compassion is *more universal* than any other buddha's universal compassion? Just as mathematics has proven that there are different sizes and levels of *infinity*—even though such a thesis remains exceedingly difficult to grasp and can be established only by mathematically disproving its opposite³²—so we struggle to understand the very idea of a *more universal universality*. In the absence of our ability to make sense of it, I argue, the *sūtra* resorts to the technique of imagining human bodies on a nonhuman scale.

This begins to happen already in the remainder of chapter 3, which relates the previous lifetimes of Śākyamuni, Amitābha, Akṣobhya, and many other named buddhas, in a lifetime when all of them were ministers, princes, and kings living in the same realm, long ago, at the time of the former buddha Ratnagarbha. The former life of Śākyamuni at this time is a brahmin priest named Samudrareṇu, and the *sūtra* tells us that one day, Samudrareṇu has a highly auspicious dream that invokes the typical themes of the body containing the universe and the body filling up the universe. In his dream, Samudrareṇu sees a ray of light that illuminates as many buddha-fields as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River. Each one of the buddhas presiding over these

innumerable buddha-fields then presents Samudrareṇu with a lotus flower. Each lotus flower contains a sun disk, and each sun disk emits sixty million rays of light. All of these rays of light—that is, sixty million multiplied by the grains of sand in the Ganges River—then enter into Samudrareṇu’s mouth and are wholly contained within his body. “And within his own belly,” the text goes on, “he saw sixty hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of bodhisattvas seated cross-legged within lotuses and meditating.”³³ Far from containing just a single universe, then, the dream gives us a vision of innumerable galactic clusters of universes, all contained inside of a single body. And yet the dream equally involves the other trope—the trope of the body filling up the universe rather than containing the universe—for we are also told that Samudrareṇu “saw his body become a thousand *yojanas* in measure,” with “wreaths in the form of suns circling around his head” and “a parasol above him in the sky that reached as far as the world of Brahmā.”³⁴ Once again, we have a body that *contains* the universe and a body that *fills up* the universe. Both happen simultaneously; the ordinary constraints of space become utterly meaningless—and perhaps we are left with a feeling of the sublime and a sense of what it could mean for something to be *more universal than universality itself*. In fact, when Samudrareṇu goes to the buddha Ratnagarbha to have his dream interpreted, each element of the dream turns out to be a foreshadowing of some element of Samudrareṇu’s forthcoming glorious career as the Buddha Śākyamuni, who will surpass in his greatness all other buddhas, as indicated by his cosmic body. In contrast, the former lives of the other buddhas (such as Amitābha and Akṣobhya) also appear within Samudrareṇu’s dream, but in much more pedestrian forms (such as animals or ordinary men). These figures are interpreted by the buddha Ratnagarbha as representing the various lowly beings that Śākyamuni will one day save in his impure buddha-field, due to his great compassion. Already in chapter 3, then, the superiority of Śākyamuni’s great compassion over that of any other buddha is visualized and expressed through the imagery of human bodies on a nonhuman scale.

The same argument regarding Śākyamuni’s superiority is further pursued in chapter 4. In chapter 4, all the kings, princes, and ministers—who, again, in future lives will be Śākyamuni, Amitābha, Akṣobhya, and other buddhas—make their bodhisattva vows (*praṇidhāna*) and receive their predictions of future Buddhahood from the buddha Ratnagarbha. It is here that Samudrareṇu is compared to a white lotus (*puṇḍarīka*)—the finest of all flowers—due to the superiority of his compassion over that of any other bodhisattva, as reflected in his vow to preside over the most impure of buddha-fields and save the very lowliest of beings. Although the white lotus serves as a concrete visual image for the superiority of Śākyamuni’s compassion, it seems to do so less effectively than the imagery of human bodies on a nonhuman scale, for it fails to exercise our conceptual powers or our ability to form an internal mental image in quite

the same way. Perhaps it is no surprise, then, that highly exaggerated bodies once again take center stage in chapter 5.

Chapter 5 focuses on the same bodhisattva—that is, Samudrarenū, or the future Śākyamuni—relating six *jātaka* tales that illustrate how this bodhisattva gradually cultivated the perfection of generosity (*dāna-pāramitā*) over the course of many lifetimes. Two of these *jātakas* involve the theme of the “flesh mountain” (*māṃsa-parvata*): number two, in which the bodhisattva is born as King Durdhana, and number five, in which the bodhisattva is born as King Ambara. In both stories, the human body is reimagined as a grotesque and ever-replenishing mountain of flesh, as a concrete expression of our otherwise inchoate understanding of “perfect” generosity and compassion.

Let us look first at the story of King Ambara, which is the shorter and simpler of the two. King Ambara is a highly generous king who constantly gives away jewels, treasures, and all sorts of wealth. But when the people of his kingdom overhear the gods in heaven refer to him as Sarvaṃdada, or “All-Giver,” they decide to put him to the test: what does it mean to truly *give all*? Eventually, they ask him for—and he gives to them—his chief queen, his sons and daughters, the women of his harem, his kingship, his feet, his eyes, his ears, his penis, his flesh and blood, and his hands. At that point, his ministers say among themselves, “This witless fool has cut off all of his limbs and lost all of his royal sovereignty. What further use do we have for this hunk of flesh?”³⁵ They pick up whatever is left of him and toss it into the charnel ground. King Ambara himself relates what happens next:

Flies and mosquitoes came there and drank my blood, and dogs, jackals, and vultures came there and ate my flesh. Then, with a tranquil heart, I made a vow: “After sacrificing all of my royal sovereignty, I gave away my entire body, with its major and minor limbs, yet I did not feel regret for even a moment, nor did I give rise to anger. Because of this, let my wish be fulfilled: May this body of mine become a mountain of flesh! May whatever beings have flesh for food and blood for drink come eat my flesh and drink my blood! And, by the power of my vow, may my body continually grow . . . until it is a hundred thousand *yojanas* in height and five thousand *yojanas* in width.” So I satiated living beings there with my own flesh and blood for one thousand years. The birds and beasts to whom I offered my tongues devoured them—yet, by the power of my vow, one after another tongue appeared until there was a heap of them as big as Vulture Peak Mountain.³⁶

Here, we might return to Vernant’s idea of making use of a corporeal code but describing the resulting body in such an exaggerated manner that it transgresses the very code through which it has been expressed and suggests something wholly immaterial. Here, the unlimited scope of the bodhisattva’s generosity (*dāna-pāramitā*, the “perfection of generosity” or “generosity that

has gone to the other shore”) is conveyed through the image of an enormous and ever-growing mountain of flesh—a mountain roughly 900,000 miles tall and 45,000 miles wide (if we assume one *yojana* to be equivalent to approximately nine miles), or, if measured in terms of time rather than in terms of space, a mountain large enough to continually feed hungry beings for a period of one thousand years. Elements of the known cosmos are also included within this image, in the form of an ever-replenishing mountain of tongues equivalent in size to Vulture Peak. The mountain of tongues is represented in a corporeal code—the everyday code of ordinary, human tongues—yet through its size, multiplicity, and ever-replenishing nature, it transgresses the code itself and points us toward something transcendent. Space, time, and the cosmos come together in a vision whose very illogicality perhaps serves to push us beyond the realm of the paltry, limited, and deficient “flesh” and “tongues” that we as human beings are more familiar with. In this way, we perhaps gain a conceptual handle on what “perfect generosity” entails.

The same trope of the flesh mountain appears in an even more elaborate manner in the story of King Durdhana, yet another generous king. When his kingdom is stricken by famine and people are suffering from hunger and thirst, King Durdhana immediately climbs to the top of a mountain, makes a vow to transform himself into a giant mountain of flesh, and then throws himself off the mountainside. Lo and behold, the transformation occurs: “By the power of my vow, my body became as large as a mountain, a hundred *yojanas* in width and one *yojana* in height. Then, humans, birds, and beasts began to eat my flesh and blood. But, O Son of Good Family, as this body of mine was being consumed by living beings, it continued to grow every day until it was a hundred thousand *yojanas* in width and a thousand *yojanas* in height.”³⁷

Here, we have a mountain of flesh that *grows* over time and multiplies its size by one thousand, even as it is constantly being eaten and diminished. This failure to follow the ordinary laws of addition and subtraction provides a tangible and mathematical way to convey the idea of unlimited generosity—generosity that *never runs out*.

The theme of expansiveness in *size* is further reinforced and heightened by being combined with the theme of *multiple body parts*, for King Durdhana now continues, “Human heads appeared everywhere, with hair, ears, eyes, noses, lips, teeth, tongues, and many hundreds of mouths. And these mouths proclaimed in a human voice: ‘O Beings, take from me whatever you want! Eat my flesh! Drink my blood! Take my eyes, ears, noses, hair, lips, teeth, and tongues! Whoever wants to, in whichever way, and however much they need, should satisfy their bodies and fulfill their wishes!’”³⁸

Though it consists of manifold body parts, this chattering mountain of flesh still speaks as a single body; in fact, the multiple mouths refer to the other body parts as *my* eyes, ears, and so forth. Thus, the entire mountain of faces

and heads is still, in some sense, the single body of King Durdhana, who urges all beings to come and eat. Thus, we are reminded that the whole grotesque vision somehow relates to or expresses the inconceivable virtue of one individual being.

In completing this elaborate vision, one final step is taken when the gargantuan mountain of flesh is carefully correlated with various features of a much larger cosmological context:

They ate the flesh and drank the blood, and some took eyes, some took ears, some took noses, some took lips, and some took teeth, and having taken them, they departed. Yet by the power of my vow, one after another [body part] appeared—there was no diminution or loss of flesh. In fact, for ten thousand years, all of the people of Jambudvīpa, along with *yakṣas*, birds, and beasts, satisfied themselves on my body. And during those ten thousand years, I sacrificed as many eyes as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River, as much blood as there is water in the four oceans, enough flesh to equal the size of a thousand Mount Sumerus, enough tongues to equal the size of the Cakravāḍa mountains, enough ears to equal the size of Mount Yugandhara and Mount Meru, enough noses to equal the size of multiple Mount Sumerus, enough teeth to equal the size of this Vulture Peak Mountain, and enough of my own skin to equal the size of this entire world, the Sahā buddha-field.³⁹

Here, we find mention of multiple well-known features of the Buddhist cosmos, including the Sahā buddha-field (the particular cosmos in which we reside); Jambudvīpa (its southern continent); Vulture Peak Mountain (a well-known mountain within Jambudvīpa); Mount Meru or Sumeru (the enormous mountain that stands at the center of our cosmos and constitutes its axis mundi); Mount Yugandhara (the first of seven concentric golden mountain ranges that surround Mount Meru in the center); the four great oceans that lie outside of the seven mountain ranges, each inhabited by one of four continents; and the Cakravāḍa Mountains that lie at the edge of our cosmos and constitute its outer perimeter.⁴⁰ The particular way in which these features are invoked is also worthy of note and is commonly found throughout the Mahāyāna *sūtras*: each feature stands not for itself, as a physical reality, but instead serves as a mere signifier representing a very large number. Thus, when the king states that he gave away “enough teeth to equal the size of this Vulture Peak Mountain,” he is not referring to the literal mountain. Instead, he is merely invoking the vast size of the mountain to approximate the extremely large number of teeth given away. The other cosmological features are similarly invoked—including the ubiquitous “grains of sand in the Ganges River,” which appear so frequently in Mahāyāna *sūtras* in this manner that they seem to truly become a standard number.⁴¹

I interpret this as the bringing together of two different types of hyperobjects: we have the geological hyperobject of mountains, oceans, and very large rivers, which involve conceptions of space; and we have the mathematical hyperobject of extremely large numbers that theoretically extend up to infinity. The two of them are brought together in a way that perhaps multiplies our own sense of boundlessness—and yet the entire vision is expressed through the corporeal code of the ordinary, bounded human body. Multiple mind-bending alternatives for conceptually grasping the bodhisattva’s “perfect generosity”—or the Buddha Śākyamuni’s superior compassion—are thus offered to exercise our limited human imaginations.

The category of *time*, however, appears here in a rather disappointing form, for the mountain of flesh is said to endure for only “ten thousand years”—a fairly unimpressive span within the context of Buddhist cosmology, or within the context of the “deep time” invoked by geology. In many other Mahāyāna sūtras, however, definitively nonhuman scales of time are similarly invoked to achieve the same effect. I am thinking in particular of chapter 16 of the *Lotus Sūtra*, famous for introducing the new Mahāyāna understanding of the Buddha Śākyamuni’s lifespan—that is, the idea that he didn’t actually pass away into nirvāṇa at the age of eighty, as people think that he did, but that in fact he has been present in this world for many, many eons, and his lifespan is virtually *eternal*. In order to convey just how much time has passed since he first attained buddhahood, the Buddha provides the following analogy:

Suppose there were a man who ground five hundreds of thousands [of] myriads of *koṭis* of *nayutas* of incalculable great manifold cosmos[es] into particles. While passing through five hundred thousands of myriads of *koṭis* of *nayutas* of incalculable lands to the east, he dropped just a single particle; and in this way he continued to drop the particles as he went towards the east, until they were all gone. . . . Suppose all of these worlds, whether or not a particle was left in them, were reduced to particles, and each particle represented a kalpa. The period of time since I became a Buddha would exceed this by hundreds of thousands of myriads of *koṭis* of *nayutas* of incalculable kalpas.⁴²

Once again, we find here a mixing of hyperobjects, as vast spans of time are signified through unimaginable expanses of space and a multiplicity of separate worlds. In this way, space, time, and numbers all come together to indicate the lifespan of one particular buddha-body. As J. Douglas Wolfe has observed in a short essay on this passage, the Buddha here “speaks of time and space as equivalent and inseparable values in calculations on the cosmic scale” and thus employs “a frame of reference firmly grounded in a four-dimensional time-space continuum”⁴³—somewhat akin to that required by Einstein’s theories of relativity. Just as the Buddha’s lifespan appears to be finite yet so long that it approaches eternity, so “modern science tells us that the universe we live

in is finite, yet unbounded.”⁴⁴ In one of Einstein’s famous thought experiments, one who travels on a beam of light toward the edge of the finite universe will *never* reach his destination, since time itself will slow down as he approaches the speed of light. Thus, the universe is physically finite—yet also completely unbounded. How is such a thing even possible? “The reason the relativistic universe seems so strange,” Wolfe observes, “is that its scale lies far outside the daily activities of human beings.”⁴⁵

To imagine such unimaginably nonhuman scales not merely in terms of mountains, rivers, and the cosmos but in terms of the *human body itself* strikes me as a poignantly human endeavor. When Buddhists in ancient India struggled to understand the enormity of *universal* compassion, the extent of *perfect* generosity, or the supremacy of buddhahood itself, how did they do so? In the *Karuṇapūṇḍarīka Sūtra*, they first turned to the concrete physical idiom of *eating* and *food*, and then imagined an enormous, multiplicitous, and talking *mountain of flesh* that would never run out or be depleted—a grotesquely abundant and satisfying meal that perhaps approximates the immaterial, the divine, the transcendent, that which lies beyond the human ken.

NOTES

1. Vernant, “Dim Body.”
2. Ibid., 23.
3. Ibid., 43.
4. “Top 10 Tallest Statues in the World,” TMW, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://themysteriousworld.com>.
5. Alan Taylor, “Photos: The 15 Tallest Statues in the World,” *Atlantic*, October 31, 2018, <https://www.theatlantic.com>.
6. “Top 20 Tallest Statues in the World,” Travelogy India, accessed June 20, 2019, <https://www.travelogyindia.com>.
7. The tallest Buddhist statue in the world, according to all three lists, is the Spring Temple Buddha in Henan, China, which is 153 meters tall.
8. Montagnon et al., *Buddhism*.
9. Montagnon et al., *Buddhism*. Several copies of the film can be found on YouTube; the scene in question occurs approximately ten minutes in.
10. Eleven-headed (*ekādaśamukha*) Avalokiteśvara and one-thousand-armed (*sahasrabhuja*) Avalokiteśvara are both popular manifestations of this bodhisattva.
11. For a comprehensive study of the origins of the “multiplicity convention” in Indian art (that is, the practice of giving images multiple body parts), see Srinivasan, *Many Heads*. Srinivasan’s study is long and complex, but ultimately she finds the origins of the multiplicity convention (going all the way back to “thousand-headed, thousand-eyed, and thousand-footed” Puruṣa in *Rg Veda* 10.90) to lie in the theme of cosmic creation.

She also interprets early representations of the multiplicity convention as “theological statements” that attempt to convey such themes as the “grandeur of the cosmic creator, his extraordinary powers, [and] the unfathomable mystery of creating many from the One” (1997, 13). Srinivasan’s conclusions thus accord with the general idea that multiple body parts are used as a means of concretely representing that which is unfathomable and beyond the human scale.

12. In actual fact, the main hall of Sanjūsangen-dō contains 1,001 images of Kannon, since the main image is distinct from its one thousand replicas.

13. Huntington, *Creating the Universe*, 54.

14. *Ibid.*, 57.

15. *Bhagavad Gīta* 7.5 (Miller, *Bhagavad-Gita*, 71).

16. *Ibid.*, 7.6 (*ibid.*, 72).

17. *Ibid.*, 10.3 (*ibid.*, 89).

18. *Ibid.*, 10.8 (*ibid.*, 90).

19. *Ibid.*, 10.12 (*ibid.*, 90).

20. *Ibid.*, 10.40 and 10.42 (*ibid.*, 94–95).

21. *Ibid.*, 11.3, emphasis added (*ibid.*, 97).

22. *Ibid.*, 11.20 (*ibid.*, 100).

23. *Ibid.*, 11.13 (*ibid.*, 99).

24. Vernant, “Dim Body,” 39.

25. *Bhagavad Gīta* 11.16 and 11.23 (Miller, *Bhagavad-Gita*, 99 and 101).

26. *Ibid.*, 11.8 (*ibid.*, 98).

27. Vernant, “Dim Body,” 7.

28. Morton, *Hyperobjects*, 1.

29. I rely on Isshi Yamada’s Sanskrit edition (see Yamada, *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka*), which is based on six modern Nepalese manuscripts, compared to the Tibetan translation (late eighth or early ninth century CE) and two Chinese translations (Taishō 157 and 158, both translated in the fifth century CE).

30. Yamada, *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka*, 2:51.

31. *Ibid.*, 2:51–52.

32. As I am not mathematically inclined, I do not really understand all of the details—but for one basic explanation of the different “sizes” of infinity, see John Matson, “Strange but True: Infinity Comes in Different Sizes,” *Scientific American*, July 19, 2007, <https://www.scientificamerican.com>.

33. Yamada, *Karuṇāpuṇḍarīka*, 2:66.

34. *Ibid.*, 2:66.

35. *Ibid.*, 2:381.

36. *Ibid.*, 2:381–382.

37. *Ibid.*, 2:364.

38. *Ibid.*

39. *Ibid.*, 2:365.

40. For a clear and coherent explanation of the standard features of the Buddhist cosmos, as presented in the single most influential source (Vasubandhu’s *Abhidharmakośa*), see Huntington, *Creating the Universe*, 30–46. Especially helpful are Huntington’s drawings (including figure 1.8 on page 33, and figure 1.9 on page 36).

41. A similar point is made by Gerald Doherty in his analysis of the *Diamond Sūtra* (“Form Is Emptiness”). Doherty argues that the sūtra consistently uses language in such a way that “words take on meaning from their relationship to other words in the system and not from any intrinsic relationship to extra-linguistic entities” (120). Citing a passage involving several such signifiers (including the “grains of sand in the Ganges River”), Doherty notes that within this passage, “the term ‘Ganges River’ is clearly not some object represented by language but purely a means of signification, one of a ‘galaxy of signifiers’ which connote nothing but the absolute indeterminacy of their objects of reference” (121). In this way, the *Diamond Sūtra* works to undermine our inherent belief in the relationship between the signified and the referent.

42. Kubo and Yuyama, *Lotus Sutra*, 235–236.

43. Wolfe, “Lotus Sutra,” 163, 164.

44. Ibid., 164.

45. Ibid., 162.

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CHAPTER 4

Movements and Patterns in Embodied Landscapes for Art

Eric Huntington

There are many ways to theorize relationships between the vast earth and immediate human experience. One could focus on how processes that exceed human scales of space and time can be perceived, such as the ways in which the slowly changing courses of rivers become discernible in patterns of erosion and sediment. Conversely, one might consider human interventions in the landscape that transcend the full perception of even their creators, such as ancient geoglyphs that are fully visible only from the sky. This chapter examines yet another possibility, exploring how even aesthetic objects and geographies that are meaningfully distinct can redefine each other through spatial movements and visual patterns. For example, a sacred sculpture from one shrine might be relocated to another in order to create a relationship between its new home and the place where it no longer rests.¹ Alternatively, a stationary map on a hiking trail could depict a small icon of itself within its own portrayal of the larger landscape, and by casting itself as a separate object within that geography (rather than merely as a projection of it) actually help viewers better understand their own location.² In these cases, artworks and geographies are capable of transformative connection precisely because they are discrete. The ways that these artworks and landscapes relate might be understood as geoaesthetic principles that tie larger landscapes to human perceptions. Examples from Buddhist traditions clearly show such principles of relationship between artwork and landscape, including the relocation of artworks through movements

of approach and internalization and the repetition of images through patterns of iteration and fractalization.

All the examples presented here also crucially involve the human body. Buddhist traditions, like some other religions, employ the body as a sophisticated framework for characterizing geographic spaces, often specifically in relation to artistic objects.³ This viewing of landscape in terms of bodily spaces is itself an aesthetic theorization of the environment, separate from any individual artwork, providing visual and material principles for meaningfully structuring space. The examples in this chapter have been selected to highlight the body as a focal point of geoaesthetics and to illustrate a range of possible relationships between body, landscape, and art, including the different kinds of bodies that can be involved, the different geographic scales they can cover, and the different relationships between artworks and landscapes they can evoke. The first two cases focus on the body of the historical Buddha as a space for artwork, first during his life and then after his death, in the form of relics. The last two cases instead address the bodies of other powerful beings that are understood to contain or be equivalent to landscapes in which artworks play defining roles. Comparing these diverse examples helps isolate the particular movements and patterns at play. The first and last cases, taken together, demonstrate the transformative power of relocations that internalize objects into landscapes defined by bodies. The second and third cases show how iteration and fractalization can create networks and hierarchies of geographically distributed sites.

An Image Approaches Its Body

This first example, in being an origin story of an image of the Buddha during his lifetime, is sometimes taken as a paradigm for thinking about images in general. While landscape per se is not at stake, the movement of the image through the space around the Buddha plays an important role in some versions of the story, and similar movements become directly relevant to geography in later examples. In this case, the movement appears in both artwork and text to be a catalyst for validating the image as an effective portrait of the teacher.

A Gandhāran image (second or third century) depicts this very scene in which an artistic image of the Buddha is being brought to the living Buddha for approval (fig. 4.1).⁴ At the center of the composition, the large Buddha sits on a throne in a teaching posture. The standing figure closest to the Buddha holds in his hands a careful miniature replica of the Buddha, complete with monastic robes, meditation posture, *uṣṇīṣa*, and halo.⁵ Thinking of different possible spatial contexts for artwork, this Gandhāran relief exhibits perhaps the most fundamental of all, the hands of a human being. Humans, after all, are the creators and patrons of artworks, touching and holding images before they are completed or installed in



Figure 4.1 Peshawar Museum #1534. Photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art.

any other location. Here, the small replica of the Buddha is also being brought for validation into the Buddha's presence, another significant spatial context. Indeed, the Buddha does not seem to look at the image or touch it to imbue it with authenticity.⁶ Rather, in this depiction at least, the image's transportation toward the Buddha appears to be the crux of the scene.

Evidence for the importance of this motion-toward can also be found in textual accounts of the creation of the first images of the Buddha, although not universally.⁷ In the earliest available text, the *Numerical Discourses* (Skt. *Ekottarāgama*, translated into Chinese in 384–385 CE), King Udayana, after commissioning the sculpture, “took the sandalwood image to [the Buddha] and asked what reward he would gain from having made it.” This account may indeed accord most closely with the Gandhāran relief, which seems to depict nothing more or less than a king carrying an image to the Buddha. The Buddha responds that the king “would enjoy a life of health and strength, and would in the end be reborn as a Lokapāla,” apparently focusing more on the benefits to the patron than the significance of a new representation of his own body.⁸

The next two stories available chronologically, both from the early fifth century, significantly alter the narrative, having the image move under its own power to greet the Buddha. The version in the *Sūtra on the Ocean-Like Samādhi of the Visualization of the Buddha* (Ch. *Guanfo sanmei hai jing*) is most elaborate: “Borne by an elephant to the place where Śākyamuni was descending the triple stair from

heaven, [the image] dismounted just as if it had been a real Buddha, walked in the air while flowers rained from under its feet and rays of light were emitted; and so welcomed its double.”⁹ Faxian’s *Record of Buddhist Kingdoms* (Ch. *Foguo ji*) similarly has the image move autonomously toward the Buddha, prompting the Buddha to establish it explicitly as his successor: “When Buddha on his return entered the *vihāra*, this image immediately left its place, and came forth to meet him. Buddha said to it, ‘Return to your seat. After I have attained to *parinirvāṇa*, you will serve as a pattern to the four classes of my disciples,’ and on this the image returned to its seat.”¹⁰ Some later authors omit the traversal of space, including Xuanzang (seventh century), who merely states that “when the Tathāgata returned to earth from heaven, the sandalwood image stood up to greet the World-honored One.”¹¹ Other traditions maintain the spatial move, however, explaining that “it is said that when the Buddha returned from the heaven of the divine beings the sandalwood statue took six steps forward to greet him.”¹²

There are multiple possible explanations for the significance of this motion-toward, not necessarily mutually exclusive.¹³ Insofar as the image is apprehended as equivalent to a living being, it may simply behave as a devotee who goes out to greet the approaching Buddha as a sign of respect.¹⁴ The Buddha’s subsequent instruction to the image to return to its seat thus counteracts the subordination to him implied by its motion of approach, helping establish the image as a proper substitute for him. Commissioned images of the Buddha, however, must also necessarily be understood as manufactured objects, since it is precisely their fabrication that generates merit for their patrons, a point clearly articulated in the *Numerical Discourses* story as well as in the *Scripture on the Production of Buddha Images* (Ch. *Zuo fo xingxiang jing*, translated into Chinese around the first century CE).¹⁵ While other manufactured objects, such as the Buddha’s robes and alms bowl, are revered because of the Buddha’s direct use or touch, this image of the Buddha is not.¹⁶ Rather, the artwork’s motion toward the Buddha helps sanctify this particular object, a representation of the very body that is approached. The image of the Buddha thus operates in spaces between the patron and the Buddha in multiple registers simultaneously. Conceived as an intermediary between the patron and the Buddha, it functions as a substitute for veneration during the Buddha’s absence. More literally, it is the object’s actual movement in the physical space between the patron and the Buddha that validates it as a sacred object.

Representing a Fractalized Geography of Relics

After death, the body of the Buddha creates places for artwork in many new ways. Most obviously, his relics are interred inside stūpas, reliquary monuments that are both aesthetic objects in the landscape and substrates for numerous figural carvings. Perhaps no objects exemplify this relationship better than the drum

slab reliefs from Andhra Pradesh that depict stūpas as devotional spaces covered in art. Given that stūpas are understood as monuments distributed throughout Buddhist geography, the replication of such images of stūpas on the sides of real stūpas can work as a fractalizing pattern to create compelling network relationships between the artworks, relics, and other sites in the landscape.

A third-century drum slab from Amarāvati illustrates how rich the artwork on the great stūpa might have appeared (fig. 4.2), including the same kinds of slabs, roundels, and structures that have been found in the archaeological record.¹⁷ Dominating the composition is the dome of a stūpa that is covered and surrounded by images. At the bottom center, a gateway opens onto a sculpture of a Buddha. In front of this sculpture and outside the walls in the foreground, human figures appear in acts of devotion to the stūpa and its artworks, mirrored by celestial figures above in the sky. With such visitors navigating around arrays of images, the stūpa seems to become not only a singular object in a



Figure 4.2 Amarāvati drum slab, British Museum 1880,0709.72. Photograph courtesy of the British Museum, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0, cropped and color-adjusted by the author.

particular place but also a small landscape unto itself.¹⁸ Furthermore, images like this one would have encircled the drum of the stūpa at Amarāvātī, a repetition that would have thoroughly objectified the stūpa as a centerpiece of devotion.¹⁹ Circumambulating visitors would have encountered these images of stūpa worship physically between themselves and the main stūpa, mediating their relationship with it and perhaps even elevating its status compared to similar monuments by giving it a sense of multiplicity rather than singularity.²⁰

This repetition is further iterated to a third level, with smaller images of stūpas appearing on the stūpas depicted in the drum slabs that would have appeared on the sides of the actual stūpa (fig. 4.3). A sculpture from Nāgārjunakoṇḍa places such a small image of stūpa worship on the face of the āyaka platform of the larger stūpa depicted in the slab (fig. 4.4). As further evidence of the placement of such slabs around real stūpas, the preceding figure from Amarāvātī even contains small representations of drum slab images of stūpas ringing the sides of the central stūpa of the relief, only partially visible at the lowest level of images behind the outer walls (fig. 4.5). This nested

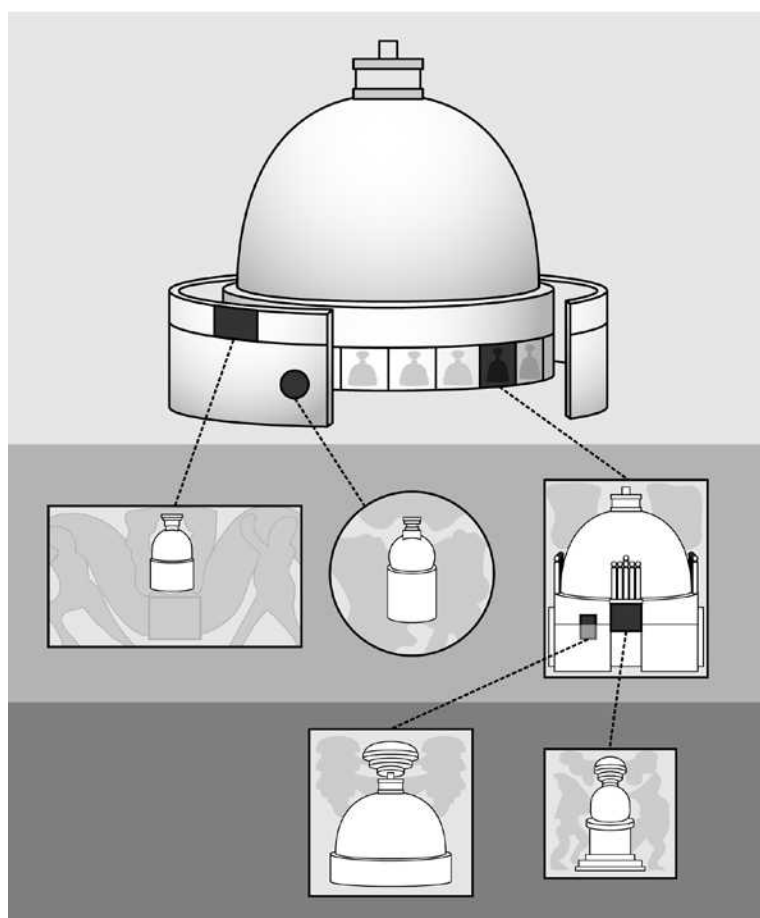


Figure 4.3 Iterations of *stūpa-upon-stūpa-upon-stūpa* imagery. Diagram by the author.



Figure 4.4 Nāgārjunakoṇḍa drum slab, Metropolitan Museum 28.31. Left photograph courtesy of the Metropolitan Museum, CC0 1.0, cropped by author. Right photograph by the author.



Figure 4.5 Amarāvati drum slab, British Museum 1880,0709.72. Left photograph courtesy of the British Museum, CC BY-NC-SA 4.0, cropped and color-adjusted by author. Right photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art, adjusted and highlighted by the author.



replication begins to fractalize space, creating a self-reflexiveness that allows the viewer to shift perspectives between multiple scales and locations. A visitor to the site can easily imagine themselves inside the images they are seeing, which portray spaces just like the ones they are in.²¹ Prompted by this first step of transposition, they might further imagine themselves inside the images depicted within those images, or at similar locations elsewhere.

Indeed, although fractalization per se requires that all the nested images be somehow similar (if in no other way than in being stūpas), differences in the images suggest that they may also simultaneously be understood to evoke a more diverse network of sites distributed across the landscape. How this network relates to real geography is hard to specify, because it is often difficult to determine whether these images represent actual regional sites, historical narratives, or idealized types.²² Some sculptures around historical stūpas, however, have been identified as depicting other known stūpas, either real or from narrative.²³ Some representations of stūpas also portray them as being decorated with images of other, non-stūpa sites, such as a shrine around a bodhi tree (fig. 4.6; note the tree at the bottom left of the image). Going beyond the



Figure 4.6 Nāgārjunakoṇḍa drum slab. Photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art.

elevation of the stūpa as a sacred object, such images suggest that reliefs of other sites on a monument might connect it to larger networks of different types of shrines across a landscape.²⁴ Amarāvātī has previously been described as a “second-order” pilgrimage site that was important not for being the site of an event from the Buddha’s life but for depicting scenes of those events in its imagery.²⁵ The same logic can surely be extended beyond depictions of historical narratives to depictions of places and monuments that might even have existed simultaneously in other locales. In depicting stūpas upon stūpas upon stūpas, a single monument can fractalize artworks, relics, and landscapes that are distributed across space and time into a complex yet readily accessible network of Buddhist geography.



Figure 4.7 Avalokiteśvara in a niche at Alchi. Photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art.

A Bodhisattva Dressed in Landscape

Shifting to examples from much later periods of Buddhism, differences in doctrine, medium, and idiom are obvious, but comparable geoaesthetic processes and patterns remain relevant. A sculptural image of the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara at Alchi (thirteenth century) wears a *dhoti* (lower garment) painted with depictions of buildings in a local landscape, including numerous temples that contain images of deities (fig. 4.7). Unlike some famous depictions of geographies on full-body figures, this landscape covers only Avalokiteśvara’s lower half, yet as in those other figures, the landscape becomes unified by being placed on a singular body.²⁶ Where in the previous case the multiplicity of stūpa images creates an expanded sense of landscape, here the circumscription of images by a

body suggests a more coherent geographic identity, but some senses of network and iteration also appertain.

One connection between art and landscape is immediately evident in the painting: the depiction of shrine images as the centerpieces of local architecture amid landscape elements. The convention of evoking shrines by depicting their main images is not unusual and appears also in earlier Pāla manuscripts.²⁷ While the Pāla manuscripts typically contain many separate paintings of individual shrines in isolation, this painting at Alchi depicts some shrines in spatial relationships with each other and specific landscape features. A shrine to Tārā atop a mountain, for example, apparently relates to another site at the base of that mountain and easily contrasts with another shrine to Tārā near a body of water (figs. 4.8 and 4.9).

While the inclusion of landscape elements adds some geographic coherence to the painting, its placement on the body of Avalokiteśvara unifies it in a different way, especially when viewed in the context of related monumental statues. The Avalokiteśvara figure is one of three similar sculptures in this shrine,



Figure 4.8 Detail of Avalokiteśvara's *dhoti*. Photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art.



Figure 4.9 Detail of Avalokiteśvara's *dhoti*. Photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art.

the other two representing Mañjuśrī, wearing a *dhoti* covered by siddhas, and Maitreya, wearing a *dhoti* covered by scenes from the life of a buddha. The clear coherence of the imagery on the other two bodhisattvas supports an interpretation of the landscape on Avalokiteśvara as a singular, meaningful piece.²⁸ Given the difficulties in identifying the individual buildings, however, scholars have suggested widely variant interpretations of their significance.²⁹ Regardless, the incorporation of the landscape into the body of Avalokiteśvara unifies it more completely than the scattered relational elements depicted in the painting.

Aside from the bodily unification of the landscape it portrays, the sculpture of Avalokiteśvara also conveys a sense of iteration, for it is also an image in a shrine in a landscape, similar to the depictions it contains (fig. 4.10).³⁰ This iterative relationship bears some similarity to the fractalization in the Andhra stūpa reliefs and may serve similarly to aggrandize the Avalokiteśvara image as a collection of other images and sites or to transpose the viewer's perspective between different scales of space. Other regional monumental images, such as those at Mangyu, do not feature similar landscape imagery on their painted *dhotis*, making the Avalokiteśvara already somewhat unusual.³¹

While related forms of Tārā and Avalokiteśvara do appear in the Avalokiteśvara *dhoti* painting, none of the shrines contains the same form as the overall sculpture, inhibiting a complete identification of the embodied figure with the depicted ones, or perhaps even enforcing a sense of the hierarchical superiority of the embodied sculpture—complicated, admittedly, by the depiction of an image of a buddha, theoretically higher in status than the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara at the bottom center of the *dhoti* (see fig. 4.10). The precise relationships between these different figures are thus not entirely clear. In any case, the iterative appearance of images in shrines in a landscape painted on an image in a shrine in the landscape redoubles the idea that the landscape is defined by such images, both in their being centerpieces of shrines (as depicted in the painting) and in their power to characterize the landscape by themselves (as the landscape is contained on the body of such an image).

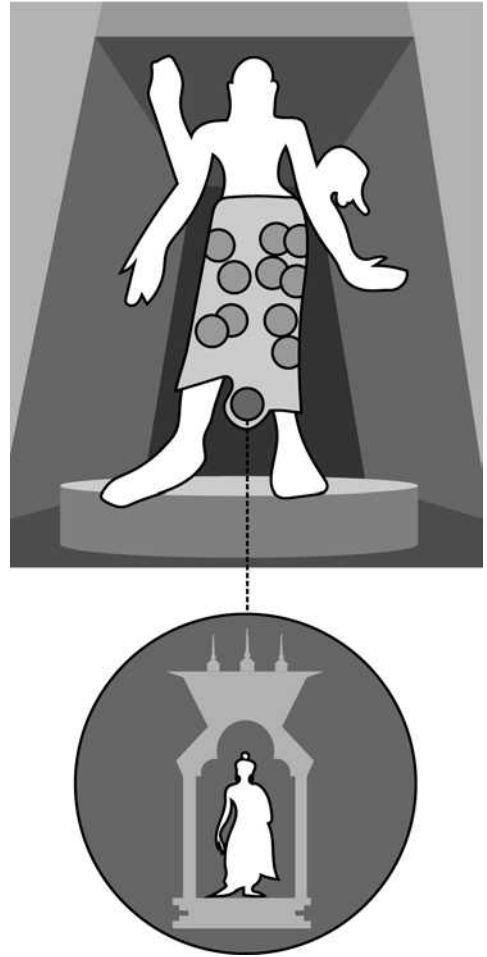


Figure 4.10 Alchi Avalokiteśvara as an image in a shrine bearing depictions of images in shrines, including a shrine with a buddha image. Diagram by the author.

Importing Images into the Body of Tibet

The embodiment of landscape is perhaps nowhere more clear than in the final case presented here, and as such, the geoaesthetic processes are perhaps even more distinctly multilayered. In narratives of King Songtsen Gampo (Tib. *Srong btsan sgam po*) subjugating Tibet and importing Buddhism, the landscape has been described and depicted as a demoness (Tib. *srin mo*) to be tamed. This famous story has been studied in detail for issues related to the political geography of the past,³² the gendered identity of the landscape,³³ the violence of subjugation,³⁴ the use of Chinese geomancy,³⁵ and more. Paintings of Tibet as a demoness (fig. 4.11) clearly express a unification of the landscape in the bodily form of the autochthonous figure suppressed under Buddhist architecture. Beyond such visual representations of the landscape as such, however, there are other significant roles for art in this story. Despite not being depicted in the painting, the process of internalizing specific sculptures into the landscape of Tibet is central to the narrative, and sculptures play key roles in defining historical characters and establishing major temples in the landscape-as-body. In some literary versions, at least, this story is as much about the power of artworks to create a Buddhist geography as it is about anything else.

This is especially true of one influential version of this story in *The Mirror Illuminating the Royal Genealogies* (Tib. *rGyal rabs gsal ba'i me long*), a Tibetan text of the fourteenth century that well postdates the events it narrates.³⁶ Other classic sources are less vociferous on the subject but still give images prominence.³⁷ *The Mirror Illuminating*, for its part, might be said to portray the demonically embodied landscape as little more than a place for artworks and their shrines to exist. Indeed, the identification of the landscape with a demoness and its subsequent suppression are directly occasioned by bringing sacred images into Tibet and the subsequent desire to make temples for them. This story of the demoness thus precisely inverts the stories of the creation of the image of the Buddha during his lifetime given above: rather than a mundane image being empowered by entering the space of the Buddha, several already-sacred images help disempower the demonic body of the Tibetan landscape when they are imported. Accompanying the reversal of status of artworks and bodies in these two cases is a reversal of the role of landscape, in the former being barely present and in the latter being the ultimate subject of the conquest narrative.

The story of the demoness in the *Mirror Illuminating* begins when King Songtsen Gampo, an emanation of Avalokiteśvara, decides to help convert Tibet to Buddhism by importing images of the Buddha from China and Nepal through marriage to two princesses from those regions, Wencheng (Tib. *rGya bza' kong jo*) and Bhṛkuṭī (Tib. *Bal bza' khri btsun*). Remarkably, this decision is motivated by another imported statue, a self-arisen sandalwood sculpture



Figure 4.11 The Tibetan landscape as a demoness. Adapted from Sørensen, Hazod, and Gyalbo, *Thundering Falcon*, fig. 94.

of Avalokiteśvara that the king brought from southern India, which emanates rays of light that lead him to the two princesses:

Next, the emanational created king again thought: “A statue of Bhagavat (Buddha) is installed in India, another is installed in Nepal[,] and one is installed in China, and in each of these countries where these three idols are installed the teachings of Mahāyāna are found diffused, so what can I do to fetch any of these three statues to further the spread of the teachings of the Mahāyāna here in this snow-capped country?” He therefore offered up a prayer to the autogenous sandalwood statue and two rays of light emanated from its heart, one of which went to the east, and one which went westwards.³⁸

After extensive nuptial negotiations, the two princesses agree to marry, bringing with them the images in question. The importance of these images to the marriages is reinforced when Wencheng’s arrival is announced by a messenger: “We Tibetan ministers are now about to arrive after having brought along the [statue of the] Jo-bo Shākya and the princess Kong-jo, etc.”³⁹

The two key images brought by the princesses, statues of Akṣobhyavajra and Jowo Śākyamuni, are eventually housed in the Trulnang (Tib. *’Phrul snang*) and Ramoche (Tib. *Ra mo che*) temples; but the construction of the former is difficult, prompting the scene in which the Tibetan landscape is described as a demoness. Wencheng gives a geomantic reading and “reckon(s) this snow-clad kingdom to have the shape of a rākṣasī-demoness resting on her back.”⁴⁰ In fact, the entire landscape is filled with positive and negative factors, but in order to quell the demoness in particular, temples are constructed on sites identified as her shoulders and hips, elbows and knees, and hands and feet, forming three

concentric frames around her heart-blood, the lake in Lhasa where Bhṛkuṭī's Trulnang temple is to be built.⁴¹ The Jowo Śākyamuni brought by Wencheng complementarily quells *nāgas* at Ramoche, so the two images actually subjugate autochthonous forces through two different ritual paradigms.⁴²

Other images also play significant roles in the construction and completion of Trulnang, especially in overcoming obstacles and protecting the project. When Bhṛkuṭī first attempts and fails construction at another site, Songtsen Gampo's tutelary image emanates a ray of light toward the correct location on which to build. When construction problems arise, a new sculpture of Avalokiteśvara produces another ray of light to defeat the demons intent on damaging the temple. As the edifice is further constructed, local deities clamor to have sculptures made of them, too, so that they can also become its protectors. For example, "a Nāgarāja . . . requested: ' . . . I shall protect [the temple]! Please make an image of me [to be installed in your temple]!'"⁴³ Finally, Trulnang's construction is completed with the installation of the king's self-arisen image of Avalokiteśvara in the last empty shrine, upon which miraculous signs appear.

This story of the Tibetan landscape as a demoness thus captures several distinct relationships between body, landscape, and art. On the one hand, paintings of the Tibetan landscape as a demoness reveal one pattern, a way of visualizing geography in terms of a demonic body whose anatomy provides a structure for shrines to suppress it. On the other hand, narrative histories highlight not only structures but also processes, such as the internalizing movements of sculptures into the landscape-body that help transform it into a Buddhist space (not to mention the creation of new sculptures within the same landscape to do much the same).



The cases above reveal different combinations of bodies, landscapes, and artworks transformed by geoaesthetic movements and patterns. An image of the Buddha is validated by its approach toward the body that it represents. A reliquary stūpa covered by images of stūpas upon images of stūpas fractalizes a single site to suggest transpositions across a network of other sites in the larger landscape. The Avalokiteśvara sculpture at Alchi unifies a landscape of images in shrines within its body even as it iterates an image in a shrine in a landscape, prompting new consideration of the power of such images to define their surroundings. The landscape of Tibet viewed as a demoness is not only unified as a body in painting but also suppressed by the importation and installation of specific sculptures and shrines across its anatomy.

These four examples also reveal the diversity of bodies, landscapes, and artworks that can participate in geoaesthetic processes and patterns. In terms of bodies, the cases center on a living buddha, fragmented relics, a bodhisattva, and a demoness. Landscapes are correlated to these bodies at scales of

the individual person, architectural sites, local regions, and an empire. And diverse artworks play significant roles, including perhaps the first manufactured sculpture of the Buddha, adornments on stūpas, local shrine icons, and self-arisen images. Looking at these varied examples together, one sees the broader potential of sanctifying through movements of approach and internalization and of networking through iteration and fractalization—powerful geo-aesthetic processes and patterns for relating body, landscape, and art.

NOTES

1. See, for example, Davis, *Lives of Indian Images*, 64–65.
2. This realization of a distinction between map and landscape differs from the dissolution of boundaries between material object and image that is also at play. See Wu Hung, *Double Screen*, 126–127.
3. Cf. Eck, *India*, 25–28; Meister, “Vāstupuruṣamaṇḍalas.”
4. Rowland, “Note on the Invention,” 184.
5. In the larger context of Buddhist history, this first replica of the Buddha may also be understood as an iteration, since the Udayana image eventually becomes a model for other copies, which themselves become models for other copies, spreading across Asia. See Shen, *Authentic Replicas*, 137–149.
6. The Buddha’s apparent dissociation has also been noted in other scenes of Gandhāran sculpture. Kooij, “No Sign,” 47.
7. For good summaries of the literature, see DeCaroli, *Image Problems*, 154–156; Soper, *Literary Evidence*, 259–273; Carter, *Mystery*, 6–16. Scholars disagree over which account correlates best to the Gandhāran relief, so several different versions may be considered, focusing on concepts of space. Carter, *Mystery*, 8n24.
8. Soper, *Literary Evidence*, 259.
9. *Ibid.*, 260. Yamabe, “Sūtra.”
10. Legge, *Fā-Hien’s Record*, 57; see also the *Biographies of Eminent Monks*, quoted in Faure, “Buddhist Icon,” 782.
11. Li, *Great Tang Record*, 139–140.
12. Dagyab, *Tibetan Religious Art*, 22.
13. On the importance of decreasing distance, see also Rotman, “Power of Proximity,” 53.
14. For examples, see Rhi, “Gandhāran Images,” 241–242. Later kings also go out to meet images of the Buddha traveling in festival processions (151–152).
15. Sharf, “Scripture on Production,” 262.
16. Cf. Rotman, “Power of Proximity,” 55.
17. Early digging at Amarāvati was not preservative, so knowledge of its relics is limited, but some relics and reliquaries have been described. In literature, stūpas are generally understood as containing relics of the Buddha. Kinnard, “Amaravati as Lens,” 82–83; Becker, *Shifting Stones*, 42nn40–41; Skilling, “Caitya,” 31.
18. Becker, *Shifting Stones*, 10, 25–40.

19. Knox, *Amaravati*, 23; cf. Becker, *Shifting Stones*, 23–143.
20. Such images related to ritual could also imply a continual simulation of performance even when no practitioners are present. See Wang, “Ritual Practice”
21. See Wu, *Double Screen*, 126–127.
22. See examples at Becker, *Shifting Stones*, 42–43; Knox, *Amaravati*, 23, 52, 106; Stone, *Buddhist Art*, 47.
23. Stone, *Buddhist Art*, 26, 47.
24. Cf. Robert Brown’s discussion of visual patterns creating sacred space in “Nature as Utopian Space.”
25. Kinnard, “Amaravati as Lens,” 98–99.
26. See, for example, Howard, *Imagery*, plates 1 and 16.
27. See Cambridge Digital Library, “Prajñāpāramitāstotra”; Kim, *Receptacle of the Sacred*, 61.
28. Goepper, *Alchi*, 51–52.
29. Ibid.; N. Tsering, *Alchi*, 15; Ham, *Alchi*, 165–182. Related attempts have also been made to identify the symbolism of the other two bodhisattvas with the images on their *dhotis* and all three bodhisattvas together as a set. Goepper, *Alchi*, 46–48.
30. For more on the architectural forms as iterative in and of themselves, see Hardy, “Kashmiri Temples,” 282–284.
31. Linrothe, “Skirting the Bodhisattva.”
32. Aris, *Bhutan*, 3–41; Blondeau and Gyatso, “Lhasa,” 15–25.
33. Gyatso, “Down with the Demoness.”
34. Marko, “Civilising Woman the Demon.”
35. Mills, “Re-assessing the Supine Demoness.”
36. See Sørensen, *Tibetan Buddhist Historiography*, xi, 159–341; Gyaltsen, *Clear Mirror*, 95–217.
37. See T. Tsering, *Mani Kabum*; Stein and Zangpo, *Butön’s History of Buddhism*; Obermiller, *History of Buddhism. The Testament Drawn from a Pillar* is also an important earlier source, about which, see Schaeffer, Kapstein, and Tuttle, *Sources of Tibetan Tradition*, 301–303; and Warner, “Genesis.”
38. Sørensen, *Tibetan Buddhist Historiography*, 199.
39. Ibid., 242.
40. Ibid., 253.
41. The exact identification of these sites has been carefully studied by other scholars. See Aris, *Bhutan*, 15–32; Sørensen, Hazon, and Gyalbo, *Thundering Falcon*, 171–215.
42. Sørensen, *Tibetan Buddhist Historiography*, 254.
43. Ibid., 271.

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CHAPTER 5

Geomorphism at “The Peak That Flew in from Afar”

Jeffrey Moser

Buddhists in medieval East Asia used a variety of artistic techniques to bridge the physical distance between their local environments and the famous sites in North India associated with the historical Buddha. In some cases, this took the form of cartographic and other visualizations of famous pilgrimages, most notably that of the great Tang translator Xuanzang, or of painting the North Indian geography of the historical Buddha in ways that made it largely indistinguishable from representations of the local environment. Such visualizations served as vehicles for imagined journeys that either brought the viewer to India or brought India to the viewer, so to speak.¹ In other cases, these techniques entailed the incorporation of local places and people into cosmic topographies whose scale was so vast they rendered the physical distance between East and South Asia negligible.² Both of these strategies can be witnessed in the history of Feilaifeng, the “peak that flew in from afar.” Located in the hills south of Hangzhou’s iconic West Lake, Feilaifeng is one of the most famous examples of a place in East Asia that came to be recognized as also and simultaneously a place in South Asia. In this chapter, I trace a transformation in the artistic processes whereby Feilaifeng was associated with the wider Buddhist world, charting a shift from a one-to-one “resonant” mode of association to a more universalizing “abstractive” mode. The evidence for this shift, I argue, can be discerned from a change in the way the sculptors who worked the living rock of the hill handled the relationship between the images they were sculpting and the stone that surrounded them.

Within the tradition of rock-cut Buddhist sculpture, there are a handful of examples of sculptors who deliberately used their sculpture to call attention to the unworked quality of the surrounding stone from which their work emerged

and to which it remained attached. It goes without saying that rock-cut sculpture is almost invariably about place making, because the site of artistic creation and the place of appreciation remain indubitably bound to one another. The use of sculpture to call attention to its geological matrix intensifies this making of place, as it associates the iconography of the sculpted form, and the various affects, associations, and meanings that accrue thereto, with the accumulated affects, associations, and meanings associated with the stone, ground, and earth. In what follows, I use “geomorphism” as a term of convenience for this practice of calling forth the geological matrix in sculpted stone.

I should stress from the outset that this working definition of geomorphism is distinct from the mobilization of color, striations, perforations, and other naturally occurring qualities of stone that occurs in sculpting traditions around the world. Such mobilization is a regular feature of East Asian stone carving, as seen in such well-known examples as the jadeite cabbage at the National Palace Museum, where the sculptor succeeded in matching the natural distribution of green and white in the jade with the prototypically green and white portions of the cabbage, and the less famous but more refined tradition of Songhua inkstones (fig. 5.1), in which the sedimentary stratigraphy of the stone reinforces the rectilinearity of the sculpted form. But these objects are detached from their matrix—free-floating implements whose ability to transform the place of their origin in the mind of their beholder is at most nominal: Songhua inkstones told their users little more about the Songhua River than that it was a source of beautiful stone.³



Figure 5.1 Songhua inkstone with lotus pond decor. Qing dynasty, Qianlong era (1736–1795). National Palace Museum, Taiwan.

To understand the way in which the geomorphic sculpture differs, consider the reclining Buddha at Wofoyuan in Anyue, Sichuan (fig. 5.2). Estimated to have been originally sculpted around the turn of the eighth century, the sculpture is an early entry in a wave of medieval projects that would transform the eroded, sedimentary topography of the Sichuan basin into a sculpted Buddhist environment; Phillip Bloom and Sonya Lee will discuss Song-era examples of this transformation in the coming chapters. The sculpture is easily the most monumental at the site: it stretches nearly twenty-three meters in length and, with its various ancillary figures, occupies almost all of the exposed wall's ten-meter vertical face. Its monumentalism follows from the willingness of its creators to select the reclining Buddha, which alone among all the compositional templates of Buddhist iconography is broader than it is tall, and thereby maximize the scale of the sculpture that could be accommodated in the available space. In her foundational essay on Wofoyuan, Sonya Lee has also called attention to the sensitive way in which the sculptors rearranged the composition—placing the Buddha on his left side rather than his right—so as to align the head with the most protruding portion of the rock wall, and thereby place the carved scripture (*kejing*) grottoes on the opposing face of the canyon in the



Figure 5.2 Reclining Buddha, Wofoyuan, Anyue County, Sichuan, China, Tang dynasty, early eighth century. Getty Images.

Buddha's line of sight.⁴ But in addition to adapting creatively to the disposition of the site, the sculptors also used the sculpture to call attention to its topography. Reclining Buddha images are often disproportionately elongated, but the image at Wofoyuan is extremely so, presenting a figure so slender that one could scarcely imagine it standing upright without toppling over. While this lateral stretching reduces the verisimilitude of the figure as a human form, it unmistakably accentuates it as an expression of the lateral striations of the wall. The squared-off corners and rectilinear mass of the image further echo the elongated stratigraphy and horizontal volumes of the surrounding stone. The result is an image that, while unmistakably the Buddha, simultaneously figures the essential character of the underlying stone. The quality that differs from other, fully detached expressions of the materiality of the medium—the thing that makes it geomorphic—is that in the process of expressing the character of its stone, the sculpture invests the topography of the region with Buddhist significance. It encourages the viewer to imagine the presence of the Buddha everywhere the same rectilinear stratigraphy is exposed. In so doing, it reconfigures the wider sense of place, and sense of the land that connects each place to every other place, by suggesting that the sculpted form is but an explicit revelation of the Buddha's presence everywhere.

Throughout the wider tradition of East Asian rock-cut sculpture, geomorphism is only an occasional phenomenon, the scope and meaning of which remains to be mapped in detail. It is not a distinguishing characteristic of a particular region or period (which may be part of the reason it has gone relatively unmentioned), nor does it appear to be associated with a particular school, scripture, or practice. Most sculptors of rock-cut Buddhist grottoes did not grant the stone such expressivity; they were guided by the presence of large, exposed areas of workable rock, and the repetitive work of their hands and chisels were, of course, informed by the stone's relative structure and hardness, but they did not treat the lithic body in and of itself as part of their subject.⁵ The only generalization that one can make about geomorphism is that, unsurprisingly, it tends to be associated with places that were regarded as having particularly beautiful or unusual stone.⁶

But while attention to geomorphism may not help us to trace the historical evolution and regional variation of rock-cut Buddhist sculpture in general, it can help us to identify different strategies that the sculptors of Buddhist grottoes used to create a sense of place, and to link that place with the other places that collectively made up the “worldly realm” (Skt. *lokadhātu*, Ch. *shijie*). And while its limited presence in the art historical record may not make it immediately relevant to discussion of wider regional and period styles, it can help us to understand the history of particular places with greater clarity. Perhaps the most striking of these places is the collection of rock-cut grottoes that occupy Feilaifeng.

The Geology of Flight

Topographically speaking, the “Peak” is a modest edifice. Measuring roughly 800 meters in length and 400 meters in width, its summit lies a mere 168 meters above sea level. Straddling a small stream whose course marks the center of a narrow valley, it is dwarfed by the surrounding hills. The distinctiveness of this situation—a stony outcropping athwart the flowing water that otherwise defines the valley as a succession of descending runnels and ridges—makes the peak a curious presence. In resisting the logic of its topography, it distinguishes itself as a recalcitrant remnant of the stone that was slower than its surroundings in its unbecoming.

The geological curiosity of the hill has attracted attention since at least the Tang and Song dynasties. If these later accounts are to be believed, it is, in part, how the peak got its name.⁷ The Xianchun era *Gazetteer of Lin'an* (1265–1274) offers what was, by then, the established account: “Yan Shu’s *Treatise of the Earth* records: ‘In the first year of Xianhe era of the Jin dynasty (326 CE), the Indian monk Huili climbed this mountain. Upon reaching the top, he exclaimed: “This is one of the lesser pinnacles of Vulture Peak! I do not know when it flew over here. When the Buddha was in the world, many deities dwelt therein. Perhaps they still do.” Thereupon he hung up his staff, founded Lingyin Temple on the spot, and named this peak “The One that Flew in from Afar” (*Feilai*).’”⁸ The association of the hill with Vulture Peak—the famous mountain in northern India where the Buddha gave several of his most important sermons—was abetted by its geology. Composed entirely of limestone, the hill is highly eroded, its surface populated with water-worn pinnacles, depressions, and crevasses, with several large caverns and numerous smaller grottoes within. One is acutely aware, when clambering over the hill’s rocky protrusions, of simultaneously climbing over voids within, and of being engaged with a complex but coherent and singular mass of stone. The geological distinctiveness of the hill endorsed the sense that it came from somewhere else, and the shadowy recesses of its interior facilitated the imagining of numinous beings inside.

The connection to Vulture Peak afforded by the hill’s geological alterity was buttressed by the large community of monkeys that lived in and around the site throughout the medieval period. As Meir Shahar has demonstrated in his detailed study of the textual traces of this community, which includes more than sixty poems written during the Tang and Song dynasties, these monkeys echoed the monkeys that a number of early Buddhist texts circulating in medieval China associated with Vulture Peak.⁹ The connection between the monkeys at Feilaifeng and the monkeys of Vulture Peak was personalized in the legends surrounding the Lingyin Temple’s founder, Huili, who was variously described as either bringing a monkey from India with him to China or being greeted by an Indian monkey when he arrived at Feilaifeng.¹⁰ Whatever the case, the

monkey's role in the narrative is to cry out in recognition of the hill's distinctiveness and thereby confirm Huili's identification of it as a portion of Vulture Peak. Being nonhuman, and thus free of the human penchant for subterfuge, the monkey transforms the speculative implications of the hill's strange geology into a reliable identification.¹¹ One is struck, across these references, by a consistent sense of the limits of the human as a source of valid knowledge and the willingness to seek verification from the nonhuman. Whether mountains or monkeys, these nonhuman actants work collaboratively to confirm what human doubt and deceit might otherwise render unreliable.

Beginning in the tenth century, a succession of patrons gave material expression to the legendary deities of Vulture Peak by sponsoring the sculpting of rock-cut Buddhist images in and around Feilaifeng's main caverns.¹² One of the earliest donor inscriptions at the site, associated with a tenth-century image of Amitābha carved inside the so-called Cave of Verdant Woods (*Qinglin dong*), explicitly locates the image at "the Chan monastery at Vulture Peak" (*Lingjiu Chanyuan*).¹³ Over the course of the subsequent centuries, hundreds of additional images and inscriptions were added. Approximately 330 of these images, and sixty inscriptions, remain extant. Virtually all of these carvings are sculpted from the stone fabric of the hill itself.

The sculptural history of the site can be divided into three discrete phases, each with its own distinct tempo and locus. During the first phase, which stretched from the heyday of the kingdom of Wu-Yue (893–978) down to the fall of Hangzhou (then Lin'an) to the Mongols in 1276, sculptures accumulated gradually. With the significant exception of the famous Southern Song representation of Budai and the Eighteen Arhats, which is situated on the outside of the hill in close proximity to the main gate of Lingyin Temple, the majority of the images from this period were sculpted inside the hill, within two of the three main caverns: the Cave of Verdant Woods and the Cave of Milky Jade (*Yuru dong*).¹⁴ The second phase was sudden and outward-facing: concentrated in the two decades immediately following the Mongol conquest, it involved the addition of more than forty discrete niches to the jagged wall of the hill flanking the approach to Lingyin Temple. Most of these were produced under the aegis of Yang Lianzhenjia, the Hangzhou Branch commissioner for Tibetan and Buddhist Affairs (*Xuanzheng yuan*).¹⁵ The final phase, stretching from the fourteenth down to the twentieth centuries, involved the addition of a handful of small, comparatively unsophisticated Buddhist figures, as well as a large number of "smoothed cliff face" (*moya*) inscriptions. Most of these inscriptions appear to have been produced not by members of the local sangha, but rather by the scholar-officials and other visitors who integrated Feilaifeng into the tourist itineraries of late imperial West Lake.¹⁶

In addition to basic issues of dating and iconographic identification, most of the existing art historical scholarship on Feilaifeng has focused on the question

of the degree to which the Yuan sculptures evince a radical break from their Song predecessors. A number of scholars have highlighted the “intrusive” nature of the Tantric imagery that appears in the Yuan, seeing it as evidence of an ostensive effort on the part of Yang Lianzhenjia to impose Tibetan-style Buddhist practices onto the local community.¹⁷ Rob Linrothe argues, in contrast, that the coincidence of Chinese, Sino-Tibetan, and Tibetan iconography and style in the sculptures commissioned by Yang suggests a more ecumenical desire to integrate the Central Asian icons that the Mongols brought with them into preexisting Buddhist imagery of the Hangzhou region.¹⁸ On both sides of the debate, the iconographic and stylistic evidence adduced has been almost entirely derived from the features internal to the sculptures themselves. Neither side has sought substantial corroboration from the *situation* of the sculptures—their position vis-à-vis one another, relative orientation, and relationship to the surrounding stone—within the wider space on, around, and within the hill.

The one exception of which I am aware is Antonio Mezcua López’s study of Feilaifeng as an evolving landscape. In a tour de force description of the human and ecological forces that have shaped the hill, Mezcua López eschews the niche-and-icon focus of most earlier scholarship and instead emphasizes the collective participation of the “whole sculptural group” in the formation of the site’s affect.¹⁹ This “landscape studies” perspective leads him to conclude that the Yuan sculptors, far from disrupting the established practices of the Song predecessors, deliberately placed the images in a manner that sustained the Song attention to the eroded, karstic peculiarity of the hill.²⁰ Mezcua López observes that the images sponsored by Yang Lianzhenjia are distributed quite widely along the hill’s northern slope, and that they work collectively to synthesize the karst formations between them into a coherent tableau. He terms this awareness “orographic,”²¹ which is exactly right: when we consider the human interventions at the site in their totality, it is clear that they reveal a consistent attention to the underlying “mountain” as a singular, unified, and coherent entity.

What Mezcua López’s interpretation understates, I think, is the substantial difference between the ways in which the Song and Yuan sculptors handled the relationship between each image and its geological matrix. When we focus our attention on the intermediate layer between the sculptures and the landscape—not the sculptures individually, nor collectively, but each in relation to the immediately surrounding stone—a rather different picture emerges. Whereas the Song sculptors actively mobilized and even accentuated the uneven irregularity of the rocky surface, generating images that undulate with their matrix, the Yuan sculptors consistently erased that irregularity, creating each image as a self-contained, internally sufficient body within a geometrically conceived niche cut straight into the rock at a ninety-degree angle. This discrepancy reveals rather different attitudes toward the stone and the hill it comprises, and suggests that while the Yuan sculptors and their patrons may have used

their images collectively in an integrative act of place making, the orographic subject that they cohered in the process was rather different from the one that occupied the space prior to their arrival. For the purposes of argument, I will suggest that the Song sculptors approached the hill in a manner that was *resonant*, while the Yuan sculptors did so in a manner that was *abstractive*.

The Resonant Mode

The challenges that modern scholars have faced in establishing a shared and consistent numbering scheme for the images at Feilaifeng are quite revealing.²² While the modern practice of organizing the imagery at rock-cut Buddhist grottoes into discrete “niches” (*kan*) accords quite well with the formal character of the Yuan-era sculpture—the boundaries of each individual or group of images being clearly defined—it feels arbitrary when applied to the earlier sculptures. This becomes obvious the moment that one steps into the southeastern entrance to the Qinglin cave: the walls and ceiling just inside the entrance are populated by a host of *luohan* images, which surround and intrude into the compositional space of adjacent representations of Amitābha and Maitreya. Chang Qing has observed that the *luohan* located alongside the Maitreya triad in “Niche 19” belongs to the same group of fifty-seven *luohan* images constituting “Niche 14” on the opposing wall, which are in turn echoed by the various *luohan* descending on a stalagmite in “Niche 21.”²³ The confusion arises from the fact that there are not really any niches in the cavern at all, just a series of images populating the natural intrusions and extrusions of its limestone surfaces. The absence of boundaries between the images is matched by the absence of boundaries between the images and the surrounding stone. Although the stone immediately surrounding each image has been smoothed to accentuate the figure’s profile, the essential attitude of the stone is preserved in the orientation of the image: each figure looks in a slightly different direction depending upon the vector of the underlying stone. A visitor intending to meet the gaze of each figure as they move through the cavern must continuously reposition themselves. The result is a ceaseless series of microadjustments in posture and attitude, which leave the visitor far more cognizant of the irregular contours of the cavern than they would be if the images were situated on a more architectonic plane. Several figures even descend from above, their sculptors having exploited the absence of clear distinctions between wall and ceiling to transform the vertical faces of the ceiling’s protrusions into images (fig. 5.3). In moving through the space, one quite literally ducks to avoid hitting the buddhas suspended there. The result is an exquisitely three-dimensional experience, in which the desire to see the images simultaneously maximizes one’s awareness of the cavern as cavern.



Figure 5.3 Buddhas in Niche 84, Yuru Cave, Feilaifeng, Hangzhou, China, Northern Song dynasty, early eleventh century. Photograph by the author.

In addition to occupying a host of different horizontal planes, many of the platforms sculpted from the stone immediately beneath the figures are rusticated, their faces scalloped to emulate, in miniature, the pocked irregularity of the unworked surfaces of the cavern.²⁴ This feature echoes the widespread Song fascination with the weathered forms of “strange rocks” (*guaishi*), which are characterized by the very foraminate quality that defines the lithic body of Feilaifeng. As demonstrated by the accounts of Lingbi and Taihu stone in Du Wan’s influential early twelfth-century *Cloudy Forest Catalogue of Stone* (*Yunlin shipu*), the desirability of these rocks was premised on their appeal to an aesthetics of scalar oscillation (e.g., of seeing the big within the small, and the small within the big) and inversion (e.g., of seeing stone from the inside out).²⁵ For the visitor steeped in this discourse, stepping inside the caverns of Feilaifeng meant experiencing the same interiority of the mountain that they experienced in miniature whenever they beheld a scholars’ rock in a garden or a studio. The rustication of the platforms reinforced these aesthetics by reiterating their ceaseless inversion: taking that which had been made large in the movement from the rock to the cavern and making it small again, and taking the inside of the mountain and returning it to the outside of the platform.

The geomorphism of the sculptural program is expressed differently, but no less vibrantly, in the Yuru cave. Here a representation of the eighteen *luohan* dominates the program. Each *luohan* figure is more than a meter in height, filling much of the available wall. Situated on a mostly continuous platform that rises thirty to forty centimeters from the present cavern floor, they begin immediately to the left of the southern entrance and proceed around the perimeter of the cave, ultimately occupying more than half of the circumference of the irregular space. While the top surface of the platform is polished smooth, its face retains the rough, unworked form of the cavern's natural wall. No attempt is made to represent a lotus seat, pedestal, or other manmade seat. Each figure sits, with their legs variously crossed in ease or meditation, on stone that is explicitly of the cavern itself. Song Buddhist figures—most notably Guanyin—were quite frequently depicted on natural stone platforms and terraces. But whereas the “natural” platforms featured in freestanding sculptural and painted icons typically gesture to somewhere other than the place where the icon is located (in Guanyin's case, the rocky grottoes of her legendary abode on Mount Putuo), here the platform reinforces the notion that the abode of the *luohan* is no different from the place its icon presently occupies: right here, in the Yuru cave.

But in addition to mobilizing the natural texture of the cavern's walls to align the imagined seats of the *luohan* with the actual site of their representation, the sculptors also expressed the character of the natural stone wall in the bodies of the figures themselves. This happens in a rather subtle way that is difficult to notice upon first glance, given the naturalistic handling of the *luohans'* physical features, which lack the geomorphic distortions witnessed at Wofoyuan and the chiseled flatness of the vertical plane behind them. Yet despite their rounded volumes, each figure remains very much of its wall, with each portion of its body—head, neck, shoulders, torso, waist, buttocks—thoroughly and completely fused to the stone behind. Slight undercutting at the shoulders and around the head conveys a sense of the body's curvature, but no feature truly breaks free of the matrix. This stands in sharp contrast to most examples of Song-era rock-cut sculpture, such as those at Dazu and Anyue, which are typically characterized by much more substantial undercutting. Unlike the later Southern Song and Yuan images at Feilaifeng, which retain their anthropomorphism regardless of the angle from which they are observed, the *luohan* in the Yuru cave lose their humanity when viewed from the side, retreating into narrow, rectangular boxes, with the tips of their noses, the forward edge of their hands, and the fronts of their legs all aligned on the same vertical plane in a way that no actual human, seated cross-legged with their back against a wall, could reproduce. When one casts their gaze to the natural stone immediately above and below the figure, one realizes that that vertical plane, so central to the distinctly rectilinear profile of the figures,

represents the location of the original stone wall. The sculpture remains “naturalistic,” but the object whose nature it inscribes changes as one examines it in three-dimensional space, shifting from the naturalism of the human body to that of the stone cavern.

Perhaps the most striking example of this compression of the human form into the shadow of the lithic body can be found in the *luohan* occupying the apex of the protruding wall immediately opposite the southern entrance, and thus directly in the visitor’s line of sight as they enter the cave (fig. 5.4). The sculpture actually comes the closest of all the eighteen *luohan* in the chamber to appearing fully in the round: the head, torso, and folded left leg are so thoroughly undercut that one realizes that they remain attached to the wall only when one circles around the side. But this sense of an independent, three-dimensional body is immediately undercut by the remarkable flattening of the bent right leg, pressed behind the tubular band of the *luohan*’s interlocked fingers. The figure’s right foot is retracted into the body to such an extent that the robe hangs, curtain-like, from knee to toe, erasing all sense of a leg within. This reverse foreshortening accentuates the enormity of the figure’s head while simultaneously inviting the viewer to imagine an invisible plane pressing back against the forward thrust of the figure’s legs



Figure 5.4 *Luohan* from frontal and profile perspectives, Yuru Cave, Feilaifeng, Hangzhou, China, Northern Song dynasty, early eleventh century. Photograph by Matthew Kluk.

and compacting them into a low-relief, almost two-dimensional space. When one casts their eyes to the rough stone fronting the platform immediately below the figure, it is clear that this invisible plane constitutes the former wall of the cavern. In this way, the sculptor not only accommodated themselves to the available stone matrix but in the process also called attention to that accommodation. This is further reinforced by the gaze of the figure's thus accentuated head, which is cast upward, at an angle, toward the apex of the cavern's natural ceiling.

But without question, the clearest example of a geomorphic sculpture at Feilaifeng is also its most famous: Budai and the Eighteen *Luohan* (fig. 5.5). Located in a rocky grotto on the north side of the hill, the assemblage overlooks the stream immediately below. Although today it can be viewed only at a distance from across the stream, it is clear that the bowl-shaped depression immediately in front of the assemblage was originally designed as a space where an individual or small group of devotees could stand and make an offering. Collectively, the sculptures occupy the full 180-degree arc of the grotto, which means that it is impossible to view all of the figures simultaneously, no matter one's distance from the sculpture. In effect, this arrangement asks the viewer to move and to visually and physically negotiate the rocky environment



Figure 5.5 Budai and the Eighteen *Luohan*, Niche 68, Feilaifeng, Hangzhou, China, Southern Song dynasty, late twelfth to thirteenth century. Photograph by Matthew Kluk.

in the process. The awareness of the natural matrix that this embodied perspective generates is reinforced at every level by the sculpted assemblage: the overhang sheltering the figures retains the irregular profile of the natural limestone, and the sculpted platforms on which the individual images are perched are rusticated in the same manner as the Yuru cave, reiterating the oscillation between micro- and macrological scales.

This grottoes-in-grottoes effect is further reinforced by the differing attitudes of the *luohan*, several of which are situated at an oblique angle to wall behind, with a portion of their bodies absorbed within the surrounding rock. This has the curious effect of suggesting that the wall is both mere shadow—a void within which the *luohan*, and presumably other deities, are concealed—and simultaneously, resolutely present—its body integral to the carefully calibrated affect of the sculptures. The coexistence of spatial void and lithic presence is also what characterizes the hill itself, both as a cultural construct and as an actual thing. This is what makes the Budai and *luohan* assemblage, and the rest of the Song sculptures at the site, so resonant: they consistently call attention to the fact of their being at Feilaifeng. Highlighting the geological distinctiveness of the site and thereby reinforcing its association with Vulture Peak, the sculptures reiterate in visual terms the same corroborative role performed by the monkeys in the lore associated with the site that accumulated in Song texts.

The Abstractive Mode

In contrast to the Song-era sculptures inside the Qinglin and Yuru caves, the Yuan sculptures, which are by and large located on the outside of the hill, are unquestionably in *niches*. Nearly every Yuan sculpture at the site is situated in a clearly defined cavity, rectangular in elevation and plan, that intrudes into the rock at a ninety-degree angle. While a handful of the niches are more complicated in elevation, with a rectangular base under an elliptical or semicircular arch, they are all geometric in character, with none of the natural irregularity of the Song carvings. This is uniformly true of the twenty niches that can be securely dated by inscription to the decade-long administration of Yang Lianzhenjia, and it holds true for almost all of the other sculptures. Whether simultaneous or subsequent, the Yuan sculptors appear to have remained within the parameters of the model established under Yang. This consistency marks the Yuan intervention at the site as strikingly coherent: While the iconography of the sculptures varies considerably, the way in which they were sculpted, stylistically speaking, and the way in which the rock was treated in their sculpting were governed by a consistent approach to the materiality of the hill.

The essential qualities of this approach were established in what has long been celebrated as one of the most important Yuan sculptures at Feilaifeng: the representation of Amitābha in Niche 89 (fig. 5.6). Dated by inscription to the year 1289, and attributed to the patronage of Yang Lianzhenjia, the image is positioned in a rectangular niche, the four sides of which intrude straight into the stone, terminating at right angles against the rear wall. The surface of the wall has been planed flat, accentuating the low-relief halo and mandorla that signal the figure's luminous divinity. Beyond the gleaming smoothness of these radiant planes, the surface of the wall is less even. Upon closer inspection, this variegated surface crystallizes into an organized succession of Sanskrit incantations incised in neat, lateral rows of Tibetan script. The



Figure 5.6 Amitābha, Niche 89, Feilaifeng, Hangzhou, China, dated 1289. Photograph by the author.

presence of this inscription eliminates the illusion of a void that was so palpable in the rear wall of Southern Song Budai assemblage. Instead, it materializes the ground into a solid and unyielding surface rendered impenetrable by the presence of the text upon it. While the image of Amitābha set before this ground is physically attached to the surrounding stone, none of this attachment is apparent to the viewer: the profile of the figure is deeply undercut, and it rests upon a meticulously sculpted lotus seat whose stylized petals are formally distinguished from the surrounding stone. The rectilinearity of the niche and parallel alignment of the sculpture extends its geometry into the space before it, creating a normative viewing position at a right angle with the image's own line of symmetry. Unlike the Song sculptures, the figure neither requests nor rewards movement on the part of its viewer. Instead, it fixes the viewing subject on a coordinate plane that bears no relation to the irregular contours and shifting elevation of the path that they traversed to stand before it. In sum, nothing about the sculpture gestures toward the hill within which it is situated. It is meticulously executed and exquisitely crafted, but also anonymous—an abstracted, mathematic figure that could be anywhere.

The inscription beneath the image hints at the way in which its relation to its matrix was understood by its creators. Restating the conflation of the Vulture Peak with Feilaifeng, the inscription announces that Commander-General Yang of Yongfu (i.e., Yang Lianzhenjia) “unfurled his banner amid the pinnacles of Vulture Peak, and therein sundered the weathered stone upon the face of Feilaifeng, revealing a golden image of a buddha, whose name was ‘Infinite’ and ‘Limitless.’” The language here is violent and extractive, and it leaves no doubt about how the buddha came to light. The image did not emerge miraculously of its own accord, nor was it discovered in a rocky crevasse. To the contrary, Yang “sundered” (*zao po*) or, more literally, “chiseled and thereby broke apart” the stone.²⁶ He *mined* a buddha from the mountain.

The inscription also explains that the image so revealed “raised a model and depicted a standard” (*qimo huayang*).²⁷ When we turn our attention to the other Yuan images at the site, it is clear that their sculptors did, in fact, emulate the logic of Yang Lianzhenjia's Amitābha. Regardless of whether they were sculpting figures whose iconography followed the established precedents of the region (what modern scholars have typically termed “Han-style”), or restated the more esoteric iconography of the Mongol's Tibetan and Tangut auxiliaries, the Yuan sculptors consistently adopted the same approach, first chiseling a rectangular void in the stone and then sculpting a mass within that void as if it were a freestanding sculpture.

Consider, for example, the Buddha image in Niche 82 (fig. 5.7). Although the exact iconography of the image is indeterminate—Chang Qing finds Śākyamuni

and Ratnasambhava equally plausible²⁸—it clearly bears none of the “alien” features of the more esoteric Yuan sculptures. But like the image of Amitābha, it is sculpted nearly in the round and set against a smooth rear wall upon which a low-relief halo and mandorla are clearly visible. Its lotus seat, as well, is clearly distinguished from the surrounding stone. The same approach even holds for the site’s one Yuan-era Budai image, which given the established Southern Song precedent, would seem a likely candidate for a more geomorphic treatment. But even though this later Budai lacks a carefully sculpted seat, it too is situated in an architectonic niche whose sharp corners and symmetrical axis are a distant cry from the rough-hewn, naturalizing abode of its Southern Song predecessor.



Figure 5.7 Buddha, Niche 82, Feilaifeng, Hangzhou, China, Yuan dynasty (1271–1368). Photograph by the author.

Gone as well is the figural-cum-lithic ambiguity of the Song sculptures. Whereas the sculptors of the images in the Qinglin and Yuru caves embraced an ambiguous boundary between form and matter—creating figures that seem to simultaneously emerge from and recede into the stone in endless, suggestive oscillation—the Yuan artists sharpened the distinction between figure and ground. The sculptors of the bodhisattva in Niche 86, for example, worked the upper portion of the rocky platform into flowing fabric whose lines are so sinuous and supple that one all but forgets that they are actually fashioned from stone. Draping soft, sensuous silk over roughhewn, porous limestone, they sharpened the distinction between the subject and matter of representation by giving it textural, tactile specificity. An as-if, mimetic logic of illusion supplants the more revelatory, geomorphic logic of both at once.

The Yuan rejection of the geomorphic approach becomes even more pronounced in the larger, multi-image assemblies. The most striking example of this is the exquisitely carved and ornamented representation of the goddess Usnīsavijaya and her attendants in Niche 84 (fig. 5.8). Here the multiheaded, eight-armed central figure is flanked by a pair of standing bodhisattvas and double pair of fearsome *vidyārājas*, or “wisdom kings” (*mingwang*). These figures emanate from the central icon in duplicable symmetries of identical forms,



Figure 5.8 Usnīsavijaya and attendants, Niche 84, Feilaifeng, Hangzhou, China, Yuan dynasty (1271–1368). Photograph by the author.

each attendant distinguishable from the others solely by the attribute that they hold in their hands. The *maṇḍala*-like geometries of the assemblage stand in stark contrast to the distinctively individualized *luohan* that cluster around the Southern Song Budai in elegant irregularity. This is a visual language of duplication and replication, of crystalline geometry and number, rather than one of furtive ambiguity, mystery, and lithic peculiarity. In an almost perfect contrast to the grotto-in-grotto, self-referential geomorphism of the Budai and *luohans*, the entire Usnisavijaya assembly is framed in architectural forms whose smooth polish and geometric ornamentation bear no resemblance to the natural profile of the underlying stone. Arrayed beneath the circular, stepped tiers of a stupa—an unmistakable allusion to the White Pagoda in the Yuan capital of Dadu (modern Beijing)—the deity's lotus seat, stepped platform, and the crisply-cut niches of the *vidyārājas* suggest an interior space whose walls have been unfolded, triptych-like, and pressed back into the face of the cliff. Like the images within it, this is a space from somewhere else, an architecture that literally intrudes into the stone.

Geoesthetics of Place Making

The striking differences between the Song and Yuan sculptures at Feilaifeng gesture toward two distinctive strategies of place making, each with its own geoesthetic implications. In blurring the distinction between image and site, and echoing the character of the rock from which they are carved, the Song sculptures foreground the fact of their being at Feilaifeng. They signify the *luohans*, bodhisattvas, and buddhas that they represent, to be sure, but more importantly they render those deities as the inhabitants of a numinous place—figures whose individual powers and stories are subordinate to the miraculous story and amazing presence of the mountain that flew. Mobilizing the peculiarity of the stone, they reconstitute in visual terms the “rhetoric of corroboration” that is so central to the tales that Song storytellers told of Huili and his monkey. In so doing, they forge a direct, bilateral connection across the time and space between the Buddha's sermons on Vulture Peak and the present Song practitioners at Feilaifeng, transcending distance through reference to those features that most distinguish the place from its surrounding environment. Aesthetic appreciation in the classical sense, which is above all concerned with difference, comes to the fore. The mountain flies, there and back again, on a voyage of distinction.

Although the Yuan sculptures blur the *iconographic* boundary between themselves and their Song predecessors, inserting Tibetan deities into the established local pantheon, their manner of depiction sharpens the boundary between those deities and their abode. The extractive logic of the geometric

niche transforms the images from an integral to an incidental presence in the mountain—representations of beings who are everywhere and all the time, and so, of course, here too. This flattens the geological significance of hill, reminding the viewer that whatever differences they might perceive in its rocky mantle are nothing more than superficial variance—ripples upon the surface of a deeper, consistent stratum. Although the geoaesthetic that abides therein is by no means scientific, it witnesses the particularity of place in the same sense that a modern geologist might: seeing in its stone traces of universal elements and world-spanning processes. An aesthetics of distinction and the nuanced appeal of a particular configuration of stones and grottoes is supplanted by an aesthetics of piercing illumination and vivid replication.

The wider textual and visual regimes of the Song and Yuan polities abound with suggestive analogues. The Song sculptures echo the attention to the particularity of local places that resounds in texts such as Wang Xiangzhi's *Record of Surpassing Sites throughout the Land* (*Yudi jisheng*) of 1224, as well as the enormous body of painting, poetry, travelogues, and other accounts of West Lake and its environs.²⁹ Although later gazetteers would write the sculptures out of their accounts of Feilaifeng, the sculptures participate in the same attentiveness to the local that defines those gazetteers. The Yuan sculptures, in turn, echo the geometric logic of the *maṇḍalas* that the Mongols' Tibetan Buddhist advisors superimposed onto their designs for the empire's sacred places. These include the equation of Mount Wutai's five peaks with the *maṇḍala* of the Five Tathāgata (*Wufang fo*) by Khubilai's state preceptor, Pakpa (1235–1280); the transformation of that *maṇḍala* into the three-dimensional architectural form of the White Stupa; and the sacred coordination of the Yuan capital of Dadu through the erection of stupas over the gates of its major thoroughfares.³⁰ In this sense, the transformation of sacred space undertaken by the Mongols involved not simply the imposition of “foreign” architectural forms such as Tibetan-style stupas but also the assertion that those forms coordinated a universal spatial logic that integrated the disparate elements of the sacred landscape that preceded them. One could argue that the rectilinear recession of the Yuan niches at Feilaifeng was a way of extending this coordinating practice to sites whose rocky irregularity made it otherwise difficult to experience—a way of imposing geometry on a place that resisted it. But whether these vague resonances constitute evidence for a shared and coherent geoaesthetics remains to be seen. What we can say with greater assurance is that Feilaifeng demonstrates the degree to which geoaesthetics implicates relationships between artworks and human bodies: by inviting movement and embodied engagement, the Song sculptures inscribed a distinctive orography, which the Yuan sculptures, by stilling their onlookers on axial vectors, effectively erased. If Reiko Ohnuma's and Eric Huntington's chapters in this volume illustrate the use of the human body as a rhetorical device for figuring the enormity of the

Buddhist cosmos, here we witness it as locus for translating that enormity into immediate, haptic sensation.

Scale matters in making of geoaesthetic distinctions: the ratio of human body to rock-cut grotto; the scale of the distances between the places that the sculptures coordinate, be they cosmic, or the “merely” continental separation of Feilaifeng from Vulture Peak; the scalar oscillation between mountain and rock that made Feilaifeng attractive in the first place to a culture excited by “strange” limestone forms. But scale is not just a matter of the shifting ratios within our subject. The scale of our historiography matters just as much. For while the Yuan intervention might appear abstractive in the context of the established practices at Feilaifeng, from the wider perspective of Buddhist sculpture, it looks conservative. Most sculptors at most times in the history of East Asian rock-cut sculpture handled the relationship between figure, niche, and matrix in the same manner as the Yuan sculptors. The recognizability of their work at Feilaifeng as distinctively “abstractive” turns on our willingness to localize the making of meaning and read the symbolism of the site against the existing contours and affordances of the site itself. The access to the inside of the stone that weathered limestone afforded, nurtured a cultural interest in interiority and in the relationship between surface and substance. This interest spurred a new, more geomorphic practice of sculpture, which in turn sparked a transformation in the symbolic capacity of an older, more established mode of rock-cut sculpture. Rectilinear niches became symbolically abstractive once geomorphic grottoes made that symbolism possible, but only in those places where geomorphic sculpting afforded the contrast. Just as the weathered limestone abetted metaphors of interiority, the geomorphic sculpture made it possible for the classical niche to look like a sign of conquest. Both the resonant and the abstractive regimes were true to the rocky fabric of Feilaifeng, for it was precisely that changing mantle that made their meaning viable.

NOTES

1. Moerman, *Japanese Buddhist World Map*; Saunders, “Xuanzang’s Journey.”
2. Eric Huntington’s contribution to this volume examines several examples of such cosmic incorporation.
3. On the tradition of Songhua stone carving, see Chi, “Pinlie duanshe.”
4. Lee, “Buddha’s Words,” 63–71.
5. Not, at least, in any obvious way that can be determined through visual analysis from the sculpture itself.
6. In his early thirteenth-century *Fangyu shenglan*, Zhu Mu remarked of Pu Prefecture (within which Anyue County was located): “The beauty of Pu is in its stone (*Pu zhi xiu yi*

shi).” Zhu Mu, *Fangyu shenglan*, 1110. Although I am not aware of any textual evidence of perceptions of the region’s geology contemporaneous to reclining Buddha, the presence of the passage in the *Fangyu shenglan*, which is drawn mostly from earlier literary sources, strongly suggests that celebration of the region’s distinctive stone preceded the thirteenth century.

7. No contemporaneous evidence of the temple’s founding and naming of the hill in the fourth century survives. For a brief introduction to some of the available sources, see Chang, “Feilaifeng,” 38–43; and Shahar, “Lingyin Si Monkey Disciples.”

8. Qian, *Xianchun Lin’an zhi* 23.4.

9. Shahar, “Lingyin Si Monkey Disciples,” 201. Most accounts indicate that these monkeys were more specifically gibbons. In light of the handful of alternative references, and the fact that the term *yuan* and its variants can also refer to simians in general, I have, following Shahar (201–202), used “monkey” here.

10. *Ibid.*, 213–224.

11. *Ibid.*, 215–216.

12. The social status of most of the Wu-Yue and Song era donors is indeterminable, as the inscriptions typically indicate only their names and genders, and suggest that they were devoted members of the sangha. A handful appear to have been court officials of various rank. There is no evidence of direct royal or imperial patronage in the commissioning of the images at the site, although it undoubtedly benefited from the wealth brought by the presence of the Wu-Yue and Southern Song courts in Hangzhou.

13. Zhejiangsheng wenwu guanli weiyuanhui, *Xihu shiku yishu*, 10. For a translation, see Chang, “Feilaifeng,” 89–90.

14. Whether the Song-Yuan era occupants of the site used these appellations, or even distinguished the caves from one another, is uncertain. No evidence attesting the use of these names predates the late Ming.

15. On the controversial figure of Yang Lianzhenjia, see Franke, “Tibetans in Yüan China,” 321–325.

16. For a lucid account of this transformation, see Mezcua López, “Cursed Sculptures,” 61–71.

17. These scholars include Swart, “Buddhist Sculptures at Feilai Feng”; Edwards, “Pu-tai-Maitreya”; and Chen, “Luelun Yang Lianzhenjia.”

18. Linrothe, “Commissioner’s Commissions.”

19. Mezcua López, “Cursed Sculptures,” 21.

20. *Ibid.*, 49–61.

21. *Ibid.*, 50.

22. At least three different numbering schemes have been proposed. For a discussion, see Chang, “Feilaifeng,” 53. My numbering follows Gao, *Feilaifeng zaoxiang*.

23. Chang, “Feilaifeng,” 138–140, 156–160. As Chang observes, twenty of these *luohan* images have surviving donor inscriptions dating them to 1000–1003 CE. Given their stylistic consistency, it is likely that most of the other images in this portion of the cavern were added around this time, roughly between the incorporation of Hangzhou into the Song empire in 978 and the first several decades of the eleventh century.

24. The term “rustication” has a narrower meaning in the context of European masonry traditions. I am using it more loosely to signal the quality that the Feilaifeng sculptures

share with those traditions: the deliberate, sculptural highlighting of a rough and unfinished surface.

25. Du, *Yunlin shipu* 1.1a–2a, 3a–b. Useful introductions to the aesthetics of *guaishi* include Schafer, *Tu Wan's Stone Catalogue*; Hay, “Structure and Aesthetic Criteria”; and Mowry, *Worlds within Worlds*.

26. Gao, *Feilaifeng zaoxiang*, 121. For translations, see Edwards, “Pu-tai-Maitreya,” 10; and Chang, “Feilaifeng,” 324–325.

27. Gao, *Feilaifeng zaoxiang*, 121.

28. Chang, “Feilaifeng,” 250–253.

29. Moser, “One Land of Many Places,” 242.

30. Yi, “‘Translating’ Wutai Shan,” 41; Campbell, “Consecrating the Imperial City,” 220–241.

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CHAPTER 6

The Japanese Image of the Buddhist Earth

Geography, Cosmology, and the Culture of Vision

D. Max Moerman

From the fourteenth through the nineteenth century, Japanese Buddhists maintained a remarkably detailed and consistent world picture: a representation of the earth as described by the seventh-century Chinese Buddhist pilgrim Xuanzang (600–664) in his *Great Tang Record of the Western Regions* (Ch. *Da Tang xiyuji*). It is an image of the earth that draws every detail of sacred topography—mountains, valleys, and deserts; rivers, lakes, and oceans; caves, rocks, and trees—from Xuanzang’s account of his overland journey from China to Central Asia and India. Produced by a fourteenth-century monastic painter belonging to the Nara temples of Hōryūji and Kōfukuji, it was preserved, copied, and venerated in Japanese Buddhist temples for the next five hundred years. This chapter examines this image, and the history of its reception, to suggest how Japanese monks understood the temporal and spatial scale of the earth and its significance as an object of Buddhist knowledge. It presents cartography as a source for the study of Buddhist geoaesthetics and suggests how such sources might help us to recognize heretofore unacknowledged dimensions of the history of Buddhism.

The World According to Xuanzang

Known as the *Map of the Five Regions of Tenjiku* (J. *Gotenjiku-zu*), the Japanese term for Buddhist India, the painting has been dated to 1364 and ascribed to the brush of a monk named Genshunbō Jūkai (b. 1297; fig. 6.1) Although the earliest example of its kind—indeed, the earliest Japanese map of the world—it

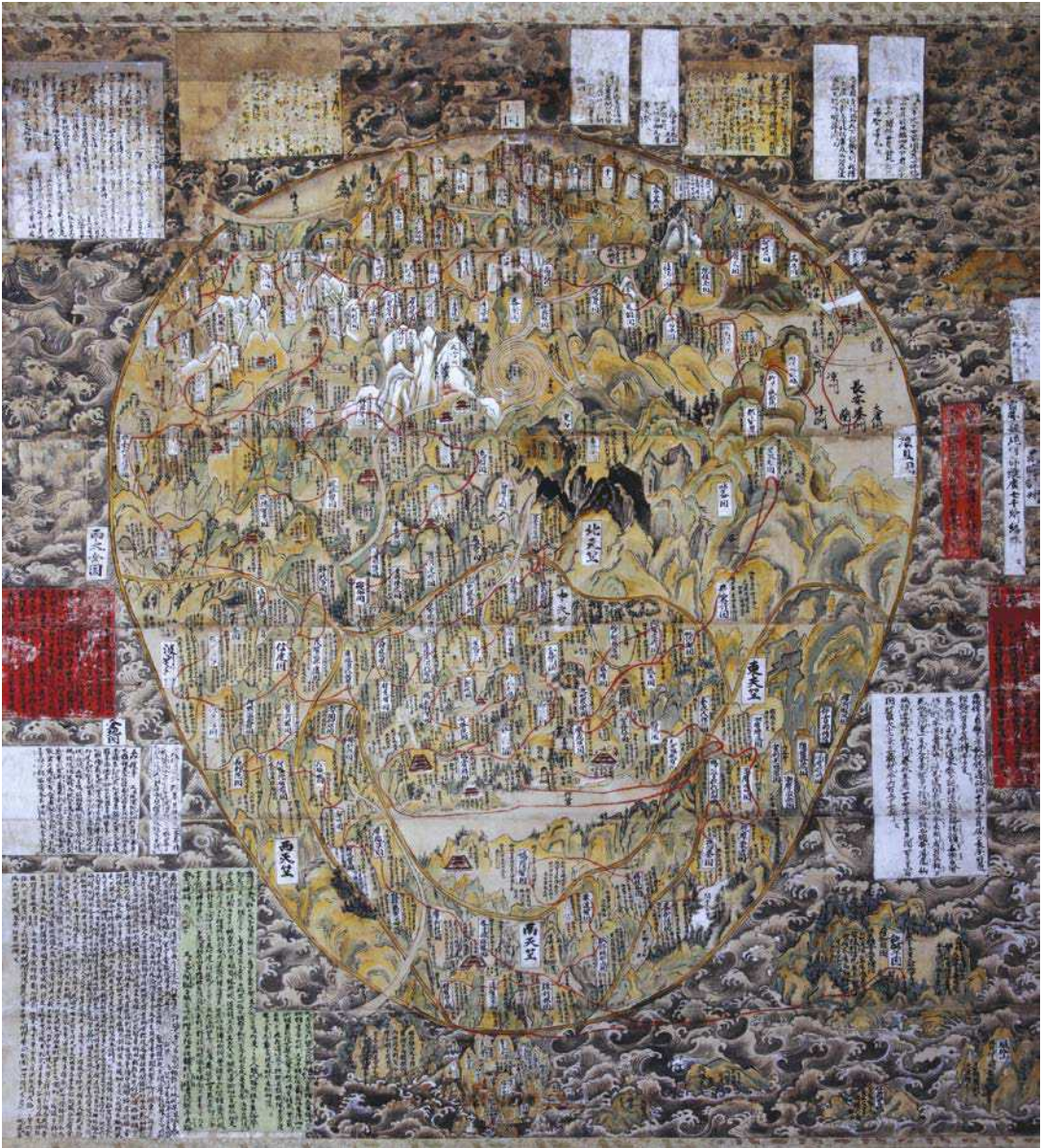


Figure 6.1 Genshunbō Jūkai, *Map of the Five Regions of Tenjiku*, 1364. Hanging scroll; ink and colors on paper, 177 x 166.5 cm. Hōryūji, Nara.

is most likely a transcription of an earlier prototype, no longer extant, from China or Korea, a provenance that reminds us that Xuanzang's image of the earth was shared throughout Buddhist East Asia. It also shares, with the rest of East Asian cartography, a relationship between text and image, in which the map, according to Cordell Yee, "was intended to complement, not substitute for, verbal description."¹ This cartographic complementarity between the verbal and the visual is expressed in a number of ways: panels of text, quoting passages from Xuanzang's *Record*, encroach on the landmass even as they frame it; hundreds of place names, each set apart in its own cartouche, at once ornament and obscure the topography; and the significant places encountered along the pilgrim's path are named, annotated, and described.

The map, a visualization of a textual landscape, represents the territorial totality of Xuanzang's *Record* in synoptic condensation and exhaustive detail. A thin red line traces the serpentine route of Xuanzang's pilgrimage. The names of every kingdom and city through which he passed are all dutifully listed—as is their size, their number of monasteries and monks, their climate and agriculture, and the customs and characteristics of their inhabitants—just as they appear in Xuanzang's text. Hundreds of place names constitute a comprehensive itinerary of Xuanzang's journey such that reading the toponyms along the pilgrim's path becomes a voyage itself. Every significant site along the way is depicted: the mountains, caves, and groves in which past masters practiced, from "the great rock pass where Prince Mahāsattva sacrificed his body to the starving tigress" to the *śāla* grove where the Buddha entered parinirvāṇa. To read the map is a dynamic and performative act: to follow the narrative of Xuanzang's pilgrimage step-by-step, and in doing so to be interpolated into the journey.

The ability of the viewer to enter the image is an essential quality of the map's power of seduction and a feature significant to its ritual function as well. In the act of looking—following Xuanzang's path with only cartouches, annotations, and images as guide—the viewer enacts the pilgrim's role. But retracing Xuanzang's route, finding one's way along the red line of the painted itinerary, is no simple feat. Viewers must orient themselves within a dense textual and visual terrain, negotiate a path through an expansive geography of word and image, and also supply much of the information that the map maker declined to transcribe from Xuanzang's extensive *Record*. The map, therefore, presumes an informed viewer, so familiar with the text as to have internalized it. Passages of Xuanzang's *Record* are inscribed throughout the map but only selectively. The text remains partial and relies on the viewer's participation. Routes and landscape elements are drawn; place names, distances, and directions are inscribed; but the vast narrative balance of Xuanzang's *Record* is necessarily supplied by the audience—likely both monastic and scholastic—who must mentally fill the spaces between the visible landmarks: the legends, the

miracles, the stūpas and relics, the experience of the Buddha's presence that Xuanzang's text describes but concerning which the map remains mute.

Such a mode of itinerant viewing is conditioned by the material facts of the object. At more than a meter and a half square, with thousands of inscriptions and countless details of landscape and architectural elements, the map requires physical intimacy and kinesthetic engagement: the performative act of approaching and moving across the painted surface. Visual efficacy, however, depends not only on a close reading but on a distant one as well. The map prescribes a kind of bifocality: the narrative can be read only up close but the scope of the Buddhist world can be appreciated only from afar. To fully experience the map, one must continually move back and forth: choreographically oscillating between text and image, between reading and viewing. *Zu*, the Japanese term for the map, implies such practices of engagement. Francesca Bray's characterization of the term as "a functional category . . . translating temporal or intellectual sequences into purely spatial terms, and encrypting dynamic processes as static layouts," underscores the kinesthetics of reception. "The perusal and decoding," she writes, is "unfolded into realization and into action."² Such maps are, in Bray's words, "templates for action," but not for the ordinary traveler. They are less practical aids for geographic navigation than perspectives on the world, projections of, and itineraries for, journeys of the imagination, and for modes of ideological and epistemological argument as well.

The earth itself, represented as an ovoid landform, is the southern world continent of Jambudvīpa, known in Japanese as Nansenbushū, and is so titled by a large white cartouche at the map's right-hand margin. The landmass is named for the enormous jambu tree (an Indian measurement the length of five hundred arm spans) tall, and oriented around the square Lake Anavatapta. At each of the lake's four sides is one of four animal heads composed of different precious substances: a silver ox to the east, a lapis lazuli horse to the west, a golden elephant to the south, and a crystal lion to the north. Out of the mouths of these animals flow four great rivers—the Indus, the Oxus, the Ganges, and the Śītā (or Tarim)—which encircle their source and radiate in four directions before emptying into the sea. This detail, based on Vasubandhu's *Treasury of Abhidharma* (Skt. *Abhidharmakośa*) is also spelled out in Xuanzang's *Record*.³

The surrounding panels identify the spatial scale of the earth as "the Five Regions of Tenjiku in the south . . . Persia in the west . . . the Barbarian Lands in the north . . . and the Land of the Han, or *Zhendān*, in the east." But the map also includes landforms not mentioned in Xuanzang's *Record*: most notably, the earliest geomorphic painting of the Japanese archipelago. The presence of Japan on the map of Jambudvīpa might seem a minor detail—a few islands at the very margins of world—yet its inclusion is no small matter. Indeed, the place of Japan within the Buddhist world, the spatial and temporal relationship

between Japan and Jambudvīpa, was a profound concern for medieval Japanese Buddhists. As the thirteenth-century monk Myōe lamented,

Born two thousand years after the death of Śākyamuni, in a remote land in the age of the Final Dharma, I could not join the assembly of the Buddha's disciples during his presence in this world and thus missed the opportunity to be guided toward the path of enlightenment. Studying the sacred teachings, I understand the Buddha's essence[,] but when I encounter difficulties in studying the sacred teachings and obstacles in carrying out religious practices, I long for the Buddha's sacred traces in Tenjiku and the Western Regions. In the past, Xuanzang set out on foot to visit those places. [If I were to make this pilgrimage,] I may not survive unscathed. People say that Tenjiku is far away and that I will not necessarily reach it. Even if the road is treacherous, even if I die, I have no fear. I must face towards Tenjiku and start walking with my will set on visiting the sacred traces of Śākyamuni.⁴

Myōe's choice of the term "sacred traces" (*J. goiseki*) is significant. According to T. H. Barrett, the term for "trace" "meant footprint, especially animal tracks or spoor, which revealed the existence somewhere of something alive and moving but not present and visible to the naked eye."⁵ Myōe's quest is explicitly modeled on Xuanzang's own journey. Xuanzang describes one rock bearing "the trace of the Tathāgata's footprint with the wheel-sign dimly visible, which sometimes emits a light," and another "with a footprint of the Tathāgata, which varies in size according to the merits of the measurer."⁶ Buddhist vision is an act of ritual engagement and exchange, a feedback loop of religious efficacy. The visible perception of the physical world is inseparable from, indeed dependent on, religious practice. Xuanzang describes the Cave of the Buddha's Shadow in similar terms: "Formerly there was a shadow of the Buddha, resembling his true features with all the good physical marks, just as if he were alive. But in recent years it is not visible to everybody, and even those who see it can only perceive a distinct outline. Those who pray with utmost sincerity may get a spiritual response and see a clear picture, but only for a short moment."⁷

Xuanzang's quest for vision is both the subject and the function of the map, and it is perhaps the reason why this fourteenth-century image of a seventh-century text was copied by Buddhist monks for the next five hundred years. One of these later transcriptions bears a marginal inscription that reads: "Making this copy, I feel as if I have traveled to Tenjiku."⁸ In tracing the route of Xuanzang's pilgrimage, a Japanese monk living a thousand years after the Tang pilgrim felt as if he too had traveled to the Buddhist Holy Land. It was for him, and for other monastics who copied and venerated the map in various temple contexts, both a devotional object and a ritual means of reenacting, by quite literally retracing, Xuanzang's journey.

The Buddhist World in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction

The link between vision and knowledge of the Buddhist world is key to printed versions of the Buddhist world map as well, the first of which was produced by the Kego monk Hōtan (1659–1738) in 1710. Like Myōe, Hōtan planned, unsuccessfully, to travel to India and thus “consoled himself,” in the words of Takakusu Junjirō, “by bathing his feet in the seawater at a beach in the province of Kii and by indulging in the thought that the water extended to the shore of the motherland of Buddhism.”⁹ Titling his work a *Handy Map of the Myriad Countries of Jambudvīpa* (*Nansenbushū bankoku shōka no zu*) or, more literally, “Map of the Myriad Countries of Jambudvīpa Seen Like a Fruit Held in the Hand,” Hōtan uses a religious vocabulary to denote not only a Buddhist vision of the world but also the very quality of Buddhist vision itself (fig. 6.2). Hōtan’s preface explains, “The wisdom eye of the sage (J. *hijiri no egan*) is far more powerful than the human eye, and sees the boundless ten-thousand-fold world just like a fruit held in the hand.”

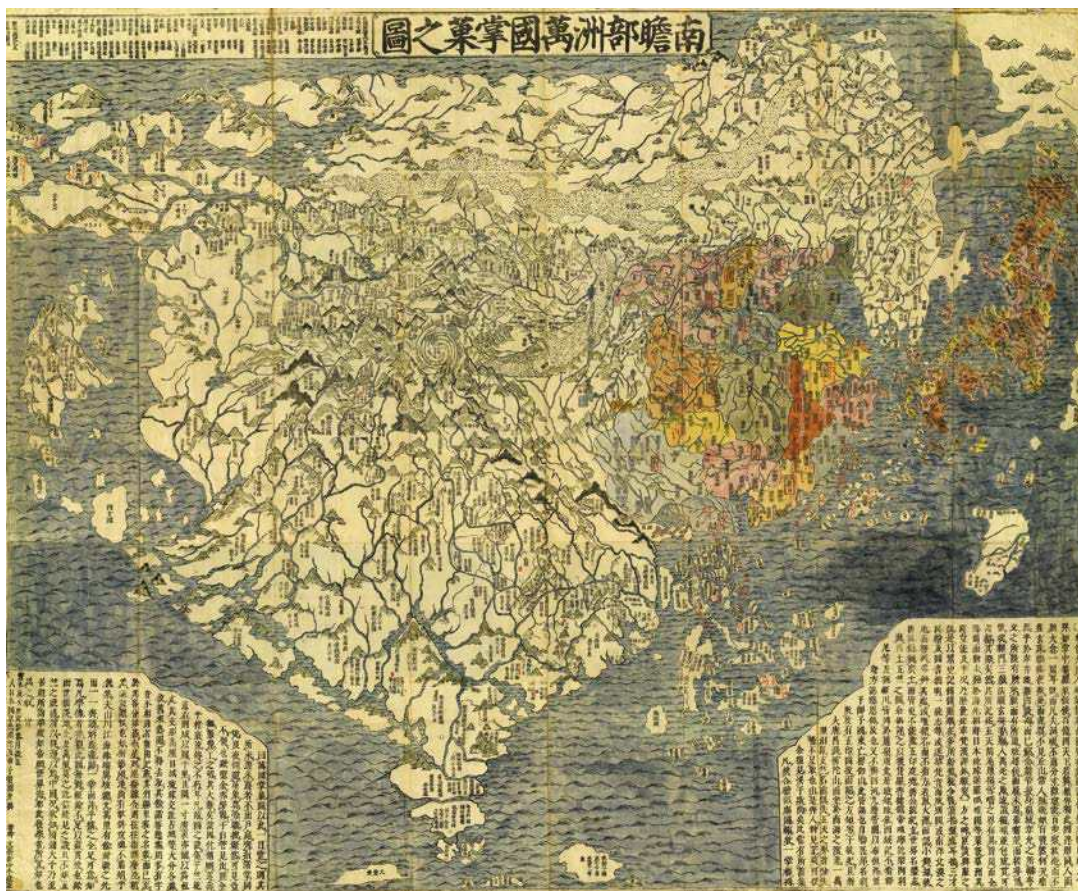


Figure 6.2 Hōtan, *Handy Map of the Myriad Countries of Jambudvīpa*, 1710. Woodblock print with hand coloring, 121 x 144 cm. David Rumsey Map Collection, Stanford University Libraries.

In the preface to his map, Hōtan also addresses the nature of the physical world, the Buddhist perception of it, and its nonhuman scale:

There are innumerable realms, as countless as the leaves of mustard grass beneath the four heavens. Our realm of Jambudvīpa is like a single grain within a great storehouse of millet. The ordinary person can see no more of the world than someone inside a cave peering through a tiny hole. Not even Li Lou, who could see something as minute as an autumn hair from the distance of a hundred paces, and who sought the dark pearl of the Yellow Emperor, had such vision. Human vision is as limited as that of the horned owl that can catch a flea at night but cannot see a hill at mid-day. The vision of an ordinary person is as far from the vision of the wisdom eye as that of a blind person is from the sighted. He can say nothing of the worlds as numerous as atoms. He is like a frog in a well discussing the vast oceans.

Hōtan's vocabulary of vision describes both a mode of perception and the world thusly perceived. His use of the term "wisdom eye" (Skt. *prajñā-cakṣus*) refers to the power of vision to discern the true nature of all things. It is one of the five levels of vision, or "five eyes," within the traditional Mahāyāna classification of knowledge.¹⁰ To this Buddhist vocabulary Hōtan adds allegories from the *Zhuangzi* to illustrate the limitations of conventional perception.¹¹

Yet Hōtan also finds limitations with previous descriptions of the scope and scale of the physical world, both Buddhist and non-Buddhist alike. He writes,

This world reaches beyond the distances travelled by such wise men of the past as Tai Zhang and Shu Hai or the remote regions explored by Ban Chao and Zhang Qian.¹² Not even the famous Buddhist monks Faxian and Xuanzang, who risked their lives traveling to Tenjiku and other distant lands in search of the Tripiṭaka, tell of it all. Although they described the Five Regions of Tenjiku, the realms of the barbarian tribes, the Pamir Mountains, and the Land of Snows, they knew nothing of foreign lands beyond the sea. They did not even visit Korea, Japan, the Ryūkyūs, Siam, or Java—countries as minor as scattered millet-seeds. Not even the successive generations of Indian and Chinese writers describe the entirety of this world.

Hōtan finds the existing cartographic record even less reliable than the bibliographic sources on which it rested. He criticizes the many manuscript versions of the *Map of the Five Regions of Tenjiku*, chastising their flaws and disputing their utility:

Many errors are to be found on copies of the *Map of the Five Regions of Tenjiku*. Such errors are not found in bibliographic sources such as Xuanzang's *Record of the Western Regions*, Huili's *Life of the Tripiṭaka Master of Daci'en Temple*, or [Daoxuan's] *Account of the Regional Spread of Buddhism* (*Shijia fangzhi*). Such

maps misrepresent the rivers and regions of distant lands. They include such errors as locating Mount Potalaka east of Simhala or failing to include Mount Lanka. In the past, copies of the *Map of the Five Regions of Tenjiku* have been venerated in famous temples throughout Japan. I have examined these maps, but I have found them to be inferior to those in [Zhipan's] *Complete Record of Buddhas and Patriarchs* (*Fozu tongji*). The place names of China and India are in disarray and the boundaries of the Five Regions of Tenjiku are obscured. It is inexpressibly lamentable. Such maps are worthless.

More than a visual display of quantitative information, the map offers a new way of seeing—total, unencumbered, and commanding. Hōtan explains: “I have integrated all of the mote-like countries of Jambudvīpa, and reduced the scale, so that it may be held in one’s hands. I have thus titled this publication ‘A Map of the Myriad Countries That May Be Held Like a Fruit in the Hand.’ With this map, one may take in the entire world in a single glance; one may visit distant places, without ever traveling beyond one’s garden gate; and one may point out the various countries of the world just as easily as pointing out the stars in the night sky.”

Such celebration of the powers of representation long preceded Hōtan. In the preface to his world map of 1602, Matteo Ricci praised his work as “enabling the spectator to travel about while reclining at ease in his study” and “to be able to scan all of the countries of the world in turn without going out of doors.”¹³ In his preface to the 1603 edition of Ricci’s map, Feng Yingjing articulated the same notion, writing that viewers of Ricci’s map “will get from it the pleasure of travelling while reclining at their ease . . . and the impression, though remaining in one’s own room, that one is travelling throughout the entire world.”¹⁴ This mode of imaginary wayfaring, literally “travelling while lying down” (Ch. *woyou*; J. *gayū*), was an East Asian geoaesthetic that extended from classical Chinese landscape painting to Edo-period print culture.¹⁵ Such imaginary travel was shared by Chinese Buddhists as well. “If you read this *Record* of mine,” wrote Yijing (635–713), who journeyed to India some fifty years after Xuanzang, “you may, without moving one step, travel in all of the Five Regions of Tianzhu [J. Tenjiku].”¹⁶ Yijing concluded his *Record*, moreover, by stating, “My real hope and wish is to represent Vulture Peak in the small rooms of my friends.”¹⁷ Hōtan’s contribution to this discursive history is to emphasize the epistemological insight of this theory of response.

Hōtan claims that an appreciation of the spatial scale of the earth and its significance as an object of Buddhist knowledge is necessary not simply for an accurate and complete understanding of the scriptures but also for the very survival of the Dharma in a changing world. If Japanese Buddhists were to compete successfully in the marketplace of ideas, then their geographic

knowledge would have to equal, or surpass, that of their intellectual competition. He concludes his preface with a warning and a call to action:

If Buddhist scholars do not examine this map when they consult the sūtras, then their investigations will be incomplete. Confucian scholars have debated geography and discussed distances for generations. [If Buddhist intellectuals do not similarly pursue geographic study,] our knowledge will be as insufficient as that of a frog in a well. There is so much still unknown about the Five Regions of Tenjiku. We must seek as much understanding of distant lands as we do our own, and even more so, of Mount Sumeru at the center of the universe and the vast trichiliocosm itself, just as Sudhana sought the Flower Realm and the vast world of Indra's Net.

Hōtan begins this, the final section of his preface, by echoing a warning that the Chinese monk Zhipan (1220–1275) had made centuries earlier about the significance of the world as an object of Buddhist knowledge: “If those who discuss the size and structure of the world do not rely on the Buddhist scriptures, their knowledge will be inadequate to the task.”¹⁸ Yet Hōtan concludes with a gesture toward the larger cosmic vision of the Buddhist tradition. He invokes the pilgrim Sudhana, whose journey toward enlightenment is the subject of the final section of the *Avataṃsaka* or *Kegon sūtra*, the eponymous scripture of Hōtan's lineage. The “Flower Realm” or the “Lotus Store World” (J. *kezō sekai*; Skt. *kusuma-tala-garbha-vyūhālaṃkāra*) sought by Sudhana refers to the pure land of the Buddha Vairocana, a cosmology of infinite world-systems. Likewise, the world of “Indra's Net” (J. *Taishaku mō*; Skt. *Indra-jāla*) is another image of limitless space and vision: an endless net hanging from Indra's heavenly palace atop Mount Sumeru, in which each strand is joined with jewels that reflect each other ad infinitum: an interconnected network of worlds within worlds. Sudhana achieved his quest for insight only at the end of his pilgrimage—and, significantly, with a visionary experience of the entire structure of the Buddhist universe: “Stripped of a delusion,” Sudhana “became clairvoyant without distortion” and, “with the unobstructed eye of liberation, saw all objects without hindrance.”¹⁹ The goal of Hōtan's map is nothing less than this soteriological vision of the world.

Hōtan's map of Jambudvīpa maintains the nuclear form of Lake Anavatapta and four great rivers that flow from the mouths of mythic beasts. The India and Central Asia of Xuanzang are still at the center of this world; their place names follow the *Record of the Western Regions*, and the size of each is given exactly as they appear in Xuanzang's seventh-century text. But Hōtan also adds new landforms to the Buddhist world as well: Europe appears in the upper left and North and South America in the upper and lower right corners of his map of Jambudvīpa. Hōtan has derived the names and forms these new lands from contemporaneous Japanese and Chinese

printed world maps based on those of Matteo Ricci. Yet in spite of this body of recent cartographic data, Hōtan gives no prominence either to the New World or the Old. His Indo-centrism relegates Europe and the Americas to peripheral lands that, in his Buddhist vocabulary, are “as minor as scattered millet-seeds.” Just as a unitary historicist narrative would presume a turn toward Western models, Hōtan’s Buddhist cartography offers instead a provincializing of Europe and the Americas.

The Buddhist World in Nineteenth-Century Japan

One hundred years later, the Tendai monk Fumon Entsū (1755–1834) would further extend Hōtan’s claims about the epistemology of vision. In his five-volume *Astronomy of Buddhist Countries* (*Bukkoku rekishōhen*) of 1810, Entsū writes:

The unsurpassed enlightenment attained by the Buddha clearly sees the innumerable worlds. The laws of karma explain the universe, even the creation and destruction of Mount Sumeru and the Triple World, and the movement of the sun, the moon, and the stars. These forms of Indian knowledge are far superior to the reasoning of contemporary scholars, which, compared to the wisdom of the Buddhas and bodhisattvas, is as insubstantial as the leaves of bamboo scattered by a whirlwind. The practitioners of Indian knowledge apprehend the true nature of phenomena and perceive everything in the world with the power of the heavenly eye.²⁰

Entsū includes a remarkable *Map of Jambudvīpa* in his five-volume compendia (fig. 6.3).²¹ Only the lower third of the map represents the realm of human habitation: a triangular landform cut off from the rest of the world. The northeast corner of this lower landmass is labeled “Asia,” the northwest corner labeled “Europe,” and “Africa” is inscribed in the southwest. As Entsū explains, “The three continents of Asia, Europe, and Africa that appear on the maps that Westerners have brought to Japan are what is called Jambudvīpa. . . . The three continents were originally one land. Its north, east, and west sides are nearly the same. Its south side is narrow and comes to a point.”²²

Entsū’s map of Jambudvīpa would inform the work of successive proponents of this Buddhist worldview throughout the nineteenth century. In 1821, Entsū’s student, the Pure Land monk Zontō (1781–1832), produced a large-format hand-colored print that offered a graphic presentation of Entsū’s world for public display (fig. 6.4). The hourglass-shaped cosmic mountain occupies the center of a radiating series of crags and seas, and the four great continents lie in the outermost oceans, with Jambudvīpa clearly foregrounded. Closely following Entsū’s *Map of Jambudvīpa*, Zontō includes Asia, Africa, and Europe within the triangular continent. Following the geography of Vasubandhu’s

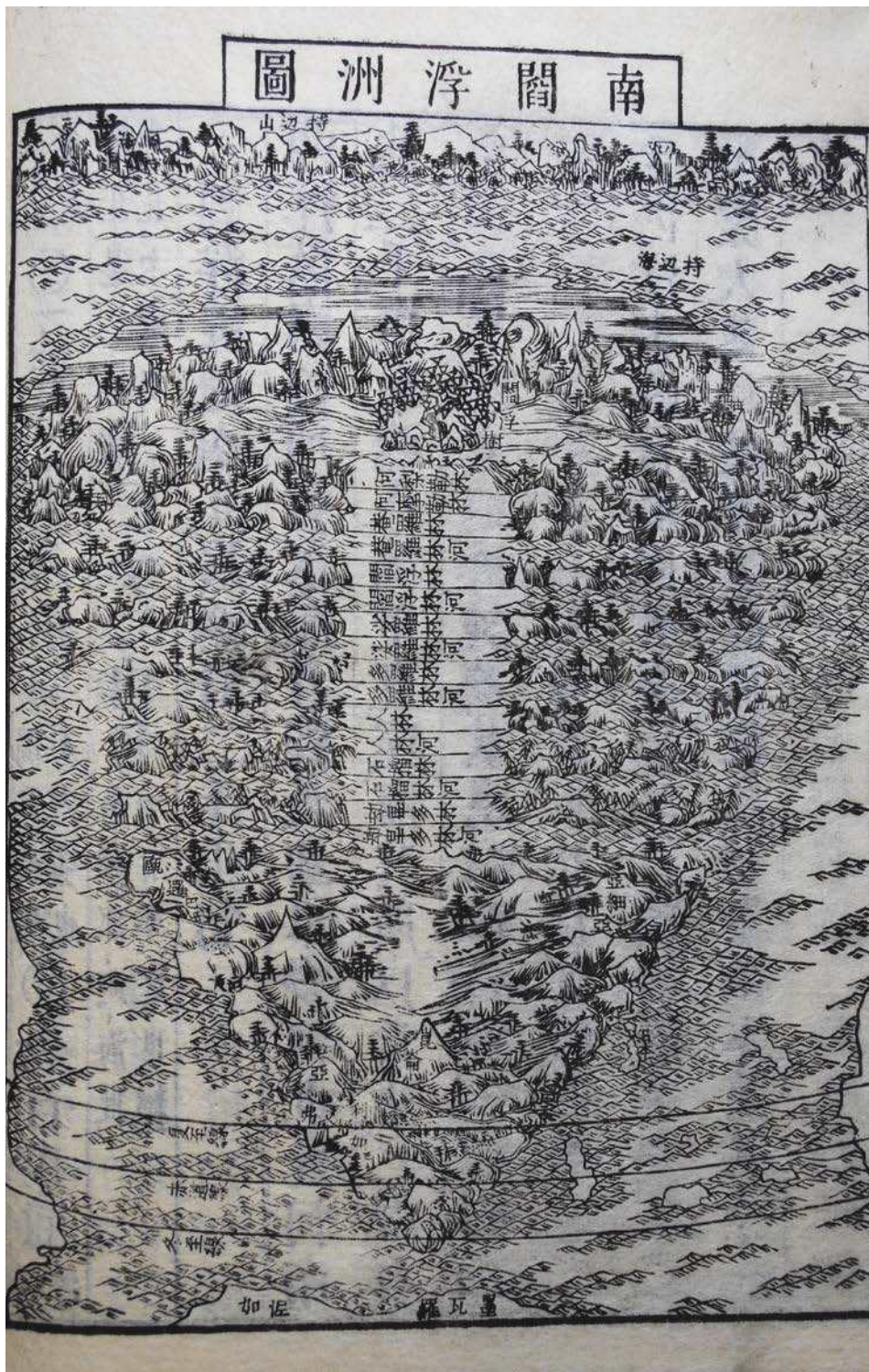


Figure 6.3 Fumon Entsū, *Map of Jambudvīpa* from *Astronomy of Buddhist Countries*, 1810. Woodblock printed book; ink on paper. Masahiko Okada Collection.

Treasury of Abhidharma, Zontō flanks Jambudvīpa with the smaller paired landforms known in Sanskrit as Cāmara and Avaracāmara. An inscription below this image reads:

According to the *Avataṃsaka sūtra*, the form of the universe is infinite, inexhaustible, and indescribable. Nevertheless, the form of the universe has often been described in both Mahāyāna and Hinayāna texts. This illustration of the Mount Sumeru world distinguishes the Three Realms of Desire, Form, and Formlessness and the Twenty-Five Stages of Existence. . . . Today those who purport to be learned and debate cosmology are unaware of the fact that the entire human realm is but one small part of the Realm of Desire. Those who refer to the world as “myriad lands” know nothing of the thousands of eons of the past and future.²³ Although they may think that they know all that there is to know, their knowledge is no more comprehensive than that of a frog in a well.

Ever since I was a child, I have had profound questions about the structure of the universe, and its past and future. These questions have only increased as I have grown to adulthood. One day, following the advice of a teacher, I read the section about the world in the *Treasury of Abhidharma* and learned of the shape and size of the universe and of the Three Realms. After investigating its details for many years, my doubts have melted away and my joy has never ceased. I have therefore produced this image so that others not be troubled with similar questions and doubts. There are of course already many illustrations of the Mount Sumeru universe[,] but they are all rather crude and rough. In recent years, a book entitled *Astronomy of Buddhist Countries* has been published. In order to clarify the foundations of calendrical science, it has produced a detailed analysis of astronomical matters and, on the basis of domestic and foreign texts, has corrected the errors of Western scholars. Those who study astronomy should read this book. The design and intention of my print is in complete accordance with it. Encompassing the various heavens and mountains where deities reside, the world of humans, and the distant worlds far away, this illustration makes small things large and large things small such that all can be seen, understood, and accepted, in a single glance.²⁴

Citing the world (*dhātu*) section of Vasubandhu’s *Treasury of Abhidharma* as his scriptural source and Entsū’s *Astronomy of Buddhist Countries* as his hermeneutic lens, Zontō offers a popular printed image of the classical Buddhist universe for the modern viewer. Like the cosmologies of Entsū and Hōtan before him, Zontō’s combines scriptural pedagogy with contemporary critique. Reaching back to the vocabulary and tropes that Hōtan had deployed over a century earlier, Zontō belittles the blinkered vision of those satisfied with the “myriad lands” of Ricci’s cartography as the myopic conceit of Zhuangzi’s

frog in a well. Zontō's most significant similarity with Hōtan, however, is the promise of a new modality of visual knowledge. Zontō's claim that his "illustration makes small things large and large things small such that all can be seen, understood, and accepted, in a single glance," like Hōtan's claim to "have integrated all of the mote-like countries of Jambudvīpa and reduced the scale so . . . one can take in the entire world in a single glance," offers the panopticism of Buddhist insight through the visual medium of the commercial print.

A few years later, Zontō produced an even more detailed map of Jambudvīpa characterized by an even greater amalgamation of Buddhist cosmology and Western cartography (fig. 6.5).²⁵ Titled *Illustration of Jambudvīpa with the Sun* (*Enbudai tsuketari nichikanzu*), Zontō's second print corresponds to his print of 1821 in size and format. The upper register is filled with a traditional representation of Jambudvīpa, similar to the upper sections of both Entsū's illustration and the detail of Jambudvīpa in Zontō's earlier print. In the lower section of Jambudvīpa, where Entsū's illustration and Zontō's earlier print had depicted an undifferentiated terrain or a simple array of toponyms, Zontō here supplies a finely detailed European-style



Figure 6.4 Zontō, *Expanded Image of the World*, 1821. Woodblock print with hand coloring, 195 x 64 cm. Library of Congress.

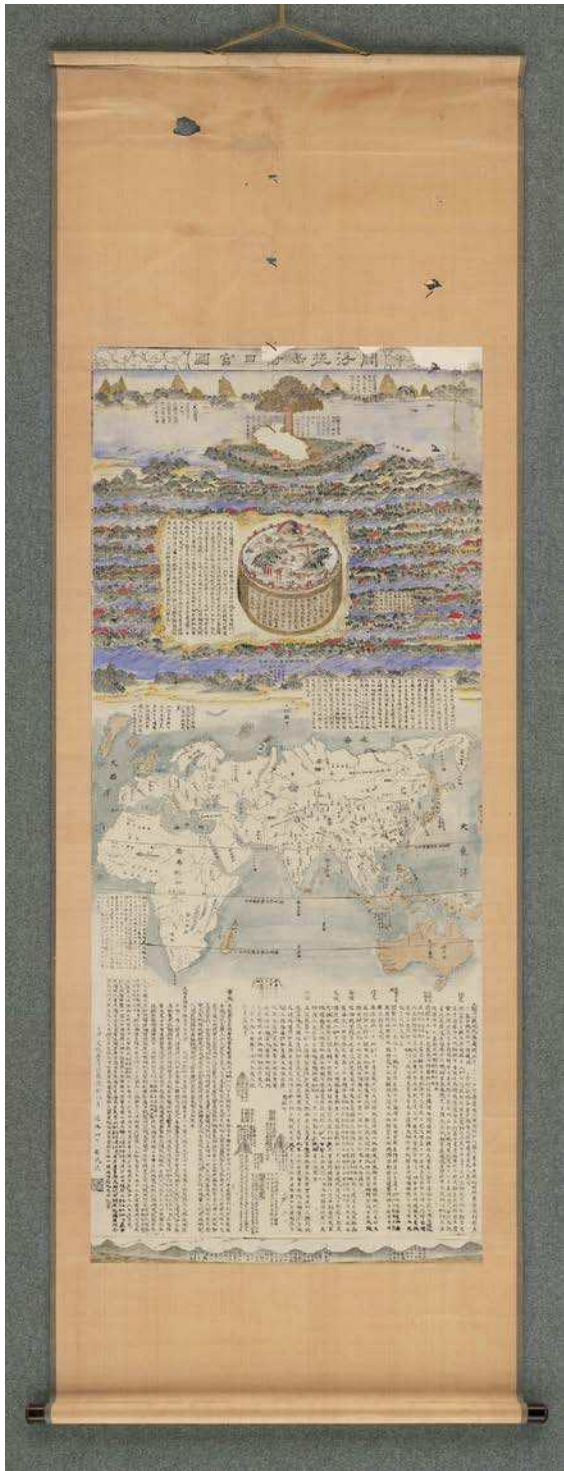


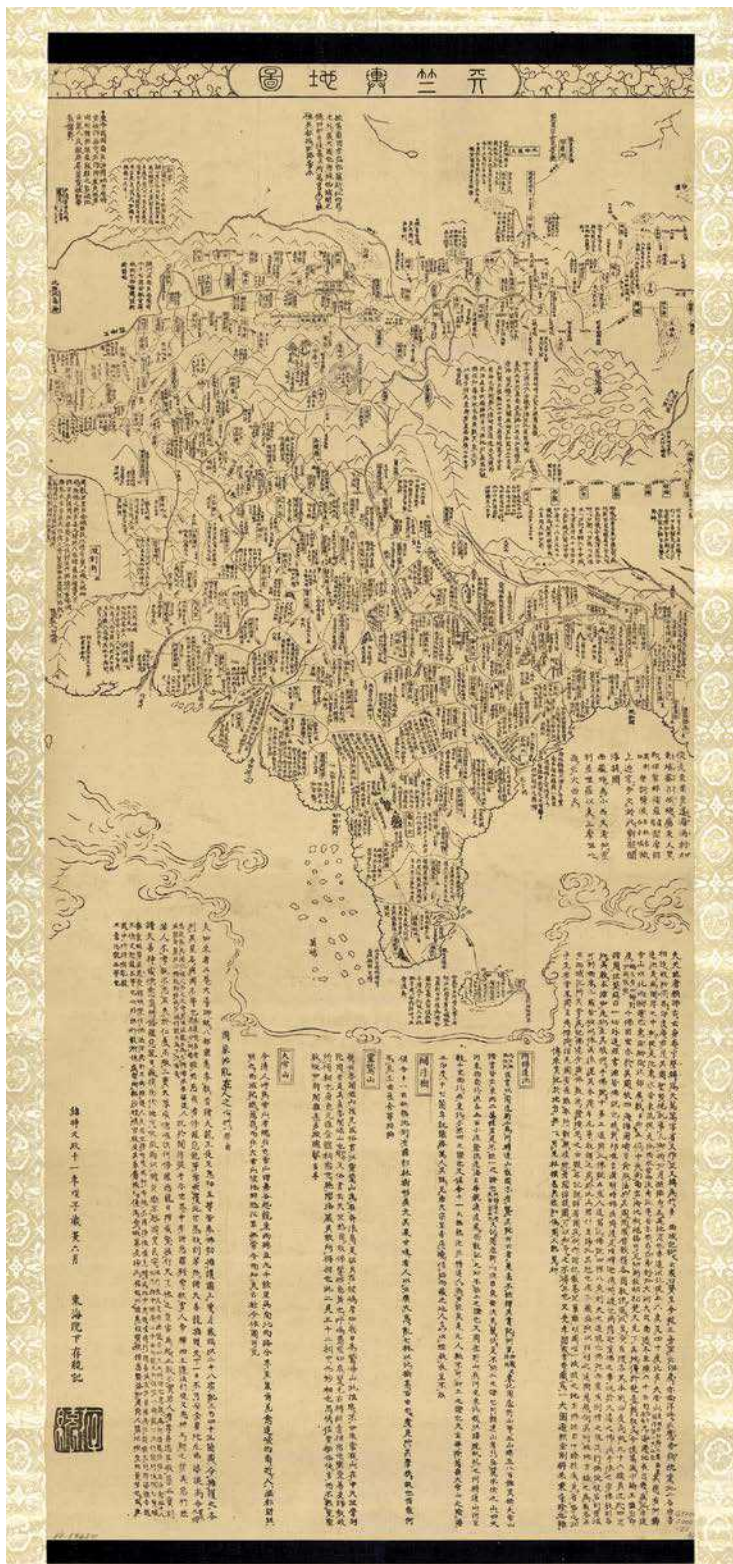
Figure 6.5 Zontō, *Illustration of Jambudvīpa with the Sun*, ca. 1821–1828. Woodblock print with hand coloring, 195 x 64 cm. Yokohama City University Library.

map of the eastern hemisphere with the continents of Asia, Africa, Europe, and Australia carefully rendered and named.

Yet however much this new map of Jambudvīpa may seem to conform to the latest conventions of western cartography, its classical orientation is marked by the mythic Lake Anavatapta at its center. Although the topography of the subcontinent appears modern, India is still named the Five Regions of Tenjiku, and its place names conform to Xuanzang's list compiled a thousand years earlier. As with Hōtan's and Entsū's maps of Jambudvīpa, the Americas remain wholly absent. What might appear to be the Pacific coastline of North America protruding from the map's eastern margin is instead labeled Avaracāmara, the island east of Jambudvīpa, according to the geography of the *Treasury of Abhidharma*. Australia is included as well, but it is given the additional name of Cāmara, the island that Buddhist sources locate to the west of the world continent. While Zontō has added Australia and North America to Entsū's Buddhist world, they have been Sanskritized and returned to the classical geography of Jambudvīpa.

If the Japanese Buddhist world maps of Hōtan, Entsū, and Zontō remained unconcerned with the geography of Australia and the Americas—reducing, erasing, or Sanskritizing their presence—their representation of India remained tenaciously canonical. The *Map of Tenjiku* (*Tenjiku yochizu*) published by Zontō in 1828 seems to conform in outline to contemporary European maps of India (fig. 6.6). Yet it divides the subcontinent into the Five Regions of

Figure 6.6 Zontō,
Map of Tenjiku, 1828.
Woodblock print,
195 x 64 cm. Library
of Congress.



Tenjiku and maintains the traditional landmarks of Jambudvīpa that go back to Jūkai's fourteenth-century prototype. We still find Lake Anavatapta at its center, together with the four animal heads out of whose mouths flow the four great rivers. Temples and stūpas are drawn throughout the landscape. In the Buddhist heartland are inscribed such sacred sites as the Diamond Throne and the Bodhi Tree where Gautama attained enlightenment; the groves and monastery of Jetavana, where the early Buddhist community was established; Vulture Peak (drawn with an avian head) where the Mahāyāna sūtras were preached; and Kuśinagara, where Śākyamuni passed into final *nirvāṇa*.

Passages of text in the lower register of the map provide further details about such crucial landmarks as Lake Anavatapta, the Jambu Tree, Vulture Peak, and the Great Snow Mountains. In his prefatory remarks, Zontō claims that “children are unable to read the detailed descriptions of India that Xuanzang recorded in the many volumes of his *Record of the Western Regions*. With this map, however, they can see it all clearly in a single glance.”²⁶ With this now familiar turn of phrase, Zontō makes the Buddhist India of Xuanzang's *Record* visible to all. He does so, however, in a manner altogether new. He has taken the geographical contents of Xuanzang's seventh-century *Record*, as had been preserved within the manuscript tradition of the *Map of the Five Regions of Tenjiku*—complete with the pilgrim's itinerary, toponymy, directions, distances, and his detailed descriptions of the devotional landscape of Buddha's sacred traces—and reconfigured it entirely within the confines of a nineteenth-century cartography of the Indian subcontinent.

Buddhist India, as represented in its classical literature of cosmology and pilgrimage, remained, it seems, the last preserve of religious identity and authenticity in an increasingly Western world. The trajectory of modernity was not, for all Japanese, ineluctable and unidirectional. Within the Buddhist visual culture of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Japan, classical views of the earth, of the universe, and of the geomorphology of India were well represented, and at times prominently so, within the marketplace of ideas and the world of the commercial print.

NOTES

1. Yee, “Chinese Cartography among the Arts,” 137; and Yee, “Chinese Maps in Political Culture,” 91.
2. Bray, “Introduction,” 2.
3. *Da Tang xiyuji*, T51.869c; Li, *Record*, 18.
4. *Myōe shōnin shingen denki*, in Kōzanji Tenseki Monjo Sōgō Chōsadan, *Myōe shōnin shiryō*, 1:237.
5. Barrett, “Exploratory Observations,” 102–103.

6. *Da Tang xiyuji*, T51.882c. Li, *Record*, 85.
7. *Da Tang xiyuji*, T51.878c. Li, *Record*, 67.
8. On this undated Edo-period transcription, see Moerman, *Japanese Buddhist World Map*.
9. Takakusu, “India and Japan,” 36.
10. Muller, *Digital Dictionary of Buddhism*, s.v. 五眼.
11. The phrase “single grain within a vast storehouse” as well as “the horned owl who can catch a flea at night but cannot see a hill at mid-day” and “the frog in the well who knows nothing of the vast oceans” are drawn from the “Autumn Floods” chapter of the *Zhuangzi*. Li Zhu’s unsuccessful search for the “Dark Pearl of the Yellow Emperor” is from the “Heaven and Earth” chapter. See Watson, *Complete Works of Chuang Tzu*, 176, 180, and 186. The *Huainanzi* also notes that “Li Zhu’s vision was so acute that he could pick out the tip of a needle beyond a hundred paces.” Major, *Huainanzi*, 55.
12. The mythical figures Tai Zhang and Shu Hai were ordered by the legendary sage-king Yu to pace the dimensions of the world from east to west and from north to south. They appear in both the *Huainanzi* and the *Shanhaijing*. See Major, *Huainanzi*, 155. Ban Chao (32–102 CE) was a general who administered Central Asia during the Eastern Han. Zhang Qian (200–114 BCE) was an imperial envoy who explored Central Asia during the Han.
13. Giles, “Translations,” 369–370.
14. D’Elia, “Recent Discoveries,” 129, 132.
15. Goree, “Fantasies of the Real,” 110–115.
16. Takakusu, *Record*, 19.
17. *Ibid.*, 215.
18. Zhipan, *Fozu tongji*, 313a22–29.
19. Cleary, *Entry into the Realm of Reality*, 366.
20. Entsū, *Bukkoku rekishōhen*, Preface, 1:1a–b.
21. *Ibid.*, 3:29b.
22. *Ibid.*, 3:6b–7a.
23. “Myriad lands” (J. *bankoku*) is a term commonly used in the titles of Japanese world maps based on those of Matteo Ricci, produced from the seventeenth through the nineteenth century.
24. Gotō, “Zontō Shōnin saku *Sekaidaisōzu*,” 11.
25. The date of the print is unclear. Although the woodblock is dated “Fifth Year of the Bunka Era (1808),” the text within the print refers to his print of 1821. The world map in the lower register of the print is also indebted to a later source. Zontō’s *Map of Tenjiku*, published in 1828, also refers to the *Illustration of Jambudvīpa with the Sun*. The print was thus produced between 1821 and 1828. Gotō, “Zontō Shōnin no *Enbudai tsuketari nichikanzu*,” 16–17.
26. Transcribed in Gotō, “Zontō Shōnin saku *Sekaidaisōzu*,” 16.

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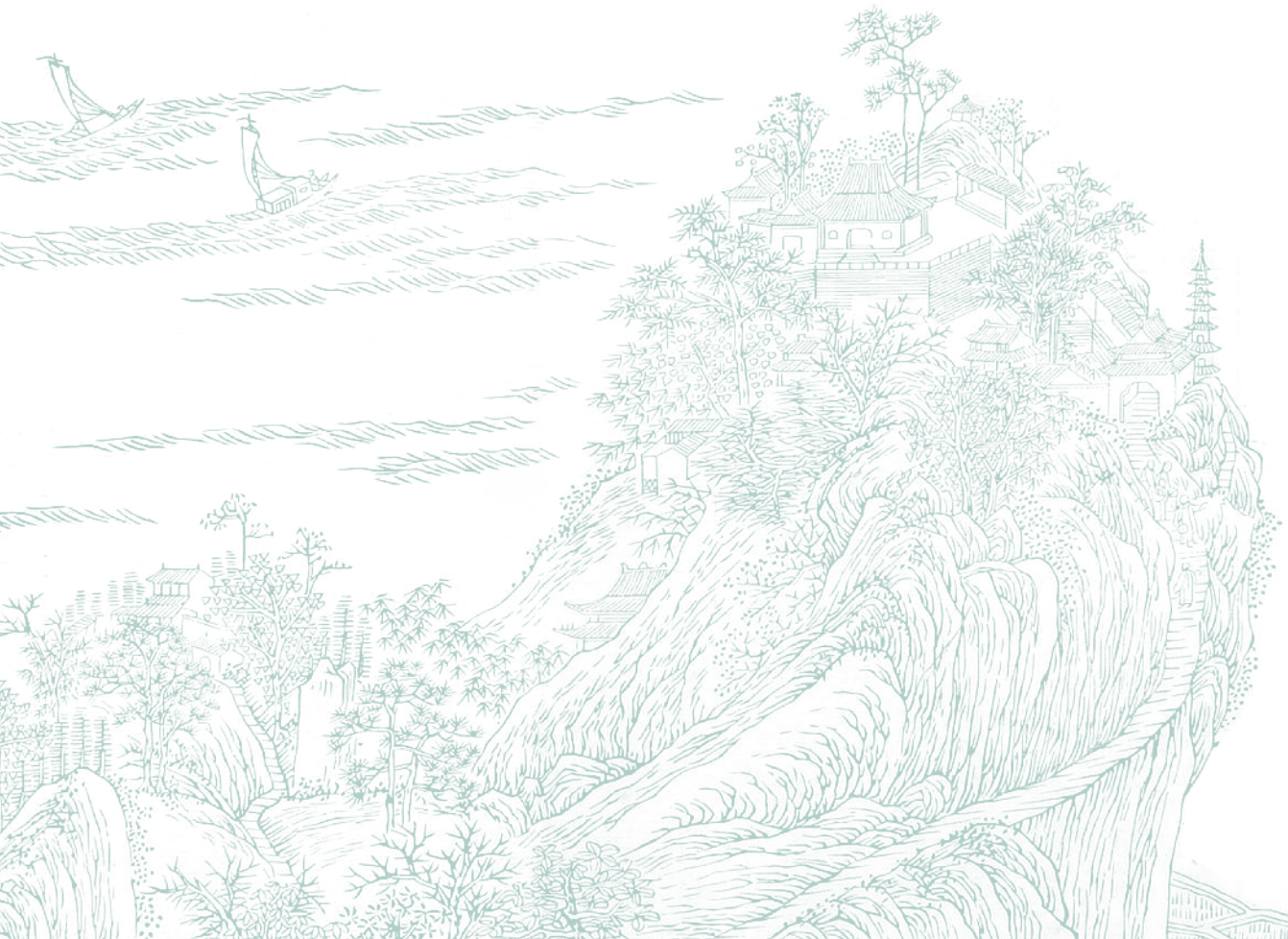
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PART III

Environments in the Shaping of Medieval Buddhism





CHAPTER 7

Human Places and Cosmic Spaces

Ecological Engagements at Ellora

Tamara Sears

One of the best-known sites in India, Ellora is notably home to nearly three dozen rock-cut monuments, dating primarily between the sixth and tenth centuries. Long recognized as an early medieval *tirtha*, or site of pilgrimage, it has been widely extolled as a place where architectural innovation and natural beauty are fundamentally interwoven. Situated along the edge of a long plateau, the site boasts thirty-four caves in total, extending across approximately one mile, and representing Śaiva (Hindu), Buddhist, and Jain religious communities (fig. 7.1). The earliest among these were the Śaiva caves, which date back to the middle of the sixth century. Within a couple of generations, the Śaivas were joined by Buddhists, who began carving out monastic spaces at the outset of the seventh century. The Jain caves date significantly later, to the late eighth through tenth centuries. Each of these occupied a distinct spatial zone. The Hindu caves, which are by far the most numerous, extend across a large stretch in the center of the site. The Buddhist and Jain caves occupy significant yet smaller areas to the south and north, respectively.

By far the most famous monument at the site is the mid-eighth-century Kailāśanatha temple, often attributed to the king Krishna I, who rose to power around 756-757 and led the Rāṣṭrakūṭa dynasty to victory over the last of the Cālukya kings. Art historians have gravitated to it for good reason. Not only is it by far the largest architectural complex at the site, it is also the only one that can be linked even provisionally to royal patronage.¹ Writing about it in 1996, Walter Smith described it as a metaphor of the temple as mountain,

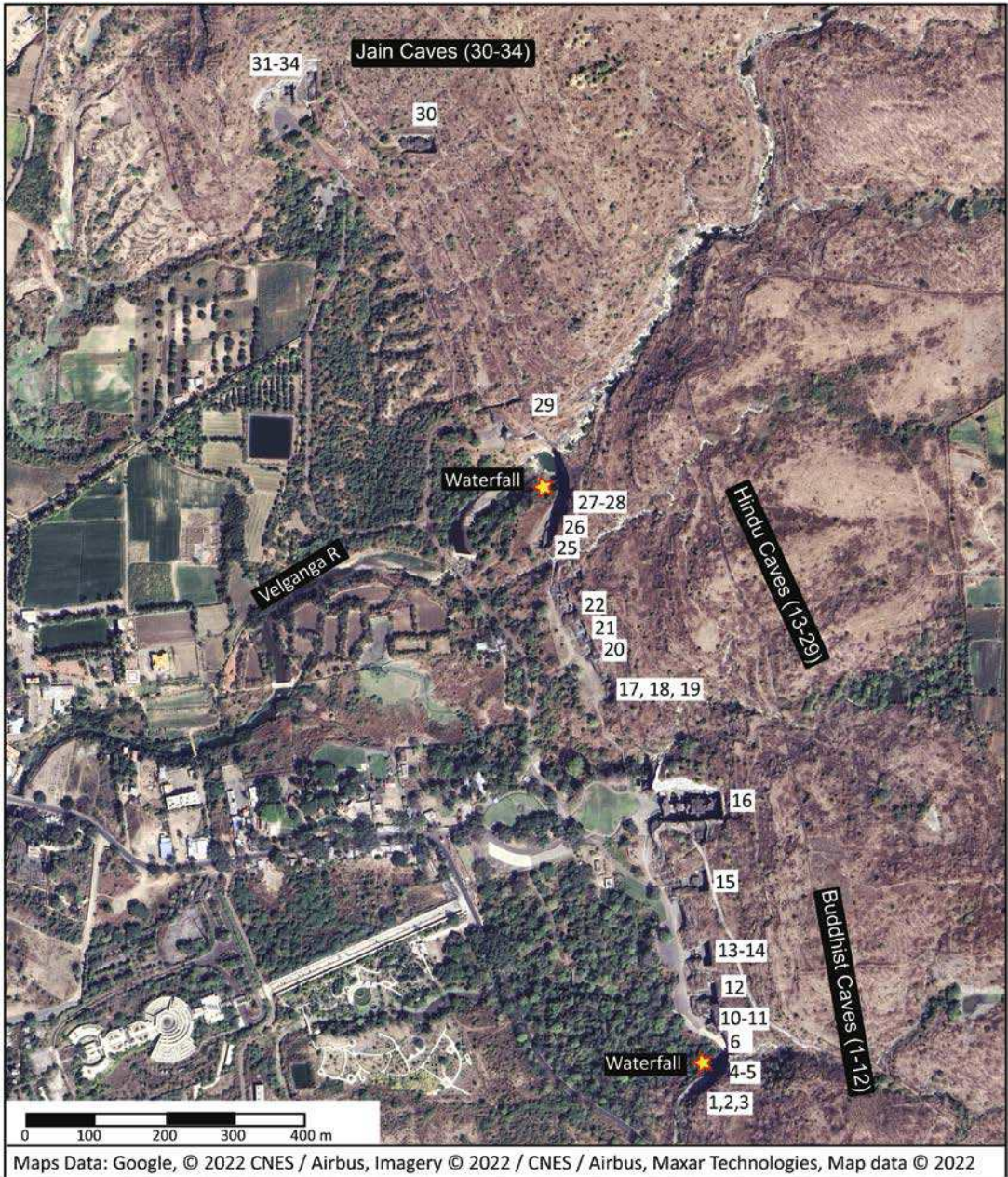


Figure 7.1 Site map of Ellora. Produced by author using QGIS.

as a “complex attempt to evoke an aesthetic equivalent . . . of the remote Himalayan abode of Śiva” and of the surrounding landscape as evoking the notion of an idyllic forest or ascetic grove conducive for the performance of austerities and yoga.² In his mind, both the monumental scale and direct approach reinforced the new imperial formation, enabling the Rāṣṭrakūṭas to

symbolically and conceptually shift the center of India from the north to the Deccan.

While the Kailāsanatha temple is impressive, it also comes late in the history of Ellora's building—after at least 250 years of earlier sustained Hindu and Buddhist construction. The earliest activity was situated elsewhere, around two horseshoe-shaped gullies that served as the site's primary watercourses. During the monsoon, the rainwaters flowed freely downward over the rock, feeding cisterns built into the structure of Ellora's monasteries and temples and filling a large reservoir below, fueling a complex hydrological system that sustained both the larger site and the landscape. Unlike the Kailāsanatha, these earlier caves were likely built not for royal display but rather to foster the growth of potent ritual practices overseen by growing ascetic communities, who not merely drew upon the idea of the mountain as a natural *tīrtha* (pilgrimage place) but also engaged the geomorphology and hydrology of the larger site in deceptively complex ways.

This chapter examines the agency of Ellora's landscape in encouraging new forms of creative engagement during this early phase of building. I look at the ways in which art and architectural practices represent not only a response to natural environments but also a mechanism for spatially and for visually expressing deeply rooted systems of soteriology and ritual practice. I draw upon recent work by scholars such as Sugata Ray, who has talked about a particular “hydroaesthetics” that emerged in response to climate change during the “little ice age” in early modern northern India, in which both the representation and the architectural framing of devotional water landscapes played a key role.³ I also draw from Sonya Lee's recent reframing of rock-cut Buddhist temples in Sichuan, China, as embedded in nature, in which the natural landscape takes on a significant role in the establishment of caves. In addition to arguing for the efficacy of sites themselves in fending off natural disasters, including the potential for flooding, through both their construction and iconographic programs, Lee examines the ways in which caves, once established, continued to engage audiences invested in their ongoing maintenance and care.⁴

Given its cultic diversity, Ellora provides an exceptional opportunity to think both through and beyond religious categories to foreground the ways in which a singular physical landscape may have inspired multiple communities to maximize the expressive potential of sculptural programs and spatial design. Thus, while my main focus is on Śaiva material, I draw in comparisons from Buddhism to take into account the fact that both groups possessed a shared cultural knowledge that was rooted in older cosmologies and understandings of the natural world. Scholars have long acknowledged that individual guilds of artisans, sculptors, and architects were employed by multiple religious communities, and that multiple guilds may have been simultaneously active at a

given building site.⁵ Similarly, building technologies and engineering practices were regionally, rather than religiously, aligned. By the time of Ellora's initial construction in the sixth and seventh centuries, the art of excavating cave temples at other sites in the region already had a robust history, stretching back at least to the third century BCE. While the vast majority of the earliest planned complexes were Buddhist, the growth of Hindu rock-cut traditions, particularly from the fifth century onward, introduced new ways of meaningfully integrating the geology and hydrology of local landscapes with sculptural programs and ritual practices.⁶

This chapter has three parts. The first part looks at Ellora's geology and topography to provide a sense for how it shaped, and was shaped by, the activities of Ellora's earliest builders. The next part then turns attention to my key case example, a Śaiva cave (29) popularly known today as the Dumar Lena, which represents the earliest of the site's fully intact excavations, with a specific focus on how its Śaiva spatial and sculptural program actively engaged Ellora's geology and hydrology. My argument is that the builders of this cave—most likely a group of Śaiva ascetics belonging to a Lakulīśa-Pāśupata lineage—consciously exploited the geology of the site in order to achieve effects that were meaningful in terms not only of managing the monsoon waters but also of homologizing natural phenomena and spiritual attainment. Finally, the last part looks at nearby Buddhist material at Ellora, and to a lesser extent at other nearby sites, in order to evaluate the extent to which we might think in terms of shared environmental concerns and practices. While the rich body of later Jain material remains beyond the scope of the current chapter, it is clear that Jain builders similarly engaged both the natural geology of the site and its earlier Śaiva and Buddhist architectural landscape.⁷

Geology and Hydrology

In my first task, that of laying out the physical structure of the local landscape, I am indebted to two sources. The first are reports published over the past fifteen years by the Geological Survey of India, with an eye toward developing a comprehensive plan for conservation.⁸ The second is a recent essay by James Wescoat, published in the journal *Geomorphology*. Wescoat builds upon the Geological Survey to analyze the evolving human use of landforms in the Deccan during different historical periods.⁹ Formed by the mass flow of lava approximately 150 million years ago, the larger region of the Deccan features a stepped landscape consisting of extensive stretches of fine-grained basalt buttes and scarps—or, in other words, isolated flattop hills and cliffs rising steeply, almost vertically, above an otherwise horizontal landscape. These scarps and buttes lent themselves well to the creation of rock-cut monuments,

making the Deccan an ideal setting for ascetic dwelling. Throughout its history, Ellora remained connected not only to other rock-cut religious centers but also to the routes connecting older cities along the Godavari River basin with newly emerging political centers in the Deccan.¹⁰

Like most of the subcontinent, the Deccan's monsoon climate presented significant environmental challenges to regional inhabitants. On the one hand, the summer rains could cause torrential flooding, mass erosion of rock surfaces, and wide-scale destruction. On the other hand, the extended dry season could produce severe water shortages unless measures were taken to harness the monsoon waters so that they could be available for use throughout the year. These difficulties were not lost on early medieval makers, who devised ways both to mitigate the damage and to safely capture and retain the runoff from the rains. Builders took full advantage of the naturally occurring gullies and crevices that proliferated along the scarps' surfaces. They intentionally incised or widened channels along the cliffs in order to better regulate and direct the flow of water into lakes, rivers, and streams that could support not only the cave-dwelling ascetics but also the development of outlying settlements. The igneous nature of the rock itself was advantageous. Its porosity enabled water to penetrate its surfaces, creating pockets of subsurface groundwater that could be tapped to create rock-cut cisterns.¹¹

At Ellora, builders were fully aware of the geological and topographic variance of surfaces and were able to exploit them to their best advantage. They targeted less fractured slopes for carving out cave temples and reserved those that were more severely porous and weathered for drainageways between excavations.¹² The hydrological landscape played a crucial role in determining the location for Ellora's excavations. The earliest of these, Caves 27–29, were clustered on either side of a massive chasm at the top of the mesa that served as both a seasonal stream and a mechanism for retaining water during the dry season (figs. 7.1 and 7.2). During the monsoon, the heavy rainfall filled the chasm, transforming it into a veritable river, whose waters cascaded over the steep ledge, down past the caves, and into a massive and naturally occurring crater, which served as a reservoir. The overflow from the reservoir, in turn, fed the local Velgaṅgā River that connected the site with nearby villages. The bed of the stream that fed the waterfall was naturally sloped and cratered. Whereas the slope directed the rainwater downward with a degree of precision, the craters increased the capacity of the stream's holdings. In addition to mitigating the impact of the full force of a torrential downpour on the caves below, the craters retained substantial amounts of water, creating a series of small ponds that persisted through the dry season.

The preference for situating cave clusters in close proximity to monsoon waters was not exclusive to the Śaiva excavations.¹³ When Buddhists began building a few generations later (ca. 600–630), they deliberately chose a location that



Figure 7.2 View of the reservoir fed by the monsoon waterfall between Caves 27 and 29, Ellora, ca. sixth century CE. Photograph by the author.

was similarly fed by overhead waters. The two earliest Buddhist caves (5 and 6) were similarly positioned on either side of a second, smaller stream that similarly transformed into a waterfall during the monsoon and provided a nearby means for retaining water throughout the year. The capacity for water storage was enhanced and the potential for storm damage was mitigated through the application of sophisticated water management and harvesting systems in many of the Buddhist caves. Water channels and drainage holes were created to direct the flow of water into tanks and cisterns below.¹⁴

It is worth noting that the builders across the site were careful to position the early excavations close enough to streams and waterfalls to take advantage of their presence but far enough away to mitigate the chance of water damage. Caves 27 and 29, for example, were situated at a comfortable distance from the massive chasm that became the site's main monsoon waterfall. Whereas cave 29 was positioned high up on the hilltop to ensure a safe viewing of the cascading water, cave 27 stood nearly 200 feet to the south, out of range of the torrential flow. This ingenuity was not lost on later travelers. In describing Ellora in the *Tadhkirat al-mulūk* (*Memorial of Kings*), a Persian history penned in the courts of Bijapur in 1612, Rafī' al-Din drew particular attention to the smooth surfaces of Ellora's temples, writing that in contrast with other sites in the Deccan, the slopes possessed "absolutely no cracks, joints, fissures, or rubble."¹⁵ It is worth

noting that in their published reports, the Geological Survey also found the quality of the rock to be “uniformly good inside caves,” in contrast to the “highly fractured zones” that extended on the uncarved portions of the site.¹⁶

Śiva’s Cosmic Topographies

That the physical landscape played a significant role in building construction and sculptural design at Ellora can be seen particularly in the case of the Dumar Lena, which was situated, as noted above, directly overlooking the site’s largest waterfall. Seen from a distance, the Dumar Lena’s chiseled exterior surfaces blend almost seamlessly into the scarp face (fig. 7.3). However, its interior possessed a remarkably complex visual spatial program that unfolded along a cruciform plan, with three entryways carved out to the north, south, and west (fig. 7.4). Situated at the fourth end, to the east, was a small, square sanctum that enshrined a large Śiva-*linga* that served as the temple’s main icon. In addition to lending a feeling of lightless and airiness to the otherwise solid stone interior, these three entrances established patterns of movement and vision that brought real-world topography into direct dialogue with a potent spatial articulation of Śaiva cosmology. Put succinctly, it enacted in visual and spatial form the full drama of cosmic dissolution and reunification, which was reinforced in significant ways through seasonal dialogues with the natural landscape.¹⁷



Figure 7.3 Overview of Cave 29 (Dumar Lena) from the southwest, Ellora, ca. sixth century CE. Photograph by the author.

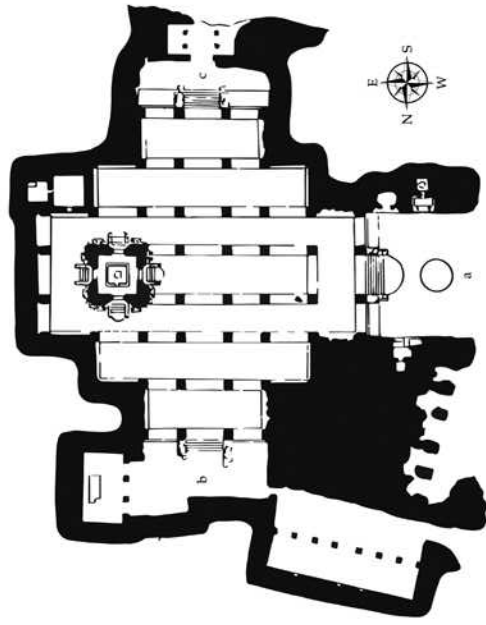


Figure 7.4 Plan and views of the exterior of Cave 29 (Dumar Lena) showing: (a) the west façade, (b) the approach along the north, and (c) the approach from the south, Ellora, ca. sixth century CE. Plan after Burgess, *Report on the Ellora Cave Temples*. Photographs by the author.

Cut into the front face of the mountain facing the valley and river beyond, the western façade likely functioned as the temple's primary pathway to the interior. Entry was facilitated by a short stairway flanked by elaborately carved lions, leading up to a four-pillared veranda, and onward directly toward the *liṅga* shrine. By contrast, the other two entrances were far less accessible. The southern entrance stood both at the end of a long, winding journey along a narrow path hugging the side of the mountain and also a full story below the level of the temple, which required visitors to undertake a steep ascent. The northern entrance was even more elusive, as it was impenetrable from the exterior world. It provided exclusive passage to a small complex of rock-cut residential caves that most likely housed the temple's resident sages. Although invisible from the exterior, both the northern and southern façades were furnished fully with the same formal stairway and verandah found to the west.

In addition to establishing two distinct axial approaches through the temple, the Dumar Lena's three entrances also served as the primary locus for its interior visual program. Flanking the passage through the bay just beyond each entrance was pair of larger-than-life-size sculptural panels. Positioned on the side walls facing each other, these panels present an interpretive challenge. Individually they follow already established modes of representing events also narrated in the epics and *Purāṇas*. However, rather than following a narrative order, each pair presents a set of homologous oppositions that highlight the potency of the god who served, in the worldview of the temple's builders, as the primary agent in the cyclical drama of the creation and destruction on a cosmic scale (*saṃsāra*). Even more importantly, each pair appears to have been positioned in ways that drew meaning through their juxtaposition with key physical features of the site itself. Simply put, soteriology, cosmology, and topography appear to have been visually and spatial woven together through the sculptural program.

To make this case, I offer a close reading of the imagery, beginning with the pair of sculptures flanking the primary entrance to the west, which depict Śiva in the acts of overcoming demons and maintaining cosmic order (fig. 7.5a–b). In the panel on the south side, Śiva and Pārvatī are seated together in their celestial palace on Mount Kailāśa. They sit closely together, their bodies intertwined. Pārvatī rests her shoulder against Śiva's torso and their gazes meet as Śiva's hand reaches over, cupping her breast. Their bodies appear fused, as if almost a single entity, immovable and fixed, unperturbed by the tumult below caused by the vigorous assault of a powerful, ten-headed demon. The story depicted is that of Rāvaṇa attempting to shake Śiva's mountainous abode. Although its source is Vaiṣṇava rather than Śaiva, here it stands as a testament to Śiva's power. As told in the sixteenth *sarga* of the *Uttarakhanda* book of Valmiki's *Rāmāyana*, while traveling in his celestial chariot, Rāvaṇa was unexpectedly halted by a magic unmovable force. Śiva's attendant Nandi appeared

and informed the demon that all living beings were forbidden entry to the god's heavenly home. Angered, Rāvaṇa threatened to tear up the mountain and uproot it from the ground. The violent upheaval was short-lived, as Śiva quelled the shaking by “playfully” pressing down on the mountain with a single big toe.¹⁸ Here Śiva and Pārvatī are depicted as an ideal royal couple, bejeweled and surrounded by courtly attendants. Their home appears as a divine analogue to a worldly court positioned, fittingly, at the entrance that looks out at the earthly kingdom beyond. The emphasis on Śiva's home as mountain, and the knowledge that Pārvatī herself was the daughter of the mountain Himavān, was likely not lost on the viewer encountering it after a steep climb.

In contrast to Śiva's seeming immobility in the scene of Rāvaṇa shaking mount Kailāśa, the panel on the north wall depicts the deity as a fierce warrior actively slaying the demon Andhaka. According to the story, which appears in numerous versions, Andhaka achieves divine powers through ascetic practice and then sets off to seduce Pārvatī, for whom he forms an uncontrollable attraction. In the ensuing battle, Śiva emerges triumphant by killing Andhaka with his trident, completely burning away his flesh, and, consequently, conquering the demon's insatiable lust for Pārvatī. Śiva's power is expressed through his *aghora* form: his blazing third eye is situated prominently on his forehead, his mouth is wide open revealing teeth that are jagged and fanged, and his matted hair is dressed with skulls. In his right hands he grasps a sword and a snake. His lower left arm stretches forward displaying the threatening *tarjani* mudra. Andhaka appears twice, indicating that we are witnessing two moments. We see Śiva grasping the demon, who hangs helplessly upside down to the viewer's lower left, and we see him again, on the upper right, as Śiva triumphantly displays his impaled body like a demonic shish kebab. Andhaka's hands reach upward, clasped in *anjali* mudra, indicating his conversion and liberation through his vanquishment, while his legs arch downward directly above Śiva's bowl, which is outstretched to capture every drop of blood, which, if allowed to hit the ground, would give birth to new demons.¹⁹

Together the juxtaposition of these panels establishes two larger meta-themes that extend throughout the larger visual program. The first emphasizes Śiva's dual nature as both a heavenly householder dwelling in a mountaintop palace and a fierce yogi living as a wilderness ascetic. The second evokes the drama of *saṃsāra*, the cycle of creation and dissolution through which gods and goddesses become separated and reunited, and in which asceticism and yoga functioned as a key means for attaining a form of spiritual liberation that resulted in the practitioner's achievement of permanent union with Śiva. In this pairing, the scene of Rāvaṇa shaking Mount Kailāśa highlights the strength of Śiva's union with Pārvatī and the god's role as protector of things both heavenly and worldly and as a divine analogue to an earthly king. By contrast, the Andhakasura-murti marks a point of separation, through which

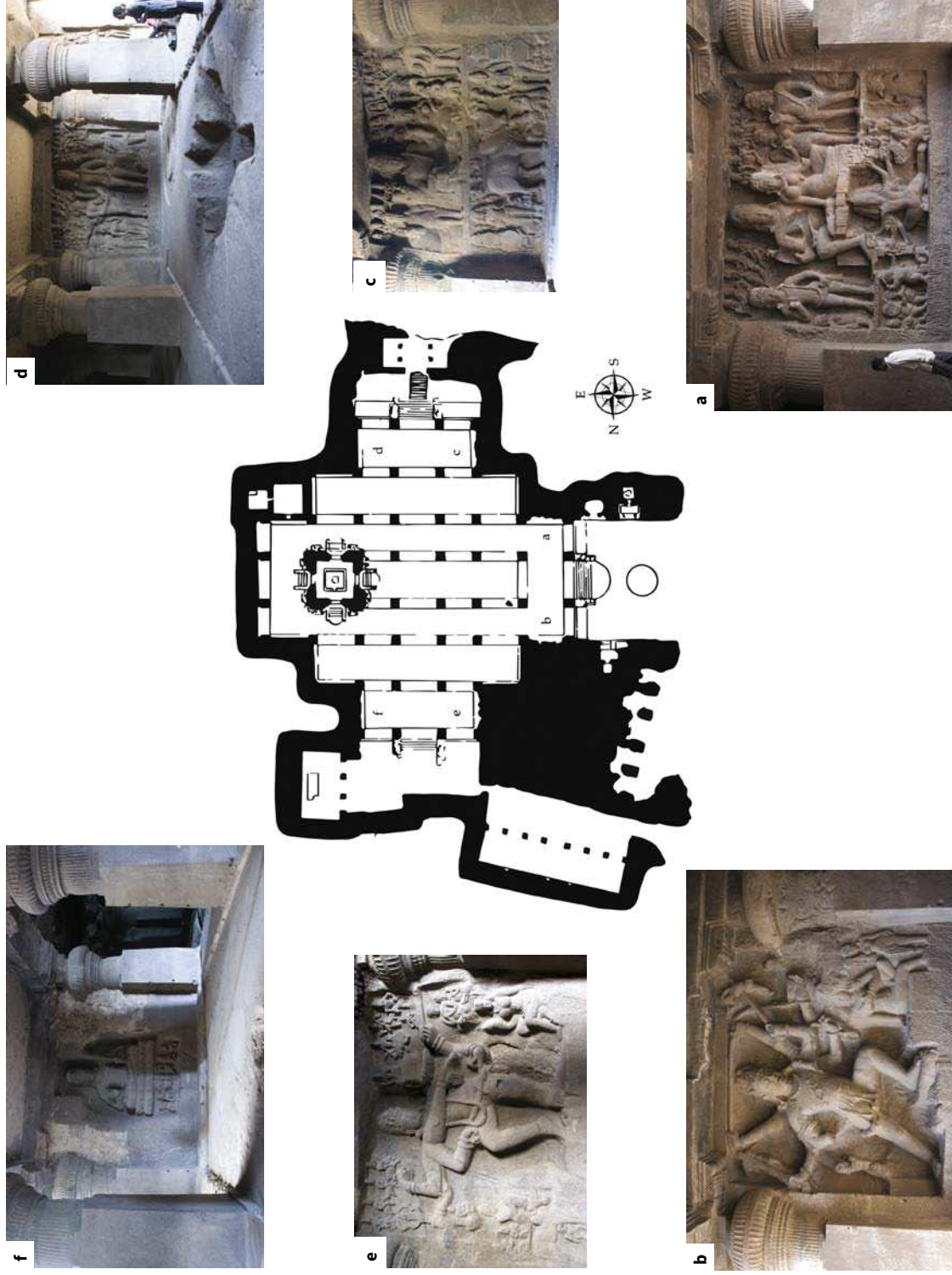


Figure 7.5 Program of Dumar Lena Cave: (a) Ravana shaking mount Kailasa; (b) Siva slaying the demon Andhaka; (c) Siva and Parvati playing dice; (d) Marriage of Siva and Parvati; (e) Siva dancing; (f) Lakulisa, ca. sixth century CE. Photographs by the author.

Śiva's strength as a fierce warrior comes from an act of renunciation and the cultivation of a fierce yogic form. Unlike in the scene of Rāvaṇa shaking Mount Kailāśa, Pārvatī sits clearly at a distance from Śiva, her back turned and her gaze averted. In defending Pārvatī's honor, Śiva is also taking on the form of an *aghora* ascetic, one whose power comes from the practice of yoga and dwelling in the wilderness rather than from enjoying the domestic comforts of being unified with his wife on Mount Kailāśa.

Visually and spatially, these two scenes serve as a fulcrum, or hinge, separating yet uniting the pairs of panels flanking the other two entrances. In both cases, we find pairs of sculptures that enact Śiva's role in the processes of cosmic dissolution and reunification, but in distinctive ways. Whereas the panels that follow to the south reinforce this cosmic drama by continuing the theme of Śiva as heavenly householder, those that continue to the north of the Andhakasura-murti emphasize the god's dual identity as a wilderness wanderer with the power to destroy worlds and as a powerful yogi achieving union with the divine.

If we begin with the south entrance, we find large sculpted narratives depicting Śiva and Pārvatī, first playing dice (west panel) and then getting married (east panel; fig. 7.5 c–d). The meaning of such a juxtaposition would have been clear to an early medieval audience. Whereas the act of playing dice led to their quarrels and separation, their subsequent marriage had the effect of bringing the two back together in a glorious moment of reunification. The story of the dice game appears in many versions. The version found in the *Purāṇas* detailing Śiva's life can be summarized as follows. In the beginning, Pārvatī and Śiva were united as lovers, living happily in their palace on Mount Kailāśa. One day, the sage Nārada enticed them to play a game of dice, promising that they will “find it more pleasing than making love.” To take up the game, Pārvatī and Śiva first had to separate themselves from their unified existence in a single body in order to become two different players. As the game progressed, the challenges and stakes became greater, and they both began to cheat. As their quarrelling intensified, their distance grew greater until finally Śiva, in a fit of rage, abandoned both Pārvatī and the game. Bereft, Pārvatī became an ascetic, renouncing the world and performing penance in order to regain Śiva's affection, enabling them to become reunited in marriage.

The reliefs work together to frame the larger narrative. The scene of the divine lovers playing dice depicts the couple in action. Śiva and Pārvatī sit in the center, surrounded by attendants. The game is already well in progress and the quarreling underway. We see Pārvatī already turning away in anger or irritation as Śiva grabs at her hand to reveal the fact that she is cheating. In the marriage panel, the separated god and goddess appear in the process of being reunited. Again Śiva grasps Pārvatī's hand, but in acceptance rather than in anger. Pārvatī turns toward him as Brahmā kneels to the side, performing the sacrifice that will seal the marriage. What brings these two images together

is the idea of play, or *līlā*, which is a significant metaphor in Hinduism for the divine or cosmic play that mediates between the absolute of god and the contingency of the world. In Śaivism, *līlā* can function as a way of describing all of reality, produced through a process of cosmic fragmentation, through which the contingent world comes into being through its separation from Śiva.²⁰

While this pairing works thematically, its positioning on the south side of the temple is unexpected. In Śiva temples of the early medieval period, Pārvatī's image is invariably found on the north wall, corresponding to the direction typically associated with goddesses. This is true even elsewhere at Ellora, where a similar scene of Pārvatī's wedding can be found on the north side of the roughly contemporary Rāmeśvara temple (Cave 12). However, if one considers the broader context of the site, the placement of the marriage scene begins to take on additional significance. Looking outward from the south entrance, a visitor to the temple would have been able to take in wide sweeping views of the outlying landscape, including the large reservoir and the waterfall that poured down during the monsoon season. Such views may have resonated particularly with the wedding scene, as medieval Indian literary sources often associated the coming of the monsoon with love and progenation.

Textual sources also connect the wedding between the divine duo with water. In the circa fifth-century *Kumārasambhava*, the poet Kālidāsa purposely utilized language that evoked the monsoon rains in conjunction with the completion of the ceremony. According to his text, as the final rite was performed, the priest especially implores Pārvatī to give up all quarrelling now that she and Śiva have been reunited. Pārvatī, in turn, “drinks” in these words “as the earth suffering summer’s fierce heat [drinks in] the first [monsoon] rain from great Indra” (7:83–84).²¹ While textual sources remain generally mute on the seasonality of the events, water plays a significant role in the detailing of the rituals. In the *Līṅga-Purāṇa*, for example, the opening of the wedding ceremony is marked by ablutions: by the washing of Śiva’s feet and the sprinkling of water over the heads of Viṣṇu, Brahmā, and Pārvatī. This is then followed by the showering of flowers, which, of course, would have been in abundance at the onset of the monsoon (103:46–51).²²

When read through an environmental lens, both the general place and the details of these two panels take on new meaning. Whereas in the dice scene, both Pārvatī and Śiva turn toward the temple interior and away from the outside landscape, in the marriage scene Pārvatī looks outward at an angle and is perfectly positioned to take in the view of the waterfall during the monsoon rains. At the same time, both the cave’s distance from the waterfall and the circuitous mode of entry, through a winding staircase below, affords the interior figures significant protection from the spray of water.

As on the south side, the two panels flanking the northern entrance bring together Śiva's cosmic drama with the physical characteristics of their immediate environment (fig. 7.5 e–f). However, both the theme and the effect are very different. Rather than opening onto a vast and fertile vista and views of flowing streams of water, the entrance gives way to a cavernous and narrow gorge enclosed by a steep and solid wall of volcanic stone. This acted as a corridor connecting the temple to a second, smaller shrine, whose entrance was positioned on axis with the *liṅga* in the main sanctum. To the west is a small narrow passageway that leads to a recessed covered area that likely served as a residence and/or ritual hall. The whole complex was accessible only through the temple and likely functioned exclusively in service of the resident ascetics. Accordingly, the panels flanking the northern entrance represent the power of Śiva's asceticism.

Featured on the west side was a large image of Śiva performing the wild *tandava* dance. The energy of the figure, who stands larger than life-size, and the vigor of the motion is captured by the movement of Śiva's eight massive arms, the thrusting of his hip, and the precarious balancing of his pose. He is surrounded by smaller figures. Above are an assortment of key divinities sitting astride their characteristic vehicles (*vāhanas*). These include, from left to right, Viṣṇu on Garuḍa, Agni on a ram, Indra on his elephant, Brahmā on a lotus, Varuṇa on a *makara* (crocodile), Vāyu on a stag, and Yama on a buffalo. Below, to his left, we find Śiva's own *vahana*, the bull Nandi, accompanied by Bhṛīṅgi, a skeletal ascetic figure who serves as Śiva's most ardent devotee. The fact that this panel follows directly from that of Śiva slaying Andhaka is not insignificant, and in some accounts, Bhṛīṅgi and Andhaka are one and the same, as Andhaka is transformed into Bhṛīṅgi after his defeat. Finally, seated at a comfortable distance to the right is Pārvatī, who sits on a nearby rock gazing at the scene with detached indifference.

The image of Śiva dancing is most often understood as expressing the god's role as both cosmic creator and destroyer. However, in the mid-first millennium, the image would have been even more readily associated with Śiva's famed encounter with the Pine Forest sages, which also provides an origin story for the practice of *liṅga* worship. Again, the story appears in many versions but generally begins with the god Śiva committing a grievous sin: the god Brahmā had affronted his pride by growing a fifth head, and so, in a rage, Śiva chopped it off. In order to perform penance and achieve expiation, Śiva renounced his heavenly home and took on the guise of a wandering ascetic. One day, as he was wandering in a pine forest, he came to a hermitage where a group of sages were living as householders together with their wives. Śiva entered the hermitage and seduced the wives and daughters with his wild dance. In some versions he is accompanied by Viṣṇu in the guise of a beautiful woman, who, in parallel fashion, aroused the desire of the sages. Upon realizing the trick, that they

had been blinded by the illusion (*māyā*), the sages became confused and then enraged. They cursed and beat Śiva, until Śiva finally taunted them and left. However, in the process, Śiva's phallus (*liṅga*) was severed and fell on the ground, turning into a pillar of fire. Scorched by the flame, drought set upon the world. In despair, the sages approached Brahmā, who instructed them to renounce their wives and to install and perform homage to a copy of Śiva's fallen *liṅga* in a shrine. In this way, the sages took up a truly celibate ascetic practice, giving up their householder lives, while also become the first lineage to practice *liṅga* worship and to achieve a Śaiva liberation.²³

Understandably, many Śaiva lineages sought to trace their genealogy back to the Pine Forest sages as a way of establishing their status as Śiva's first and most faithful.²⁴ This was true of the Pāśupatas, who were the likely occupants of many caves at Ellora. One of the most prominent of the early medieval Śaiva movements, the Pāśupatas were known for their pure asceticism and cultivation of antisocial behavior.²⁵ Early medieval sources describe the Pāśupatas as living in temples, clothing themselves only in ashes and bark, and wearing their hair in tall, unkempt matted locks. They were expected not only to detach themselves from society but to actively court the censure of others to achieve isolation and worldly detachment. The name Pāśupata itself denoted the sect's particular attachment to Śiva in the form of Pāśupati, which literally denoted his status as "lord of animals" but metaphorically evoked the idea of the bondage of the individual soul (*paśu*), which was fettered like a sacrificial beast and unable to become truly free.²⁶ Notably, the term "Pāśupata" was also used to denote a spear- or arrow-like weapon that Śiva used to wound the demon Andhaka before subjugating him with his trident.²⁷

Pāśupata practitioners traced their lineage back to the human sage Lakuliśa, who is represented in the panel just across from the scene of Śiva's forest dance. Lakuliśa was widely understood as both a historical teacher and the twenty-eighth, and last, incarnation of the great god. Appropriately, he is represented here as both a human sage, indicated by the presence of only two arms, and a divinized spiritual teacher. While his Śaiva affiliation is emphasized through his tall matted locks of hair, his identity more specifically as Lakuliśa is established through the large club (*lakula*) in his left hand. Seated in yogic meditation upon a blossoming lotus, he wears a sacred thread (*yagñopavīta*) and is shown as ithyphallic, indicating his practice of celibacy and the retention of the sacred seed. Honoring him below are six celestial devotees, including two serpent kings (*nāgas*) and four serpent queens (*nāginīs*) flanking either side of the lotus stem. It may be notable also that the image of Lakuliśa is aligned with the front entrance to the temple's *liṅga* shrine at the center, which reinforces his status as both worshipper and manifestation of Śiva.

In short, the two panels work together with the physicality of the stone just beyond the entrance to establish the area as a zone of ascetic residence and



Figure 7.6 Drainage channel at the west end of the northern entrance, Dumar Lena Cave, Ellora, ca. sixth century CE. Photograph by the author.

yogic practice. Whereas on the south side, scenes of marriage and householding existence looked out toward the world beyond the temple, here the panels emphasizing renunciation and yoga led directly to an interiorized zone of ascetic residence.²⁸

While the interiorized nature of the space beyond the northern entrance lent itself well to the notion of the cave-dwelling ascetic, it was also vulnerable to flooding during the monsoon season. To mitigate the problem, the builders fitted the complex with a drainage system consisting of a grooved passage that could facilitate the flow of water from the temple area westward toward a small opening at outer end of the complex (fig. 7.6).

That the problem of managing rainwater was a key concern is similarly suggested through one last aspect of the visual program. Both the north and south entrances are symbolically girded by the presence of life-size ren-

derings of the river goddesses: Gaṅgā (the Ganges) standing at the southern entrance and Yamunā at the north. Normally the river goddesses are found together on temples, where they serve as auspicious figures flanking a single entrance or doorway. The fact that here they are positioned apart is unusual, and yet it makes sense from both a spatial and a geologic perspective. In addition to retaining an alignment with the entrance to the temple's interior sanctum, each was positioned in close proximity to the flow of water pouring down on either side of the temple during the monsoon season. The unusual placement of Gaṅgā on the south rather than north, as found elsewhere at Ellora, may have been intended to engage the nearby monsoon waterfall, recalling the story of the river's descent from the heavens, during which the destructive force of her falling was mitigated through the intervention of Śiva, who allowed the water to trickle down gently through his hair.

Buddhist Geologies

The practice of creatively engaging natural landscapes was not exclusive to Hindu groups. As Gregory Schopen has shown, Buddhist monks were fully aware of “the cultural, aesthetic, and erotic values attached to the Indian garden” found in a broader range of Sanskrit courtly texts.²⁹ Buddhist monasteries (*vihāras*) became both objects of an aesthetic gaze and sites from which to enjoy beautiful views of the landscape. Similarly, Julia Shaw’s work on Sanchi has revealed the many complex ways in which the siting of hilltop monasteries and stūpas actively engaged their local topographies in ways that maximized their visual presence, both from the settlements below and also from other, nearby Buddhist hilltop sites.³⁰ In addition, their siting took full advantage of the local hydrology, utilizing networks of reservoirs and dams to ensure adequate water both for daily use and for irrigation.³¹

The same was true of the dozen caves at Ellora associated with Buddhist practice. Situated at the far southern end of the site, these are typically dated at least a generation or two after their Śaiva counterparts. The earliest were Caves 5 and 6, which were excavated around the turn of the seventh century. As building progressed, activity moved increasingly northward toward the Hindu temples that today stand at Ellora’s center. Caves 8–10 likely date to circa 650, and Caves 11 and 12 to around the turn of the eighth century. As in the case of the earlier Śaiva temples, the location of the Buddhist cluster also pivoted on a key water feature: a second overhead gorge that transformed into a waterfall that both created a scenic view and could be harvested during the monsoon season. The earliest two caves (5 and 6) were situated on either side of the falls, which fed a small stream that collected as a small pond in the valley below. The two caves may well have functioned as a pair, with Cave 5 serving primarily as a residential *vihāra*, and Cave 6 as a Buddha shrine (figs. 7.1 and 7.7). Both caves are set high on the scarp face and are endowed with a deeply recessed portico that would have protected the interior from the forceful spray of the monsoon rains.

In writing about Ellora’s Buddhist caves over thirty years ago, Geri Malandra proposed that the spatial arrangement and sculptural programs of the caves formed a larger three-dimensional *maṇḍala* that could be activated and experienced bodily through the movements of worshippers. Such “*maṇḍalic*” thinking, as she termed it, was suggested both by the representation of two-dimensional *maṇḍalas* on the walls of the cave temples and by the programmatic arrangement of images. At the center of Ellora’s unique *maṇḍala* was a large enshrined icon of the Buddha possibly envisioned more specifically as Vairocana, holding his hands in *dharmacakramudrā* and seated in *pralambapādāsana*. Beyond the central shrine, other divinities formed protective rings in a relatively consistent pattern across the site.



Figure 7.7 View of Caves 5–9, from the south, Ellora, ca. seventh century CE. Photograph by the author.

In the case of the earliest excavations, such as Cave 6, the *maṇḍala* was relatively simple, limited to the area immediately around the large Buddha icon that served as both the center and culmination of the three-dimensional experience. Flanking him on the inner walls of the sanctum was a pair of two-dimensional *maṇḍalas*, each consisting of nine *dharmacakramudrā* buddhas seated in *padmāsana*, accompanied on one side by a group of worshippers making offerings (north) and on the other by the trio of Avalokiteśvara, Jambhala, and Mañjuśrī (south; fig. 7.8). Facing him to the west was the goddess Tārā. Moving beyond were Avalokiteśvara and Maitreya, acting as door guardians, and Bhṛkuṭī and Mahāmāyūrī, both of whom appear in Buddhist sculpture for the first time at Ellora, flanking the walls of the preceding verandah. By the time that Caves 11 and 12 were excavated, in the mid-eighth century, the *maṇḍala* had become far more complex, extending vertically through as many as three stories, with a far vaster pantheon of supporting divinities. Caves 11 and 12 also exhibit a significant iconographic shift through which Māravijaya Śākyamuni (or Akṣobhya) in *bhūmisparśamudrā* supplanted the earlier *dharmacakramudrā* Buddha Vairocana as the focus of the *maṇḍala*.³²

Although the logics underlying Ellora's Buddhist and Śaiva shrines were fundamentally different, they yield useful comparisons, as the builders of the Buddhist caves at Ellora drew liberally from the Śaivas in ways that were new at the turn of the seventh century. The most obvious can be seen in stylistic and iconographic details, and particularly in the treatment of the

bodhisattvas Avalokiteśvara and Maitreya, who are positioned as door guardians (*dvārapāla*) on either side of the shrine.³³ In scale and composition, they are almost identical to those found at the Dumar Lena, and their tall matted locks of hair (*jaṭāmukuta*) are more in line with the treatment of Śaiva ascetics than of Buddhist saints. Indeed, if seen only from a distance, one would be hard-pressed to determine their Buddhist affiliation (see fig. 7.8). It is only in smaller iconographic details, such as the figure of Amitābha and the stūpa-like



Figure 7.8 *Maṇḍalas* to the right of the Buddha icon, with the trio of Avalokiteśvara, Jambhala, and Mañjuśrī below, Cave 6, Ellora, ca. seventh century CE. Photograph by John C. Huntington. Courtesy of the John C. and Susan L. Huntington Photographic Archive of Buddhist and Asian Art.

crest jewel in Avalokiteśvara's and Maitreya's hair, respectively, that their identity becomes clear. Also drawn from the Śaivas is the placement of images of the river goddesses Gaṅgā and Yamunā found in Cave 6 on the corners of the door lintel above the sanctum. In turn, the Śaivas borrowed heavily from the Buddhists, as seen particularly in the iconography of Lakuliśa, as expressed through both textual references and visual imagery.³⁴

While such details may stem from a shared set of artistic practices, or the employment of overlapping guilds of sculptors, others may represent theological borrowings. For example, Pia Brancaccio has noted the connection between Avalokiteśvara's ability to loosen bonds and set prisoners free and the god Śiva's growing role in liberating followers from the fetters or binds (*pāśa*) of existence. Accordingly, at Aurangabad in the sixth century, we find for the first time the introduction of a *pāśa*, in the form of a coiled rope, in the iconography of Avalokiteśvara.³⁵ Similarly, the employment of river goddesses on the corners of the door lintels may gesture also toward a shared cultural desire to bring the celestial and terrestrial waters together in the visual program of entrances and ceilings, as Gautam Vajracharya—through his analysis of sources affiliated with both Buddhism and Hinduism—has suggested was the case at nearby Ajanta.³⁶ In fact, this atmospheric gesture can be seen already in the first century BCE, in the pairing of the Vedic gods Sūrya and Indra, shown respectively flying on a pregnant cloud and wielding a thunderbolt, on either side of the entrance to Cave 19 at Bhaja.

Such features mark a significant shift from earlier Buddhist practices and likely represent a response to the rapid institutionalization of Śaiva ascetic movements in the late sixth and seventh centuries, at precisely the moment when Buddhist institutions within India began witnessing waning support in many areas of the Indian subcontinent. Indeed, the excavations at Ellora and Aurangabad remain among the last of a thousand-year tradition of monumentally conceived Buddhist rock-cut sites in the Deccan. By the seventh and eighth centuries, the primary centers of Buddhist production had already begun shifting solidly to northeast India and the Himalayas.

Seismic Soteriologies

While the monsoon rains provided Ellora's Buddhists and Hindus with an abundant and auspicious resource for interweaving ritual performance with sacred metaphor, the force of the falling water was another matter entirely. In addition to facilitating rebirth and procreation, monsoons could bring about rockslides and tremors, particularly along rocky cliffside landscapes. The significance of such seismic activity in medieval Indic religious imaginations has been articulated most clearly by Eugen Ciurtin, through his work on

earthquakes in Buddhist literature.³⁷ Most notably, he calls attention to the special treatment of earthquakes in a separate *sūtra* (*Bhūmicālasutta*) in one of the most important early Buddhist texts, the *Mahāparinirvāṇa-Sūtra*. Commonly known as the “earthquake *sūtra*,” the text provides a list of eight causes, each of which can be tied to either a cosmic-level disturbance—such as the sequential disturbance of water by wind and earth by water, or to a momentous event in the life of a Brahmanical ascetic or Buddha, which Ciurtin likens to “a kinetics of salvation.”³⁸ Not every earthquake is equal in scale or experience. Whereas small tremors are designated simply as “earthquakes,” those that cause the mountains, rivers, trees, and oceanic waters to move are considered “major earthquakes.”³⁹ By far the most important and seismically tumultuous earthquake coincides with the occasion of the Buddha’s enlightenment, which, as is well known to Buddhologists, is precisely the place in the larger *Mahāparinirvāṇa-Sūtra* at which the earthquakes *sūtra* is embedded.⁴⁰ In examining the function of earthquakes in early Buddhist literature, Ciurtin suggests that the occurrence of earthquakes in Buddhist literature also has the effect of anchoring *saṃsāra* to the life story of the Buddha.⁴¹

Drawing from a wide range of textual and visual sources, Ciurtin has argued that such seismic activity should be regarded not merely as fanciful literary motif but rather as evidence of significant geological engagements. Ciurtin’s case for understanding the connection between literary metaphors and real-world events is rooted in Buddhism’s geographic origins in areas straddling the boundaries between the Indian and Eurasian plates. In such cases, authors likely possessed firsthand knowledge of the effect of seismic shakes. The Deccan, by contrast, is not often considered a high-risk region. Indeed, in their assessment of the geology and geomorphology of Ellora, the Geological Survey of India notes that the caves of Ellora are located in “one of the most seismically rigid zones” of the Deccan and that “the cave structures as such do not bear any signatures of damage by earthquake in the past.”⁴² Nonetheless, the region as a whole is recognized as a moderate risk zone for seismic activity, and at least two major earthquakes have occurred in the Deccan in the past half century: in Konya in 1967 and Latur in 1993. The severity of these recent earthquakes has caused scientists to reconsider the likelihood of hidden tectonic boundaries that lie under the Deccan trap.⁴³ Recent studies have shown that other districts that have been traditionally presumed as tectonically stable may have a longer history of microseismic activity, with recurring incidences of low-magnitude (2.0–3.9) shakes.⁴⁴ Indeed, for the caves at Ellora that stand along the western edge of the Maismal plateau, we have a historical record of nearly a dozen mostly minor earthquakes occurring between 1859 and 1993.⁴⁵ We should assume that even subtle tremors likely would have been felt by residents. Even today, residual vibrations can be felt at Ellora, even from earthquakes with distant epicenters, and the Geological Survey has noted the vibrations caused by

increased tourism and the expansion of highways as a pressing threat to the conservation of Ellora's cave temples.⁴⁶

Given that seismic disturbances were interwoven with both soteriologies of practice and phenomenological experience, it is worth considering the ways in which they were evoked through medieval Buddhist imagery. For example, the prominent display of the Vessantara *jātaka* (tale of the Buddha's past life as the Prince Vessantara) in Cave 17—in the painted murals at nearby Ajanta (ca. fifth century)—could not but have called to mind what Ciurtin has described as “one of the greatest seismic *dramatis personae* in Buddhist scriptures and commentaries.”⁴⁷ Indeed, references to earthquakes meaningfully mark catalytic moments in the narrative as told in nearly every recension of the story from the earliest Pāli version onward.⁴⁸ Most significantly, earthquakes serve as a framing device in Āryaśūra's circa fourth-century Sanskrit retelling, with a major shake marking the prince Vessantara's gifting of the royal elephant, the event that sets off the key chain of events in the story, and another occurring with the offering of his children near the end.⁴⁹ It may be significant that, at Ajanta, the scene of Vessantara leaving the palace—a key moment that precipitates a massive shuddering of the earth—is positioned on the cave's exterior, on the veranda facing outward from the rocky surface, rather than in the interior, where the narrative is otherwise largely found.

Ellora no longer retains any trace of such an extensive mural program, and direct connections between its imagery and seismic activity are conjectural. However, it is well within the range of possibility that the increasing prominence of icons denoting the Buddha's enlightenment following the defeat of Māra would likely have called to mind the major earthquake accompanying the pivotal moment. In such instances, he is shown in *bhūmisparśa-mudrā*, or the earth-touching gesture, often accompanied by a small female figure representing the earth herself.⁵⁰ While the earth-touching mudra is most frequently interpreted as calling the earth to bear witness, visually the image could not help but suggest the Buddha's imperviousness to tremors, reminding the viewer also of Māra's inability to shake him from his meditative trance. Another potential connection may be made with Vajrapāṇi, who takes on increasing importance in this period and appears prominently in guardian positions not only in several caves at Ellora but also at the nearby site of Aurangabad.⁵¹ As Pia Brancaccio has noted, in his initial form as a *yakṣa*, Vajrapāṇi was associated with mountains and caves, and his magical *vajra* had the power to shake mountains and break solid rock.⁵²

I suggest that more can be gleaned through a closer look at Ellora's earlier Śaiva temples, which provide an even clearer sense of potential seismic engagements. The most significant instances can be found in the episode of Rāvaṇa shaking Mount Kailāśa, as told in the *Rāmāyana* and as encountered prominently in the veranda of the main entrance to the Dumar Lena temple

(see fig. 7.5a). Within Vālmiki's original late-first-millennium text, the episode occurs as part of a longer narrative of Rāvaṇa's rise to power. As told in greater detail above, the demon Rāvaṇa attempts to uproot Śiva's heavenly mountain, an effort quelled simply through the playful pressing downward of the god's big toe. The canonical version by the sage Vālmiki is replete with atmospheric analogies, likening Rāvaṇa to "a storm cloud charged with rain" (16:12) and describing his assault as a literal hefting of the mountain upward "together with its deer, its beasts of prey, and its trees" (16:20).⁵³ The pressing down of Śiva's toe in some ways functions as a visual analogue to the Buddha's earth-touching gesture, indicating his ability to stabilize the shaking earth while also vanquishing a demon who poses a threat to cosmic order. In this case Śiva's toe also represents his military prowess, driving down the mountain, crushing the demon's arms, and causing him to release a terrifying and "tremendous cry" (literally, *rāvaṇa*), from which the demon's name was derived, that resounded across the three worlds, bringing terror to both humans and the divine.⁵⁴

Such scenes of Rāvaṇa shaking Mount Kailāśa are common in the longer history of Indian art. However, at the time of Ellora's establishment, such scenes were still relatively rare. The earliest known occurrence is a modest, fifth-century sandstone relief from Mathura.⁵⁵ In the sixth century, we begin to find increasing instances, especially at rock-cut sites such as Elephanta and Ellora. At Ellora alone, the episode is represented no fewer than seven times in prominent positions in at least five different temples. In addition to its appearance at the Dumar Lena cave, it is featured three times within the Kailāśanātha temple complex (Cave 16, ca. eighth century) and also found in large niches along the walls of Caves 14, 15, and 21.⁵⁶ It seems not unreasonable to conclude that the scene resonated particularly well with the mountainous landscape and would have been understood not merely as a metaphor for Śiva's heavenly home but also as an assertion of Śiva's stabilizing power. Indeed, part of what made Śiva's home potent was its stability, the fact that it was unshakeable by storms or seismic events, which were frequently associated with the conflict between demons and gods. The *Purāṇas*, for example, are filled with countless stories describing the aggression of powerful demons in seismic terms. Their attacks caused mountains to crumble, the earth to quake, the winds to roll, and the oceans to agitate.⁵⁷

In this case, it may perhaps not be coincidental that, in the Dumar Lena cave, the scene of Rāvaṇa shaking Mount Kailāśa was paired with the defeat of the demon Andhaka, which unfolds, according to the story, at the foot of a mountain cavern in which Pārvatī has taken refuge (see fig. 7.5b). Again here, textual sources describe Andhaka's attack in terms of storms and seismic events. In the *Rudrasaṃhitā* of the *Śiva Purāṇa*, Andhaka's army is described as "fearlessly roaring like rumbling clouds" (48:15), striking at Śiva's entourage "like the mountains hit with Indra's thunderbolt" (48:30), his final assault unfolding like

an earthquake.⁵⁸ His demon forces smash the entrance to Pārvatī's mountain refuge, destroy the flower gardens and water sheds, and vigorously "stir up the sunny peaks of the mountain" (46:3–8). After Śiva's divine army finally defeats them, and Andhaka has been fatally skewered, Śiva holds the demon "aloft in the sky like a long pole," as seen in the Ellora frieze, leaving his body to be simultaneously baked by the hot sun of the dry season and drenched by the torrential flow of the monsoon rain. Here, the extreme vacillation between rainy and dry seasons serves to enact a penance on the demon, ultimately allowing him to achieve expiation and become redeemed as one of Śiva's foremost devotees. In the *Śiva Purāṇa*, the final victory scene concludes with a reminder that the battle was won also on behalf of the mountain itself, as the text reminds us that Pārvatī herself was the daughter of the mountain Himavat.⁵⁹



In addition to suggesting new interpretations for religious imagery in early medieval India, looking comparatively at Buddhist and Śaiva engagements in the context of a single site provides an alternative framework for viewing the relationship between religious communities. As Abhishek Amar has recently argued for the case of Bodhgāya and Gayā, the tendency of scholars to frame Buddhist and Brāhmaṇical orders as either contentious or syncretic both obscures the complexity of human agency and fails to take into account the ways in which multiple groups may have been responding to new historical phenomena. Instead, the concurrent presence of diverse religious communities within a region or at a given place needs to be more specifically situated and historically contextualized in order to better assess the negotiated dynamics of inclusion, appropriation, and competition.⁶⁰

I suggest that such scholarly tendencies also reinforce an anthropocentric approach to monuments, whose makers may be more fruitfully understood as responding to environmental conditions. At Ellora, very little is known about the specific religious or political circumstances that prompted the building of massive new Buddhist and Śaiva complexes because the inscriptional record at the site, especially prior to the eighth century, is minimal at best. Geri Malandra has suggested that the power of Ellora was less in its affiliation with a particular political ruler or religious group than in its collective identity as a pilgrimage site or *tīrtha*, literally a "crossing place" between the sacred world of the gods and the realm of human existence.⁶¹ In the making of the *tīrtha*, the abundance of natural resources and the natural spectacle of Ellora's waterfalls played a significant role in amplifying its potency as a sacred center. In short, the site itself took on significant agency in both the form of monuments and the generation of meaning.

That the topography and hydrology of Ellora was by far its greatest attractor is attested to by its continuing appeal for many centuries thereafter. Jain

communities began building their own complexes at the site in the eighth and ninth centuries, in some cases directly modeling their activities on the earlier Śaiva and Buddhist excavations; and Brāhmaṇical activity continued through at least the twelfth century through the excavation of small shrines along the stream at the top of the scarp that fed the waterfall next to the Dumar Lena.⁶² The inherent natural appeal of the site continued long after it fell into disuse. In September 1683, the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb remarked particularly both on the marvel of the monsoon, which annually transformed Ellora into a blossoming garden, and on the massiveness of the main waterfall, which he estimated as being no fewer than one hundred yards wide.⁶³ A century later, both waterfalls—cascading over the Buddhist and Śaiva excavations, respectively—were used as dramatic framing devices in a now-famous aquatint panorama extending across three plates of Thomas Daniell’s publication of a volume dedicated to the excavations at Ellora, published initially in 1803–1804.⁶⁴

Recognizing the enduring appeal of a local landscape can shift agency from human to nonhuman actors by emphasizing the ways in which natural environments elicit power over viewers. For later visitors, the site was one that spoke to past histories, framed through various imperial lenses. However, in the sixth and seventh centuries, Ellora’s natural features drew both Śaivas and Buddhists for reasons that were also rooted in real-world concerns, including shifts in patterns of movement, trade, patronage, and religious transformations brought about through the steady rise of tantrism in both Buddhist and Brāhmaṇical worlds. Their coexistence may have spurred new appropriations, syntheses, and dialogues and be seen most potently through shifts in iconography and the shaping of relationships between ritual and geological space.

NOTES

1. Evidence for royal patronage is extremely tenuous—there is a notable absence of donative inscriptions, and the connection between the Kailāśanatha temple and the Rāṣṭrakūṭas is drawn from a later reference in a copper plate from elsewhere. See Owen, “Kings or Ascetics?,” 184; R. G. Bhandarkar, “Rashtrakuta King.”
2. Smith, “Architectural and Mythic Space,” 13, 15–16.
3. Ray, *Climate Change*, esp. 22, 29–34, and 45–49.
4. Lee, *Temples in the Cliffsides*.
5. For example, see Dehejia and Rockwell, *Unfinished* (2016); Misra, *Ancient Artists*; Ramaswamy, “Vishwakarma Craftsmen.”
6. Fergusson and Burgess, *Cave Temples*; Burgess, *Report*; Dehejia, *Early Buddhist Rock Temples*; Willis, *Archaeology*; Collins, *Iconography*; Berkson, *Cave of Śiva*.

7. See Owen, "Worshipping the Jina."
8. Sinha, *Geoscientific*.
9. Wescoat, "Human Use."
10. Wescoat looks at four distinctive contexts of human-landform relations in the Deccan; none encompasses the main period of construction by Hindus or Buddhists at Ellora during the sixth and seventh centuries. During the period between 850 and 1300 CE, Wescoat notes a significant shift. Whereas at the start of the Common Era, settlements had a northwest-to-southeast corridor along the Godavari River, during the ninth century movement began instead to follow the scarps and buttes that ran north-south directly toward the new capital at Devgiri (present-day Daulatabad). The rock-cut temples at Ellora then lay along the new route and remained in active use, primarily by Jains.
11. Mubayi, "Ellora-Khuldabad-Daulatabad," 133–134.
12. Wescoat, "Human Use," 182.
13. Malandra (*Unfolding*, 11) also notes, "It is no accident that both the earliest Hindu and Buddhist caves were the ones excavated closest to the most active streams, that have worn horseshoe-shaped gullies into the scarp." See also Owen, *Carving Devotion*, 7–8.
14. These can be observed particularly in Caves 1, 3, 11, and 12. Sinha, *Geoscientific*, 169, 175, 201, 214.
15. Ernst, "Admiring the Works," 102.
16. Sinha, *Geoscientific*, 169.
17. For a comparative analysis of the ways in which rock-cut temples during this period served as "a visual essay in Saiva cosmology and psychology," see Handelman and Shulman, *God Inside*, 7. Earlier, Michell suggested passage through the Elephanta temple be interpreted as "a progression toward god" ("Architecture of Elephanta," 17).
18. Goldman and Goldman, *Rāmāyaṇa of Vālmiki*, 7:265–266.
19. On different versions of this story, see Collins, *Iconography*, 57–65.
20. See, for example, Sax, *Gods at Play*. This notion of *līlā* frames Handelman and Shulman's analysis of Elephanta in *God Inside*.
21. Quoted from Collins, *Iconography*, 70. See also Kale, *Kumārasambhava*, 46.
22. Shastri and Tagare, *Liṅga-Purāṇa*, 2:570.
23. Davis, "Origin."
24. See, for example, Sears, *Worldly Gurus*, 57–60.
25. Inscriptional evidence indicates that, in the early medieval period, the Pāśupatas were believed to have originated in the region of Laṭā (Gujarāt), from which they then spread to southern Rajasthan and eventually further across the subcontinent. See D. R. Bhandarkar, "Eklingji Stone." For recent reassessments, see Acharya, "How to Behave"; and Bisschop, "Śaivism," 483–486.
26. Davis, *Ritual*, 637–638.
27. Collins, *Iconography*, 58.
28. Vidya Dehejia speculates whether the architect may have intended to cut away the stone to make a proper entrance from the outside world. However, given the clear accommodation for drainage, it seems far more likely that this northern complex was intended to remain inaccessible from outside the temple. See Dehejia and Rockwell, *Unfinished*, 73.
29. Schopen, "Buddhist 'Monastery,'" 497.

30. Shaw, “Stūpas.”
31. See also Shaw, *Buddhist Landscapes*; Shaw, “Landscape.”
32. Malandra, “Ellora.” For detail on the interior programs and iconography of Caves 5, 6, 11, and 12, see Malandra, *Unfolding*, 26–34, 92–97, 62–90.
33. Malandra, *Unfolding*, 28, figs. 19, 21, 35, 40–42. On the increasing popularity of *bhūmiśparśamudrā* forms of the Buddha from the seventh century onward, see Leoshko, “About Looking.”
34. See, for example, Bisschop, “Śaivism,” 486; Shah, “Lakulīśa.”
35. Brancaccio, *Buddhist Caves*, 143–145. Brancaccio notes similarities between the iconography of Śiva as lord of the yogis at Elephant, with Avalokiteśvara in Cave 2 at Aurangabad.
36. Vajracharya, *Frog Hymns*, 122–126.
37. Ciurtin, “Buddha’s Earthquakes”; Ciurtin, “Thus.”
38. Ciurtin, “Buddha’s Earthquakes,” 63, 68–70.
39. Blum, *Nirvana Sutra*, 1:49–50.
40. In later texts, a major wavering of half-worlds causes an earthquake whenever a future Buddha approaches a bodhi tree as a foreshadowing of attaining enlightenment. *Ibid.*, 1:75.
41. Ciurtin, “Thus,” 29, 39–43.
42. Sinha, *Geoscientific*, 89.
43. Veeraswamy and Raval, “Remobilization.”
44. Sarup, “Study of Tectonics,” 2378.
45. Sinha, *Geoscientific*, 92.
46. To mitigate the possibility of future damage, the geological survey recently recommended shifting the parking area farther from the site. *Ibid.*, 100–102.
47. Ciurtin, “Buddha’s Earthquakes,” 90. On the *Vessantara jātaka* at Ajanta, see Dehejia, “On Modes of Visual Narration,” 390–392.
48. Gombrich and Margaret, *Perfect Generosity*, 11, 32, 76, 90–92.
49. Meiland, *Garland*, 1:211, 253.
50. As Geri Malandra has demonstrated, icons of the Buddha seated holding his hands in *bhūmiśparśamudrā* (earth-touching gesture) took central positions within sculptural programs at Ellora’s Buddhist caves, situating the enlightenment moment at the center of a cosmic architectural plan. See Malandra, “Ellora,” 72. See also Leoshko, “About Looking,” 68.
51. Malandra, *Unfolding*, 48, 53, 65, 68, 71, 81, 88; Brancaccio, *Buddhist Caves*, 167–174.
52. Brancaccio, *Buddhist Caves*, 169; Lamotte, “Vajrāpaṇi.”
53. Goldman and Goldman, *Rāmāyaṇa*, 7:265.
54. *Ibid.*, 265–266.
55. Sharma, “Rāvaṇa,” 328–329.
56. For the precise location of these images, see Dhavalikar, *Ellora*, 35, 39, 55–56, 67, 69, 76.
57. Shastri, *Śiva Purāṇa*, 4:1841.
58. *Ibid.*, 2:1013–1014.
59. *Ibid.*, 2:1002–1006.
60. Amar, “Buddhist Responses.”

61. For discussion of the possible dynastic and political context and of the site as a pilgrimage crossing, see Malandra, *Unfolding*, 5–14.
62. Owen, *Carving Devotion*, 28–35; Dhavalikar, *Ellora*, 84–85.
63. As quoted in Malandra, *Unfolding*, 1.
64. Daniell, *Hindoo Excavations*, plates 1–3.

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CHAPTER 8

Riverine Buddhism at Changlu Monastery

Jason Protass

The vast lower Yangzi River, from Nanjing downriver to the sea, has supported Buddhist monasticism. Riparian institutions held thousands of community members, were connected to international waters, produced riverine rituals, and endured cycles of de- and reconstruction. We might say the environment of the lower Yangzi (also spelled Yangtze) was significant in the history of Buddhism. We could even say that the Yangzi River asserted its powerful capacity as a historical agent. The river's width made it both a boundary and a major waterway, and violent floods were a constant possibility. This lower stretch of the river was a frontline of wars, and today its wharf-lined banks host exceptionally large factories and chemical plants. The following case study of the Buddhist monastery at Changlu illustrates how the Yangzi River has been a significant factor in the history of one institution.

The historical Changlu Monastery, now part of Luhe District of Nanjing City, China, is especially well known for two reasons. Bodhidharma is said to have crossed the Yangzi on a single reed and come ashore at Changlu village; and Chan monastic codes still observed across East Asia today are modeled on life at eleventh-century Changlu Monastery. That Changlu Monastery was destroyed nine times and rebuilt ten is less known. The cyclic life of this monastery is inextricable from the local history of the river. The following study of dynamics at the site, seen through particular events set against a *longue durée*, reveals the distribution of forces that shaped riverine Buddhism here—geoaesthetic dynamics that likely could be found in other places and at other times. I emphasize behaviors that are in direct relationships to either riverine processes (such as erosion and sedimentation) or affordances (such as qualities

that make possible transportation), rather than metaphorical figurations of rivers in Buddhist teachings. I eschew contemplating medieval Buddhist ideas about nature uprooted from the medieval worlds in which those ideas lived.

The riparian environment of Changlu was the immediate context in which Buddhists there lived out their religion. Buddhists responded to the possibilities afforded by the river in material and conceptual ways, and evidence of their responses entwines the material and the conceptual. I argue that most of these Buddhists' behaviors, if not all, were imbued with their concepts about their environment (that were not necessarily "green" or "ecofriendly"). Indeed, the river, with its long natural history, preceded the religious lives of people who lived by its banks. The river predetermined a matrix of possibilities but not which of those possibilities people would enact. The people who inscribed Buddhism on this landscape did so through actions driven in part by their contemporary cultural logic, and yet they also did so in ways imperceptibly pre-shaped by the physical materiality of the river. A religious history of a river is one of shifting horizons. The river was often churning, constantly flowing, and periodically breaking its banks; people engineered waterfront features of the monastery, propitiated flood-making dragons, and relocated the monastery to higher ground. The physical realities of the Yangzi River engendered the conditions by which local people made significant contributions to Buddhist history.¹

The first section of this chapter focuses on the dynamics between the material and the conceptual in the relationships of Buddhists to the environment at Changlu, which I refer to as Buddhist engineering. This is illustrated in the imagined origins of Changlu Monastery as the site of Bodhidharma's landfall during his miraculous escape from Nanjing as well as in the historical founding of the monastery in the Northern Song dynasty (960–1127). Because of my interest in the material experiences of Buddhists, I linger on early construction projects that demonstrate direct relationships with the Yangzi River. I focus especially on the monastery's iron gate built into the near shore, which I argue was both a well-engineered and a ritually effective project. I compare this with other iron projects, including a massive statue of the Spirit of Shensha erected on the riverbank. Next, the second section focuses on how the affordances of the Yangzi River were a significant reason for the flourishing of Changlu Monastery. The river and the watershed played roles in geopolitics, domestic and international transportation, and religious practices. Fertile agricultural holdings and ease of transportation made it possible for the monastery to feed between one thousand and two thousand monks every day, thus making possible Buddhist monasticism at an unusually large scale. One of Changlu Monastery's most enduring influences was the Chan monastic rules, titled *Rules of Purity for the Chan Monastery* (*Chanyuan qinggui*), developed in part because of the vitality of the lower Yangzi River. The third section turns our

view from prosperity to precarity. The river's capacities also brought various kinds of destruction to Changlu Monastery, from floods to fires to war. A brief final section discusses contemporary Changlu Monastery, rebuilt by a community displaced by gargantuan chemical factories.

Buddhists in medieval Chinese society did not enjoy epistemological hegemony. Unfortunately, due to limitations of space, this chapter introduces only those non-Buddhist ways of knowing the world that impinged directly on the history of the Buddhist community at Changlu. Where relevant, the indigenous Chinese five elements theory is introduced. In a world inhabited by dragons, one's engineering would have to address the challenges that dragons present. Finally, as a methodological note, this environmental history of a Chan Buddhist monastery was realized by reading across genres beyond standard Chan records and draws from Buddhist hagiographies, county gazetteers, official chronicles, literati river diaries, and Japanese pilgrim's journals.

Medieval Buddhist Engineering

Medieval Chinese Buddhists responded to the possibilities afforded by the Yangzi River in conceptual and material ways that likely differ from those of most readers of this book. Buddhist engineering resists our categories as we commonly use them, presenting different figurations of materiality and belief. Medieval Buddhists, nonetheless, conceived of and engineered solutions that transformed their environments. Learning more about medieval Buddhists and their environments may also lead us to new ways of seeing the assumptions hidden within our own worldviews.²

Medieval Buddhist engineering valued empiricism. Countless medieval Buddhist projects in China were well-engineered constructions that endured for centuries. For example, the Wan'an Bridge over Luoyang River of Quanzhou, with its clever stone pylons designed like small skiffs, was first constructed in the eleventh century and periodically repaired thereafter. Even today, visitors can view the Buddhist iconography and passages from scripture inscribed on stone by its original Buddhist patrons.³ Other medieval water management solutions included rain rituals, the propitiation of dragons, and installing statues and pagodas along the riverbanks. The ritualists who performed such practices were judged by their effectiveness. For example, a spring flood in the imperial capital of Kaifeng in 1119 could not be controlled by the emperor's favored Daoist priest, Lin Lingsu, and instead was tamed only after prayers to the Buddhist saint Sengqie.⁴ Empirical effectiveness mattered in these religio-environmental dramas. To understand the drama of Changlu, we must consider its environmental and human actors.

We could refer to the river as an agent of Buddhist history because it established a distinct matrix of possibilities upon which humans could act. The river provided possibilities, though it was not responsible for which of those possibilities people enacted. Nonetheless, the river afforded some Buddhisms and not others. As a result, the material and conceptual aspects of Buddhism were entwined with one another from their inception. Each of the three examples introduced in this section illustrates a religious idea that both emerges from the riverine environment and animates actions that take place within it. The examples are: the mythological origins of Changlu, the historical founding of a monastery, and the unofficial vernacular religion.

In both the historical and imagined origins of Changlu Monastery, the Yangzi River features prominently. The earliest Buddhist activity associated with the site is the famous tale of Bodhidharma escaping from Nanjing to Changlu by crossing the river on a reed in 527, which significantly predates the construction of a proper Chan monastery in the eleventh century. Though a historical Bodhidharma existed, our knowledge about him is very limited. Regardless, all branches of Chinese Chan, Korean Sŏn, and Japanese Zen have revered Bodhidharma as the twenty-eighth Indian patriarch in a lineage of awakened masters descended directly from the Buddha, and as the person who came to China to transmit the awakened mind to Chinese disciples. The association of Changlu with a key event in the Bodhidharma mythology was a boon for the monastery, conferring prestige, attracting pilgrims and patrons, and embedding Changlu in the East Asian art historical record.

The story of Bodhidharma crossing the vast Yangzi on a narrow reed is a good example of the entanglement of material environment and religious imagination. The Bodhidharma legend appears in numerous sources, and a detailed account is even found in local government histories. The Chinghua Era (1465–1487) *Luhe County Gazetteer* records a version of the well-known story: in 527 Bodhidharma addressed the Liang imperial court inside the city of Jiankang (modern Nanjing), and insulted Emperor Wu (464–549). Bodhidharma escaped by crossing the vast Yangzi standing on a single reed and alighted on the northern shore at the town of Changlu.⁵ The symbolism of this story is especially potent if one is familiar with the nearly mile-wide span of the lower Yangzi River. As an outward manifestation of his liberation, Bodhidharma mastered the nearly impassable river waters. He thereby enacted the canonical Buddhist parable wherein beings on this near shore of *saṃsāra* remain in danger and suffering, while the Buddha's teachings serve as a vessel to carry Buddhists to the far shore of liberation. Changlu was the place on the far shore from Nanjing city, where this religious hero landed during his escape north. Because this tale of Bodhidharma crossing the Yangzi River on a reed has circulated widely down to today, Changlu Monastery has long been

associated with the tumultuous waters of the Yangzi.

Knowledge of this miracle, supposedly from the sixth century, appears only in records from the mid-eleventh century, a time after imperial patronage had already funded the construction of a grand monastery directly on the north bank of the Yangzi.⁶ Thereafter, Bodhidharma crossing on a reed to Changlu became a prominent motif in the visual and literary record across East Asia. An ink-wash painting (fig. 8.1) by a Buddhist layman bears a didactic verse by the illustrious Chan monk Yishan Yining (1247–1317): “He came across rivers and deserts,/to face the Emperor and say ‘I don’t know.’/As soon as his gambit failed he made an escape,/his feet treading upon the waves.”⁷ Yishan Yining is one of several Chan monks who emigrated to Kamakura, Japan, where he widely influenced the development of literature in Japanese Zen. In Japan, he added poetic colophons to additional paintings of Bodhidharma crossing the Yangzi.⁸ Within China, the image of Bodhidharma crossing the Yangzi was carved into stele at Shaolin Monastery—a site even more closely associated with Bodhidharma.⁹ A later Chinese *gāthā*, or religious verse, by the great monk Hanshan Deqing (1546–1623) celebrated Bodhidharma’s mastery of the river: “The sea of suffering has no shore,/his heel has nothing to rest on,/except this single reed,/all the way to that other shore.”¹⁰ Through images and verse, a story about Changlu and the Yangzi circulated widely and endured for centuries.

Perhaps, like the time needed for Bodhidharma’s travel by reed, it took a



Figure 8.1 Li Yaofu (active ca. 1300), *Bodhidharma Crossing the Yangzi River on a Reed*, with inscription by Yishan Yining (1247–1317). Hanging scroll; ink on paper. Edward Elliott Family Collection, Purchase, The Dillon Fund Gift, 1982. Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York.

full day's journey for an ordinary medieval traveler from the metropolis of Nanjing to reach Changlu by boat.¹¹ In other words, the myth of Bodhidharma crossing on a reed was associated with Changlu in particular, and not someplace else on the shore, because Changlu is where a traveler would alight after one day. It was only logical that Bodhidharma had landed here, in Changlu, because the physics of the river (its width and currents) would naturally bring a riverine traveler to the Changlu wharfs. According to travel diaries, one would arrive at the river gate, a real place that one could understand to be the very shore reached by Bodhidharma. This belief led to the construction in 1211 of a hall to honor Bodhidharma, sponsored by Emperor Ningzong. During early Ming reconstruction, a pair of sandals said to have belonged to Bodhidharma was enshrined there. Across generations, the connection to Bodhidharma was made real and was one source of inspiration for the regular fashioning and refashioning of Buddhism at Changlu. The reality of the river made it possible for this particular Bodhidharma myth to be emplaced here, which, as it led to pilgrimage by boat as well as to patronage and construction, altered the shoreline.

We turn now to the historical construction of Changlu. Construction at Changlu Monastery fulfilled additional religious needs beyond manifesting the story of Bodhidharma. The historical founding of the famous Changlu Monastery appears to predate its earliest associations with Bodhidharma and is instead tied to the life and career of Empress Liu (968–1033), who was the first great patron of the monastery. She was born in Sichuan, land of the upper Yangzi River system. Accounts differ regarding the early life of Empress Liu, though all agree she came from relatively humble origins.¹² According to the Northern Song scholar Shao Bowen (1057–1134), one of our earliest sources on the subject, when the future empress was a young woman, she traveled downriver with her father. They descended through the Three Gorges and arrived at Jade Spring Temple (*Yuquan si*), where a Buddhist monk skilled at physiognomy immediately recognized her future nobility.¹³ After prophesizing her fortuitous destiny, the monk provided financial support for her distant travel onward to the Song capital at Kaifeng. There, indeed, in 983 she entered the palace of the future Emperor Zhenzong (968–1022), and rose in rank until becoming empress in 1012. Her *de facto* rule began as early as 1019, and after Zhenzong's death, Empress Dowager Liu ruled Song China through formal regency from 1022 to 1032. She then sought to honor the monk for his perspicacity. Shao Bowen records the event as follows:

The venerable from Jade Spring was by then living in Changlu. The Empress summoned him several times, but he would not come, and so she sent a messenger to ask what he needed. He responded, "This monk has no needs.

However, Jade Spring Temple lacks a monks' hall, and at Changlu the temple has not even a mountain gate.¹⁴ Perhaps the Empress could think of them." The Empress took valuable items from her personal residence and bequeathed them as funding for the two temples. Thereby, they built Changlu Monastery overlooking the river, its gate standing in the water.¹⁵ As soon as the gate was built, it was destroyed by [the flood of] a river-dragon. The Empress, feeling compelled to restore it, ordered crude iron totaling tens-of-thousand *jīn* be piled below, and so the gate was then realized. Indeed, river-dragons fear iron!¹⁶

The highest imperial authority sponsored construction that transformed a small temple at the mouth of the Changlu River. The once insignificant temple became one of the largest and finest Buddhist monastic institutions in East Asia, one that remained prominent for hundreds of years. The *Yizheng County Gazetteer* records further details of how the empress financed the enormous cost of materials and five years of labor, all completed by 1027.¹⁷ We will focus here on the river gate that celebrated the riparian location of the monastery, an object that served material and imaginative functions, and whose construction transformed local hydrological processes. I am not aware of evidence for other riverine entryways to monasteries from the Song dynasty; however, in later times, other lower Yangzi River sites also had gates that opened directly onto the river. A later example showing a gate built on land for those arriving by boats can be seen in early photographs taken at nearby Jinshan Monastery in Zhenzhou (fig. 8.2).¹⁸ According to contemporary accounts, the river gate at Changlu was similarly located near a wharf.

The river gate, at first, was placed directly into the riverbed without buttressing. Almost immediately after its initial construction, however, the unfortified river gate was damaged by floodwaters. A solution was engineered. Many tons of iron were sunk to the riverbed to create a foundation. To my knowledge, there has been no archaeological survey to search for the iron deposits. As I show below, though iron may corrode fairly easily, the gate stood for a remarkably long time. We should infer that it was well engineered. Another reason for its success is offered by our historical commentators, one whereby the material solution also operated within its cultural *imaginaire*: Shao Bowen tells us that the iron foundation struck fear into the river-dragons who cause floods. We can also understand that the heaps of iron had further consequences: as they altered the river's propensity to meander and erode the riverbank, later travelers attested to silt deposition that rendered the gate inaccessible to river travelers.

With this practical hydroengineering solution, the riverine gate survived at least one hundred and fifty years, as attested in Southern Song (1127–1279) records. In his *Record of a Boat Trip to Wu* of 1177, Fan Chengda (1126–1193) observed, as his boat approached, that the river waters beat against the durable



Figure 8.2 Photograph of boats moored by the entrance to Jinshan Monastery of Zhenjiang, by Edward Bangs Drew (1843–1924), from album compiled by Anna D. Drew in 1887. Harvard-Yenching Library of Harvard College Library, Harvard University.

temple gate.¹⁹ “This is the place Bodhidharma crossed the Yangzi on a single reed,” he wrote. He was concerned about erosion nearby and noted the loss of the surrounding villagers’ homes that “had all washed away,” likely during floods. Fan described the monastery as standing at the edge of a sandy shoal. He observed that it was no longer possible to moor a boat and makes clear that such had once been the regular practice. We can speculate that the local wharf washed out like the villager’s homes, or that sedimentation had made the wharf inaccessible. He records that he walked after his vessel docked at a wharf five *li* away, roughly one hour’s travel on foot. (During the Song, one *li* was roughly equivalent to half a kilometer.) Up until Fan’s visit in 1177, at least, the iron-reinforcement continued to resist the tendency of the river to erode the banks beneath the gate and the nearby shoreline. The erosion and sedimentation processes of the riverbank, which were the result of the gate’s own iron reinforcement, had in turn rendered the gate unreachable by boat. Fan notes that villagers had built a small thatch-hut memorial to Bodhidharma at the new wharf. A kind of religious sedimentation deposited a new, unofficial Bodhidharma memorial five *li* away, constructed by villagers to welcome people to the wharf that became newly important as the most convenient still-accessible landing site. Although some aspects of the religious imagination

remained consistent, such as the connection to Bodhidharma, manifestations of this religious *imaginaire* moved along the shoreline according to the sedimentation and transformations of the Yangzi.

There is no record of the gate's demise. In 1185, after most of the temple's buildings were destroyed in a flood, the central structures of Changlu Monastery were rebuilt several *li* away from the river on higher ground. For several centuries, local historians noted that an old mountain gate (though possibly a reconstruction) stood near "Bodhi Bridge," some distance from the new monastery.²⁰ That ornate stone bridge itself was depicted as recently as 1885, when it appeared in the top right of a woodblock image of Changlu Monastery in the *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer* (fig. 8.3).²¹ In this representation, Bodhi Bridge is shown near ship masts, an apparition of the monastery's old site, and a reminder to viewers of the monastery's proximity to the river. As Buddhists constructed sacred space here, the shifting of the riverbank necessitated maintenance strategies that differed from those seen, for example, in Maria Heim's analysis in this volume of heritage trees that occupied fixed locations. In texts and images like those above, key historical events needed to be inscribed and reinscribed on the ever-shifting shore. The infrastructures of riverine Buddhism undulate and move.

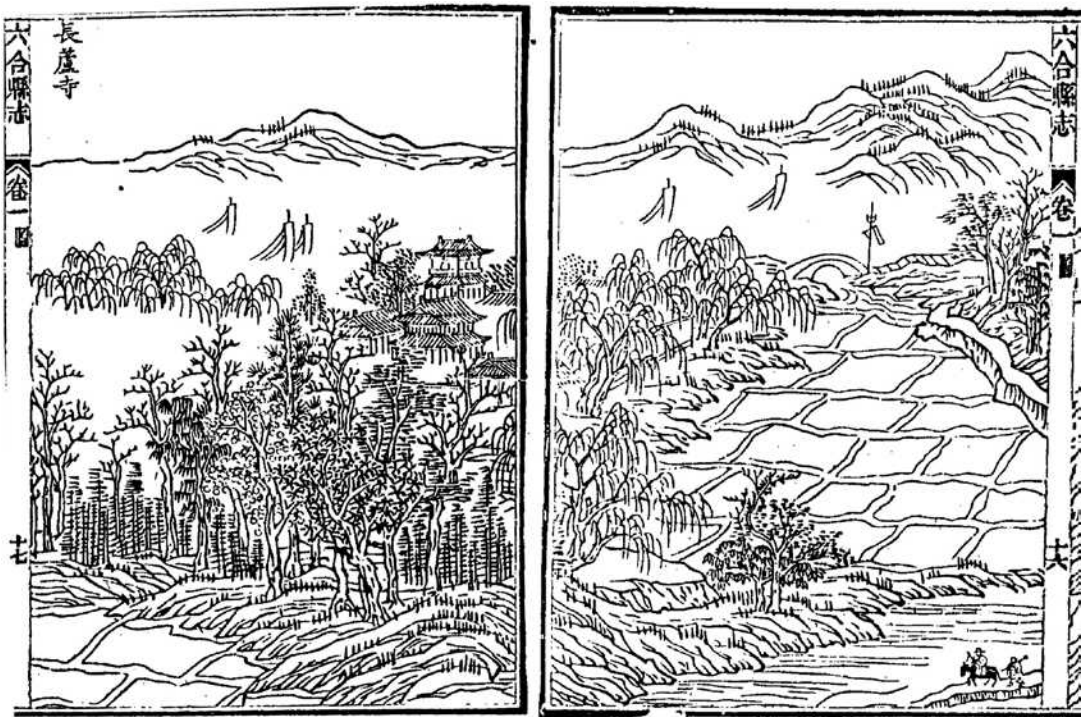


Figure 8.3 Changlu Monastery amid woods, fields, and waterways, with sails in the near distance. Woodcut from *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 1885.

Changlu's riparian location, on the path of travelers, is one reason it became the focus of Empress Liu's donations. The religious urge to construct a monastery at the Changlu shoreline—an act of karmic merit-making—required hydroengineering solutions. Plans for a riverine gateway demanded an enormous iron embankment to secure it. A religious good deed altered the river's flow and processes of erosion and deposition, which transformed the banks and shore. Given these material, imaginative, and environmental variables, I argue that these riverine gateways were multivalent. In his study of a Song-era religious site on a midriver island, Poul Anderson argues that premodern Chinese ironworks along rivers could have both “symbolic and practical functions.”²² Similarly, the iron-reinforced gate at Changlu was imaginatively, materially, and environmentally consequential. Most simply, the gate greeted those who arrived by boat. It marked the farthest extent of the sacred space of the monastery. Perhaps less obvious to us today, the use of iron was symbolically powerful. The iron-reinforced structure also was understood to control flooding, because, as Shao Bowen tells us, river-dragons fear iron.

In Shao's text above, a river-dragon, or *jiao*, caused the flood. Across time and space, the Chinese word *jiao* was a multivalent draconym, not a single concept.²³ The *jiao* as a water creature appeared in pre-Buddhist early Chinese texts such as Qu Yuan's (d. 278 BCE) *Elegies of Chu*. In the Song dynasty, river-dragons and Buddhist monks might regularly interact. A similar *jiao* was noted by the Buddhist monk Wenying (fl. 1078) in his miscellany *Pure Discussions over Jade Teapots*. Wenying wrote that as a young man in the lower Yangzi region he learned that a *jiao* will cause a flood when it hatches underwater; hence, in the local idiom *jiao* were referred to as “the flood makers” (*fahong*).²⁴ Also related, the Buddhist saint Sengqie of Sizhou (617–710) was widely venerated in the Song for his posthumous ability to control floods caused by river spirits and to ensure the safety of those who traveled by water.²⁵ Dragons and other spirits of rivers needed to be assuaged, one way or another. Elsewhere in Luhe County a non-Buddhist shrine to the Dragon King (*Longwang miao*) received offerings to request appropriate and timely rainfall and to avert natural disasters.²⁶ A river was home to dragons, and Buddhists in China responded to this environmental reality.

River-dragons fear iron because dragons correspond with the element wood, which can be controlled by the element metal, according to Chinese five phases cosmology. Poul Anderson documented similar symbolic uses of iron rods or pillars to control waters, as well as Chinese myths in which flood waters are controlled by various metals, particularly iron.²⁷ Iron objects could be embossed with symbols that themselves were understood to be efficient at controlling water, or they could be cast into efficacious icons such as oxen or a Buddhist protector deity. This same understanding clearly informs the Song

record of Empress Liu's patronage of an iron-reinforced monastery gate to control the river-dragon. The enormous installation of iron resolved a hydro-engineering challenge and made it possible to extend the boundary of the monastery's sacred space onto the riverbed. Song writers such as Shao understood hydroengineering to have solved a material problem that was inseparable from the threat of a flood-making dragon.

Not all Song dynasty engineering, however, can be said to have fulfilled both practical and symbolic functions. We can compare the iron-reinforced gate at Changlu with another eleventh-century Buddhist iron project, a pagoda constructed nearby downriver at Ganlu Monastery. Ganlu is atop a steep promontory overlooking the Yangzi River near Zhenjiang, about one day's travel downriver from Changlu. There in 1069 an old stone pagoda collapsed. A hidden crypt emerged, and in it were reliquaries, sacred objects, and several Tang inscriptions. The community raised an enormous sum to cast a nine-story pagoda from iron, completed in 1078, to reinter the items.²⁸ Modern archaeology has recovered Song inscriptions that reflect the wishes of the community that sponsored the iron pagoda. Yunmen Chan master Baojue Wuzhou (eleventh century), then abbot of Jinshan Monastery (also located on the Yangzi), noted that the prominence of this rock jutting over the river made this site well suited for transmitting the karmic benefits of the relics to numerous passersby. The notion that the iron pagoda would control the waters is absent from all the excavated inscriptions. The stated intention of those who built the pagoda was not to tame the river. Nonetheless, over time the local community came to understand the large iron structure atop the riverside rock as exerting control over the waters below. A local children's song transcribed in 1583 went, "When winds blow down the Iron Pagoda, / Waters flood the Zhenjiang sluice." This popular song gained new meaning when the iron pagoda toppled in a storm that year, and a series of watery disasters caused numerous drownings.²⁹ In response, monks quickly took the lead to restore the iron pagoda. The pagoda can be seen in a woodblock (fig. 8.4) published in his illustrated travel journal by the Manchu bannerman Linqing (1791–1846), who also wrote confidently that the iron pagoda had been built "to subdue the tidal waves of the river."³⁰ The upper stories of the pagoda were damaged several times, most recently in the turbulent nineteenth century. Today, the surviving remnants of the pagoda are an amalgamation of Song and Ming craftwork (fig. 8.5).

The iron pagoda at Ganlu illustrates how multiple layers of meaning can accrue at a religious site specifically in response to the environment. Over centuries, the Song monks' intention to instrumentalize the geoaesthetics of the site to amplify the effects of relics was forgotten. Nonetheless, the iron pagoda continued to participate symbolically in water control, even if it had no immediately obvious engineering impact on the river. (In 2013, the remnants of the pagoda entered the register of nationally protected cultural sites—sedimenting new



Figure 8.4 Ganlu Monastery on Mount Beigu abutting the Yangzi River, with Iron Pagoda at the right. Woodcut from *Hongxue yinyuan tuji* (xylograph produced in Yangzhou, 1847), digitized by Waseda University Library.

layers of meaning.) Back at Changlu, by contrast, the iron reinforcement of the river gateway served both imagined and physical hydroengineering functions.

Similar to the Ganlu Pagoda, at Changlu, near its river gate, an enormous iron statue of the Spirit of Shensha (*Shensha shen*^a) stood in direct relationship with its environmental context. According to historical gazetteers, a ferrous avatar was placed near the riverbank to assist in pacifying the flood-making river-dragon.³¹ The name of this Spirit of Shensha was more often written “Spirit of the Deep Sands” (*Shensha shen*^b). This minor Buddhist deity appeared fiercely

before pilgrims, including Xuanzang (602–664), who was led to water in the desert, thus inspiring “Sandy,” one of the protagonists of *Journey to the West*.³² Earlier still, the deity appeared in Chinese Buddhist spell books.³³ Shensha was generally associated with averting calamity. When the Japanese pilgrim Jōgyō (d. 867) traveled to China from 838 to 839, he obtained a Shensha icon and a dedicated liturgy that he carried back to Japan: “Today all people of Tang China revere this deity for protection from natural disaster and other benefits.”³⁴ In the Song, the Spirit of Shensha was worshipped by Buddhist monks across sects and geography.³⁵ The Shensha that appeared on the Yangzi at Changlu was, unlike any other Shensha icon that I am aware of, made of iron.

According to an article in the modern *Jiangsu Provincial Gazetteer*, that iron object retained its terrifying humanoid shape as recently as 1953, when a team measured it as being over five meters tall and five meters around.³⁶ It was destroyed shortly thereafter, and only the pedestal remains today. This prominent feature of the local riverscape was excluded from most Chan sources, which often focused on the legend of Bodhidharma. Nonetheless, far-flung texts suggest that the iron-bodied instantiation of the Spirit of Shensha at Changlu was widely known to be capable of controlling water spirits. The émigré monk Dongming Hui (1272–1340; J. Tōmyō E’nichi), whose career took him to Japan, in a list of famous monastery protectors included “the Great Spirit Shensha of Changlu Monastery who holds firm the snake’s head.”³⁷ Nearer Changlu, the local names for the “Vajra Spirit” (*Jingang shen*) and “Iron Vajra” (*Tiejin shen*) that are recorded in gazetteers hint at the vernacular understanding of the Buddhist identity of this protector deity. A Yuan dynasty (1279–1368) popular ballad begins: “Spirit of Shensha with body of iron, /he can defeat watery monsters!”³⁸ Fragments such as this suggest that the Spirit of Shensha appeared riverside as an iron icon because both the deity and iron were directly relevant to the riparian context.

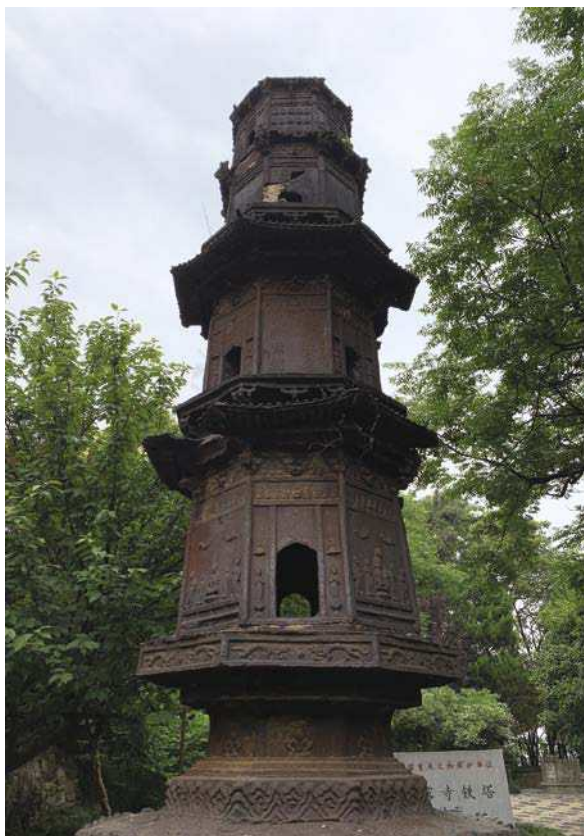


Figure 8.5 Remnants of the Iron Pagoda at Ganlu Monastery, Zhenjiang City: two lower stories cast during the Song Dynasty and two upper stories during the Ming Dynasty. Photograph by the author, 2019.

The religion of those who lived by the river included but was not restricted to Buddhism. The religions of the river can be seen in the diary of the Japanese Buddhist pilgrim Jōjin (1011–1081), who arrived at the Song seaport city of Ningbo and then traveled inland by riverways. When boatmen lost the wind they prayed to spirits and tossed lots to forecast the weather.³⁹ Jōjin also noted the various religious activities that took place directly upon wharfs.⁴⁰ He recounted that his boat once pulled up to a riverside temple, and without disembarking the men onboard “supplanted from a distance” (*yao bai*).⁴¹ The men also revered icons of the aforementioned Buddhist saint Sengqie. Sengqie was a historical person from Central Asia who traveled to east China and founded a monastery along the Huai River. There, he self-mummified and posthumously continued to respond to petitions and prayers, becoming the object of widespread devotion in the Song.⁴² The popular Sengqie was venerated even in the Song imperial court, as mentioned above, after the Daoist Lin Lingsu failed to turn the floodwaters.⁴³ As for the river religion near Changlu Monastery, the ferrous Spirit of Shensha likely played a prominent role. The faint echoes of on-the-ground voices, hinted at above, can also be gleaned from elite accounts, such as a Yuan-era traveler’s poem: “At their Sanskrit intoning, the river dragon emerges, /when the monks fast, the wild starlings scatter.”⁴⁴ Here, the dragon is as much a part of the natural world as a flock of birds. So the actions of the monks, perhaps in a rainmaking or rain-controlling ritual, are able to communicate with their local dragon. For some observers, the activities of the Buddhist monks inside Changlu Monastery held implications for the broader river religion beyond the monastery gate.

The compilers of Chan records seldom made note of the Spirit of Shensha at Changlu, despite its continuous presence up to the 1950s. Nonetheless, such a river-taming icon was congruous with numerous recorded activities in Chan monasteries. Buddhists in medieval China were well known for their ability to both conjure and curtail rain and snow.⁴⁵ A Chan abbot from the Song or later would lead the monks in procedures invoking rain during drought, or sunshine after excessive rainfall. In the Yuan era, the imperially sponsored Chan monastic code included a liturgy for rainmaking that called for a rainmaking altar and daily regimens for intoning rain-eliciting scripture.⁴⁶ Earlier sources indicate rainmaking activities in Chan monasteries by the eleventh century. Chan master Zongze, who had studied at Changlu and later returned as abbot, gave ritual thanks after a successful petition for rainfall.⁴⁷ Though Buddhist rainmaking rites were widely practiced and not limited to riverside contexts, rites sponsored at Changlu Monastery would have been in response to local conditions. The monks prayed for the right amount of rain to support agriculture, and the Spirit of Shensha tamed excess waters. From the perspective of the riverine community near Changlu Monastery, Chan monastic rites as well as the cultic veneration of Shensha were part of a

continuum of practices aimed at addressing the various threats posed by the local river system.

Reflecting on the distribution of agency around Changlu, we see the river itself was a precondition for the Buddhist monastery and some practices at this site. The riparian environment invited a range of human responses; yet those material conditions also constituted a horizon of possibility. People in this matrix of possibility made sense of their world through cultural and religious logics, which together with a repertoire of semimythologized local history also gave people the means to conceive of actions by which they engineered transformations in their imagined and material environments.

Material and Spiritual Prosperity

In addition to facing the river's dangers, a riverine monastery was enriched by the abundance of the river system, and important contributions to Buddhist monasticism emerged from this prosperity. The Northern Song capital itself was located at the confluence of four rivers, a wise choice, according to imperial officials, for access to the rich resources that could meet numerous needs.⁴⁸ The lower Yangzi River system afforded advantages to large institutions and made possible the material, social, and spiritual prosperity of Changlu Monastery. This is evident in Changlu's architecture, its relation to travelers, and the foundational system of monastic law that spread from Changlu across East Asia. Numerous examples can attest to each of these qualities of prosperity.

The material prosperity of society in the lower Yangzi River region extended to the physical structures of its religious institutions. Scholar and statesman Wang Anshi (1021–1086) composed a memorial inscription for the construction at Changlu Monastery of a library to house a copy of the Buddhist canon. He recorded that the tremendous sum of thirty million cash (or thirty thousand strings) had been raised to procure fine materials and labor for the project.⁴⁹ The river system itself was the means by which large quantities of stone and timber could be transported to this riverside site. Similarly, at nearby Jinshan Monastery, the large sum of thirteen thousand strings of cash was spent to reconstruct a “Water and Land Hall” after a fire in 1048.⁵⁰ Enormous material wealth was directed to the construction of riverine Buddhism.

In addition to ornate buildings, the monastery complex at Changlu readily fed many hundreds, at times thousands, of people every day for centuries. By the year 1084, over one thousand monks resided inside Changlu Monastery.⁵¹ Between 1123 and 1128, the monastery accommodated seventeen hundred monks, the greatest number in its recorded history.⁵² Shortly thereafter, in 1130, Changlu Monastery was destroyed amid the Song-Jin wars (1125–1142),

an event detailed further below. Ever after becoming diminished in scale, the monastery was still home to several hundred monks in 1170, as recorded by the poet Lu You (1125–1210) in his river diary.⁵³ Lu You was impressed that Changlu Monastery had recovered more than other sites after the war. The economic productivity of riverine society and the strategic importance of the newly walled nearby city of Luhe likely underpinned its rapid recovery.

As others have shown, monasteries in China were integrated into local economies, in possession of fertile and productive farmlands, and earned revenue from capital-intensive equipment such as oil presses.⁵⁴ Monasteries near water could develop hydraulic milling facilities.⁵⁵ For example, a hand-scroll with diagrams of Jiangnan region monastery architecture from the 1200s includes a “schematic for a water powered mill” (*shuimo yang*) at the Bishan Temple of Ningbo.⁵⁶ After the Song-Jin wars, Changlu Monastery received a large imperial gift of farmlands measuring “hundreds of *mu*” (dozens of acres) that would generate revenue for the monastery.⁵⁷ Later gazetteers record that these farmlands were located over twenty *li* away from the river, far enough that they likely did not play a role in the daily regimen of the Chan monks at the monastery.

The most important contribution of Changlu Monastery to broader Buddhist history surely is the *Rules of Purity for the Chan Monastery*. This rulebook became a foundational model for Buddhist monasticism across East Asia.⁵⁸ The rulebook’s origins are in the prosperity of the lower Yangzi River region that made possible large Buddhist monasteries with hundreds or thousands of monks. In these large monasteries, some directly on the Yangzi River, management and instruction involved a team of monastic officers who assisted the Chan master qua abbot. This religio-educational culture was codified in the *Rules of Purity for the Chan Monastery*, completed in 1103 by Chan master Zongze (d. 1106). Zongze studied at Changlu Monastery. When serving as a teacher elsewhere, Zongze composed this rulebook to reproduce the monastic culture and disciplined training he had experienced firsthand at Changlu. In his preface to this text, he writes that these behaviors learned at Changlu were conducive to spiritual progress in a communal setting.⁵⁹ Shortly after completing this rulebook, Zongze was invited to return to Changlu and head the community as abbot. The wealth and size of Changlu made possible by this riverine setting “afforded” the creation of a mode of monastic life that in turn became a model for elsewhere. Many further “rules of purity” codebooks and aides were composed based on Zongze’s model and have governed innumerable Buddhist monasteries across East Asia down to today, including the Zen monasteries of Japan. A geoaesthetic reading of Zongze’s *Rules of Purity* might regard the book as the metaphoric “sediment” of the Yangzi, deposited in locales far from the riverbank itself. Or one might argue that if the Yangzi River afforded this monastic culture,

then the river itself in some way participated in the formation of East Asian Buddhist monasticism.

Sociologically, the Song-era developments at Changlu were so widely influential because riverine monasteries were part of international transportation networks. Song and Yuan sources describe river and seafaring vessels that could carry up to five hundred passengers.⁶⁰ Along these waterways, Buddhist monasteries served as inns for monks and official travelers, offering lodging, food, and baths.⁶¹ Lu You in his diary about traveling the Yangzi reports staying in roughly sixty temples and dining with abbots and other monks.⁶² Judging from the numerous poems written by official travelers, people frequently stopped at Changlu when coming or going to nearby Nanjing.⁶³ The illustrious Huang Tingjian (1045–1105) wrote a poem titled “Impeded by Rain, I entered Changlu Monastery [for shelter]” (*Zufeng ru Changlusi*). Changlu Monastery was imbued with both practical and symbolic functions as a shelter for passersby. Fan Chengda wrote in his diary of 1177 about spending one night in the monastery after departing Nanjing. The next morning, he joined that day’s Buddhist rite of wishing the emperor health and longevity.⁶⁴ Literati poems in later centuries often depict a bucolic river scene. Poets imagined that the seemingly eternal soundscape of the monastery together with the timeless presence of flora and fauna could connect them to Bodhidharma’s arrival on these shores.⁶⁵ With its location directly on the Yangzi River, Changlu Monastery was a regular waystation for travelers.

In addition to members of the literati, Buddhist monks also wandered the great river as part of their religious occupation. Ambitious monks would seek out excellent teachers to guide them toward awakening and instruct them in liberation from suffering. The numerous records of itinerant monks traveling between monasteries include international examples. The Japanese pilgrim Kaku’a (b. 1143) reached Song China in 1171. After a period of study in Hangzhou with Xiatang Huiyuan (1103–1176), also known as Fohai, he left to wander upriver: “In autumn the next year, he set off traveling for Nanjing. When he alighted on the river-shores of Changlu, he heard the drums. At once, he had a great insight and only then understood the meaning of the teaching that had been offered by Master Fohai. [Instead of proceeding to Nanjing, he turned around] and returned to Lingyin Monastery. He composed five *gāthā* [poetic verses] to express what he had seen. He finally departed east to return home across the sea.”⁶⁶

It is said that Master Fohai gave approval to Kaku’a for his awakening at the shores of Changlu, and wrote a *gāthā* in response. Japanese and Chinese monks commonly communicated by writing in lieu of speech, known as “brush-talk,” and frequently included verse. The five verses by Kaku’a survive. The first depicts a monk arriving by boat suddenly understanding the thusness of all things; the third describes the ineffability of awakening as being

like the moment a foot suddenly touches the earth disembarking from a boat. Sometimes the river itself became the language for understanding the dharma.

In these and numerous other ways, Buddhist monastic culture flourished in proximity to the capacities of the Yangzi River. A river is a thoroughfare, facilitating the movement of people, food, and building materials. The river and nearby farmlands provided material sustenance and made possible a lively monastic culture. The flourishing of Buddhist monastic culture shaped Zongze's Chan rulebook as well as Kaku'a's poems of awakening. The various forms of religious prosperity enjoyed at Changlu were supported by the abundances of the river.

Forms of Precarity

An abundance of water, however, was also dangerous. Historical gazetteers record a series of destructive events, including three floods and four fateful military events, followed by periods of reconstruction. The earliest recorded flood of consequence, according to Luhe County gazetteers, occurred in early summer of 964, though it is unclear what buildings existed at that time. Another flood in fall 1023 occurred amid the imperially sponsored construction that had begun that year, and destroyed the initial river gate, as discussed above. In addition to the dangers posed by floods, proximity to the river made Changlu Monastery vulnerable also to military forces for whom it held strategic importance. Since the 1980s, the riverine needs of the nation and the global economy have similarly affected the monastery.

The most well-documented example of destruction occurred during the Song-Jin wars (1125–1142). In late 1129, Jin troops were advancing on Nanjing. The retreating Song forces sought to hold the Jin army on the north banks of the Yangzi. In desperation, on the evening of the thirteenth day of the eleventh month (or January 1, 1130), Song officials destroyed the monastery at Changlu before it could fall under Jin control and be used for military purposes. Song officials meticulously recorded the destruction, perhaps to justify this extraordinary action. The following summarizes the incredibly detailed account in *Sanchao Beimeng huibian*.⁶⁷ Du Chong (d. 1141), the former governor of Kaifeng and responsible for protecting Nanjing, was told by an advisor: “Changlu Chongfu Monastery has rooms totaling some two-thousand bays. If the Jin seize it, they could lash [the timber] into crafts and cross [the Yangzi]. For this reason we should raze the monastery.” Facing this military conundrum, Du Chong ordered the razing of the grand Changlu Monastery. One of his generals set off with a small battalion, traveling by boat to the monastery, where the abbot Daolin (n.d.) welcomed them. Daolin, upon learning that Changlu, one the largest and finest monasteries in the

known world, was to be destroyed, purportedly responded, “The rise and fall of all things have their season. Whatever things come to be will also be destroyed. Why would I have an opinion?” After reflecting on the Buddhist teaching of impermanence, the monk went before the main icon of the Buddha and offered incense one last time. The Song general then stood before the living icon of the Buddha and read the imperial edict. I would underscore that solemn moment: the Song military official informed the Buddha of the reasons Changlu Monastery would be razed—so much wood so close to the river at this moment could become weaponized and endanger those on the other shore.

The compilers of our records do not render judgment or offer expiation, and we are left to struggle with the ethics of destroying the grand monastery, which burned through the night until “the foundations were covered in ash, only metal nails surviving.” Changlu Monastery’s proximity to the river during wartime shifted its horizons of possibility. The innumerable wooden walls, floors, and ceilings of the monastery’s magnificent timber buildings could be dismantled and refashioned into vessels that would enable soldiers to cross the very river that had made such abundance possible. This event illustrates how the capacities of the river that made the monastery prosperous—access to abundant timber and metal materials, villagers and farmers that provided foodstuffs, and proximity to wharfs and riverine transportation—could also be the cause of its ruin.

In this and other wars, monasteries were garrisoned by troops and frequently destroyed.⁶⁸ And yet the monastery at Changlu would again be built near the river. As noted above, Fan Chengda saw Changlu’s buildings precariously close to the water on his visit in 1177. Within several years, the riverbank collapsed and the main buildings were destroyed.⁶⁹ Shortly after that, and no later than 1185, the monastery was rebuilt on slightly higher ground, several *li* away.⁷⁰ That slightly elevated location selected in or shortly before 1185 is today a protected area known as Old Changlu Monastery, to which we will return below. Even at this new elevation, the river continued to influence Changlu Monastery.

The records of Changlu Monastery in the Luhe County gazetteers condense centuries into a pattern of periodic destruction and reconstruction. The monastery was damaged by Jin troops in 1206, again for its strategic location, and large-scale reconstruction was completed in 1211, during the reign of Emperor Ningzong (r. 1194–1224). The monastery was then destroyed during the Yuan-Ming war (1352–1368), and in 1368 reconstruction was led by Chan master Wujin Zudeng (n.d.) with sponsorship from Ming Emperor Hongwu (r. 1368–1399). After the Ming capital moved north to Beijing, there are fewer records of activity at the monastery. It seems the monastery fell into disrepair—a form of destruction by neglect that is not unique to riparian environments—until a major rebuilding effort in 1622. We have some additional records from the late

Ming through Qing eras; however, a detailed environmental history of these intervening centuries would exceed the limits of this chapter. The remainder of this chapter brings us to the contemporary inheritors, who were forced to rebuild Changlu Monastery at a third site and yet continue to refashion the Song as a golden age and source of charisma.

Modern Changlu

Today, the newest Changlu Monastery stands ten kilometers west of the old site. Cycles of destruction and reconstruction have continued but with different modern timbres. Changlu Monastery, like other religious phenomena in modern China, is the inheritor of a series of transformations that began in the late Qing. In 1858, during the Taiping Civil War (1850–1864), Changlu Monastery was again destroyed, together with many other riverine monasteries throughout the region.⁷¹ Only two small buildings survived the civil war, each a mere three bays wide. The iron Spirit of Shensha remained, but its shrine building was reduced to ash. Changlu locals rebuilt the temple rooms with grass thatch and rehung the large Qianlong-era bell to the best of their ability.⁷² Such humble patronage is in stark contrast to the imperial grandeur of centuries past. In 1920, the abbot Chiyi (n.d.) raised funds from adjacent cities for new construction.⁷³ Though still relatively modest, Changlu Monastery again had an abbot and hosted monks. At that time, Qing- and Republican-period construction sat atop the stone foundations laid down in the Song dynasty thanks to the investment of local communities. A culture of reconstruction has proven more durable than the structures themselves.

During the People's Republic of China, the infrastructure at Changlu Monastery was repurposed. In 1960, the grounds were selected for Changlu Middle School. "We no longer hear temple bells, now we hear the voices of studying," a local historian observed.⁷⁴ Around that time, during the Great Leap Forward, liturgical objects were melted down for scrap, including the Qianlong bell. Later, during the Cultural Revolution, the giant icon of the Spirit of Shensha was melted for raw materials.⁷⁵ Today, a placard beside two empty footprints in its old stone foundation indexes the absence of the Spirit of Shensha. During these waves of modernization marked by antisuperstition campaigns, many of the functions of the riverine monastery were effaced. In the period of reforms and opening that followed, a Nanjing City commission in 1983 surveyed the site, noted its Song dynasty foundations and stone wells, and declared it a protected cultural area. Buddhism and religion are politically safe when they can be sanitized as traditional culture.

The river's capacity to change the lives of those on its banks continues to take further turns. Changlu's location near the Yangzi River again holds strategic

importance. In 2001, construction began on the Nanjing Chemical Industrial Park, one of only three such national-level projects. Today, over one hundred chemical manufacturing companies are clustered onto forty-five square kilometers of wharf-lined riverfront, served by new highways, rail networks, and pipelines. This includes BASF-YPC, a US\$5 billion Sino-German joint venture by BASF, the largest chemical producer in the world, and Sinopec, one of the world's largest petrochemical conglomerates. The BASF-YPC factories now supply over three million tons of polymers and basic chemicals to the Chinese industrial market per year.⁷⁶ As a result of such investments that rely on this location on the Yangzi River, Nanjing now boasts one of the ten highest GDPs per capita among prefectural cities in China.

According to a publicly available 2005 BASF-commissioned report, Changlu was selected for an industrial park exactly because from this location: "The Yangzi offers rather quick access to international waterways."⁷⁷ The deep channel at Changlu makes international industrial supply chains possible. In addition, the river provides a ready source of water needed for manufacturing processes. The site's proximity to the metropolis of Nanjing, once a reason for river travelers to spend the night, now ensures a labor force for the riverside chemical industry.

Not entirely unlike the wars in previous centuries, the modern nation's need for riverine industrial development has displaced the Changlu community. The 2005 BASF-commissioned report found that residents of Changlu complained "they can no longer eat fish from the local rivers or use the local water." A Changlu taxi driver called these environmental impacts "slow suicide." The report concludes: "The future of the [Changlu] community does not look bright."⁷⁸ Approximately thirty thousand people from Changlu District, including two thousand farmers, would be relocated.⁷⁹ When I visited Nanjing Chemical Industrial Park in January 2018, one could still find, amid the factory stacks and miles of elevated pipelines, the protected cultural site of the former Changlu Middle School. The Southern Song location of Changlu Monastery is now on a street directly across from Nanjing Titanium Dioxide Chemical Company (fig. 8.6.). Green stands of large trees rise above the walls of the protected grounds, attracting flocks of birds. In the former middle school, now rededicated to vocational training for local chemical industrial jobs, one small temple building remains (fig. 8.7).

In 2009, a new Changlu Monastery was built ten kilometers to the west, on a small hill in Taizishan Park (fig. 8.8). This relocation of the temple to a nearby urban park mimics that of the displaced residents into residential towers. Two kilometers from the industrialized riverfront and somewhat closer to Nanjing, this new location can be reached on foot from the Dachang Metro Station. A large stone mortar—recovered in 1997 during construction at the middle school, and said to be from the Song dynasty—was moved to the new temple.



Figure 8.6 View of Nanjing Titanium Dioxide Chemical Company from the front gate of Old Changlu Monastery, Luhe County, 2018. Photograph by the author.



Figure 8.7 Old Changlu Monastery's front gate, Luhe County, 2018. Photograph by the author.



Figure 8.8 Main hall of new Changlu Monastery under construction, Taizishan Park, Nanjing. 2018. Photograph by the author.

The large weathered stone, labeled and prominently positioned during my 2018 visit, conveys a physical connection to the previous location and history. According to the local Luhe historian Liu Rongxi, who recompiled scattered epigraphs and temple lore, the monastery had been destroyed nine times and had now been rebuilt a tenth time. In newspaper interviews, the abbot Miaoqiu emphasized the glorious Song-era history of Changlu. He explained that the layout of the Meditation and Monks' Halls are based on a Song style uncommon in Chinese monasteries today. A public sign from 2011 to mark a second round of construction conveys the manner in which this history tallies with Chinese modernity: "To propagate Buddhist culture and establish a harmonious society, to protect the intangible cultural heritage of Jiangsu Province, to provide myriad Buddhists a fine religious activity space, the Nanjing Industrial Development Board decided to rebuild the Song dynasty imperial family temple of Changlu Chongfu Chan Monastery in Taizishan Park."⁸⁰

During a second visit in November 2018, I found Changlu Monastery at Taizishan Park bustling with things both new and old. The construction of additional buildings was ongoing. The refectory was open, and after a vegetarian meal, donations could be made with a mobile phone by scanning the temple's QR code. I spoke with monks, lay devotees from nearby communities, and day travelers from Nanjing. Twelve of some several dozen monks remained in residence after an intensive retreat. According to the vice abbot, the monastery

had a reputation for discipline and rigorous practice, and aspired to live up to its history as the birthplace of the “rules of purity” so as to become a monastic training center once again. In the main hall, approximately fifty women and men wearing the long-sleeved black robes of formal Buddhist laypeople gathered to perform “the three periods of attentive recitation” (*sanshi xinian*), a full-day ritual led by the vice abbot to benefit groups of visiting mourners. Communal lay practice appeared to be a regular activity. A flier announced that the temple would soon begin a twenty-one-day group recitation of all eighty chapters of the *Avataṃsaka Sūtra*. The karmic merit was said to be dedicated to liberating sentient beings as well as to praying for good rainfall, the aversion of natural disasters, and the stability of the nation. Such relatively traditional values are central to the communal life of the new temple, were spoken of by community members, and appear on signs and placards throughout the grounds. In addition, the monastery hosts one-day retreats for busy professionals in a more cosmopolitan style. These occur in a modern building called “Bodhidharma Chan Pavilion” that includes a library, a classroom, and a multifunctional space that on the day I visited had seating arranged for a zither performance. According to a 2015 booklet with essays and testimonials titled *One-Day Chan*, these retreats teach both contemporary breath mindfulness as well as *gong’an* meditation specific to Chan, interspersed with physical activity, a tea experience, vegetarian meals, and a concluding ceremony that invites the sharing of personal insights and the fashioning of a communal experience.⁸¹ Among other things, the new Changlu Monastery is a destination for professionals and students from Nanjing who seek relief from modern living. The participants in these three kinds of practice at the new monastery—monastic, communal, and retreatant—had some overlap. The religious life of the new Changlu Monastery reflects the broader contemporary Buddhist revival across China, and not a riverine Buddhist modernity only.

Displaced and rebuilt at a third site, a Changlu Monastery is still near the Yangzi River outside Nanjing. Even as the monastery’s leaders look to the past to assert authenticity and authority, the monastery can be defined by its relationship to the local people as well as by the national needs of the river.



The lower Yangzi River shaped the history of Buddhism. The most obvious facets of such a riparian environmental history are visible along the riverbanks, where Buddhists and others interacted with their physical environment in material and conceptual ways. Other more subtle threads of this riverine history were submerged within the flow of Buddhism and can be thought of as more like sediment of the Yangzi deposited far from the shores at Changlu. In the above history of a single site, we see that medieval Buddhism also involved attempts to engineer and alter the environment as well as periodic interventions by the state.

Buddhists adapted institutions and practices to the geoaesthetic conditions of the lower Yangzi River. The resultant style of monasticism, epitomized in the “rules of purity” codebooks, was then translated into other environments and environmental values. The abundance of the river also made possible infrastructure for official travelers and religious pilgrims. Despite the repeated flourishing of cultures and economies at Changlu, nonetheless, the riverine monastery community was compelled to respond to the fluctuations of the Yangzi River. Damage from floods necessitated a ferrous avatar of the Spirit of Shensha together with hydroengineering and relocation to higher ground—responses that yoked together conceptual and material operations. The monastery strived to prevent droughts and floods, and thereby to benefit the local community as well as its own farmlands and revenue streams. Proximity to the Yangzi River conferred advantages on and brought dangers to Changlu Monastery. Perhaps the most startling example of this duality posed by proximity to the river came in the form of the Song state. The grand monastery that had been built by Song imperial patronage was then razed by Song imperial forces in order to prevent its wooden beams and planks from falling into the hands of their enemy. The longer drama of riverine Buddhism at Changlu is a story of tension between environmental determinism, the changing needs of state actors, and the religious lives of the people who live by and wander through Changlu.⁸²

Much has been written about Buddhism on sacred peaks and in premodern and modern urban spaces. Recently, scholars have also turned their attention to what is now termed “maritime Buddhism.” Riparian monasteries and religious communities are deserving of further reflection. Riverine Buddhism at Changlu has repeatedly flourished in proximity to the capacities of a powerful river system, and was repeatedly destroyed by floods, armies, and factories. Rivers created the conditions for significant events in the history of Buddhism. If we want to tell further histories of riverine Buddhism, we will have to continue exploring the entanglements of human imagination, individual and collective actions, and their watery environments.

NOTES

Abbreviations

T = *Taishō shinshū daizōkyō* volume number, page number, register, and line number(s).

X = *Shinsan Dai Nihon zoku zōkyō* volume number, page number, register, and line.

SKQS = *Siku quanshu*

SBCK = *Sibu congkan*

Citations separated by a slash / are to the traditional fascicle number and page, followed by modern page number(s).

1. For a general natural and social history of the Yangzi, see Van Slyke, *Yangtze*.
2. On such spirit of comparison, see Campany, “Very Idea of Religions,” 290.
3. Liu, *Luoyang Wan’an qiao zhi*. The full-body relic of the monk Yibo 義波 who supervised fundraising efforts was enshrined in a temple on the eastern bank.
4. *Fozu tongji*, T49.421c10–18.
5. At least eight historical Luhe County gazetteers from the 1500s on survive and quote from the earlier Jiading text of 1218 and the Chenghua text of 1476. I have had access to the *Jiading Era Luhe County Gazetteer* of 1553 and the *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer* of 1885. In addition, Shiina (“Sōdai no Shinshū Chōroji,” 41–42) reproduces the Kangxi-era text of 1648.
6. Compiled before 1101, the *Jianzhong Jingguo xudenglu* (X78.758b2–3) records an earlier dialogue about Bodhidharma “on a single reed crossing from Jinling.” Slightly later examples can be found in Cao, “Yiwei dujiang.” Iconography is also discussed in Brinker, *Zen*, 150.
7. Translation modified from Wen Fong, *Beyond Representation*, 355. Zen monks created similarly styled ink wash paintings of *Bodhidharma on a Reed*, such as that of Fūgai, in Stephen Addiss, *Art of Zen*, 56–57.
8. Fontein and Hickman, *Zen Painting and Calligraphy*, 53–56.
9. Lachman (“Rushleaf Bodhidharma”) discusses a Yuan-era stele at Shaolin with a verse attributed to Emperor Renzong.
10. “Breaking Off a Reed to Cross the Yangzi River” 折蘆渡江, in *Hanshan laoren mengyouji*, X73.713c14.
11. In *Wuchuan lu*, 2.26a, Fan Chengda reports arriving the day after departing Nanjing downriver. Lu You reports that traveling upriver against the current the same distance took several days. *Ru Shu ji*, 169–170.
12. For dating Empress Liu’s career, I follow the analysis in Chaffee, “Rise and Regency.”
13. Alternatively, in *Huizhu yuhua*, 22.33b–34a, Wang Mingqing (1127–after 1214) states that a monk named Fadeng was from Sichuan too, and already living downriver in a hut at Changlu.
14. A “mountain gate” (*shanmen*) was typically the outer gate of a monastery’s precincts. This gate served a symbolic function, marking the boundary of the temple’s sacred space, and was a site for rituals. The word “mountain” does not necessarily correspond to a geophysical feature.
15. Compare the passage in *Xu zizhi tongjian changbian*, 2363: “[Of these two monasteries,] only Changlu overlooks the river, and the gate stands in the water” 獨長蘆寺臨江，門起水中。
16. 玉泉長老者，已居長蘆矣。后屢召不至，遣使就問所須，則曰「道人無所須也。玉泉寺無僧堂，長蘆寺無山門，后其念之。」后以本閣服用物下兩寺為錢。以建長蘆寺臨江，門起水中，既成，輒為蛟所壞。后必欲起之，用生鐵數萬斤疊其下，門乃成。蓋蛟畏鐵也。 *Shaoshi wenjian lu*, 1.10b–11b. Shao’s text was widely quoted by Song sources, including *Xu zizhi tongjian changbian*. Per *Taiping zhiji tonglei*, 6.5b–6a, in the seventh month of 1024, the empress donated a name plaque and a large sum of cash. More details on construction cited below in *Chongxiu Yizheng xianzhi*.
17. *Chongxiu Yizheng xianzhi*, 20.27a–b/264, quoting from the *Longqing Era Zhenzhou Gazetteer* of 1567. (Yizheng 儀徵 was earlier known as Yizhen 儀真 and Zhenzhou 真州.) Fragments of two Song-era gazetteers survive.

18. Scott, *Building the Buddhist Revival*, 67–85, discusses nineteenth-century reconstruction of Jinshan Monastery.
19. *Wuchuan lu*, 2.26a. Hargett (*Jade Mountains*, 106–114) refers to this and similar travelogues as “river diaries,” written for publication and circulation. I consulted the translation in Hargett, *Riding the River Home*, 160.
20. The Kangxi-era gazetteer of 1648 notes the mountain gate still standing mere steps from Bodhi Bridge. Shiina, “Sōdai no Shinshū Chōroji,” 41–42.
21. *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 3.25a.
22. Anderson, *Demon*, 44.
23. On the polyvalence of *jiao* in early and medieval sources, see Schafer, *Vermillion Bird*, 217–221; and Carr, “Chinese Dragon Names,” 126–131.
24. *Yuhu yeshi*, 7.2b. The title of this source is also given as *Yuhu qinghua*.
25. Dudbridge, *Hsi-yu chi*, 142; citing earlier work by Makita Tairyō.
26. *Jiajing Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 3.15b–16a/898–899; and Yuan-era commemoration of reconstruction, 7.5b–7b/1076–1080.
27. Anderson, *Demon*, 44–45, 71–75.
28. Zheng et al. (“Jiangsu,” 315) transcribe the Song inscription. Ganlu’s abbot was Guangzhao Yingfu (late eleventh century), who subsequently became abbot of Changlu Monastery. The broad influence of his disciple Zongze is discussed below. The Tang crypt included gold objects and relics, together with an inscription by Li Deyu (787–850), who had sponsored the stonework project.
29. *Dantu xian zhi*, 6.7b–8a.
30. *Hongxue yinyuan tuji*, fascicle 2b, unpaginated. Cf. Anderson, *Demon*, 72.
31. Shensha as a subduer of the river-dragon and pacifier of the river is described in the Changlu Monastery entry of the Jiajing- and Kangxi-era Luhe County gazetteers. The later text speculates that Shensha was installed by Empress Liu during the iron fortification; this cannot be corroborated with Song sources. *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 1.28b.
32. Dudbridge, *Hsi-yu chi*, 18–21.
33. Strickmann, *Chinese Magical Medicine*, 312–313n47. Shensha appears again in a thirteenth-century tantric pantheon in Fujian, described in Davis, *Society and Supernatural*, 129–131 and 289n51.
34. *Jōgyō wājō*, T55.1070c25–1071a1; modified from Dudbridge, *Hsi-yu chi*, 19–20.
35. For example, in the north, a Chan master’s song “Encomium for the Deity Shensha” 讚深沙神, *Fenyang wude chanshi yulu*, T47.623a1–21. Jōjin recorded seeing shrine halls at Tiantai monasteries in the southeast; Wang, *Xinjiao*, 33 and 52.
36. Wang and You, “Qiannian gucha,” 42.
37. Fragment in *Zenrin shōkisen*, 147, b1–2. I did not find a corresponding passage in *Tōmin osho goroku*.
38. 參沙之神鐵作身, 可以壓伏水怪降. “Song of the Spirit Shensha” 參沙神歌, fourteen couplets; *Bianshan xiaoyin yinlu*, 2.55a–b.
39. Wang, *Xinjiao*, 6.
40. *Ibid.*, 236.
41. *Ibid.*, 40.
42. For an extensive study of Sengqie, see Huang Ch’i-chiang, *Sizhou dasheng*, 13–79.
43. *Fozu tongji*, T49.421c10–18.

44. *Jiajing Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 8.8a/1257.
45. Capitanio (“Dragon Kings”) describes Buddhist rainmaking through the late Tang, and Daoist rainmaking through the Song.
46. *Chixiu Baizhang qinggui*, T48.1115a19–b3. Related texts are found in Zhongfeng Mingben’s *Huanzhu’an qinggui*, X63.577b5–c6. For more context, see Heller, *Illusory Abiding*, 207–215.
47. Shiina “*Jikaku zenji*,” 193, no. 101.
48. Comments by Qin Guan (1049–1100) described in Liu, “Picturing Yu,” who argues that the frequent flooding of the Yellow River also sustained terrible costs.
49. “Memorial of the Sutra Repository of Changlu Monastery, Zhenzhou,” *Linchuan xian-sheng wenji*, 83.9a–b.
50. “Memorial of the Water and Land Hall at Jinshan Monastery,” by Zeng Gong (1019–1083), discussed in Bloom, “Descent,” 193. Once a riverine island, Jinshan became a peninsula after a nineteenth-century land reclamation project.
51. When Yuan tong Faxiu (1027–1090) was abbot, prior to his summons to the capital in 1084; *Chanlin sengbaozhuan* (X79.543c15–16) and *Jianzhong Jingguo xudenglu* (X78.699c18–23).
52. This is according to Hongzhi Zhengjue (1091–1157) in the memorial for Zhenxie Qingliao (1088–1151), cited in Schlütter, *How Zen*, 99.
53. *Ru Shu ji*, 169–170; translation in Chang and Smythe, *South China*, 67–68.
54. Gernet, *Buddhism*, 142–152.
55. Huang Minzhi, *Songdai fojiao*, 417–418.
56. The handscroll is known as *Gozan Jissatsu Zu*. It has been reprinted several times, including in *Zengaku daijiten*, *bekkan*, 21.
57. These lands gifted during the Shaoxing reign (1131–1162), per all Luhe County gazetteers. The Luhe city wall was first constructed in this same postwar period.
58. For a translation and introduction to *Chanyuan qinggui*, see Yifa, *Origins*.
59. On Zongze’s motivations, see Foulk, “*Chanyuan qinggui*,” 283–286.
60. Zhang, *Transformative Journeys*, 46.
61. *Ibid.*, 100–101, citing Huang Minzhi, “Song Yuan.”
62. *Ibid.*, 101.
63. To give an example available in translation, Sargent (*Poetry of He Zhu*, 325–326) analyzes a poem written while traveling between cities and sent to friends.
64. *Wuchuan lu*, 2.26a. Translation in Hargett, *Riding the River Home*, 160.
65. Starting in the Ming, “Evening Bell at Changlu” became the eighth of “Eight Iconic Scenes of the Six Peaks.” Four full suites of poems can be found in the *Jiajing Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 8.9b–17a; and one from the Qing era in the *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 7.55b–56b.
66. *Jiat tai pudenglu*, X79.413a6–8.
67. The thirteenth day of the eleventh month in the third year of Jianyan. “Du Chong razes Changlu Chongfu Chan Cloister of Zhenzhou,” *Sanchao Beimeng huibian*, 134.12b–13b/976–977. For a complete translation, please contact the author.
68. More examples are discussed in Protass, “Geographic History.”
69. *Jiajing Era Luhe County Gazetteer*, 3.17a/901.
70. *Ibid.*, 3.18a/903.

71. Jinshan Monastery was likewise destroyed in the Taiping Civil War. Shortly after funds were raised in the 1860s for reconstruction, a disastrous flood necessitated that those monies be diverted for humanitarian relief. As a result, the nearby flood, though not directly affecting the monastery (already war-destroyed), nonetheless delayed construction by some years. See Scott, *Building the Buddhist Revival*, 76.
72. *Guangxu Era Luhe County Gazetteer* of 1885.
73. *Tangzhi shiyi*, 1.25b–26a/513–514.
74. Wang and You, “Qiannian gucha,” 42.
75. *Ibid.*
76. *BASF-YPC*, 5.
77. Kurz and Schmidkonz, “Impact,” 16. Note that this publication was a BASF-commissioned study completed by German Technical Cooperation in 2005.
78. *Ibid.*, 53, 71.
79. *Ibid.*, 46, citing “Luhe Municipal Planning Commission.”
80. From a photograph in the author’s collection.
81. *Yiri chan*. N.b. seven-day retreats were advertised as well. The *gong’an* practice generally focused on “who is reciting the name of the Buddha?” On the history of this practice, see Schlütter, “Who?”
82. This “trialectic” of actors was inspired by Zhang (*River*, 6–7) and her study of the Yellow River. Zhang’s groundbreaking work was one of the inspirations for my research.

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CHAPTER 9

Masculine Mountains

Gendered Affordances

at Dali's Stone Treasure Grottoes

Megan Bryson

Buddhist carvings in caves or grottoes appear from Ellorā and Ajaṇṭā in India to Yungang, Dazu, and Dunhuang in continental East Asia to Sōkkuram in the Korean peninsula. Often these carvings depict various buddhas, bodhisattvas, deities, and guardians as well as human donors. These figures—human and superhuman alike—embody a range of gender representations, from androgynous monks or nuns to muscular protectors to feminine bodhisattvas. A lesser-known set of grottoes dating from the ninth to thirteenth centuries can be found at Stone Treasure Mountain (*Shibaoshan*; also known as Stone Bell Mountain, *Shizhongshan*) in the Dali region of what is now southwest China's Yunnan Province. During its main period of artistic activity, Stone Treasure Mountain belonged to the territory of the Nanzhao (649–903) and Dali (937–1253) kingdoms, and its set of Buddhist carvings includes depictions of rulers alongside a distinctive array of deities.

Unlike most Buddhist carving sites, Stone Treasure Mountain includes few female figures, whether deities or donors. Its main site, Stone Bell Temple (*Shizhong si*) features only masculine figures in central roles (female attendants and/or donors appear in Caves 5 and 7). This chapter argues that the Stone Treasure Mountain carvings constitute the recognition and instantiation of the mountain as a masculine place. For patrons and artists of the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms, the mountain afforded recognition as a site of masculine divine power due to its location on the frontier, a space that required both wrathful guardians for protection and Nanzhao and Dali kings for political authority at the polity's northwestern boundary.¹

This chapter considers the disproportionately masculine carving program of Stone Treasure Mountain through questions of how medieval Buddhists interacted with their environments: How do perceptions of the landscape manifest in the act of carving Buddhist figures into the living rock and engaging with the figures ritually? Moreover, how do the affordances of particular places—how people perceive certain possibilities in their landscape due to a variety of contextual factors—shape this engagement? Buddhist grottoes assume an interrelationship between a living landscape and the people responsible for carving the images: the mountains are suitable carving sites because they already embody divine presence, so sponsors and artists both affirm that presence and channel it into specific forms. After artists carve images out of the rock, the site can serve as a ritual space to which practitioners invite specific gods to protect the state (among other things), furthering the integration of the landscape and human activity. In the case of Stone Treasure Mountain, and especially Stone Bell Temple, this integration of landscape and human activity is clearly gendered: the site's location requires the protection and authority of masculine rulers and gods, and the carving of those male figures reinforces and constitutes the mountain's masculinity.

Gendered Affordances

Stone Treasure Mountain's masculinity developed through human encounters with their environment, but such encounters can be theorized in various ways. Sugata Ray's study of climate and environment in sixteenth- to nineteenth-century Vaishnava art and architecture takes seriously perceptions of geographical formations (such as Govardhan Hill) as divine, namely, as embodying Krishna himself. Ray observes, "The material of stone and the material that constitutes the divine body merge to transform Govardhan hill into a sacred relic, immanent with vital force. The hill is no longer inert matter. Rather, obscuring object-subject binaries, it is the very substance of quartzite rock that is entangled in relational circulatory flows that intimately connects representation, theology, and the natural environment."² Though Dali's Buddhist environment (in all senses of the word) operates differently from the Vaishnava world under consideration here, this description of the rock-divine body assemblage also works for the Stone Treasure Mountain carvings. Both are also recognized as masculine places, but in different ways: Govardhan Hill is the god Krishna's body, while Stone Treasure Mountain has become the home of various gods and rulers. However, Ray goes on to describe such rock formations as "agentive," which raises questions about the concept of agency and about relationships between human and nonhuman entities.

Scholars of visual and material culture frequently invoke material or object agency to productively challenge the anthropocentric view (or assumption) that humans impose agency on nonhumans unidirectionally, and to highlight material and conceptual constraints on human activity. This approach draws on Bruno Latour's actor-network theory that places human and nonhuman actants on the same level in explaining change as a process informed equally by both kinds of entities. Latour and others (including archaeologist Carl Knappett and political theorist Jane Bennett) observe that materiality is not only necessary for human survival, it is also necessary for human sociality—including human interactions with superhuman entities—which is mediated through things.³ From this perspective, people do not exert total dominion over passive things; instead, things bring their own power or agency to bear on human interactions with the nonhuman.

In the realm of Buddhist visual culture, Michelle C. Wang and Wei-cheng Lin's theory of performative agency, "defined as the visual and material properties of Buddhist artworks and sites that have the capability to both engage *with* as well as be engaged *by* devotees in a transformative manner" (original emphasis), applies to sites such as Stone Treasure Mountain, where paths encourage visitors to follow a set route past the grotto carvings.⁴ Alfred Gell also locates agency in works of art, which he refers to as indexes, though he sees this agency as distributed throughout the process of sponsoring, creating, and encountering the index, such that the work of art is embedded in intersubjective or distributed agency.⁵ Gell's four-part schema of prototype, artist, index, and recipient, each of which can act as agent and/or patient (i.e., passive participant), could translate to the work at Stone Treasure Mountain, with the recipient-as-agent sponsoring the carving; the artist acting as patient in accepting the commission and following prototypes for the carvings but also as agent in carrying out the carvings; and then the index-as-agent inspiring ritual behavior. Though Gell's schema is more formulaic, it generally aligns with Jane Bennett's concept of the agency of assemblages, which also explains the complex of human and nonhuman actants at work in Stone Treasure Mountain.⁶ Like Bennett's example of an electrical grid, Buddhist grottoes thwart the nature-culture divide in bringing together rock, trees, transportation infrastructure, tools, artists, patrons, and wealth.

This and other notions of distributed agency or personhood that place human and nonhuman actants on the same level offer rich theoretical frameworks for making sense of Buddhist encounters with the environment. However, the concept of agency, even when qualified as distributed or applying to assemblages, still bears the genealogical baggage of the agency-structure debates, and as such connotes resistance and individual will in ways that distract from the project of rethinking human-landscape interaction in middle-period Dali.⁷ Attempts to locate agency in nonhuman actants also elide the

persistent centrality of human perception: Gell does not actually claim that an index (e.g., a painting of a Hindu deity) acts like a person, but rather that human worshippers perceive the index acting in that way. Even nonhuman entities that do things regardless of human perception, such as the geological formation of mountains, do not necessarily fit agency's connotations of intention or will. From this perspective, ironically, ascribing agency to nonhuman entities is itself anthropocentric: to connect with the material world on an equal level we have to make it more like us.

James Gibson's concept of affordances provides an alternative framework for thinking about how sentient and nonsentient entities interact. Affordances refer to the combinations of qualities that condition how sentient beings interact with the material world, including their own bodies.⁸ As Gibson explains, affordances cut across concepts of objective and subjective, or physical and phenomenal: they entwine materiality and perceptions of that materiality.⁹ Inasmuch as perceptions of affordances develop in culturally and historically specific ways, people in, say, the Dali kingdom will perceive certain possibilities in a rock cliffside that would not be perceptible to someone in medieval Rome or modern Dali. Affordances thus allow for nonhuman and human entities to occupy roles of equal importance in networks of interaction without ascribing agency to material objects (or people). People cannot do whatever we want with any object, but neither can objects completely dictate what we do with them. Though the concept of affordances may seem overly passive (see Phillip E. Bloom's chapter in this volume), it need not foreclose the possibility of environments working on—indeed, transforming—human visitors. Such transformative power can in fact be one of the environment's affordances, if people perceive such possibilities. Sonya Lee's work on cave temples in Sichuan mobilizes the concept of affordances to understand how sponsors, artists, laborers, devotees, and restorers transform, and are transformed by, the natural and built environments of Leshan, Dazu, and Bazhong.¹⁰

Affordances can be gendered in different, but interrelated, ways: gender can shape how people perceive the possibilities available to them, and people can perceive certain objects or places as having gendered properties. For example, the upper reaches of several sacred mountains in Japan, such as Mount Kōya and Mount Kinpu, were traditionally off-limits to women; the line that demarcates this gendered division is known as *nyonin kekkai*, "women's boundary." As Heather Blair observes, large stones usually marked women's boundaries, and women who crossed the line, such as the nun Toran, turned to stone as karmic punishment for their transgression.¹¹ Stone—part of the mountain itself—is the medium of exclusion, and women who turn into stone thus embody both the landscape and their own exclusion. Such mountains demonstrate a range of intersecting gendered affordances: women's boundaries

developed through the perception of the mountain as an esoteric ritual space (Sk. *bodhimaṇḍa*; Ch. *daochang*; J. *dōjō*) that needs to be demarcated and protected (Sk. *śimābandha*; Ch. *jiējiē*; J. *kekkaï*) to expel potentially harmful forces. From monks' perspectives, women constituted a potentially harmful class who could pollute or otherwise disrupt the pure ritual environment. Sacred mountains thus afforded entry to men (though men were required to purify themselves first), but not to women, which means that men and women perceive different possibilities in these places and relate to them differently.

Unlike Mount Kōya and Mount Kinpu, Stone Treasure Mountain was not off-limits to women. However, these Japanese examples illustrate how gendered affordances can operate in other Buddhist mountains. Medieval carvings from sites such as Longmen and Mount Langfeng, in present-day China, offer additional examples of gendered affordances in that both sites feature nuns' and lay women donors' images and inscriptions. Amy McNair points out how nuns and lay women donors at Longmen framed their carving projects as gendered acts whose merit they dedicated to all women.¹² Women of means perceived the possibility of transforming their own karma, or even all women's karma, by transforming the landscape through carving.

As Wendi Adamek shows, Mount Langfeng, located near the better-known Baoshan, was the site for many nuns' (and some lay women's) funerary niches, showing that Buddhists recognized the mountain as an appropriate locus for memorializing women. Like the women who crossed the "women's boundary" line in Japan, these women at Mount Langfeng also "turn to stone" in the carvings made of them, but the latter's lithification signifies something else. Nuns memorialized at Mount Langfeng were often depicted androgynously, with flat chests and broad shoulders, which suggests shedding the female form as an embodied sign of buddhahood, or at least progress toward that goal. Carving women's forms into the mountain also effected their integration into the buddha Vairocana's dharma realm, in which all is awakening.¹³ Adamek, following Timothy Ingold's "taskscape," coins the term "practicescapes" to explore Buddhist interactions with Baoshan: "Over time, social networks and human-made features transformed Baoshan's pleasant but rather ordinary landscape into a place where resident, transient, and deceased members of the Buddhist community, the *saṃgha*, could attain salvation and perhaps buddhahood."¹⁴ Inasmuch as medieval Chinese Buddhists saw the female form as an impediment to awakening, the landscape's ability to effect salvation for deceased women constitutes a gendered affordance. Women and men perceived in Mount Langshan, as an abode of Vairocana, the possibility of transforming even women into buddhas.

These examples from other East Asian environments demonstrate that middle-period Buddhists mobilized conceptions similar to modern gender discourses in invoking "women" as a class. As in modern gender discourses,

masculinity usually went unmarked in middle-period Buddhist Asia, which means that any analysis of masculinity must depart from the sources' explicit conceptual worlds. However, it is precisely because masculinity operates as the invisible complement to visible femininity that it requires our attention. Buddhist texts and images code different figures as masculine and express different forms of masculinity. For example, buddhas are masculine figures with distinctive bodies bearing the thirty-two marks of the "great man" (Sk. *mahāpuruṣa*; Ch. *dazhangfu*; J. *daijōbu*). While buddhas embody what Dessislava Vendova describes as "Middle Way masculinity" that bridges and transcends extreme indulgence and asceticism, dharma guardians often appear as hypermasculine and quasibestial, with bulging muscles, glaring eyes, bared fangs, and minimal clothing.¹⁵ Attending to different kinds of masculine Buddhist figures reveals different forms of Buddhist masculinity, as the Stone Treasure Mountain carvings illustrate.

Just as concepts that overlapped with modern gender discourse circulated in middle-period Buddhist Asia, concepts similar to affordances also circulated in the Sinitic discourse that held sway in the Dali kingdom. Following François Jullien, the concept *shi*, which he renders as "disposition," encompasses the dynamic and static configurations of a given situation: *shi* refers to "the kind of potential that originates not in human initiative but instead results from the very disposition of things."¹⁶ Bennett adopts this concept in elaborating on the agency of assemblages, and *shi* does correlate well to the assemblage, if not to agency.¹⁷ Like affordances, *shi* confronts people with a material environment in which they perceive various possibilities. However, *shi* differs in its greater fluidity and emphasis on efficacy.

Writings from and about the Nanzhao and Dali courts show that Sinitic discourses played a hegemonic role in these regimes. The Nanzhao court kidnapped the Tang official Zheng Hui to educate royal sons and serve as a prime minister (Ch. *qingpingguan*), and Nanzhao records frequently cite Chinese classics such as the *Book of Changes* (Ch. *Yijing*).¹⁸ Later, the *Song History* (Ch. *Song shi*) recorded that Dali kingdom envoys consistently requested texts from the Song court and its representatives. Though not all aspects of Nanzhao and Dali kingdom court culture drew from Sinitic traditions, especially in the realm of visual and material culture, Nanzhao and Dali texts are written in Sinitic script and cite Chinese classics, including those pertaining to idealized gender roles.¹⁹ As in other parts of East Asia, Nanzhao and Dali Buddhist writings show limited proficiency with Sanskrit (here, written in Nāgarī script), which they reserved for mantras and *dhāraṇī*. This means that concepts such as *shi*, "disposition," would have been known to those responsible for carving sites such as Stone Treasure Mountain.

Stone Treasure Mountain: Carving Out a Niche

Buddhist carvings at Stone Treasure Mountain demonstrate how the Nanzhao and Dali courts interacted with their territory. Stone Treasure Mountain lies in the mountains approximately twenty kilometers southwest of the present-day Jianchuan County seat, in Dali Bai Autonomous Prefecture; as befits its location in the Himalayan foothills, its elevation is 3,083 meters (10,115 feet) (maps 9.1 and 9.2).²⁰ Though a freeway now allows passengers to travel between Dali's Old City and Stone Treasure Mountain in under two hours, during the peak carving period of the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms the route would have required several days of arduous travel. As the Nanzhao kingdom expanded over the eighth century to conquer and absorb neighboring states, Jianchuan was one of the last redoubts for regional rulers who wished to remain independent. One such holdout, the Sanlang regime centered in Jianchuan, survived for several decades with Tibetan support; it eventually fell to Nanzhao in 794, when Nanzhao reestablished its alliance with Tang and broke with Tibet.²¹



Map 9.1 Location of Stone Treasure Mountain in relation to Dali, Dharma Treasury Temple, and Kunming. Google Earth.



Map 9.2 Location of Stone Treasure Mountain in the Jianchuan region. Google Earth.

Though it is impossible to determine conclusively when people began carving Buddhist images from the sandstone slopes of Stone Treasure Mountain, the process had certainly begun by 850, when we find the first dated inscription at Cave 12 dedicating statues of Amitābha and Maitreya.²² One of the sponsors, Zhang Banglong, may have been a Nanzhao official, which suggests that Buddhist carving projects at Stone Treasure Mountain extended Nanzhao political authority to the newly conquered northwest.²³ Throughout the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms (and possibly continuing into the Yuan and Ming dynasties), people carved a total of 140 figures in sixteen caves across three different areas of Stone Treasure Mountain: half of the caves (1–8) belong to the Stone Bell Temple (*Shizhong si*) area; three caves (9–11) belong to Lion Pass (*Shiziguan*); and the remaining five caves (12–16), including Zhang Banglong's images, belong to the Shadengjing area.

Jianchuan's remoteness placed it outside the trade and transportation routes that cut through more accessible parts of Nanzhao and Dali territory, but as Nanzhao history shows, Jianchuan occupied a frontier where people from Tibetan areas, the Dali plain, and possibly Pyu or Pagan (modern-day Burma) could encounter each other.²⁴ In fact, a few caves include Tibetan and Sanskrit inscriptions. However, given that people continued to make inscriptions at the site into the Republican period (1911–1949), it is difficult to determine their dates.²⁵ In the Nanzhao and Dali periods, Stone Treasure Mountain was close to minor population centers such as Jianchuan, Jianxun, and Moutong. It also lies just to the west of the Heihui River, which flows from Lijiang in the north and eventually joins the Lancang (a.k.a. the Mekong) River south of the Dali plain. A ninth-century Tang record further notes that the Jianchuan area was home to several salt mines, meaning that the area around Stone Treasure Mountain could support human habitation quite well.²⁶ For Nanzhao and Dali authorities, Stone Treasure Mountain's relative inaccessibility was probably an advantage, as it would be naturally protected from rampaging armies.

For ruling elites in the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms, the closest examples of similar sites were probably in Sichuan at places such as Bazhong and Dazu's Beishan, where carving began during the Tang dynasty. The Nanzhao court had extensive contact with Chengdu, which was both the site for Nanzhao elites to educate their sons and the victim of multiple Nanzhao military raids.²⁷ Stone Treasure Mountain resembles sites such as Beishan and Bazhong in the size of its niches and statues. Unlike more elaborate grottoes, Stone Treasure Mountain does not include monastic dwellings among its caves, nor richly colored murals, plaster statues, or monumental buddhas. Its niches and the figures within them are fairly small in size and number and must be accessed by a path cut into the side of the slope. Though Stone Treasure Mountain now includes temples, such as Stone Bell Temple, amid the carvings, the structures probably did not exist during the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms. Stone Treasure

Mountain may not reach the variety, intricacy, and scale of such grottoes as Ajaṇṭā and Ellorā, Mogao, Dazu, Yungang, and Sōkkuram; but its carvings suggest that Nanzhao and Dali Buddhist elites drew on nearby models of patronage for Buddhist grottoes to craft their own site for displaying and instantiating politicoreligious power.

Within Nanzhao and Dali kingdom territory, Stone Treasure Mountain was the most elaborate Buddhist carving site, but it was not unique. To the west of Kunming, near what is now Anning City, there are niches with Dali-period Buddhist figures carved into the hillside by Dharma Flower Temple (*Fahua si*).²⁸ Similar niches with similar Buddhist figures were carved near Wase on the east bank of Er Lake in the Dali plain, probably also during the Dali kingdom.²⁹ These sites are badly deteriorated, but what survives suggests considerable continuity with Chinese carving sites; that is, we do not see some of the distinctive elements of Dali Buddhism that appear at Stone Treasure Mountain, such as images of Nanzhao and/or Dali kings, Ajaya Avalokiteśvara, Mahākāla, or a rarely seen set of eight *vidyārājas*. However, these distinctive elements *do* appear at another Nanzhao- or Dali-era carving site.

Boshenwahei is located within present-day Zhaojue County, to the east of Xichang, the seat of Liangshan Yi Autonomous Prefecture in the southern part of Sichuan Province. Its huge boulders depict almost ninety Buddhist figures and almost twenty animals outlined with shallow incisions. Boshenwahei Buddhist carvings mirror those of Stone Treasure Mountain in their general content, such as Nanzhao/Dali rulers and wrathful dharma guardians, including a possible set of *vidyārājas*. Also like Stone Treasure Mountain (but unlike the Dali plain and Kunming regions), Boshenwahei was located near the edge of Nanzhao and Dali territory. The carvings here, which include an imperial excursion, seem designed to extend Nanzhao and Dali authority to their northern frontier. In fact, records about the region (often coming from Tang, Five Dynasties, and Song sources) suggest that the Nanzhao and Dali courts wielded little direct control over this area but instead relied on the cooperation of regional authorities who often mediated between Dali and officials based in Chengdu.³⁰ It is also worth noting that the Boshenwahei carvings required far fewer resources than did the Stone Treasure Mountain carvings, and they also transformed the landscape less dramatically. In fact, it is quite difficult to perceive the carvings at Boshenwahei unless one views them from a particular angle.

Stone Treasure Mountain was a site created from the synthesis of the landscape's perceived potency, the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms' geopolitical landscape, and the broader Buddhist phenomenon of carving grottoes from the living rock. The specific configurations of its carvings further demonstrate how Buddhists of the Nanzhao and Dali kingdoms channeled divine power in ways that recognized and reinforced the landscape's gendered presence.

Masculine Mountains: Stone Bell Temple's Gendered Affordances

Stone Treasure Mountain's three main carving sites—Lion Pass, Shadengjing, and Stone Bell Temple—differ in ways that highlight Stone Bell Temple's masculinity. Lion Pass includes the only prominent female figure in Cave 9, which depicts a royal couple with their attendants. An inscription identifies the male ruler as Shengzhuluo (?), though it uses irregular characters and the third character in the name is not fully legible. Modern scholars have interpreted this figure as the first Nanzhao ruler Xinuluo and his wife, but this requires several interpretive leaps that sources do not support. Based on the figure's titles, it is likely that this figure either was a Nanzhao or Dali king or served as a regional ruler. The inscription refers to the female figure as an empress (Ch. *houfei*), and also mentions the royal children and attendants that stand behind and next to the central couple.³¹ The presence of this empress and a female attendant highlights the total absence of female figures in similar scenes of Nanzhao or Dali rulers in the neighboring Stone Bell Temple site.

Inscriptions from Shadengjing indicate that women were involved in sponsoring some of the carvings at Stone Treasure Mountain. As noted above, the earliest dated carvings come from Cave 12, sponsored by the local official Zhang Banglong and his family: "Zhang Banglong, Sandanbai of Shazhuifu Shangyi, his wife, Sheng Menghe, and their sons Longqing, Longjun, Long[xing], Long[an], and Longqian have the good karma to reverentially make these [statues of] the buddha Maitreya and the buddha Amitābha. Recorded on the twenty-fifth day of the seventh month of the eleventh year of our king's Tianqi reign era [850]."³² Cave 13 at Shadengjing features a central carving of Ajaya Avalokiteśvara (Ch. *Acuoye Guanyin*) flanked by eight carved stūpas (four on each side) and a later outline drawing of the Medicine Buddha. It, too, bears inscriptions that identify a married couple as the sponsors: on the right, "carved on behalf of the Dali kingdom image donors Yaoshi Xiang, his wife Guanyin Gu'ai . . . etc.," and on the left, "carved in offering to the donors, Yaoshi Xiang, his wife Guanyin, etc."³³ Finally, Caves 5 and 7 at Stone Bell Temple include female attendants and/or donors flanking statues of Avalokiteśvara.³⁴

These examples show that some women did participate in sponsoring carving projects at Stone Treasure Mountain; but the only two donative inscriptions that list women as donors come from Shadengjing, which is relatively far from Stone Bell Temple and Lion Pass. The female figures represented at Stone Treasure Mountain tend to be secondary figures, with the exception of the empress at Lion Pass Cave 9. Compared to contemporaneous East Asian carving sites, such as the nearby Dazu and Bazhong, there is a dearth of feminine deities and human women depicted at Stone Treasure Mountain, and especially at Stone Bell Temple.

My analysis of the Stone Treasure Mountain grottoes focuses on three caves in the Stone Bell Temple area: Caves 1 and 2, which show central royal figures with their attendants; and Cave 6, which features eight brilliant kings of wisdom (Ch. *mingwang*; Sk. *vidyārāja*) flanking the buddha Mahāvairocana. The end of the chapter turns to Cave 8, which consists of a central carving of a vulva/yoni surrounded by Buddhist figures. Cave 8's central vulva image is probably a later addition that cannot be discussed within the Dali kingdom that is my focus here; however, it still bears on the Dali kingdom context by highlighting the other caves' masculinity. Caves 1, 2, and 6 channel masculine power tied to rulership and martial ferocity. In addition to examining each cave's gendered program separately, I consider how they work together to create a cohesive space that entwines esoteric ritual and royal authority. Caves 1, 2, and 6 offer different affordances in how they engage visitors separately through their gendered visual and spatial regimes as well as collectively through the path that takes visitors past each site in sequence. Stone Treasure Mountain's gendered grottoes interpellate visitors as subjects of Dali kingdom masculine royal power and wrathful deities, and in doing so they constitute and affirm the site's masculinity.

One of the challenges in studying the Stone Treasure Mountain grottoes is that the dates are almost impossible to determine because Dali kingdom rulers adopted the dress and Buddhist forms of their Nanzhao predecessors. To avoid anachronistically projecting later developments into the past, I treat the royal figures in Caves 1 and 2 and the eight *vidyārājas* in Cave 6 in the context of Dali kingdom Buddhism, even if they were created during the Nanzhao kingdom. In connection with this approach, I am more interested in how visitors to Stone Treasure Mountain engaged with these figures and their landscape than in how and why people carved these images in the first place.

The path that now cuts through the Stone Bell Temple area takes visitors past the caves in sequence, starting with the royal figures in Caves 1 and 2 and moving through the buddhas and bodhisattvas of Caves 3 and 5 before reaching the wrathful figures of Cave 6, then on to Avalokiteśvara in Cave 7, and finally to the vulva surrounded by Buddhist figures in Cave 8. It would also be possible to go in the opposite direction, but the royal figures remain farther down the hillside than the explicitly Buddhist figures.

Male Authorities: Human Kings and Vidyārājas

Dali kingdom visitors to Stone Treasure Mountain would have encountered the rulers in Caves 1 and 2 as smaller-than-life-size figures sitting above their eye-line. Cave 1 consists of a round vault framed by a rectangular exterior; its niche is 1.68 meters tall, 1.66 meters wide, and 0.4 meters deep. The niche's eaves are carved into three layers, and it has an arched ceiling and a rectangular floor.

Around the inner niche is a lintel with a linked pearl design. Within the niche a central, royal figure 1.05 meters tall sits cross-legged on a dragon throne, flanked by attendants (fig. 9.1). Two senior officials sit facing each other at each end of the niche, two attendants stand on the proper left, and three attendants stand on the proper right. In addition to these, a squat figure sits cross-legged on a cloud pedestal in front of the throne, balancing a lotus table holding three bowls of offerings on his head.

The central figure is usually identified as the Nanzhao ruler Yimouxun (r. 780–808), but this is based on unsupported identifications of the two senior officials as the prime ministers (Ch. *qingpingguan*) Zheng Hui and Du Guangting.³⁵ In the absence of reliable identifications, the royal figure in Cave 1 could be either a Nanzhao or Dali ruler, as he wears their distinctive tall crown with three horizontal bands at the bottom, lotus petals adorning the bottom of the oblong center, a banded spire on top, and ribbons fluttering up on either side.³⁶ The ruler wears a long, belted, wide-sleeved robe that hangs over the seat of the throne. His face has an air of individuality, with a wide nose and thick lips that distinguish him from the ruler in Cave 2.

Cave 2 houses a larger assembly also centered around a royal figure (fig. 9.2). Its niche is 1.95 meters tall, 1.53 meters wide, and 0.7 meters deep. The niche



Figure 9.1 Royal figure, Cave 1, Stone Treasure Mountain, Dali Bai Autonomous Prefecture, Yunnan. Photograph by Halazhang, CC BY-SA 4.0.



Figure 9.2 Royal figure, Cave 2, Stone Treasure Mountain, Dali Bai Autonomous Prefecture, Yunnan. From Li Kunsheng, *Nanzhao Dali guo diaoke huihua yishu*, 58–59, fig. 34.

is square, with a curtain draping over the top, and the eaves are decorated with lotus and linked pearl patterns. As in Cave 1, a ruler sits cross-legged on a dragon throne wearing a tall crown (more ornately decorated than in the first cave) and a long robe. His nose and part of his left cheek have broken off and been replaced, but he also has facial features that convey a sense of individuality. Two lions crouch on the base of the throne. Six attendants stand on each side of the ruler, and two senior officials sit facing each other at the edge of the niche. What distinguishes this scene from the previous one (in addition to the greater number of attendants), is the monk holding *mālā* beads and sitting underneath an umbrella on the proper right.³⁷

Caves 1 and 2 integrate masculine political power into the landscape and homologize Dali's rulers with the Buddhist figures that populate the rest of the Stone Bell Temple grottoes. Carving royal images into the rock of Stone Treasure Mountain makes rulers one with their land, in a sense naturalizing their hegemony over this territory. Such images also tap into the landscape's masculine forces: the scenes in Caves 1 and 2 depict only men, though the men's different ranks are visually distinct. Such a single-sex scene might not usually demand attention for its gendered depictions, given the invisibility cloak that

masculinity wears to make itself normative. As noted above, Cave 9 in the Lion Pass area, which depicts a royal couple with their children and attendants, relativizes the all-male groupings in Caves 1 and 2. However, visitors to the Stone Bell Temple section would not see Lion Pass Cave 9; instead, they would follow a different path to take them from Caves 1 and 2 to another masculine scene, in this case, of the eight wrathful *vidyārājas*.

Cave 6 is the largest niche at Stone Treasure Mountain, measuring 4 meters tall and 11.26 meters wide. Six square pillars divide the cave into five sections, of which the central section is slightly taller than the rest and features a curved gate, unlike the square gates of the other sections. The central section has three-tiered eaves, and the others have sparrow braces in their upper corners. A decorated three-layered platform at the bottom of the cave elevates the figures, and in each section the platform is marked by four drum-shaped bulges. The top layer is carved with floral motifs; the middle layer has *cintamaṇi* (wish-fulfilling) jewels; and the bottom layer shows animals and flower petals.

The central figure is a 1.66-meter-tall carving of the buddha Vairocana sitting cross-legged on a throne and making the *dhyāna* (meditation) *mudrā* with his left hand, and the *bhūmisparśa* (earth-touching) *mudrā* with his right; Ānanda and Kaśyapa stand on each side (fig. 9.3).³⁸ Vairocana has a double-layered flaming full-body aureole, while his attendants each have a small,



Figure 9.3 Vairocana with Ānanda and Kaśyapa, Cave 6, Stone Treasure Mountain, Dali Bai Autonomous Prefecture, Yunnan. Photograph by the author.

round aureole behind their head. Each side of the buddha additionally features four seated *vidyārājas* (each 0.5 meters tall), each with an identifying cartouche, for a total of eight: from the viewer's left to right, they are Yamāntaka (east), Trailokyavijaya (southeast), Aparājita (south), Mahācakra (southwest), Hayagrīva (west), Vajrahāsa (northwest), Padanakṣipa (north), and Acalanātha (northeast) (fig. 9.4).³⁹ Each *vidyārāja* sits in front of a flaming, teardrop-shaped aureole. An image of Mahākāla (1.8 meters tall) stands on the viewer's far left, and Vaiśravaṇa (2.1 meters tall) appropriately stands on the far right, next to the *vidyārāja* of the north; they, too, have teardrop-shaped, flaming aureoles.

Similar sets of *vidyārājas* come up elsewhere in Dali kingdom Buddhism: they are the object of devotion in the *Paeon to the Four Kinds of Avatars of the Eight Wisdom Kings of the Oceanic Assembly* (*Haihui ba mingwang sizhong huan-xian gezan*); in an illustration of a nude man, they label different parts of his body; and they may also appear among the Boshenwahei carvings.⁴⁰ Of particular interest here is the *Paeon*, which is appended to *Invitation Rituals for General Use* (*Tongyong qiqing yigui*), one of six ritual texts that have been found only in Dali. *Invitation Rituals for General Use* draws liberally from Tang esoteric



Figure 9.4 Seated *vidyārājas*, Cave 6, Stone Treasure Mountain, Dali Bai Autonomous Prefecture, Yunnan. Photograph by the author.

Buddhist creations and translations to invite and identify with awakened and powerful beings. Its inclusion of the *Paean* suggests that Dali kingdom Buddhists could have used it in rituals at Cave 6, where the various beings' cartouches appear to descend with the clouds. *Invitation Rituals for General Use* specifically prescribes that the practitioner ritually realize their oneness with the *dharmadhātu* and with the vajra being, which relates to the figures of Cave 6. Following from this textual tradition, Dali kingdom Buddhists could have ritually engaged with the carved landscape to tap into their own divinity. Similar to how Ray discusses devotees' participation in the Krishna rock assemblage, Dali practitioners become one with the rock itself, as the rock is the medium for the divine images, and thus for awakening. From the perspective of esoteric Buddhist ritual, the rock affords carving into buddhas, *vidyārājas*, and dharma guardians, which in turn afford intersubjectivity with their viewers. Like Baoshan, it is a Buddhist practicescape.

Cave 6 follows other strands of Buddhism in visually and ritually defining awakening (and its related powers) as masculine. It also resembles Caves 1 and 2 in presenting an all-male scene with the central figure elevated above the rest, flanked by a set of attendants, with a matched pair on each end of the niche. Different forms of masculinity dominate each scene, with the royal figures joined by civil and martial officials, and the placid Vairocana and his monastic companions joined by wrathful, weapon-wielding guardians. Visiting these caves in sequence homologizes these different kinds of figures: the rulers become Vairocana, and the officials become *vidyārājas* and dharma guardians. This effectively merges political and religious power, which is already a common feature of esoteric rituals such as the *abhiṣeka* (Ch. *guanding*). Just as the landscape allows practitioners to identify with the powerful beings of Cave 6, so too does it engender the synthesis of the Dali court with the buddha Vairocana's esoteric (oceanic) assembly. In both cases, the "civilized" masculinity of the central figure anchors the attendants' martial masculinity, channeling the latter's potentially disruptive powers for state protection and individual awakening.

Disruptions: Feminine Power at the Peak

The masculinity of Caves 1, 2, and 6 becomes most apparent when contrasted with the scene in Cave 8, which replaces the central royal and awakened male figures with a vulva (fig. 9.5). This vulva appears to be a later transformation of this cave: none of the inscriptions from the Dali kingdom or Yuan period mentions it, and its deeper niche and crude carving style suggest that it was created later than the cave's other images, which depict Buddhist figures and officials. Despite its later date, the carved vulva offers an opportunity to think about the gendered affordances of Buddhist grottoes and of mountains in general. Even with a sense



Figure 9.5 Vulva, Cave 8, Stone Treasure Mountain, Dali Bai Autonomous Prefecture, Yunnan. Photograph by the author.

of what to expect, the vulva's sudden appearance in a landscape populated mainly by masculine buddhas, bodhisattvas, devas, and rulers is visually disruptive and highlights the masculinity of the rest of the Stone Bell Temple section.

Cave 8 is smaller than the other niches under consideration, measuring only 0.89 meters tall, 0.69 meters wide, and 0.65 meters deep. It is divided into two registers: the top level contains five niches, of which only the central niche is recessed to display a 0.52-meter-tall carving of the vulva. The other four niches display shallower carvings: immediately on either side of the vulva are Vaiśravaṇa (right) and Dhṛtarāṣṭra (left); and on the ends are groupings of a central buddha with three smaller figures below. The far left features Vairocana sitting cross-legged on a lotus pedestal: below him a small seated buddha is flanked by Uṣṇīṣavijāya on the left and possibly by Maheśvara on the right. The far right depicts Amitābha in the same posture with an identical group below.⁴¹ Five niches with buddhas and officials line the lower register, but they are damaged beyond recognition.

Two inscriptions that probably date to the Dali kingdom are found in this cave: the first is a couplet that reads, “Gather a crowd on the road of transformation, and open wide the door of skillful means” (*guangji huasheng lu, da kai fangbian men*). The second is a longer inscription with many missing or illegible characters that includes references to the bodhisattva Guanshiyin, *devarājas*, generations of sons and grandsons, limitless fields of merit, saving beings

of the four kinds of birth, and the date, which is the third day of the eighth month of year four of the Shengde era, that is, 1179.⁴² Later Yuan inscriptions record the names of visitors, many of whom came to burn incense; none of the inscriptions mentions the current central image.

Today, the vulva is known by its name in the Bai language, Ayangbai, which combines the terms for “girl” (*ayang*) and “opening” (*bai*). Scholars have appealed to notions of matriarchal religion, fertility worship, and esoteric Buddhism’s emphasis on the feminine principle to explain its incongruous appearance among various Buddhist figures.⁴³ Views also diverge on the carving’s date vis-à-vis the other figures in Cave 8: some scholars see the vulva as a pre-Buddhist fertility icon, while others see it as a later addition. Based on archaeological and epigraphic evidence, I follow Liu Changjiu and Song Boyin in treating the vulva as a later carving made from the Buddhist figure (possibly Guanyin) that previously occupied the central niche.⁴⁴ As Liu observes, though in recent history women have treated the vulva as a locus of fertility worship, the addition of the inscription *xipinai*, meaning “dead woman’s vulva,” above the Dali kingdom inscription suggests that not everyone has treated the carving with such reverence.⁴⁵

Cave 8’s central image thus affords reverence or irreverence, depending on the viewer’s perception, but seems to consistently afford identification as a vulva.⁴⁶ Though this carving cannot be considered in the context of Dali kingdom Buddhism, it throws into relief the masculinity of those earlier carvings farther down the mountain. That is, for contemporary viewers, the rock vulva affords recognition of the Stone Treasure Mountain grottoes’ masculinity.

Masculine Affordances on the Frontier

The carvings at Stone Bell Temple, including Caves 1, 2, and 6 under consideration here, mark Stone Treasure Mountain as a masculine place. Moreover, the carved rulers and attendants, and buddhas and wrathful guardians, constitute specific forms of masculine mastery that homologize political power and Buddhist awakening. These carvings bring together affordances into an assemblage—or disposition, *shi*—that includes rock, artistry, patronage, esoteric ritual, and transportation infrastructure. For the Dali kingdom court, a key aspect of Stone Treasure Mountain’s gendered affordances was its location on the kingdom’s northwest frontier. Frontiers require special protection against foreign invasions and domestic uprisings. In this case, the special protection is afforded by the masculine presence of rulers, buddhas, and wrathful dharma guardians. The carving program at Boshenwahei, on the Dali kingdom’s northern frontier, illustrates this logic by including a similar set of masculine figures.

This argument does not rely on the intentionality behind the Stone Treasure Mountain carving regime—no Dali court Buddhist would have described

masculinity as a thread linking the figures at Stone Bell Temple—but instead rests on the correlation between masculinity and the kinds of power and presence perceived as necessary to protect the frontier. Despite its distinctive location, surrounded by a variety of polities, cultures, and languages, the Dali kingdom was not necessarily unique in this way. Perhaps further studies of Buddhist carving projects along political frontiers will reveal whether or how masculine affordances operated in other times and places.

NOTES

1. I use “divine” to refer to superhuman or supramundane forces, which in these contexts often include spirits of space and place as well as Buddhist figures.
2. Ray, *Climate Change and the Art of Devotion*, 85.
3. Latour, *Reassembling the Social*; Knappett, *Archaeology of Interaction*; Bennett, *Vibrant Matter*.
4. Wang and Lin, “Introduction,” 7.
5. Gell, *Art and Agency*, 28–50. I am grateful to Aaron Reich for pointing me to this source.
6. Bennett (“Agency of Assemblages,” 445) favors Deleuze’s *assemblage* over similar concepts such as network and empire.
7. Giddens (*Central Problems*) popularized the concept of agency as a way of explaining how individuals operate within larger social structures. The agency-structure debate refers to different views of how individuals or other entities function within social structures. Mahmood’s (*Politics of Piety*, 29–34) critique of agency takes aim at the agency-structure debate’s fixation on resistance as the ideal mode of individual engagement with social structures, especially where women are concerned. She aptly identifies this understanding of agency as embedded in liberal Western subjectivity that does not necessarily translate to other places (and times). Mahmood proposes an understanding of agency as ethical self-formation. However, this notion of agency also does not translate well to nonhuman entities.
8. Gibson, “Theory of Affordances,” 67.
9. *Ibid.*, 69–70, 78.
10. Lee, *Temples in the Cliffside*, 21–22.
11. Heather Blair explains that these proscriptions arose in the ninth century and in most places remained until the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. Mount Kinpu (Kinpusan) is the only site that preserves the ban on women, even though such bans are now technically illegal. See Blair, *Real and Imagined*, 49–50, 53–54.
12. McNair, *Donors of Longmen*, 140.
13. Adamek also notes that the *Lives of the Nuns* (Ch. *Biqiuni zhuan*) praises nuns whose bodies become like stone or wood. Adamek, *Practicescapes*, 25, 316, 319n833.
14. *Ibid.*, 23–24.
15. Bryson, “Introduction”; Vendova, “Middle Way Masculinity.”
16. Jullien, *Propensity of Things*, 13.
17. Bennett, “Agency of Assemblages,” 460–462.

18. *Jiu Tang shu*, 197:5281; *Nanzhao tuzhuan*, 148–149; *Song shi*, 496:14231. The *Song shi* lists the texts that Dali kingdom envoys sought from their Song counterparts, including the *Wenxuan* (Literary Selections), *Chunqiu houyu* (Later Remarks on the Spring and Autumn Annals), and *Qieyun* (Spelling Rhymes).
19. For example, the funerary inscription for the royal niece Gao Ji (ca. 1230s) compares her marriage to the classical Chinese example of Yao's daughters marrying Shun and uses language from the *Book of Odes* (Ch. *Shijing*) to describe her propriety and fidelity. See *Dali guo gu Gao Ji muming bei*, 11.
20. Stone Treasure Mountain is located around 26°23'36.2" N latitude, and 90°50'51.1" E longitude.
21. Backus, *Nan-chao Kingdom*, 100; *Man shu*, 24–26.
22. See page 205 for a translation of this inscription. *Zhang Banglong zaoxiang ji*, 5–6; and Liu Changjiu, “Yunnan Jianchuan,” 102. The ninth-century *Man shu*, or “Book of Barbarians,” identifies Shazhui as the site of a salt mine located to the southeast of Jianxun, a city to the northwest of Jianchuan. *Man shu*, 64.
23. The 899 *Nanzhao tuzhuan* (Illustrated History of Nanzhao) mentions a high official (*qiuwang*) named Zhang Bang as well as Zhang Luopi, Grand Prime Minister and Prince of Lancang Commandery (*Da qingpingguan Lancang jun wang*), and his son, General Zhang Pibang. Though their timeline is unclear, based on the patronymic linkage system, Zhang Pibang's son could very well be Zhang Banglong; or Zhang Bang could be an abbreviated version of his name. The title (?) Sandanbai also shows up in the *Nanzhao tuzhuan* in connection to the early regional leader Zhang Lejinqiu, who cedes power to the first Nanzhao rulers. *Nanzhao tuzhuan*, 144–146.
24. Stone Treasure Mountain is only around one hundred kilometers east of the modern Burmese border (as the crow flies), but the mountainous terrain would have made the journey extremely difficult.
25. These inscriptions appear in Caves 5, 6, and 7. Liu Changjiu, “Yunnan Jianchuan,” 98–100.
26. *Man shu*, 64.
27. *Xin Tang shu*, 222b:6281–6282; 215a:6027; *Zizhi tongjian*, 249:8078.
28. The figures include eighteen arhats, Śākyamuni in *parinirvāṇa*, Kṣitigarbha, Avalokiteśvara, etc. See Li Kunsheng, *Nanzhao Dali guo diaoke huihua yishu*, 126–132.
29. This site includes two areas: Fengmingtai has five grottoes with images of buddhas, bodhisattvas, and animals; and Longraoshi has eighteen grottoes, each with an image of an arhat. Li Kunsheng, *Nanzhao Dali guo diaoke huihua yishu*, 164–167.
30. *Zizhi tongjian*, 269.
31. *Yuan Mei zaoxiang ji*, 6.
32. *Zhang Banglong zaoxiang ji*, 5–6; and Liu Changjiu “Yunnan Jianchuan,” 102. The ninth-century *Man shu*, 64, or “Book of Barbarians,” identifies Shazhui as the site of a salt mine located to the southeast of Jianxun, a city to the northwest of Jianchuan.
33. Dali kingdom Buddhists frequently inserted the names of buddhas, bodhisattvas, etc., between their family names and personal names. Damage and wear to this inscription make it difficult to determine what the wife's name was, but it at least included the name Guanyin. See *Yaoshi Xiangfuren Guanyin Gu'ai*, 6.
34. Li Kunsheng, *Nanzhao Dali guo diaoke huihua yishu*, 70 fig. 48, 74–75 figs. 55–56, 96–97 figs. 91–92.

35. I have traced this identification to Li Jiarui, “Shibaoshan,” 61–62. There are additional problems with the theory that Du Guangting served as an official in the Nanzhao kingdom.
36. Liu Changjiu (“Yunnan Jianchuan,” 95) describes the crown as a “precious vajra stūpa lotus flower crown” (*jingang baota lianhua tounang*).
37. In fact, it is the unsubstantiated identification of this monk as the Nanzhao-era figure Gepi in Li Jiarui (“Shibaoshan,” 61–62) that led to the unsubstantiated identification of the central royal figure as the Nanzhao ruler Geluofeng (r. 748–779). References to Gepi as a member of the Nanzhao royal family appear only in the Yuan and later; see Hou Chong, *Baizu xinshi*, 264; and the 1334 epitaph *Gu zhengzhi Gongqian heshang mubeiming*, 108.
38. Liu Changjiu, “Yunnan Jianchuan,” 99. Though there is some scholarly debate about the central buddha’s identity, Luo Zhao, Hou Chong, and Huang Huang have convincingly argued that it is Vairocana instead of Śākyamuni. See Luo Zhao, “Jianchuan shiku Shizhong si”; Hou Chong, “Jianchuan Shizhongshan shiku”; and Huang Huang, “Jianchuan shiku Shizhong si.”
39. Hou Chong, “Dali guo xiejing yanjiu,” 43. In Chinese, their names are (in sequence): Liuzu zun mingwang, Jiangsanshi mingwang, Wunengsheng mingwang, Dalun mingwang, Matou mingwang, Daxiao mingwang, Buzhi mingwang, and Budong mingwang. Similar sets of eight *vidyārājas* appeared in Tang Buddhism: textually in the Tang *Great Marvelous Vajra [Being] Scripture* and visually as carvings on a gold lotus pedestal from Dharma Gate Monastery (*Famen si*). See Damiao *jingang da ganlu junnuli*, T19.340c12–341a18; Wu Limin and Han Jinke, *Famen si Tangdai digong*, 74–77.
40. The *Great Marvelous Vajra [Being] Scripture*, Dali illustration, and *Paeon* correlate each of the wisdom kings to a bodhisattva, but their correlations differ somewhat. Hou Chong, “Dali guo xiejing yanjiu,” 58. Howard (“Eight Brilliant Kings,” 96) observes that at Boshenwahei only seven *vidyārājas* are visible, but an eighth could be hiding under moss.
41. There may have been renovations to this cave, as Liu Changjiu identifies different figures beneath Amitābha.
42. Wang Shili and Yang Xiaojian, “Shilun Nanzhao,” 85.
43. These perspectives plus an argument that combines fertility worship and esoteric Buddhism in Wang Shili and Yang Xiaojian, “Shilun Nanzhao,” 83, 86–87.
44. Liu Changjiu, “Yunnan Jianchuan,” 103; Song Boyin, *Jianchuan shiku*; Beijing daxue kaoguxue xi, “Jianchuan shiku,” 82.
45. Liu Changjiu, “Yunnan Jianchuan,” 103.
46. One scholar, in personal communication, proposed that the image could instead depict a phallic *lingam*, but I have encountered no other support for this hypothesis.

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CHAPTER 10

The Geoaesthetics of Ritual in the Chinese Buddhist Sanctuary of Shizhuanshan (ca. 1082–1096)

Phillip E. Bloom

To propose a geoaesthetics of Chinese Buddhist ritual is, in a sense, to propose a paradox. After all, contemporary scholarship typically assumes that Chinese Buddhist liturgies adopt the sorts of distinctly anthropic spatial and temporal limits that geoaesthetics flouts. Modeled on banquets, such practices involve a human liturgical host's purifying a ritual arena; inviting supramundane guests into that space; offering to them incense, flowers, food, and scriptures; entreating them with prayers and requests; and ultimately thanking and dismissing them.¹ These liturgies take place only in specific spaces (home altars, temple halls, or monastic grounds), and they last only specific periods of time (from the few moments needed to offer incense to the multiple months necessary to complete certain rites of repentance). Such a model of ritual necessarily considers liturgy to be a uniquely anthropic performance—that is, an activity in which humans function as agents whose physical and mental actions effect both worldly and otherworldly transformation.²

A geoaesthetics of ritual, by contrast, would seem to demand almost diametrical conceptions of time, space, and agency. The space of ritual would not be the confines of a lay home or a monastic compound; it might instead be a mountain, a landscape, or the environment writ large. The time of ritual would not be limited to moments or months; it might instead extend beyond

the human life span and perhaps even eternally. And the agents of ritual might be not only humans but also objects, images, rocks, trees—and perhaps even wind, water, and light. In short, a geoaesthetic approach to ritual would seek to conceptualize a temporally, spatially, and ontologically expansive assemblage of agency.³ Through such an assemblage, the efficacy of ritual (if not the performance per se) might be extended both eternally and environmentally.

A small late-eleventh century Buddhist sanctuary known as Stone Seal Mountain (*Shizhuanshan*)—located at the border of Dazu District (*Dazu qu*) and Rongchang District (*Rongchang qu*) in modern-day Chongqing Municipality (*Chongqing shi*), China—seems to do precisely this.⁴ Consisting of cliffside images, inscribed texts, and stone architecture embedded in a forested landscape, it constitutes a geoaesthetic matrix (that is, an environment of both artificial and natural objects within which an assemblage of human and non-human agency takes form) that holds the potential to extend the efficacy of ritual eternally (fig. 10.1). As visitors roam through this space, view its images, and appreciate its trees, they are transformed into Dharmic agents who themselves go on to perform anthropic forms of ritual. Significantly, *Shizhuanshan*'s images even directly afford worshippers a vision of the effects of their performative practices. In this chapter, I follow inscriptions at the site to argue that although *Shizhuanshan itself* does not perform ritual, its geoaesthetic assemblage of human and nonhuman agents together perpetually generate new anthropic ritualists who extend the efficacy of ritual beyond the site itself.



Figure 10.1 Covered niches embedded in the landscape of Luohan wan, Shizhuanshan, Rongchang District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, ca. 1082–1096. Photograph by the author.

To make this argument, I begin with a brief description of the Song dynasty (960–1279) sanctuary of Shizhuanshan. I then move to a close reading of a stele composed by the site’s patron in 1090, complemented by a discussion of specific visual features of its twelve image-filled niches and its forested landscape. Through comparisons to canonical Buddhist sources as well as to other Song sites that similarly seem to propose an eternal, environmental form of ritual efficacy, I ultimately seek to elaborate a conception of a geoaesthetic mode of Chinese Buddhist ritual.

This chapter’s idiom of affordances, agency, and geoaesthetics is, of course, not emic to my source material. Like other contributors to this volume (see especially Megan Bryson’s chapter), I have been inspired by James Gibson’s classic work on affordances to think about the ways in which particular objects and environments (together arranged into what I call “matrices”) offer, provide, or furnish specific forms of human interaction—in this case, visual and corporeal interactions that spur visitors’ intention to ritualize.⁵ Importantly, the materials at Shizhuanshan, particularly its patron’s stele, seem to suggest that objects such as images and beings such as trees do not merely *afford* interaction but instead *actively transform* those that interact with them: in short, visitors become worshippers by interacting with images and trees. These materials seem to demand that their contemporary interpreter conceptualize nonhuman forms of agency. Consequently, to make sense of this image-filled landscape that catalyzes the visitors who walk through it, I have turned to the actor-network theory of Bruno Latour, particularly as interpreted by Jane Bennett and Carl Knappett, who seek to theorize the agency collectively generated through the interactions of human and nonhuman actants.⁶ Following their work, I conceive of agency simply as the capacity to do or to effect change; I do not assume any sort of intentionality on the part of the actants that I discuss.⁷ In bringing Shizhuanshan into dialogue with these works, I hope to show that this site—and possibly many others—provides compelling material through which to rethink conventional contemporary understandings of ritual and to conceive of it, instead, as a practice that can assume geoaesthetic form.⁸

A Sprawling Sanctuary

Shizhuanshan is the name given to one of the many low sandstone plateaus that fill the southwestern corner of Dazu District. Rising approximately seventy-five meters above the surrounding valleys, its slopes descend precipitously, exposing up to ten meters of unvegetated sandstone escarpments. The Song dynasty Buddhist sanctuary that is my focus spreads across this plateau (fig. 10.2). It consists of two groups of image-filled niches carved into the sandstone cliffs; a stele engraved into one of the outcroppings; a stone pagoda;⁹ and the



Figure 10.2 Map of Shizhuanshan. After Dazu shike yanjiuyuan, ed., *Shizhuanshan, Shimenshan, Nanshan shiku kaogu baogao shangce*, Dazu shike quanji 5 (Chongqing, China: Chongqing chubanshe, 2018). Map provided by Dr. Mi Defang, Dazu Academy of Rock Carvings.

surrounding landscape, whose forests were originally cultivated as an essential element of the site. The small Temple of the Buddha’s Assembly (*Fohui si*) may also have been part of the original sanctuary, but some scholars speculate that it was not founded until the early Ming dynasty (1368–1644).¹⁰

Both the contemporary and Song experiences of Shizhuanshan center on twelve image-filled niches, which are carved into two cliff faces separated by the fingerlike outcroppings of the eponymous plateau. The primary group of nine niches is now known as Zimu dian (literally, Mother’s Hall); the secondary group of three, as Luohan wan (Arhat Bend).¹¹ Moving east to west along the cliff face at Zimu dian, visitors first encounter iconic assemblages of the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha and the Ten Kings of Purgatory; Laozi and fourteen patriarchs of Daoism; the buddhas Vairocana, Maitreya, and Śākyamuni and various bodhisattvas (fig. 10.3); and Confucius and his ten disciples.¹² Continuing farther, they come upon a small niche containing images of the bodhisattvas Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra; they then proceed to view low-relief carvings of the seventh-century master physician Sun Simiao, the local earth and mountain gods (fig. 10.4), and the fifth-century Buddhist thaumaturge Baozhi, who was revered in the Song as a miracle worker.¹³ The “saintly mother” (*shengmu*) Hārītī, who was associated with Buddhist rites of food distribution and with vernacular supplication for childbirth, occupies the westernmost niche at the site. A kilometer southeast at Luohan wan, an iconic



Figure 10.3 Wen Weijian et al., Zimu dian niche 7: the Buddhas Vairocana, Maitreya, and Śākyamuni, Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, 1082. Photograph by the author.



Figure 10.4 Wen Weijian et al., Zimu dian niches 3 and 4: Earth God (and Mountain God?) (*left*); and Sun Simiao (*right*), Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, ca. 1082–1096. Photograph by the author.

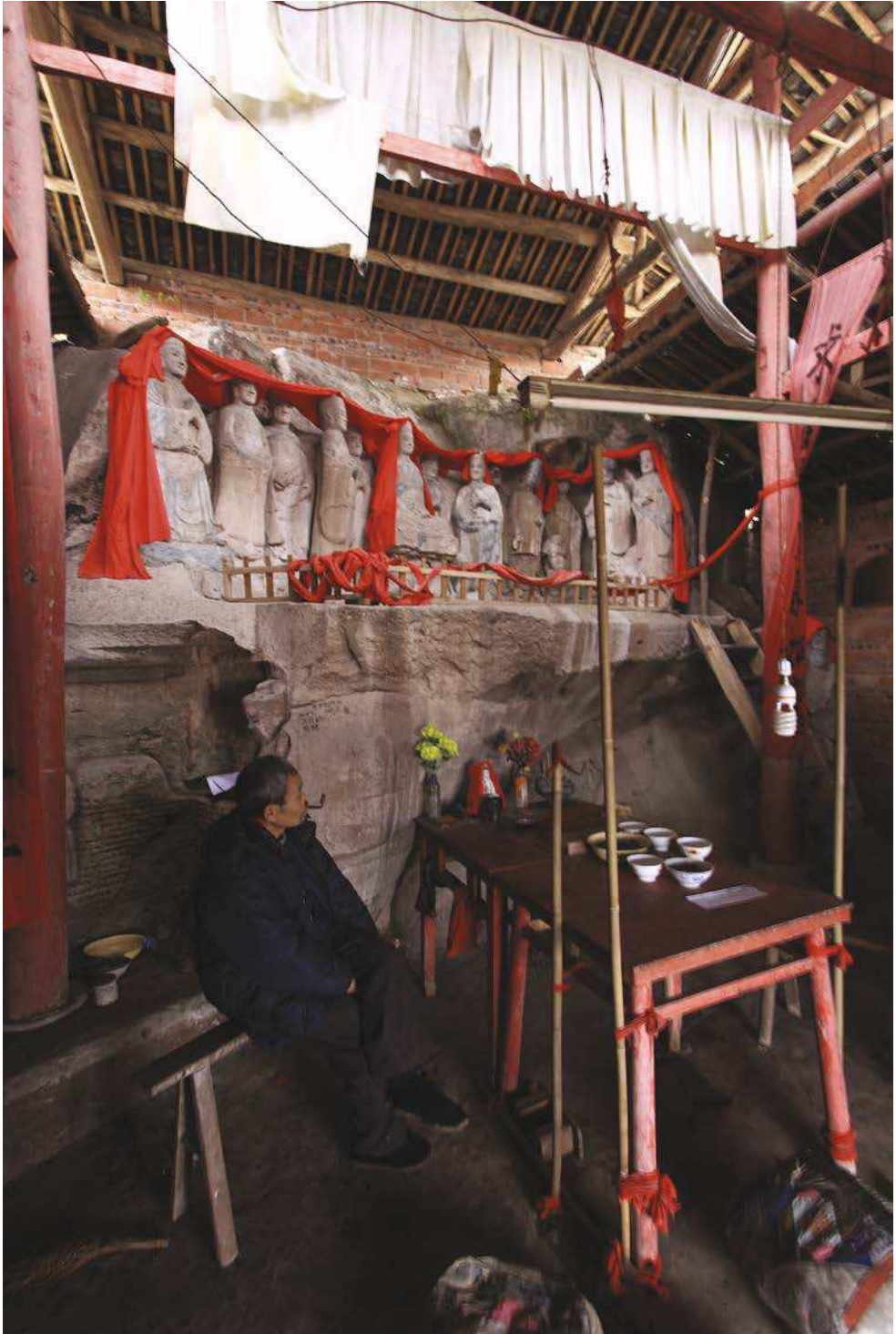


Figure 10.5 Wen Weijian et al., Luohan wan niches 10 and 11: King of Longevity (*cliff face, lower left*) and Tejaprabha and Eleven Planets (*above*), Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, ca. 1082–1096. Photograph by the author.

assembly of the astral buddha Tejaprabha and eleven planets is carved into the same escarpment as a narrative depiction of the King of Longevity (*Changshou wang*), a figure propitiated for both health and wealth (fig. 10.5).¹⁴ A standing figure of the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara surveys the landscape from a nearby outcropping (fig. 10.6). In short, the eclectic pantheon of spirits that occupy these niches covers all dimensions of time and space—from the past to the future, from the local to the cosmic—and includes figures that allay the concerns of both the living and the dead.

Inscriptions beside several of the niches indicate that they were carved between approximately 1082 and 1096 by two generations of a family surnamed



Figure 10.6 Wen Weijian et al., Luohan wan niche 12: Avalokiteśvara (attended by Yan Xun and his wife), Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, ca. 1082–1096. Photograph by the author.

Wen.¹⁵ Moreover, they record that the completion of the niches of the three buddhas and of Confucius and his disciples was celebrated in 1088 with a performance of the Water-Land Retreat (*Shuili zhai* or *Shuili hui*), a Buddhist ritual of universal salvation that frequently served to fete the finishing of images and architectures.¹⁶ Most importantly, they clarify that the images were sponsored by a single lay patron named Yan Xun, a wealthy member of the local gentry.¹⁷

Although earlier scholarship has made important strides in clarifying the social, historical, and ritual dimensions of Shizhuanshan, the most distinctive feature of the site—namely, its landscape-encompassing sprawl—has yet to be the object of sustained consideration. Indeed, the sanctuary covers much of its eponymous plateau: the niches at Zimu dian alone are spread across a six-hundred-and-fifty-meter cliff face, and a full kilometer separates them from the niches at Luohan wan to the southeast. To experience the site as a whole, the visitor must walk several kilometers in total, traversing terraced fields, bamboo groves, and stands of conifers. Such an experience of a Buddhist sanctuary is decidedly unusual. Most cave-shrines and cliff carvings exist in close proximity to one another and to the monasteries that housed the monks who cared for them. The hundreds of niches at Dazu's Beishan, for example, were immediately adjacent to the monastic community that maintained the icons.¹⁸ Shizhuanshan, however, seems to have been intentionally designed to encourage visitors to roam—to experience the sanctuary as an expansive landscape.

Why might Shizhuanshan have been designed in such a way? Why create a site in which visitors must traverse through space and over time to interact with an eclectic array of images? To answer these questions, we must turn to a close reading of a stele that Yan Xun composed in 1090 and had carved into the escarpment at Luohan wan.

From Admonitions to Geoaesthetics

Titled “Admonitions against Damaging the Various Icons and Felling the Conifers and Plantings around the Niches and Pagoda” (*Jing ren sundong zhu zunxiang ji zhefa kan ta qianhou songbo peizai ji*), Yan Xun's stele serves primarily as a list of regulations concerning the use and protection of Shizhuanshan (fig. 10.7).¹⁹ The rules differ little from those found in contemporary museum galleries or sculpture parks: no touching, no drinking, no roughhousing. However, Yan's admonishments are framed by considered comments concerning Shizhuanshan's function as a geoaesthetic matrix that affords the spiritual transformation of visitors into ritual agents. According to Yan, it was the temporal and spatial experience of encountering images embedded in a forested landscape that would ultimately lead visitors to follow the Buddha's Dharma and to ritualize on their own.



Figure 10.7 Yan Xun, “Admonitions against Damaging the Various Icons and Felling the Conifers and Plantings around the Niches and Pagoda” (*Jing ren sundong zhu zunxiang ji zhefa kan ta qianhou songbo peizai ji*), Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, 1090. Photograph by the author.

In point of fact, the opening sections of the stele reveal that Yan was concerned above all with Buddhist practice, particularly ritual.²⁰ He recounts that it was his desire to carry out lay liturgy that first motivated him to create Shizhuanshan. He writes, “I have read the writings of the Buddha, have personally carried out practices throughout the years, and have held retreats for some days. [However,] having been born at the end of the Buddha’s Dharma, I am not intimate with the Buddha’s assembly; I cannot invoke and invite [them], as I am far distant from the Buddha’s time. Though longing to perform the affairs of the Buddha [or “rituals”], I was not able.”²¹ In other words, Yan had attempted to carry out the daily ritual activities—in his terms, *xiuxing*, *chi zhai*, and *zuo fo shi*—expected of a devout layperson, but he felt unable to do so because of his temporal distance from the Buddha Śākyamuni. Thus, he decided to create his own ritual arena suitable for “invoking and inviting” (*quanqing*) deities. To this end, he purchased the “superlative site” (*sheng di*) of Shizhuanshan with five hundred thousand coins—a sum approximately equivalent to the funds necessary to feed fifty adults and thirty-three children for a year in the late eleventh century.²² Later passages in the stele suggest that Yan amassed his fortune by managing three estates, at each of which he planted vast forests.²³

Yan decided that his sanctuary would be structured around a personal pantheon carved into the eternally present medium of stone. His stele identifies the spirits depicted, listing them according to a hierarchy of spiritual advancement (buddhas, bodhisattvas, the founders of China's other religious traditions, and assorted other spirits) rather than according to the date of their carving or their physical position at Shizhuanshan. In point of fact, there does not seem to be a specific logic underlying the images' date of execution or geo-spatial positioning. Yet the niches were not added willy-nilly: Yan's stele was composed six years before the last dated niche was completed, which suggests that he conceived of the sanctuary and its pantheon as a unified whole inspired by his specific devotional needs.

The visual features of Shizhuanshan's images speak to their transformational function, integrating anthropic liturgical practice into the broader geoaesthetic vision of the site (which Yan elaborates later in the stele). At first glance, the figures appear as conventional icons. Lining their niche shoulder to shoulder and facing directly outward, they establish a direct connection with their viewer-worshipper, who almost feels compelled to make offerings in front of them.²⁴ However, many of the figures are adorned with a surprising motif: small, scroll-like bands of clouds surround the heads of certain figures and cover the façades of several niches (figs. 10.8 and 10.9).²⁵ In the visual idiom of Song Buddhist art, clouds often served as visual metaphors for spirits' manifestation within a ritual arena.²⁶ Such manifestation occurs most commonly in response to officiants' offerings of incense, a phenomenon directly rendered in the paintings that adorned the arenas of various Song rituals.²⁷ Given such visual precedents, the clouds of Shizhuanshan likely suggest that the spirits are manifesting to the worshippers who supplicate—in Yan Xun's terms, “invoke and invite” (*quanqing*)—before them. Ultimately, the form of these images might allow us to posit a transformational process of viewing: first approaching the images as conventional icons, visitors might pay homage to them just as they might any other Buddhist sculpture; in the course of interacting with the icons, the bands of clouds become apparent to the worshipper, emphasizing the spirits' manifestation in specific response to the visitors' acts of worship and thereby testifying to the efficacy of their supplications.

Although the creation and protection of these icons seems to have been Yan Xun's primary concern, the images were but one part of the sanctuary of Shizhuanshan as a whole. In transforming the site, Yan also horticulturally reshaped its landscape. He writes that he “planted pines and cypresses and various flowering and fruiting trees around the site's niches, halls, and pagoda.”²⁸ He further claims to have cultivated more than one hundred thousand conifers at Shizhuanshan and his other estates.²⁹ Why might Yan have paid such attention to foresting the slopes of this sanctuary?

Yan seems to have understood trees to fulfill two functions—one protective, one agential (that is, transformational). He first clarifies his conception



Figure 10.8 Detail of clouds surrounding the head of Vairocana Buddha. Wen Weijian et al., Zimu dian niche 7: the Buddhas Vairocana, Maitreya, and Śākyamuni, Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, 1082. Photograph by the author.

of trees as protectors of architecture. He writes, “In an area of ten *zhang* [approximately thirty-one meters] around the niches, halls, and pagoda, one must not build architectural structure but instead exclusively plant pines and cypresses, and flowering and fruiting trees. After all, architectural structures will deteriorate if not maintained over time, [whereas] conifers mature, their



Figure 10.9 Detail of clouds surrounding the Baozhi and his attendant. Wen Weijian et al., Zimu dian niche 2: Baozhi, Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, 1085. Photograph by the author.

shadows becoming denser as they age.”³⁰ In this passage, Yan identifies two complementary experiences of time—one anthropic, the other botanical. As an artificial construction, architecture is dependent upon humans, and like humans, architecture decays with age. Trees, however, transcend such concerns; the longer they exist, the stronger they become. Thus, he believes, botanical features can better protect the icon-filled niches than the wooden shelters that have so commonly been used to shield outdoor images in China. Trees’ decidedly nonanthropic experience of time guarantees the eternal existence of the sanctuary, liberating Shizhuanshan from its dependence on humans.³¹

Moreover, Yan argues that when trees are combined with images and architecture, they become capable of fulfilling far more complex functions

than the merely protective. Later in the stele, he develops his vision of image-tree symbiosis further to speak of the agential function that Shizhuanshan's features collectively fulfill. Simply put, he articulates, if only cursorily, a vision of the site as a geoaesthetic matrix through which an assemblage of transformative agency is created. He argues, "If the niches, halls, tower, and images crafted now are protected together, and if the pines, cypresses, and trees ten *zhang* around the niches, halls, and tower manage not to be felled, [then] *all people who visit and worship will generate a joyful heart. They will together give rise to compassionate action and will together carry out the affairs of the Buddha* [or "ritual"]. In so doing, they will fulfill my intentions, and I will rejoice."³² Conceptually, this is the key passage in the stele. In essence, Yan declares that the site's images, structures, and forests will together inspire visitors to find joy in the Dharma and to begin taking the first steps on the path toward awakening; moreover, these new converts will go on to perform the "affairs of the Buddha" (*foshi*)—a term that Yan employed earlier when relating his desire to perform lay liturgy and that refers as much to ritual as to any other form of Buddhist practice. Consequently, it seems that Yan conceived of Shizhuanshan as something like a geoaesthetic matrix for the perpetual generation of ritual agents. By interacting with the features of that matrix (images, trees, etc.), visitors are sewn with the seeds of goodness, which cause them to blossom into ritualizing followers of the Buddha.³³ In turn, these new devotees will continue to propagate the Dharma, inspiring others to follow the path—and so on in perpetuity. In short, we can conceive of Shizhuanshan as a matrix within which an assemblage of human and non-human agency takes shape through the interaction of visitors, images, and trees; the ultimate output of that assemblage is anthropic ritual agents. So long as the site exists, and so long as visitors flow through it, ritual efficacy is extended without end.

Yan claims that his efforts bore quick fruit. By 1090 Shizhuanshan had come "to serve as a site where local people worshipped and that they visited together" as pleasure-seekers.³⁴ We might imagine visitors first paying homage to certain images and then wandering through Shizhuanshan's forested hills to experience the rest, admiring the landscape in the meanwhile. The site thus seems to have had a dual profile, simultaneously spiritual and ludic. For Yan Xun, the pleasure of roaming the site likely was an essential component in its ultimate spiritual efficacy, as it was the combined experience of viewing images and wandering through the forest that would awaken in visitors a devotion to the Buddha and his rituals. Today, Shizhuanshan still fulfills these paired functions: Zimu dian hosts a small number of tourists each day while also furnishing space for offerings by local worshippers; the niches at Luohan wan are used even more actively by laypeople, who have created permanent spaces for worship around some of the carvings (see fig. 10.5).³⁵

The Agency of Trees, Texts, and Images

Yan's stele presents an undeniably compelling vision of Shizhuanshan as a geoaesthetic matrix, a site whose constituent features perpetually inspire visitors to ritualize. However, Yan's language is terse, and the vision that he presents remains comparatively abstract. How might we understand more precisely the functioning of this site and the agency of its constituent actants? Comparisons to both canonical and contemporaneous parallels may help to clarify the issues at hand.

For one, the notion that botanical features (such as trees) and material objects (such as images) might inspire a person's devotion to the Dharma is central to descriptions of the Western Pure Land, a paradisiacal place believed to provide the ideal conditions for attaining awakening.³⁶ According to one of the Pure Land scriptures, when the trees of the Pure Land are blown by the wind, they produce miraculous sounds that cause the newly reborn to spontaneously contemplate the Three Treasures, a foundational practice incorporated into many Song rituals.³⁷ Birds and flowing waters are said to constantly sing the Buddha's Dharma, while artificial features such as nets of jewels generate sounds that similarly inspire reborn worshippers to ritualize. The text thus presents the Western Pure Land as a space whose every feature affords a transformative sensory experience that focuses inhabitants' attention on attaining awakening—a process that begins with the simple rite of contemplating the Three Treasures. Although Yan Xun does not explicitly invoke Pure Land imagery in his description of Shizhuanshan, one cannot help but wonder if a similar vision might not have inspired the site; after all, such descriptions were well known to Buddhists in the Song, who encountered the Pure Land's features both in the sūtras themselves and in the images displayed at “recitation assemblies” (*nianfo hui*), which attracted tens of thousands of worshippers.³⁸ Much like the Pure Land, Shizhuanshan is a sanctuary whose features exist to afford the transformation of visitors into agents of the Dharma.

Other models of nonhuman agency were also available to Yan Xun. Perhaps the most common of these models derives from *dhāraṇī* worship, which posits a transformative power generated through the interaction of text, matter, and natural forces. According to the *Uṣṇīṣavijayā Dhāraṇī Sūtra*, the ur-text of the cult, the spell-like *dhāraṇī* should be written on tall banners or pillars placed atop high hills or towers.³⁹ The sūtra notes that whenever a person passes through the light reflected from such a pillar or is anointed with dust blown from it, that person will immediately receive the benefits typically associated with other forms of ritual practice, such as chanting. Wearing an inscription of the *dhāraṇī* in an amulet on one's body was understood to confer similar blessings.⁴⁰ Like many other patrons in Dazu, Yan Xun made use of the form of the *dhāraṇī* pillar as an inscriptional ground outside several of the niches at

Shizhuanshan (fig. 10.10). The text of the *dhāraṇī* itself, meanwhile, is inscribed on several pillars in the region.⁴¹

The agency of *dhāraṇī* and other spell-like texts was harnessed in a variety of ways in the Song. For example, a mid-twelfth-century site sponsored by the eunuch Dong Zhongyong (1104–1165) employed five stone pillars engraved with two scriptures—one Buddhist, one Daoist—to save the ghosts of unburied war casualties.⁴² Dong installed the pillars on the opposite sides of a river valley in eastern China that had been the site of a major battle between the Song and Jurchen armies. Strikingly, Dong is said to have erected the pillars so that



Figure 10.10 Detail of *dhāraṇī* pillar. Wen Weijian et al., Zimudian niche 7: the Buddhas Vairocana, Maitreya, and Śākyamuni, Shizhuanshan, Dazu District, Chongqing Municipality, China, Northern Song dynasty, 1082. Photograph by the author.

“the grasses and trees, the wind and rain might bolster the sounds of the two scriptures and carry over the souls of the dead.” In essence, the pillars created a ritual environment in which living beings and natural forces virtually recited engraved texts. Within this geoaesthetic arena, the inherent power of the recited texts ensured that the rancorous ghosts of the war dead could be ferried away to be reborn.⁴³ Given the ongoing interaction of such living beings and natural forces with the site’s stone pillars, this virtual ritual arena might be understood to function eternally.

In each of these examples, the vectors of agency are slightly different, but the underlying concept is the same. The trees, birds, and nets of the Pure Land, as well as the pillars and amulets of the *dhāraṇī* cult, all afford to worshippers sensory interactions that cause them to ritualize, that convey blessings upon them, or that directly transform them for rebirth. In each case, it is an assemblage of agency distributed among nonhuman actants that results in the transformation of humans. The trees of the Pure Land, for example, are blown by wind, which causes them to produce miraculous sounds; hearing those sounds in turn causes the newly reborn to spontaneously contemplate the Three Treasures. Agency is not exclusively located in, or exerted by, any individual entity within this network; rather, it is through the interaction among tree, wind, sound, and worshipper that the transformation that leads to ritualized contemplation is accomplished.

In designing Shizhuanshan, Yan Xun arguably employed a similar logic. In the geoaesthetic matrix of Shizhuanshan, natural and artificial features—specifically, forests and images—function as an assemblage of nonhuman actants that afford the transformation of visitors into ritual agents. More concretely, interactions with the site’s images and forests inspire visitors to devote themselves to the Buddhist path, to sow good karmic roots, to rejoice in the Buddha’s teachings, and to carry out the Buddha’s affairs—that is, his rituals. So long as the site exists to afford to visitors interactions with its features, Shizhuanshan functions as not only an environmental matrix of spiritual transformation but also an eternal one.

Shizhuanshan’s images play a noteworthy role in this assemblage. By specifically making use of cloud imagery in rendering the spirits that appear at Shizhuanshan, Yan Xun creates a space in which supramundane figures are represented responding to ritual acts of invocation (see fig. 10.8). At such a site, it is always possible to meet with spirits in a specific manner otherwise limited to the confined time-space of conventional ritual performance. The images concretize the vision of ritual that Yan Xun articulates in his stele. The site does not merely use images and forests abstractly to inspire visitors to carry out Buddhist ritual; instead, it affords viewers the eternal opportunity to experience the efficacy of ritual through the representations carved into its niches.⁴⁴ At any moment, visitors can actually perceive the effects of anthropic ritual action: they can see that deities are manifesting in response to their invocations. The

images thus perpetually testify to the efficacy of ritual and unendingly serve as encouragements to worshippers to propagate their practice.



Ultimately, we can see Shizhuanshan as a geoaesthetic matrix through which the spatial, temporal, and agential limits of conventional, contemporary conceptions of ritual and its efficacy are exploded. Shizhuanshan shows that ritual need not be conceived solely as an activity performed in confined halls; instead, an entire landscape can be harnessed to effect the spiritual transformation of participants, who will themselves go on to perform anthropic forms of liturgy. Ritual need not be limited to the few moments, days, or months of a single performance; instead, through an assemblage of agency such as Shizhuanshan, the possibility of spiritual transformation can be afforded as long as the assemblage exists. And ritual need not be performed by humans alone; instead, material objects, including images, rocks, and trees, can all function as nonhuman actants that effect transformation through their interactions with humans.

Significantly, Shizhuanshan does not abnegate conventional conceptions of ritual entirely. After all, the Water-Land Retreat was physically performed there in 1088, and the ultimate output of Shizhuanshan's geoaesthetic matrix is new human followers of the Buddha, who will themselves go on to perform his affairs through their own anthropic agency. In other words, Shizhuanshan might best be understood as bringing conventional conceptions of ritual performance into dialogue with an expanded vision of ritual possibility. In the end, Shizhuanshan encourages scholars to follow Yan Xun in conceptualizing broad assemblages of ritual agency—geoaesthetic matrices in which humans, rocks, images, and plants all function as vibrant forms of matter that collectively perpetuate spiritual transformation.

In rethinking ritual, contemporary scholarship might look not only to sites such as Shizhuanshan that so explicitly link images, texts, landscape, and humans. Instead, with an understanding of geoaesthetics in mind, we might also seek to reassess the design and ritual function of a wide variety of familiar Buddhist sites. Monasteries, for example, incontestably served as geoaesthetic matrices of architecture, images, fields, and forests, whose every constituent element transforms the humans who interact with them into agents of the Dharma. Closer attention to the individual features of such matrices, however, likely will reveal spatially and temporally specific adaptations of such universal geoaesthetic principles. Temples may be found to embrace springs that chant, trees that preach, rocks that ritualize, and more. In short, a geoaesthetic vision of ritual may eventually open contemporary eyes to a vivid vision of the intersections between vibrant matter and human performance—a vision that defamiliarizes sites and practices whose function and meaning we have largely assumed transparent.⁴⁵

NOTES

1. On the “guest-host” paradigm, see Sharf, “Thinking through Shingon Ritual,” 58n13; Strickmann, *Mantras et mandarins*, 45–52, 367–411. Although both Sharf and Strickmann treat specifically Tantric ritual as a form of divine banquet, this paradigm also underlies a far broader range of Mahāyāna practices; see Hou, *Zhongguo fojiao yishi yanjiu*. On the use of this paradigm in China’s Daoist, state, and vernacular religions, see, for example, Feuchtwang, “On Religious Ritual,” 61–70; and Chau, “Hosting.” For a broader, conceptually stimulating introduction to Buddhist ritual, see Sharf, “Ritual.” Kamata (*Chūgoku no bukkō girei*) offers a comprehensive survey of Chinese Buddhist ritual forms.
2. Certainly, officiants make use of implements (e.g., censers, musical instruments, and images) and texts in the course of these performances, but those objects exist merely as tools to extend human agency within the limited time-space of liturgy. In this model of ritual, objects themselves do not necessarily exert agency, nor is there any means of expanding the forms of agency exerted during ritual beyond the temporal and spatial limits of a particular performance.
3. I adapt the term “assemblage of agency” from Bennett, *Vibrant Matter*, 20–38.
4. English-language overviews of this site include Zhao, “Rock Carvings”; Bloom, “Descent of the Deities,” 229–238; and Zhao, “Unified Three Teachings.”
5. Gibson, *Ecological Approach*, 127–137.
6. Latour, *Reassembling*, 63–86; Bennet, *Vibrant Matter*; Knappett, *Thinking*, 22–34. For a compelling summary of the ways in which Latour’s sociological theories serve analysis of works of art and literature, see Felski, “‘Context Stinks!’”, and Roberts, “Things,” 64–66.
7. In this regard, my work diverges from other contributors to this volume, such as Megan Bryson, who specifically seeks to avoid discussions of agency because of its implications in philosophical discussions of intentionality and in sociological debates about the primacy of environments (“structure”) or independent action (“agency”) in shaping society. As will shortly become clear, my source materials seem to demand a consideration of agency because of their insistence on the capacity for the landscape to transform those who interact with it.
8. Inspired by theories of the agency of objects, scholars of Chinese Buddhism and Buddhist art have also begun to reconceptualize the relic crypts of pagodas as sites in which miniature objects do the ritualizing. For example, see Wang, “Ritual Practice”; and Kim, “Eternal Ritual.”
9. Due to spatial constraints, the pagoda—known as the Tower of the Buddha’s Assembly (*Fohui zhi ta*), a name that may suggest that it was meant to serve as a site for the descent of the future buddha Maitreya—is not discussed in this chapter. For further information, see Li and Gao, “Dazu shike Mile,” 76–80. Chu (“Song wu,” 65–67) speculates that the tower was moved to its present position during the Ming dynasty (1368–1644).
10. Chu, “Song wu,” 60–67.
11. The niches at Zimu dian are numbered and fully described in Liu, Hu, and Li, *Dazu shike*, 526–532; and Hu Liangxue and Chen, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 515–526. For descriptions of the niches on the southern cliff, see Yang, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 6–8 and 55; and Chen, “Dazu shike,” 357–361.

12. The names of the spirits included in the following list are adapted from a stele composed by the site's patron in 1090, which is discussed in detail in the following section of this chapter. Although the original stele is heavily damaged, its full text was engraved on an independent stele held at Fohui si during the fifteenth century. The later stele's text is recorded in Chongqing Dazu shike yishu bowuguan et al., *Dazu shike mingwen lu* (hereafter *MWL*), 326–327. Revised transcriptions are published in Wu and Wang, “Dazu,” 18–19; Chu, “Song wu,” 61; and Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 142–144. When citing the stele in the remainder of this chapter, I provide references to both *MWL* and the revision in Gao.

13. The niche includes an inscription that suggests Baozhi's capacity to heal through Dharmic means; *MWL*, 316. On the worship of Baozhi, see Makita, “Hōshi oshō.”

14. The niche seems to be inspired by the *Changshou wang jing*, T3, no. 161. See Chen, “Dazu shike,” 353–354.

15. For an overview of the Wen family, see Hu Wenhe, “Dazu Shizhuanshan.” On the Wen family's carvings at Shizhuanshan, see Hao, “Wen shi.”

16. For a compelling introduction to Water-Land Retreat, see Stevenson, “Text, Image.” See also Bloom, “Descent of the Deities.”

17. Yan Xun's social status is reconstructed in Chu, “Song wu,” 61–63.

18. On Beishan, see Suchan, “The Eternally Flourishing Stronghold,” 74. See also the account of the relations between the monasteries and cave-shrines at Yungang (Shanxi Province) in Yi, *Yungang*.

19. *MWL*, 326–327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 142–144. Similar admonitions concerning the activities appropriate to a particular site were frequently inscribed in steles or rocks at its entrance. Harrist (*Landscape*, 98–112), for example, provides a stimulating discussion of Great Platform Mountain (*Dajishan*), a sixth-century Daoist sanctuary in Shandong that uses textual inscriptions to transform a landscape into a ritual space.

20. The very first lines of the stele present a brief history of Buddhism. Yan claims that Buddhism has survived multiple imperial purges because it helps the ignorant avoid harm and pursue the good and because it helps the wise realize the nature of things and accord with principle; in other words, Buddhism leads everyone to become a buddha. Yan also notes that Buddhism serves as a supplement to Confucian rites.

21. *MWL*, 326; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143.

22. *MWL*, 327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143. Discussed in Chu, “Song wu,” 62–63.

23. Yan's father seems to have been wealthy enough to avoid corvée service. *MWL*, 327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143. Discussed in Chu, “Song wu,” 62.

24. The iconicity of Chinese Buddhist sculptures and paintings is treated concisely in Wu, “What Is *Bianxiang*?,” 129–130; Foulk, “Religious Functions”; and Kieschnick, *Impact*, 52–80.

25. These cloud forms were first extensively treated in Hou, “Shizhuanshan shike.”

26. Ide, “Buddhist Paintings”; Bloom, “Descent of the Deities,” 272–331.

27. Bloom, “Visualizing Ritual.”

28. *MWL*, 326; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143. I have translated *kan tang ta* as “niches, halls, and pagoda.” Chu (“Song wu,” 65–67) argues that it is a single term meaning “a pagoda with niches.”

29. *MWL*, 327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143.

30. *MWL*, 327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143.

31. Inevitably, perhaps, the images were covered by architectural structures in the Qing, if not before; see, for example, the Qing steles on the restoration of the niche of Confucius and his disciples in *MWL*, 335–337. Most recently, the niches at Zimudian were subjected to a massive cliff-stabilization project undertaken by the National Cultural Heritage Administration (*Guojia wenwuju*) in 2018, while those at Luohan wan have been sheltered and resheltered several times by local worshippers since their rediscovery in 2003.
32. Emphasis added. *MWL*, 327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143.
33. These horticultural metaphors are inspired by Yan’s own words. He justifies his admonitions by claiming, “If [visitors] do not know what is forbidden, then I fear this land for sowing fortune will also [come to] grow the roots of misfortune.” *MWL*, 326; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143. This is a foundational metaphor that is repeatedly employed in discussions of all forms of Buddhist practice: to make offerings to the buddhas, to do good deeds, and to perform ritual is metaphorically “to sow the land of fortune” (*zhong fudi*; more commonly, *zhong futian*) and “to cultivate the roots of goodness” (*xiu shan’gen*) that will lead one to blossom into buddhahood. On these metaphors, see Walsh, *Sacred Economies*, 109–115.
34. *MWL*, 326–327; Gao, “Dazu Shizhuanshan,” 143. Early Indian monasteries similarly functioned as sites of both pleasure and awakening; see Schopen, “Buddhist ‘Monastery.’”
35. Ming and Qing inscriptions by monks and laypeople alike testify that the site has, in fact, always attracted visitors seeking both pleasure and awakening. Ming and Qing records concerning Shizhuanshan are compiled in *MWL*, 333–344; and Liu, Hu, and Li, *Dazu shike*, 332–336.
36. I thank Ryuichi Abé for suggesting this comparison.
37. *Fo shuo Amituo jing*, T12.347a12–24. Sūtras describing other Pure Lands, such as that of Bhaiṣajyaguru, describe similarly agential flora. However, the other sūtras on the Western Pure Land simply say that its features recite the Buddha’s Dharma, spontaneously transforming their hearers.
38. Reading and recitation of the Pure Land sūtras is detailed in the biographies of worshippers included in texts such as *Fozu tongji*, T49.260c18–290c22. For a prototypical *nianfo hui* during the Song, see *Siming zunzhe jiaoxing lu*, T46.857c25–28, 862a26–c24.
39. *Foding zunsheng tuoluoni jing*, T19.351b9–18.
40. For a compelling discussion of such uses of *dhāraṇī*, see Copp, *Body*, 141–196.
41. *MWL*, 20, 22–23.
42. Cao Xun, “Dong taiwei muzhi,” in Zeng and Liu, *Quan Song wen*, 191:135.
43. Tibetan prayer flags constitute a familiar contemporary example of a similar such virtual ritual machine. Like the pillars described by Cao Xun, prayer flags harness the wind to “recite” the mantras, *dhāraṇīs*, or sūtras printed on their surfaces; the entire cosmos is thus filled with the virtual sound of those texts, suffusing all sentient beings with their blessings. So long as the wind blows, the ritual act of text recitation is perpetually performed.
44. For similar arguments concerning the representational ritual function of other cave-shrines, see Sharf, “Art in the Dark”; and Bloom, “Mediating Mind.”
45. In this respect, I share great sympathy for Jeffrey Jerome Cohen’s project to defamiliarize the contemporary material world through consideration of medieval conceptions of lithic vibrancy; see his *Stone*, esp. 1–18.

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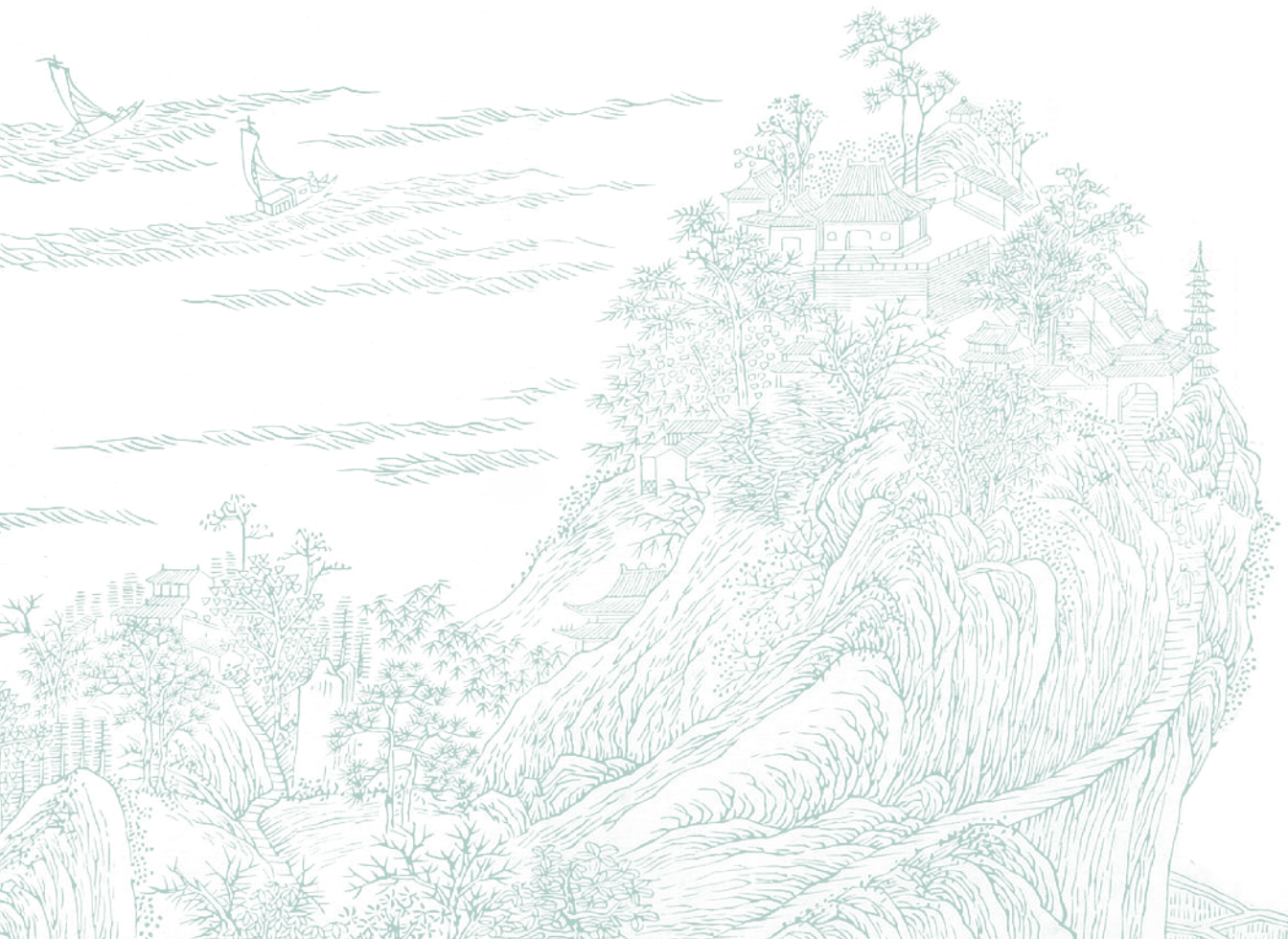
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PART IV

Environments as Mediums of Practice





CHAPTER 11

“Occasions Both Worldly and Transcendent”

Sacred Trees in Buddha’s India

Maria Heim

Scholars have long been fascinated by the presence of trees in Buddhist imaginations, textual traditions, rituals, and landscapes. Some scholars have suggested that the early Buddhist tree cult was grafted onto an even earlier cult of tree shrines; friezes at early Buddhist archaeological sites have prompted archaeologists to suggest that the tree roots found at a small wooden structure at Lumbinī, the pilgrimage site identified with the Buddha’s birthplace from at least Ashoka’s time, may indicate a Buddhist affiliation with trees as early as the sixth century BCE.¹ Other scholars have emphasized the symbolic features of the great trees of the Buddha’s biographical story, where depictions of the pipal tree in particular are said to be aniconic symbols of the Buddha and his awakening.² Still others have centered on the history and contemporary pilgrimage activity on the ground at the Mahābodhi, the great tree shrine where the Buddha was said to have attained awakening.³

I enter the discussion to direct attention to two features of the Pāli tradition’s approach to the trees present and described in the landscape of Buddha’s India, as we have come to know them in the early texts. I draw on the commentaries ascribed to Buddhaghosa, the great fifth-century CE commentator, that note and discuss the many trees and groves that occur in the canonical sources.⁴ First, some of the most important trees mentioned are individual trees, that is, named trees that were probably already well known localities in the region or that were made famous by the Buddha’s association with them. Buddhaghosa’s thinking about trees is neither abstract nor symbolic: rather, specific trees were locally famous places that aided and supported in very specific ways the

Buddha's experience and his ministry. Second, Buddhaghosa sees these famous trees as vectors connecting a specific *place* with the immeasurable and transcendent *space* into which the Buddha's transcendence reaches. Trees are, as he puts it, "occasions both worldly and transcendent."⁵

Buddhaghosa has a strong sense of the vastness of *space* and the minuteness of our world within it, and his reading of the Buddha's achievement of omniscient awakening emphasizes the transcendent sense of cosmic space into which the Buddha's knowledge extends. But he also evinces a strong sense of *place*, the concrete and particular spots of earth, and the precious trees, caves, mountains, rivers, cities, and people that ground us in a location from which we may develop our imaginations of the immeasurable. In the following pages I track the imaginative work of *looking outward to space* and *looking back to place* with a special focus on the particular trees that Buddhaghosa thought formed a vector between the immeasurable and transcendent on the one side, and the close and tangible on the other. In Buddhaghosa's terms, trees and groves are "occasions both worldly and transcendent"—they ground us in ordinary life and they afford experiences of the extraordinary.

"Occasions Both Worldly and Transcendent"

Buddhaghosa's interpretation of certain notable trees as "occasions both worldly and transcendent" occurs in his commentary on the opening lines of the Vinaya as he considers the occasion of the teachings of the monastic rules, an event that occurred while the Buddha was staying at the roots of Nāḷeru's Neem Tree. This stately tree, "pleasing, delightful, and presiding like a king over other trees, stood in the midst of the coming and going near to the city" of Verañjā.⁶ We learn further particulars: the tree is a *pucimunda*, that is, a neem tree (which can indeed grow to great size and preside over other trees), and it is called Nāḷeru's because it was named after a certain *yakkha* named Nāḷeru (a *yakkha* is a nature spirit). The tree stood near Verañjā as "a place appropriate for and frequented by renunciators," who could retreat from the hustle and bustle of the town while still gathering alms in it as necessary. Buddhaghosa launches into an extended exegetical technique in which he explains the role of Nāḷeru's Neem as a place for renunciators, while Verañjā is a place for householders who support them; the tree is a place for solitude, the town a place for teaching; the tree a place for "retreating out of wisdom," and the town a place for "accomplishing the welfare and benefit of others"; the tree a place where the Buddha could be "unsmeared by the world," and the town where he could be "nourished by the world by one born in the world."

As Buddhaghosa toggles back and forth between the tree (a tangible place in which the Buddha experiences transcendence) and the town (a practical place

from which to interact with the world), Nāḷeru's Neem becomes an opportunity for Buddhaghosa to stipulate the role that specific trees play in the Buddha's story. He mentions that "this technique of exegesis should be understood here starting in this way by this method": by stating the particulars of the specific tree in question the audience is reminded that "the Buddha was staying in a grove, for the Bhagavan is always born in a grove because it is an occasion both worldly and transcendent, first in Lumbinī, second, at the Bodhi Tree." In other words, when encountering trees in the Buddha's life story (as one does everywhere in the canonical sources), one should remember the specific trees of the Buddha's birth and awakening, and interpret other trees similarly, as "occasions both worldly and transcendent." This requires endeavoring to see how they make possible at once the ordinary and practical everyday activities of the Buddha and his profound experiences that radically transcend all ordinary matters.

The idea of an "occasion" (*samaya*) in Pāli commentary is important: an occasion for a teaching can be a certain meeting, opportunity, moment, time, locus, or cause of an event.⁷ In this sense, occasions are affordances in providing the conditions, circumstances, and support for important things to happen. The trees and groves that we see everywhere in the biographical narratives function as occasions in this specific sense.

It is essential to note that Buddhaghosa is not here speaking of trees in the abstract. His trees are specific named trees, locations that renunciators had long frequented, and were notable landmarks in the Buddha's time and perhaps even still in Buddhaghosa's time, a millennium later. They were places that the Buddha inhabited because, at least in some cases, they had been there long before him and were locally famous resorts for renunciators. The Buddha also seems to have had a great fondness for shade.⁸ Buddhaghosa writes in a register that is markedly grounded and "historicist" in orientation (perhaps in contrast to some of the more symbolic literary styles considered in our other chapters in this volume). The trees he discusses are actual places where these events happened and many of them sound like places he himself might have visited (or could imagine visiting) as actual sites. For him, Nāḷeru's Neem Tree, Gaṇḍa's Mango Tree at Sāvatti, the Ānanda Bodhi at the gate of Jetavana, Blind Man's Grove south of Sāvatti, and the Banyan Wood near Kapilavattu were specific historical localities (to name just a handful of the named trees and groves in which key events and teachings occurred in the Buddha's career).

Heritage Trees

In this respect, it may be helpful to introduce the notion of "heritage trees," or "champion trees," as analogous sites in our own context. A heritage tree is a specific tree with a name, known for its antiquity and cultural and historical value.

Consider the Fortingall Yew in Perthshire, Scotland, a tree that may be as old as five thousand years and perhaps Britain's oldest tree. A prehistoric tumulus has been found in the vicinity indicating Bronze Age activity, and this yew may have been a cult site for Iron Age peoples; later, Roman legions would have marched past it. The yew was Christianized in the medieval period and came to find itself standing in a churchyard. Today it has become a tourist site. Similar heritage trees can be found all over the world (El Árbol del Tule in Oaxaca, the UNESCO site cypress tree Jōmon Sugi in Japan, the Cotton Tree in Freetown, Sierra Leone, and, of course, the Bodhi Tree itself).⁹ Champion trees, the largest or oldest known in their species (such as the giant General Sherman sequoia and Methuselah, an ancient bristlecone pine, both in California), are famous regionally and, increasingly, globally. In all these cases we have individual, named trees of great antiquity that have watched human epochs come and go and that function as extraordinary living links to distant pasts.

India has many native tree species that can grow to advanced size and age, but banyan, pipal, and neem trees have attracted the most worship.¹⁰ At one time ancient India was covered with forests, although deforestation had long been underway by the Buddha's time. But it was thought that sometimes forests come back. The texts mention four great forests (*mahāraññas*), Daṇḍaka, Kāliṅga, Mejjha, and Mātanga, all of which are large forests said to have grown over ancient civilizations that now lie beneath them.¹¹ Specific woods were known to be landmarks where events of political and historical importance occurred, such as Blind Man's Grove (*Andhavana*), a day's walk from Sāvattthi, where King Pasenadi was ambushed and nearly assassinated by bandits; Blind Man's Grove was also thought to be an ancient forest that got its name due to an incident in the time of the previous buddha, Kassapa.¹²

But most salient for Buddhist concerns were the named groves and trees that were major landmarks and well-known localities for renunciators from all traditions. To name a few of these: Queen Mallikā's Park had a hall for renunciators of various stripes to gather and debate;¹³ Peacock Feeding Grove (*Moranivāpa*) was a retreat for renunciators; and Great Wood (*Mahāvana*) near Vesālī with its Peaked Roof Hall (*Kūṭāgārasāla*) was a famed resort where Jains, Brahmins, and Licchavi nobles visited the Buddha on his stays there. Albertina Nugteren has argued that in the Buddha's postawakening career, parks and orchards, "with their shady groves of trees, clear rivers and friendly villages," were preferred to dense forests and wildernesses "dominated by uncontrolled growth, non-Aryan tribes, and ferocious animals."¹⁴

As the early community became established, it was through the donations of woodland parks and ashrams that its success was marked. Forested resorts were gifted by kings, queens, and wealthy people to the Buddha and his community: most famously, Jeta's Wood (*Jetavana*) donated by the wealthy Anāthapiṇḍaka, who first purchased it for eighteen crores; Bamboo

Forest (*Veḷuvana*) given by King Bimbisara right after the Buddha's awakening; Ambapālī Wood at Vesālī, gifted by its namesake, the renowned courtesan *de luxe*, Ambapālī; and Jīvaka's Mango Grove, given with a monastery to the community by the wise physician Jīvaka. Within Bamboo Forest, Squirrel Feeding Woods (*Kalandakanivāpa*) was a popular resort for the Buddha, and we often find him teaching there. Banyan Forest Park (*Nigrodhārāma*) was the residence for the Buddha and his monks when visiting the Sākyaans and his home city, Kapilavatthu, and where he performed the Twin Miracle. Rosewood Grove (*Siṃsapāvana*) was a delightful site near Kosambī that furnished the handful of leaves that the Buddha took up in his "handful of leaves" simile.¹⁵ In this lovely lesson, the Buddha asks his disciples which is greater—his handful of leaves or the leaves still up in the trees, and then likens what he has taught them to a mere handful out of the vastness of everything that he knows.

Buddhaghosa discusses the features of these trees, groves, and woods with a vivid sense of place and a keen eye for detail. For example, the royal park called Young Mango Grove (*Ambalaṭṭhikā*) on the road between Rājagaha and Nālandā where the Buddha gave the Brahmajāla and the Rāhulovāda suttas, was shady and had plenty of water, had a building with pictures painted for the pleasure of the king, was surrounded by a fence, and was so well guarded by sturdy gates that it could have been the celestial tree Mañjusaka itself. The park got its name because of a young mango sapling growing near the gate.¹⁶ The texture of the comments make it seem almost as though Buddhaghosa had been there. These kinds of geoaesthetic details, themselves incidental to the main plot of the narrative, suggest that the commentarial authorities on which Buddhaghosa relied considered it essential to take notice of and preserve such description. This is perhaps because such details collapse time—reading them gives one the impression that one could go there now and find the young mango growing by the gate and be reminded that "just yesterday" the Buddha gave the Brahmajāla sutta near that tree. That Buddhaghosa is writing a thousand years after the Buddha was present is nowhere discernable.

We also know that trees occasion and support all the major events and teachings of the Buddha's life and career. Blossoming sal trees have a special importance in the Buddha's life events, for it was leaning on a blossoming sal tree in a sal forest near Lumbinī that his mother gave birth to him; the tree bent down a branch for her to grasp, offering the only support she needed in labor and delivery.¹⁷ The Bodhisatta made a brief visit to a "blossoming sal grove" shortly before his awakening at the Bodhi Tree as he walked from the Goat Herder's Banyan to the Bodhi Tree.¹⁸ And he passed into final *nirvāṇa* flanked by two sal trees that promptly burst into flower out of season, showering the Buddha's body with petals and pollen.¹⁹ It is a curious fact that none of these sal trees endures as a heritage tree, a named individual, although sal trees can become quite imposing in height, girth, and age.²⁰ Lumbinī Park was

memorialized at least by the time of the emperor Ashoka, but a specific tree was not. What seems to be important is that the *blossoming* of these sals heralds key moments in the Buddha's career (*Shorea robusta* blooms with clusters of small white or pale yellow fragrant flowers).

Another significant tree offering a gentle affordance in the Bodhisatta's development was the rose apple or jambu tree (a small ornamental fruit tree) under which the Bodhisatta meditated as a young man during the harvest festival of the Sākyans. It was "in the cool shade" of this jambu tree that he first experienced the advanced stages of contemplation known as the *jhānas*.²¹ Later tradition records that as he sat there, the shade cast by other trees moved as the sun coursed across the sky, but the jambu's shade remained a full circle over the Bodhisatta.²² If this tree ever had a name, it has been lost to history.

As important as all of these groves and trees are, the trees I wish to spend the remaining space discussing are heritage trees—specific named individuals that functioned, each in its way, as a shelter for the Buddha as well as a vector for his transcendent experience. Naḷeru's Neem is just one of a number of trees, not exhaustively treated here, that we can begin to explore as heritage trees that functioned as occasions for the Buddha's teaching. We may briefly mention Gaṇḍa's Mango at the gate of Sāvatti, the Ānanda Bodhi Tree at the gate of Jetavana, and the Auspicious Sal Tree near Kosambi, to suggest something of the complex treescape of the Buddha's teaching and miracles, before moving on to a more extensive treatment of the four trees of awakening and how they ground the Buddha's experience of world transcendence and the immeasurability of space.

Gaṇḍa's Mango was named after the gardener (Gaṇḍa or, in some manuscripts, Kaṇḍa) of King Pasenadi who was taking a particularly fine mango to the king when he happened upon the Buddha and offered it to him instead. This was fortuitous because having heard rumors that the Buddha was planning to perform a miracle under a mango tree near Sāvatti, the Buddha's detractors had chopped down all the mango trees in the vicinity. The Buddha ate Gaṇḍa's mango and gave the seed to Ānanda, who planted it at the gate of Sāvatti, whereupon it sprang up fully flowering and fruiting to a height of one hundred *yojanas* (a *yojana* is about seven miles), thus affording the extravagant miraculous display that came to be known as the Twin Miracle.²³ Nearby, at the entrance to Jetavana, is another tree planted by Ānanda and named after him, the Ānanda Bodhi Tree. The people of Sāvatti asked Ānanda for a place to worship the Buddha when he was away, and so Ānanda and Moggallāna took a fruit from the original Bodhi Tree and, with King Pasenadi and the lay patrons Visākha and Anāthapiṇḍaka, had it planted there with great ceremony. When planted the sapling sprang forth to the height and width of fifty *yojanas* and grew five branches. The Buddha consecrated it by spending a night under it in the rapture of his attainments. This became the first recorded instance of the

practice of taking cuttings and seeds from the Bodhi Tree (and later its descendants) to consecrate new places to worship the Buddha.²⁴ A tree stands at this site to this day as a place of worship—perhaps the original sapling, or at least a descendent of it.

Finally, I cannot resist giving a brief account of the Auspicious Sal Tree (*Bhaddasāla*) in the Protected Forest Thicket (*Rakkhitavanasaṇḍa*) near the village of Pārileyya, to which the Buddha repaired when weary of the unremitting bickering of the Kosambī monks. A certain bull elephant named Pārileyya, the leader of his herd, had also retreated to the same forest seeking the pleasures of solitude and relief from the strife in his community. These two great leaders in the same situation were deeply simpatico. Pārileyya took to providing all of the attending duties of the Buddha, bathing him; bringing him fruit, water, and twigs for cleaning his teeth; gathering firewood and kindling fires; and sweeping and tidying the Auspicious Sal under which they both sought refuge from the world.²⁵ He protected the Buddha at night by patrolling the forest with a stick in his trunk, a detail that gives the forest its name, Protected Forest Thicket.²⁶

The Trees of Awakening

The most famous tree is of course the Bodhi Tree, and it is under this extraordinary pipal that we will see the Buddha's transcendence and omniscience extend outward, springing forth in every direction in the vast space of the cosmos. But before the Bodhi Tree captures all of the attention, it bears noting that the seven-week awakening experience was structured by four heritage trees, each of which afforded shelter as it also shaped specific events and experiences in the protracted climax of Siddhattha's story. The *Jātaka Nidāna*, one of the earliest biographies of the Buddha's life, furnishes in a single source the complex treescape of the awakening, but we will supplement its narrative with details from other texts.

The events begin at Goat Herders' Banyan (*Ajapāla Nigrodha*), located on the banks of the Nerañjā River. It is hard to imagine a more magnificent shelter than a mature banyan; like the pipal to which it is related, this fig tree has aerial roots creating numerous structures in what can become a huge house-size entity. This one got its name because goat herders had long sheltered there. The backstory of a young woman, Sujātā, who had been praying to the *yakkha* of Goat Herder's Banyan for a good marriage and pregnancy, and the mistaken identity of the Bodhisatta when she takes him for the *yakkha*, is well known. It is she who offers the thick and nourishing milk-rice that breaks the Bodhisatta's fast. Her taking him for a *yakkha* is understandable: his golden presence at the banyan cast a radiant golden hue over it.²⁷ Upon receiving the alms, the

Bodhisatta rose from the tree and circumambulated it in worship—sometimes trees pay homage to him, and sometimes he pays homage to them.²⁸

From Goat Herders' Banyan he goes to the banks of the Nerañjā River and casts his alms bowl into the water. He then repairs to the blossoming sal grove, already mentioned, where he meditates for a few hours before heading in the evening to the pipal (also called *aśvattha*, *ficus religiosa*, or “sacred fig”) tree that becomes the Bodhi Tree. As Nugteren describes the pipal tree, we can imagine the lovely shade it provides:

It is a tree of light and shade, of rustling leaves, of sun-dappled, quivering, shady reflectiveness which does not draw one into the dark recesses of irretraceable growth, like a *banyan* does; on the contrary, it affords cool, translucent reflectiveness without obscuring one's view, without imposing itself, without enclosing.²⁹

It is at the foot of this tree, in the dancing of shimmering light and shade, that we become witness to a slowly building cosmic spectacle.

When he approaches and stands to the south facing the tree, the southern side of the universe slopes downward to Avīci hell and the northern part reaches up to the heavens, so that we see the universe like a flat disk or wheel being tilted. When he moves to the western flank of the tree, the same thing happens, with the western slope bending downward to hell and the eastern part up to the heavens. As he goes around the tree, the flat disk of the universe tilts upwards in whatever direction he faces. Finally, he settles, cross-legged, on the eastern side of the tree, his back to the trunk, facing outward to the east. Dramatic events then commence: the deities of the ten thousand world-systems gather to praise him, he does battle with Māra's legions (at which the deities scatter), and Earth herself bears witness to his conquest of Māra and the Ten Perfections that made it possible. The battles with Māra are legendary: for example, Māra hurls mountain-shattering tornadoes, epic floods that reach above the tops of the trees, missiles made of mountain peaks, and storms of glowing embers and ash. All of these assaults turn to flowers or precious substances as they approach the Bodhisatta.³⁰

With Māra's defeat, the tree softly casts down its young leaves to rest on the Bodhisatta's robe in homage. He now experiences the three watches of the night and becomes awakened, achieving omniscience by dawn, and causing the ten thousand world-systems to quake in response. Then we witness a spectacular light and vegetal profusion as radiance extends to all of these worlds: trees, plants, and lotuses burst into blossom and fruit, rivers cease, sea waters turn sweet, and dark places fill with brilliance.³¹ He spends the next four weeks at the Bodhi Tree in different orientations to it each week, the first week meditating on the throne of awakening with his back to the trunk, then moving off to the north and staring with unblinking eyes at the seat of awakening for the

next seven days.³² He then performs the Twin Miracle in the air (the same one that he will again perform later at Banyan Forest Park and Gaṇḍa's Mango), and spends the third week walking up and down between the throne of the awakening and a Jewel House he constructs.

The fourth week he spends in the Jewel House to the northwest of the tree, contemplating the Abhidhamma, which are “the endless methods of exposition” that start to work out the implications and applications of his insights. It is here that we go outward from Earth in a trajectory toward outer space, casting beyond the particular locality at the tree and shooting outward to other worlds. Alluded to in the *Jātaka Nidāna*, this experience is elaborated by Buddhaghosa more substantially in the commentary to the Abhidhamma. This text reports that when the Buddha contemplates the first six books of the Abhidhamma in the Jewel House, no rays of light are emitted from his body. But when he plunges into the seventh book, the *Paṭṭhāna* (“Starting Points”)—the only place where the Buddha's omniscience begins to find room to accommodate it—rays of light of six different colors (blue-black, golden, red, white, copper, and shimmer) shoot forth from his body.

Emanating from all parts of his body, these rays of light cast out so far that they catch the whole earth, including the waters and the atmosphere, before springing out to open space. From there they suffuse the heavenly worlds from the lower realms of the Four Great Divine Kings all the way to the highest Realms of Form, and even the Formless Realms, before reaching further to open space. From there

they sprang out horizontally into endless world-systems. In so many of these places there is no moonlight in the moon, no sunlight in the sun, no starlight in the stars, and nowhere is there light in the pleasure gardens, palaces, and wishing trees of the deities, in their bodies or their ornaments. Even the Great Brahmā, able to suffuse the three thousand thousand-fold world systems with light, became like a firefly at sunrise. There was known only the mere borders of the moon, sun, stars, divine pleasure parks, palaces, and wishing trees. The Buddha's rays overwhelmed so much space.³³

We are hurtling out from the Bodhi Tree to the farthest reaches of imaginable space as our eyes follow the rays emanating from his body. But lest this experience be seen as a miracle of his resolution or attainments, Buddhaghosa clarifies that this is a physical light that comes from his body (which itself expands to eighty cubits) when reflecting on the “abstruse and subtle Dhamma” that is omniscient knowledge of the methods of this text: “But this was not the Buddha's magical power of resolve, nor the magical power created by meditation. Rather, the blood of the Lord of the World became bright as he contemplated the abstruse and subtle Dhamma, and his physical form became bright, and the complexion of his skin became bright. The actual material form that

arises from such awareness completely and steadily established itself in a place measuring eighty cubits. He contemplated in this manner for seven days.”³⁴ In other words, the magnitude of the achievement of realizing the teaching (the Dhamma) in its most extensive form (the Abhidhamma, especially in its final book) can perhaps best be imagined by its physical magnitude reaching into the deepest depths of outer space. What is achieved under this particular tree in this seven days can be understood through the profusion of radiance lighting up the distant cosmos. The Bodhi Tree is the singular occasion that affords this opening out into the infinity of space.

The site of the Bodhi Tree stands outside of time, or at least it persists through and beyond human epochs. It is the same site where the Bodhi Trees of all buddhas, past and future, stand, although the specific trees differ (previous buddhas sat under sal, neem, *champaka*, bamboo, banyan, and other trees).³⁵ The site is considered “the navel of the universe,” and no other place can support the weight of a buddha’s awakening.³⁶ Between buddhas it is the “Bodhi spot,” a bare piece of ground smooth with sand, like silver plate, where not even grass can grow, although around it luxuriant vegetation and trees stand in a circle facing the site “in reverential salutation.”³⁷ No one, not even the deities, can travel in the air above it, and at the end of the world it is the last spot to disappear and the first to reappear at the beginning of a new world.³⁸ As for the Bodhi Tree itself, it has been entwined with our Buddha since his birth since it is one of the seven “co-natals” born on the same day he was.³⁹

Returning to the grounds of the tree and the remaining days of the seven-week sequence of awakening, the Buddha is at this point ready for a change of scene, so he returns to Goat Herders’ Banyan for his fifth week of awakening. Here he is assailed by the daughters of Māra, whom he rebuffs before teaching them the Dhamma. He then shifts again, for the sixth week, to the Mucalinda Tree, associated with the great *nāga* king Mucalinda.⁴⁰ A commentary says that the Mucalinda is called a *nīpa* or a *nicula* tree, depending on the region, but there are some differences of opinion among modern scholars about which exact species, or even genus, this tree is.⁴¹ There are several different candidates: *cadamba/kadamba* (a huge tree with a broad crown), Indian oak (teak), or *Barringtonia racemosa* or *Barringtonia acutangula* (both flowering estuary trees). Regardless, we do know that the week the Buddha spends at the Mucalinda is cold and rainy, and that the *nāga* king comes around him, coils him up in seven spirals of his great serpent body, spreads his hood above the Buddha, and protects him from the elements. Lest this sound stuffy, the interior space provided by the coils is actually quite large, enough room for the Buddha to move about, although in fact he spends all seven days in the seated, cross-legged posture.⁴²

When the rain stops and the sky clears, the Buddha emerges and repairs to yet another tree, the Kingstead Tree (*Rājāyatana*), where he sits for seven

days “enjoying the bliss of freedom.”⁴³ This tree is thought to be *Buchanania latifolia*,⁴⁴ a small nut tree; a stūpa was built at this site, and today there stands a small tree with a sign marking its significance. This concludes the full seven weeks of awakening. However, an additional event was recorded at this site: two merchants, Tapussa and Bhallika, come by and give the Buddha rice cake and honey balls, the first offerings to him since Sujātā’s. They become the first lay disciples.

Though the seven weeks of awakening are finished, we learn further details about trees as the Buddha sets out into the world. He returns now to Goat Herders’ Banyan, and it is here that the famous episode of his hesitation to teach and the deity Brahmā Sahampati’s imploring him to do so takes place. The Buddha then looks around the world and sees that indeed there are some beings “with little dust in their eyes” who can grasp the enormity and subtlety of his teaching, and so he assents to a career of teaching the Dhamma. From here he sets out to the Sarnath Deer Park near Varanasi.⁴⁵



It is under specific named trees at particular places that the important events in the Buddha’s life occur. In the canonical and commentarial Pāli sources, the Buddha’s awakening is inconceivable without the Bodhi Tree and its spot of earth, the axis mundi of the world that supports all buddhas and occasions their awakenings. While the features of the Bodhi Tree are well known, the vital role that other heritage trees played in the awakening and then the teaching has not been as widely recognized. Everywhere we see particular trees occasioning the Buddha’s experiences in their practical support and as vectors to the immeasurable and transcendent.

As an affordance or occasion that allows the Buddha to cast rays into the farthest reaches of the cosmos, the Bodhi Tree combines two domains that Buddhaghosa (and the tradition he represents) put in constant dialogue: the immediate, concrete, and particular, and the endless, immeasurable, and transcendent. Everywhere Buddhaghosa sees the former as occasioning a glimpse of the latter, and his work is pervaded with a recurrent fascination with how small, local, mundane, and particular gestures and places permit an apprehension of the immeasurable. One example from a very different context occurs in a discussion of the “loving physical acts” of tender care Venerable Ānanda performed for the Buddha. When helping the Buddha with ordinary acts of living such as washing his face, Ānanda’s gentle services were “measureless, without limits,” and “so great that the world is too narrow and the heavens too small to contain them.”⁴⁶ It is always through the concrete, apparently ordinary particulars that the immeasurable can be glimpsed or held. We might suggest further that without grounding in the mundane and the particular, the immeasurable has no context, reference point, or vehicle for access.

Here it is specific trees that occasion the “worldly and transcendent,” with the idea of occasion as the opportune moment, place, or confluence of circumstances working much like our idea of affordance. The Pāli commentarial tradition seamlessly unites a grounded and “historicist” arboreal imagination (the trees are not symbolic entities in this literature) with a sense of wonder at the vast cosmic experiences they render possible.

NOTES

1. Fogelin, *Archaeological History*, 83.
2. Foucher (“Beginnings”) advanced the theory that trees and other “aniconic” images in early Buddhist sculpture are symbolic representations of the Buddha. Huntington (“Early Buddhist Art”) critiques this symbolic treatment of trees and the notion of aniconic representation in favor of an interpretation of such depictions as showing early Buddhist places of worship.
3. A comprehensive and subtle treatment of trees in the Buddha’s biography and landscape, as well as a useful history of the Mahābodhi site, can be found in Nugteren, *Belief*, chapter 3.
4. Buddhaghosa is considered by the tradition to have edited and translated into Pāli most of the ancient commentaries, but modern scholars have tended to see a smaller set of commentaries (specifically those of the four *nikāyas*) as directly issuing from his hand. He may also have been working as the head of a team of scholars.
5. *Samantapāsādikā* i.110, translated by Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 234.
6. The quotations and discussion in this paragraph and the next two are from the *Samantapāsādikā* i.106–110 (Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 230–234). Throughout the chapter, all translations are my own, from the Chaṭṭhasaṅgāyana editions: but where they are available, I give citations to other translations as well.
7. See Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 197–201, 231–232.
8. Nugteren, *Belief*, 193. She points out how the Buddha was always seeking the shade of trees as well as parasols and even the hoods of cobras. “Shade, in Buddha’s life, does not seem to mean merely the absence of direct sunlight, it also indicates the right reflective mood, the right measure of withdrawal and participation, a balance between coolness and compassionate concern” (193).
9. The Bodhi Tree at Bodh Gayā in Bihar and at Anurādhapura in Sri Lanka have complex histories. The Theravada tradition holds that the Sri Lankan tree began as a sapling taken from the original tree in India during Ashoka’s time (3rd century BCE) and has been standing ever since. But the Bodh Gayā tree at the site now taken to be that of the Buddha’s awakening in Bihar may not be the original tree (see Nugteren, *Belief*, 197–229, for the history of both trees).
10. See Haberman’s marvelous book on tree worship of these three trees (*People Trees*, 2016).
11. The four are mentioned at *Majjhima Nikāya* i.378 (Ñāṇamoli and Bodhi, *Middle Length Discourses*, 483).

12. Malalasekera, *Dictionary*, 1:111. The account of its name during Kassapa's time is at *Majjhima-Aṭṭhakathā* i.336ff.
13. *Papañcasūdanī* ii.710.
14. Nugteren, *Belief*, 163.
15. *Samyutta Nikāya* v.437 (Bodhi, *Connected Discourse*, 1857).
16. *Sumaṅgalavilāsinī* i.41–42.
17. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.52 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 69–70).
18. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.70 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 93).
19. *Dīgha Nikāya* ii.138 (Walshe, *Long Discourses*, 62).
20. A Tibetan account has it that there were four pairs of sal trees between which the Buddha passed into *parinirvāṇa*, and that when he passed away the sal trees “turned as white as the wings of a white crane; their bark peeled off and the wood itself splintered. It gradually dried up and the remains crumbled away completely” (Skilling, *Questioning the Buddha*, 460). Perhaps it is appropriate that the trees present at the Buddha's death also perished.
21. *Majjhima Nikāya* i.246 (Ñāṇamoli and Bodhi, *Middle Length Discourses*, 340).
22. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.58 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 77).
23. Sarabha Miga Jātaka (no. 483), translated by Cowell et al., *Jātaka*, 4:166–167.
24. Kālīṅga Bodhi Jātaka (no. 479), translated by Cowell et al., *Jātaka*, 4:142–143.
25. *Udāna* 4.5. Translated by Ireland, *Udāna*, 58–59. *Udāna* commentary translated by Masfield, *Udāna Commentary*, 2:612–616.
26. Malalasekera, *Dictionary*, 2:704.
27. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.69 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 91).
28. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.70 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 92).
29. Nugteren, *Belief*, 207.
30. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.72–72 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 96–98).
31. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.76 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 100).
32. *Atthasālinī* 12 (Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 241–242).
33. *Atthasālinī* 14–15 (Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 243).
34. *Atthasālinī* 15 (Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 243).
35. Malalasekera, *Dictionary*, 2:319.
36. Kālīṅga Bodhi Jātaka (no. 479), translated by Cowell et al., *Jātaka*, 4:143, 146.
37. Kālīṅga Bodhi Jātaka (no. 479), translated by Cowell et al., *Jātaka*, 4:146. Malalasekera, *Dictionary*, 2:320. These vines, creepers, and trees “make reverential salutation to the Bodhi spot” (*bodhimaṇḍaṃ padakkhiṇaṃ katvā*).
38. Malalasekera, *Dictionary*, 2:320.
39. *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.54 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 71–72). The other co-natals are Yasodhara, Channa the minister, Kāludāyī the minister, a lordly elephant (perhaps Pārileyya), the royal horse Kanthaka, and the four treasure urns.
40. It seems that, as suggested by the *Udāna* commentary, the *nāga* king is named Mucalinda after the tree.
41. *Udāna* commentary translated by Masfield, *Udāna Commentary*, 1:263. There are several different possibilities for this. *Nīpa* could be *nauclea cadamba* (Rhys Davids and Stede, *Pali-English Dictionary*, 375); *Anthocephalus chinensis*, Indian oak, *Barringtonia racemosa* (Cone, *Dictionary of Pāli*, 631) or *Barringtonia acutangula* (Rhys Davids and Stede,

- Pali-English Dictionary*, 355; Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 107). Nicula could be Indian oak or *Barringtonia racemosa* (Cone, *Dictionary of Pāli*, 550) or *Barringtonia acutangula* (Rhys Davids and Stede, *Pali-English Dictionary*, 355).
42. *Udāna* commentary translated by Masefield, *Udāna Commentary*, 1:264.
43. Vinaya i.3 (Horner, *Book of the Discipline*, 4:5). *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.80 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 107).
44. Rhys Davids and Stede, *Pali-English Dictionary*, 569.
45. Vinaya i.4–9 (Horner, *Book of the Discipline*, 4:6–13). *Jātaka-aṭṭhakathā* i.81 (Jayawickrama, *Story of Gotama Buddha*, 108–109).
46. This passage is translated and discussed in Heim, *Voice of the Buddha*, 30.

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CHAPTER 12

Vidyārājas and the Articulation of Ecological Interdependence at Cave Temples

Sonya S. Lee

The *vidyārājas*, literally “kings of wisdom” in Sanskrit, are ferocious warrior deities in Buddhism. At the most fundamental level they are wrathful emanations of buddhas and bodhisattvas that function as guardians against demonic spirits and as destroyers of any obstacles to enlightenment. The *vidyārājas* are more formidable than other protective guardians in the Buddhist world because many, in previous incarnations, were notorious troublemakers themselves who eventually turned their weaknesses into a source of strength. Their karmic past has led them to experience the full spectrum of conditions of sentience, and they have thereby gained the knowledge of beings that are utterly different from them and, hence, the unique ability to overcome these beings in situations in which they become adversaries. In this light, the *vidyārājas* thus embody a key aspect of ecological interdependence in Buddhism, namely, the benefits of having made deep connections with other beings through transmigration. The fluidity of human becoming nonhuman and vice versa certainly resonates with critical ecological thinking in the wake of the devastating spread of the novel coronavirus across the globe since 2020. As N. Katherine Hayles has reminded us, the latest pandemic “offers an opportunity to rethink the ways in which we can identify with each other and with life forms radically different from us.”¹ Drawing on recent research that shows

the presence of ancient virus DNA within human stem cells, Hayles urges us to look deep inside ourselves and reconceptualize the world around us in ways that can connect us with something so invisible, alienating, and ferocious as the coronavirus. In a different way, the story of the *vidyārājas* shows what the world might look like if humans were to adopt a more inclusive cosmological and ethical stance toward the nonhuman.

The present interpretation of the *vidyārājas* is based on a specific example created sometime between the late twelfth and mid-thirteenth century in southwest China. The Buddhist cave temple complex Baodingshan, located in what is now Dazu District of Chongqing, boasts a remarkable set of cliffside relief carvings of the *vidyārājas* as part of an enormous pictorial program featuring thirty-one compositions that spread across the site's U-shaped valley terrain (fig. 12.1). At the westernmost edge of the north cliff, near the exit, located in a single row just above eye level (fig. 12.2), these ferocious warriors, despite being left incomplete from the waist down, are highly dynamic in appearance, exuding superhuman power in their multiple heads with animated expressions and many arms wielding exotic weapons. With hair rising and ribbons swirling around their bodies, the figures' intense, direct gaze toward the space in front of them does not fail to intimidate visitors as they approach the cliff



Figure 12.1 *Vidyārājas* Aparajita (left), Mahachakravajra (middle), and Padanakshita (right), from the Ten Austerities of Liu Benzun, Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.



Figure 12.2 Ten Austerities of Liu Benzun (*bottom row*), Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.

face. The effect is amplified with ten such figures in a collective grouping. Clearly, the patrons and artisans of Baodingshan had embraced the challenge of articulating the complex interdependences between humans and non-humans by drawing on the geoaesthetic potential of the setting to represent the *vidyārājas* in ways that enabled their viewers to experience the terror and ferocity they elicited as well as the promise of redemption and transcendence.

The relief carvings of the wisdom kings from southwest China illuminate ecological interdependence in Buddhism from the material culture perspective. Not only does the *vidyārāja* theme underscore an understanding of the human-nonhuman interrelationship pertaining to a particular time and place but the cave temple setting also brings into focus the nonsentient medium of stone that constitutes a significant portion of the spatial environment. Through the human encounter of carving pictorial images out of a mountain cliff, the rock surface becomes something animate and meaningful. The affectivity of the *vidyārājas* intensifies the interaction between the images and the human visitors, such that their material presence would trigger certain modalities of perception and imagination that led the visitors to see beings in other paths of existence. It was in this fluid state of receptivity that the decorated rock surfaces assumed an outsize role in heightening humans' awareness of nonhumans. Set in an open landscape dominated by red sandstone cliffs, the carvings were

reified in the minds of the visitors through the ever-changing effects of sunlight, atmospheric moisture, and wind as well as by the sound and smell of flora and fauna, all of which helped bring out the figures' perceived aliveness. The integration of the *vidyārāja* theme into a larger composition showcasing the Buddhist cosmology in a nutshell further signaled that both human and nonhuman participants were anticipated in the design from its inception, even though their supposed interactions would become visible to humans only under certain viewing conditions.

The choice of a sculptural representation of the *vidyārājas* at Baodingshan as the focus of the present study exemplifies an attempt to understand ecological interdependence in Buddhism through the lens of material culture rather than one based solely on Buddhist texts and doctrines. In fact, visual materials such as this offer a particularly effective conduit for examining local adaptations of mainstream concepts and ritual practices that often involved sponsorship and participation by non-elite members of a community who were frequently left out of official records in premodern China. The effort to recover these forgotten voices is integral to one of the overarching goals in the present volume, whereby historical analysis of premodern materials and discussion of specific ecological viewpoints mutually inform each other. For our case at Baodingshan, the scarcity of documentation about the site's founders and builders among in situ inscriptions and local gazetteers has compelled researchers to focus on visual evidence to make inferences about its original design, purpose, and targeted audience. The *vidyārājas* are an ideal subject for exploring the significance of the site's setting in a remote mountain not known for having a unique physical environment or a long history of cultural activities. Because Baodingshan lacks the salient features that define sacred mountains in China, the site's perceived potential for effecting its religious agendas might instead be gauged more effectively by the site-specificity of its pictorial contents.² The topic of *vidyārājas* helps highlight two key aspects of relief carvings at Baodingshan in particular: visibility and marginality. Visibility refers to the representational practices that made visible the Buddhist cosmological framework and the ways that interrelationships of sentient beings operate within it. These practices manifested in the choice of motif, mode of composition, and adaptation of key iconographic elements from textual sources. Marginality, in contrast, concerns more specifically the *vidyārājas*' immense power to overcome unruly beings from different realms of the Buddhist universe. This unique ability appealed particularly to Buddhist devotees in premodern times, who looked to these kings of wisdom as effective agents in negotiating with or defending against demons and other nonhuman actors that caused diseases and epidemics. The *vidyārājas*' role in healing activities was articulated at cave temples through their strategic placement in marginal spaces that symbolically mirrored the deities' fluidity in traversing different realms.

Visibility

The cliffside relief carvings at Baodingshan belong to a venerable tradition of Buddhist sculpture in southwest China that began more than fifteen hundred years ago and is still going strong today. Despite their unfinished state, the *vidyārājas* are representative of a mature phase, dating to the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, that has been called the “Baodingshan monumental style.”³ Although the figures are slightly larger than life-size, their relative proximity to the ground puts them in a perfect position to engage the viewers with their energetic poses and vivid expressions. As Angela Howard observes, the images’ style of calculated affectivity is a clear indication that all of the grand compositions at the site were intended to facilitate the teaching of concepts and practices central to the school of Buddhism espoused at Baodingshan.⁴ I would expand on this interpretation by arguing that religious instruction was just one of many activities at Baodingshan that centered on religious healing involving both human and nonhuman participants. The pictorial carvings without a doubt offer the most compelling material with which to probe into the site’s purpose and meaning. The present focus on the *vidyārājas* shows that their arresting presence was meant to persuade the site visitors of the realness of those invisible forces purportedly at work in shaping their physical and spiritual well-being. The relief carvings, in short, concretized the physical qualities of the place, thereby making them accessible to those with untrained eyes who otherwise might not have noticed them.

Like the majority of pictorial motifs depicted at Baodingshan, the *vidyārājas* were based on major schools of teaching in Buddhism prevalent during the Song dynasty (960–1279). Although this category of beings first emerged within the esoteric context in China, their mode of representation and grouping with other themes within the same composition at Baodingshan all point to a local adaptation not common outside Dazu or the Sichuan region. One telltale sign of this process was the expansion of the number of *vidyārājas* to a configuration of ten. As such, the set at Baodingshan is the largest known example in East Asian material culture. The more typical combination is in a group of either five (Acalanātha, Yamāntaka, Trailokyavijaya, Kuṇḍali, and Aparājita) or eight (the above plus Hayagrīva, Mahāchakravajra, and Padanakṣipa). The addition of Ucchuṣma and the Great Vidyārāja of Impure Traces to the eight is exceptionally rare, as these two figures can be found only at Baodingshan.⁵

Significantly, the group of ten *vidyārājas* parallels the same number of episodes in the biography of Liu Benzun, a semilegendary Buddhist master from the tenth century who was known for his ten self-sacrifices or austerities. Moreover, the wisdom kings appeared in the same pictorial narrative based on Liu’s biography, occupying the bottommost part of the same cliff face. The *vidyārājas*’ connection with Liu Benzun underscores their centrality to the founding of

Baodingshan. After all, it was Liu's teaching that was purposely revived by a preacher named Zhao Zhifeng (ca. 1159–1249) nearly two centuries after Liu's time.⁶ Both men are known to have practiced religious asceticism to gain healing power, and both carried out their respective healing regimes at devotional grounds especially set up for rituals. But one key difference between them lies in the location at which these activities occurred: Liu carried out his mission mostly at ritual spaces in urban areas in Chengdu and its vicinities, whereas Zhao did his at a remote mountain location in Dazu that he then turned into a cave temple complex. Baodingshan thus constitutes an exceptional example of a devotional ground built to serve as a center of religious healing.

The close association of the *vidyārājas* with Liu Benzun manifests in both word and image at Baodingshan. The coexistence at the site of a textual version of Liu's biography and a pictorial narrative based on select episodes thus allows for a critical comparison. Before we get to the specifics, it is important to note that the textual version has been preserved on an engraved stone stele at another section of the same site called the "Small Buddha Bend" as well as in abbreviated form as captions in the monumental pictorial composition at the main section, the Large Buddha Bend.⁷ As the focus of the stele text, Liu's biography narrates the master's life from birth to death, detailing in particular the ten episodes of self-sacrifice that took place after he quit his job as the county inspector in Jiazhou (today's Leshan) and began his practice in earnest. In each episode, which is called a *lian* (austerity) in the text, Liu responded to a particular problem that he then resolved by sacrificing a part of his body in honor of specific Buddhist deities.⁸ The sacrifices enabled the master to acquire immense healing abilities, which he in turn put to use to help others and as a result accumulated even more merit for himself.⁹

The *vidyārājas* made their presence felt throughout Liu's biography primarily through Mahāchakravajra, or the Diamond Warrior of the Great Wheel, who is referenced twice. The first reference is indirect, made when the text describes how Liu gained magical power through ritual practice in the early part of his life, namely before performing his ten self-sacrifices: "Liu ate vegetarian meals, dressed in paper-thin clothes, and led a very austere life. He concentrated on practicing the Mantras of the Great Wheel in Five Parts, while reciting and memorizing the middle sections of the Yoga sūtras. After several years of practice, he had perfected the rituals."¹⁰ The "Mantras of the Great Wheel" are the incantations and other ritual actions exclusively related to Mahāchakravajra, whose power a practitioner might invoke to achieve certain benefits. A scripture titled "The Three Kinds of Attainment through the Dhāraṇī of the Dharma Gate of the Mind by the Pure Dharma Body of Vairocana" further explains that the mantras of Mahāchakravajra are central to achieving the Lower Attainment (*Sadhārāṇasiddhi*) in esoteric practices, a state of mind that endows the practitioner with the power to perform magical feats such as subjugating demons

and other heavenly beings.¹¹ This was precisely what Liu Benzun did after achieving this state through his practice. According to the biography, on the fifteenth day of the sixth month in 886, he made a vow to the Buddha and made use of the incantations to defeat malicious spirits that had caused epidemics and famine across Sichuan. Two months later, he burned one of his index fingers as an offering to the buddhas in a properly prepared ritual ground at home in Jiazhou while making a vow to deliver all sentient beings from their sufferings and delusions. At that moment, a voice was heard in the sky, urging him to leave his hometown and with his power perform good elsewhere.¹² This episode marks the first of ten austerities that Liu would perform throughout his career.

The second reference to Mahāchakravajra occurs in Liu's sixth austerity, in which the wisdom king appeared in his bodily form as a witness to the master's smelting of his heart, which was carried out in the seventh month of 905 in honor of various buddhas to end all afflictions and delusions for sentient beings. The episode follows more or less the same formulaic pattern underlying the narrative of all of Liu's other austerities. As noted earlier, the master's power rested on his ability to resolve the problem at hand by sacrificing a specific part of his body. In so doing, he combined the role of the victim and that of the sacrificer in achieving the desirable outcome for himself and his followers. A being with supernatural power such as the Buddha or Heavenly King would appear as a witness to each austerity and to each corresponding vow. That Mahāchakravajra participates in the narrative as a witness is a clear indication of his high status within the Buddhist cosmological framework to which Liu Benzun subscribes. More importantly, his presence lends legitimacy to Liu's practice, which became more daring and impactful later in his career as he took on greater challenges by sacrificing additional body parts. By the sixth episode, the master had progressed well beyond the initial stage of relying on incantations related to the *vidyārāja* to defeat demonic troublemakers (as seen in the first austerity) to a more advanced level where he sought to address fundamental conditions at the root of all human suffering. Indeed, one of Liu's greatest achievements was resuscitating a man who had passed away three days earlier by incinerating his own genitals as his ninth austerity. Through this and other sacrifices, the master demonstrated that he was indeed an incarnation of the Buddha Vairocana as he claimed to be, thereby surpassing the *vidyārājas* in status and power.

We now turn to the pictorial representation of Mahāchakravajra and other *vidyārājas* at Baodingshan, part of a highly hierarchical compositional scheme that depicts the "Ten Austerities" of Liu Benzun in four levels (fig. 12.3). The topmost level represents a celestial realm occupied by the Five Jinas (Vairocana, Ratnasmbhava, Amitābha, Akṣobhya, and Amoghasiddhi) and their four emanations in bodhisattva form (Mañjuśrī, Avalokiteśvara, Samantabhadra, and Mahāsthāmaprāpta). Immediately below the top level is the realm of the humans in which Liu Benzun carried out his self-sacrifices, composed of two



Figure 12.3 The Four Levels of Beings in the Ten Austerities of Liu Benzun, Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.



Figure 12.4 Liu Benzun's sixth austerity, from the Ten Austerities of Liu Benzun, Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.

levels. The upper level presents the ten episodes side by side, with the even-numbered ones on the viewer's right and the odd-numbered ones on the left. Like the textual narrative, each episode follows a highly prescribed structure showing Liu at the moment of mutilating himself, accompanied by the corresponding supernatural witness(es). It is in the sixth austerity where we find Mahāchakravajra participating in the action as a witness (fig. 12.4). In addition to the caption that specifies his identity based on the written narrative, the two weapons he holds—a wheel and spear—correspond faithfully to his key iconographic attributes prescribed in pertinent ritual texts.¹³ In the lower level, an additional seventeen human characters from the narrative gather, all facing outward as if in a group curtain call. They flank the two sides of an outsize icon showing the mutilated body of Liu Benzun, which occupies the center, straddling the two levels of the human realm. In the fourth and bottommost level, the collective group of ten *vidyārājas* (Mahāchakravajra is the second from the right) hold court with their imposing bodies. Their dynamic engagement with the viewers in front of them contrasts sharply with the narrative figures from the two levels immediately above, whose still, somewhat uptight manner conveys a sense of psychological distance. The level of viewer disengagement appears to increase as we move farther upward along the cliff face. In the second level from the top, the Liu Benzun in each of the ten austerities is fully absorbed in the action, oblivious to the world beyond the narrative. Likewise, the deified figure of Liu in the middle of the second and third levels gazes out at the viewer with otherworldly disinterest. The Buddhist deities in the topmost level exemplify the highest degree of remoteness from the human realm, as they are farthest from the ground-level viewer. Their detachment is accentuated by the roundels that encase each of the nine deities as well as by the positioning of the entire tier on a perch protruding from the cliff face.

Two observations can be made about the pictorial representation of Mahāchakravajra and other *vidyārājas* that help illuminate the broader discussion on ecological interdependence in Buddhism. The first concerns the considerable fluidity of all beings in transmigrating between realms within the Buddhist cosmological system. The notion of reincarnation through an endless cycle of births and rebirths is central to Buddhism as well as to other major Indian religions, such as Hinduism and Jainism. At Baodingshan in southwest China, the concept was at the heart of the site's pictorial program and overall mission, as it was represented in different versions through the medium of cliffside relief carving. One particularly memorable version is the Wheel of Reincarnation, which depicts the Great Demon of Impermanence, frequently interpreted as Yama, the Lord of Death, holding a large wheel consisting of multiple compartments with symbolic images inside, created along three concentric bands and with six ribbon-like rays of light emitting from the center outward (fig. 12.5). The composition is methodical and cerebral, relying on



Figure 12.5 Wheel of Reincarnation, Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.

simple geometric shapes and numerological groupings of humans, animals, and supernatural spirits to explain how the beings in the six paths of existence relate to one another through the twelve links of dependent origination.¹⁴ Basic conditions in life, such as sadness, ignorance, and desire, are conveyed in vignettes featuring either a single figure striking a particular pose or interactions between two figures. The working of karma, which is foundational to reincarnation, is given a vivid imagery that underscores the interconnectedness between different kinds of sentient beings through transmigration. In the outermost band of the gigantic wheel is a chain of cylinders, each with human

heads at one end and animal feet at the other, as if these beings underwent transformation upon entering the cylinder. Given the conceptual complexity inherent in the composition, it was likely intended as a didactic tool for visitors to familiarize themselves with basic concepts in Buddhism.¹⁵

The Wheel of Reincarnation contrasts tellingly with the ten austerities of Liu Benzun as the latter articulates some of the same ideas through spectacular figures and sensational scenes of violence. The appearance of Liu Benzun both in the narrative sequence of the ten austerities and as a deified icon amply demonstrates the working of karma. In this particular pictorial setting, doing good deeds (however painful) means that one can achieve a better existence in the next life, attain enlightenment, or even complete extinction and release from the world of transmigration. Some of the buddhas and bodhisattvas in the celestial realm (e.g., Vairocana and Samantabhadra) also make appearances elsewhere within the human realm, underscoring their ability to cross boundaries of existence for specific purposes (in the present case, to approve Liu's actions). Likewise, Mahāchakravajra has shown his power to traverse different realms, as he appears in the sixth austerity episode and at the bottom of the entire composition. Interestingly, even though each *vidyārāja* is closely associated with a specific buddha or bodhisattva, he does not belong to the realm of the celestials or that of the humans but rather remains earthbound.

In the Liu Benzun composition the purposeful separation of the realm of the humans from that of viewers points to the possibility that the latter is identified not only with humans but also with any beings in the other paths of existence within the Buddhist cosmos, namely, animals, hungry ghosts, and the inhabitants of hell. In many Mahāyāna texts, human beings and animals are described as living together on the surface of the Mount Sumeru realm; spirits and demonic gods live five hundred *yojanas* (unit of linear measurement equivalent to the distance a cow yoked to a cart could pull) under the earth, and the inhabitants of hell, even deeper.¹⁶ In this light, the *vidyārājas*' placement at the lowest level of the composition, sharing space with the viewers, is especially emblematic of the transmigratory fluidity within the Buddhist system, an a priori condition guaranteeing that all beings do not stay in one form of existence permanently. This concept lends itself to a distinct mode of interpersonal and interspecies relationships, whereby there are incentives to treat others with kindness, and having the awareness that the person or animal that one is in contact with might bear possible kinship connections from previous lives.

The second observation about the pictorial representation of Mahāchakravajra and other *vidyārājas* concerns the local adaptation of Buddhist ideas and practices. As noted above, the Liu Benzun cult was unique to Sichuan, and what we have seen at Baodingshan represents a specific revival of the master's teaching under a self-proclaimed follower named Zhao Zhifeng in the twelfth and thirteen centuries. Zhao's preference for communicating Liu's teaching through

relief carvings at a cave temple complex no doubt contributed to some notable discrepancies between the textual version of the Liu Benzun narrative and the pictorial one. In the case of the *vidyārājas*, although Mahāchakravajra is referenced only twice in the textual narrative of Liu Benzun's ten austerities, he and nine other wisdom kings came to occupy a quarter of the entire pictorial space, constituting one of the three realms of actors that made up the broader cosmological framework underlying the story. The prominent role they assumed in shaping the purpose of the Liu motif was predicated on the perceived potency of the *vidyārājas* in gaining control over a wide range of unruly beings within the Buddhist universe. This ability was made visible by assigning the *vidyārājas* to a liminal position within the Liu Benzun composition, which itself was placed at the outermost edge of the cave site. The subject's doubly marginal placement underscores one key aspect of Buddhist material culture, namely, that the choice of any iconographic motif is inseparable from the spatial context of which it is a part. This correlation between image and place was a feature central to the allure of the cave temple as a setting for a host of ritual activities that involved both human and nonhuman participants.

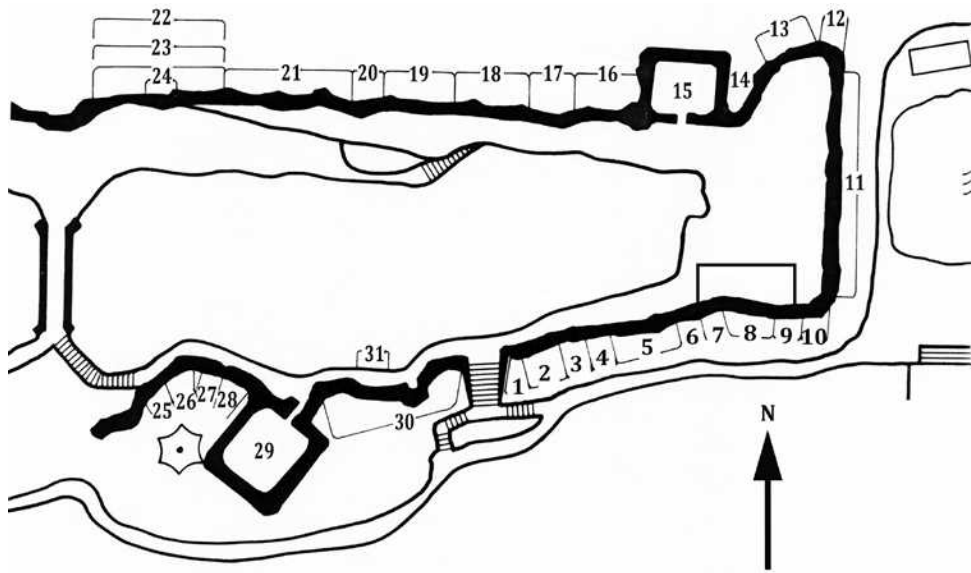
Marginality

As a space marking the interface between nature and culture, cave temples purport to be replete with magical potency endowed by nature, as they are full of dangers for humans who might come in contact with animals and beings from other realms. The in-between nature of these places makes them suitable for their human users to carry out activities that are deemed infelicitous or impermissible in urban settings. Zhao Zhifeng must have recognized the potential for his religious mission, for he chose to build his headquarters as a cave complex on a remote mountain called Baodingshan rather than in a metropolis such as Chengdu, where Liu Benzun was based two centuries earlier. In so doing, Zhao was following the long tradition of Buddhist monks in medieval China who made use of their extraordinary powers to sense the divine in nature in order to help their community connect with these forces through image-making projects.¹⁷ While Zhao's ability to detect the sacred might well have been an innate gift, we also know from founding records of Chinese Buddhist monasteries that monks often relied on traditional geomantic divinational knowledge to determine the proper location for a monastery, and they paid special attention to the morphology of the landscape, the disposition of certain celestial bodies, the presence of certain plants and trees, and other natural features unique to the place.¹⁸ The terms *shi* (meaning "propensity") and *ling* ("numinous" or "efficacy"), the former discussed in greater detail in chapter 9 of this volume, were frequently used by period writers to describe their interaction with a particular

place, and also at times the perceptual processes through which they came to make sense of it.

The remarkable program of cliffside relief carvings created to define the physical space of Baodingshan offers us another means beyond textual records by which to explore the richness in geoaesthetic implications that cave temples possess. My use of the term “geoaesthetic” is strategic in that it aims to highlight the unique characteristics of cave temples. More than other Buddhist monastic complexes composed mainly of timber-framed structures, cave temples were a kind of place that derived their significance not only from their siting in nature but also from the human-made markings that decorated their rocky setting. While it is useful to draw on Gary Shapiro’s use of the term “geoaesthetics” to focus attention on what it means to live on and think with the earth through artificial works made to be part of the earth; the definition of space underlying relief carvings at Baodingshan is rooted in the visual language of Chinese Buddhist material culture.¹⁹ One common strategy is to define space by showing bodies populating a given area or in ensembles of various configurations. When adapted to the topographical particularities of Baodingshan’s U-shaped valley, with its sandstone cliffs measuring about eight meters tall on one side and half that height on the other, this basic formula manifested through a plethora of figures of all sorts and sizes teeming across cliff surfaces to make visible the Buddhist cosmos in different dimensions. The figural multitude was further organized into thirty-one pictorial motifs, each strategically selected, paired up, and designed to facilitate a range of activities in which the devotees would participate under the guidance of Zhao and the more advanced members of the group (fig. 12.6). Within this context, the Liu Benzun composition played a central role in shaping the site’s overall religious purpose and function, as it amplified the potential of the place as a cave temple complex through its professed marginality. Not only did the carvings of the deified master and the *vidyārājas* underscore the site’s particular character as a space straddling multiple realms, they also came to serve as key signifiers of divine power in ways similar to those natural features that compelled visitors to identify the site as *shi* or *ling*.

The strategy of visualizing the Buddhist cosmos in an open landscape marks a notable departure from the traditional understanding of the nature of Buddha images. In early Buddhist stories such as the Great Miracle at Śrāvastī, likenesses that the Buddha created of himself were described as possessing qualities associated with the Buddha, such that these images would act with agency and intention but were distinct from the Buddha.²⁰ Whether the images were made of wood, stone, or gold, their animate quality derived not from the material itself but rather from the Buddha’s unique capacity for creating active copies of himself. This capacity also helps distinguish material images made by the Buddha’s disciples or other Buddhist deities, all of which were supposed to act as an extension of the embodying exemplar.



- | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|
| 1. Prowling Tiger | 17. Thunder and Lightning |
| 2. Nine Protectors of the Law | 18. Sutra of Repaying Kindness |
| 3. Wheel of Reincarnation | 19. Pure Land of Amitayus Buddha |
| 4. Three Immortals | 20. Six Roots of Sensations |
| 5. Three Worthies of Huayan | 21. Hell Tribunals and Punishments |
| 6. Precious Relic Stupa | 22. Ten Austerities of Liu Benzun |
| 7. Vairochana Retreat | 23. Ten Vidyarajas |
| 8. Thousand Armed Avalokiteshvara | 24. Daoist Deities (Qing Addition) |
| 9. Manifested Wall City | 25. Daoist Deities (Qing Addition) |
| 10. Gathering of Humans and Devas | 26. Stele Pagoda (Qing Addition) |
| 11. Buddha's Nirvana | 27. Liu Benzun in His Perfected State |
| 12. Birth of Siddhartha | 28. Roaring Lion |
| 13. Nine Nagas Bathing Siddhartha | 29. Cave of Complete Enlightenment |
| 14. Mahamayuri | 30. Ox and Herdsman |
| 15. Devotional Ground for Vairochana | 31. Two Licchavi Women |
| 16. Sutra on Parent's Profound Kindness | |

Figure 12.6 Distribution of pictorial motifs at the Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Diagram by the author.

At Baodingshan, there are no stories found among in situ records that reveal how images of the Buddha and other figures carved along the cliff faces were understood by the site's users. Yet important evidence about their perceived agency can be found in the wishes inscribed in cartouches adjacent to many of the representational figures, which are a telltale link to their spatial setting. For example, on the underside of the awning above the Five Jinās and their emanations in the Liu Benzun composition (see fig. 12.3), Liu's official title, "Chief Upholder and Patriarch of the Yoga School of the Tang," appears alongside two couplets: "May rain and wind alternate harmoniously / May the

realm prosper and people be safe” on the viewer’s right, and “May Buddha’s light grow brightly / May the wheel of the Dharma perpetually revolve” on the viewer’s left.²¹ The large size of the inscription indicates that the characters were meant to be seen and read aloud by the visitors. The easy orality of the couplet lines and the universal nature of the articulated wishes possessed the quiet power of enticing visitors into uttering them with sincerity and thereby making these wishes their own. Most intriguingly, the peculiar location of the inscription underscores the site-specificity of the visitors’ action: visitors needed to walk underneath the awning and stand in front of the Buddha and all other deities in the composition in order to fully participate in this imagined world with their body and senses. In so doing, the human worshippers thus helped activate these cliffside images as religious icons that could make wishes come true.

It is no coincidence that either the first or both couplets appear at several smaller groupings of cliffside images located strategically along the routes to Baodingshan within a five-kilometer radius of the site’s core area, the Large Buddha Bend. Of the six locations in question, both couplets are repeated at the two closest to the core area, namely, the Small Buddha Bend and Daota; whereas the first couplet is present only at Songpolin, Guangdashan, Zhushishan, and Fozuyan.²² What these outcrops and the Liu Benzun composition have in common is their respective marginal position within the site’s overall design. As noted earlier, the Liu Benzun composition is located at the farthest point from the original entrance of the Large Buddha Bend, which was marked by the Prowling Tiger and Nine Protectors near the middle of the opposite south cliff (see fig. 12.6). Within this spatial layout, the Liu Benzun composition functioned more or less as a marker of the site’s physical and symbolic outer boundary. As at other outcrops with the same couplets, human visitors were encouraged to make wishes to benefit all beings.

As if to amplify the marginal location of the Liu Benzun composition, the builders of Baodingshan placed a much greater emphasis on the intermingling of sentient beings from different paths of existence than on most other themes in the Large Buddha Bend. The Hell Tribunals and Punishments adjacent to the composition is the only other motif that exhibits a similar range of cosmological scope within an equally hierarchical compositional structure (fig. 12.7). The composition’s bipartite structure—the Ten Kings of Hell making judgments of the dead under the watchful eye of Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva in the upper half, and scenes of horrific punishment of the condemned inhabitants of hell in the lower half—echoes the division of the Liu Benzun composition into three horizontal levels that correspond to the realms of the celestials, the humans, and the viewers. The physical contiguity of these two scenes provides another compelling reason to link them together thematically. Seen in this light, the ten *vidyārājas* at the bottommost section of the composition appear to have taken on the job



Figure 12.7 Hell Tribunals (*top*) and Punishments in Hell (*bottom*), Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.



Figure 12.8 Nine Protectors of the Law, Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.



Figure 12.9 Buddha and Eight Protectors of the Law, Zhishishan, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249.
Photograph by the author.

of guarding the boundary of the site while protecting the world of Liu Benzun against any inhabitants of hell who might seek to enter from the adjacent space.

The *vidyārājas*' marginality extends into the space of the viewers as well and encompasses both living human visitors and beings from other paths of existence that roam the open space. Their function is similar to that of the ubiquitous protective guardians inside the Large Buddha Bend and at the various outcrops in Baodingshan's surrounding area. The Nine Protectors near the site's original entrance (fig. 12.8) are an example at the Large Buddha Bend, while a group of eight protectors flanking the central Buddha at Zhushishan is an example from the surrounding area (fig. 12.9).²³ The collective presence of these figures helps define Baodingshan as a site with a series of imagined enclosures whose respective boundaries the visitors would need to cross in succession as they approached from the outside. Symbolically, the guardians convey a perception of the outside world as one ravaged by malicious spirits of all sorts, underscoring the need to expel them by force. But once visitors reached the core area, they were assured by these guardians that the site was free of any potential harmful interference and hence suitable for carrying out ritual activities. Working in tandem with the iconic images of buddhas

and bodhisattvas, the guardians were instrumental in transforming decorated mountain cliffs into proper spaces for religious activities.

The *vidyārājas*, however, are more than typical protective guardians, whose main task was to safeguard the Buddha or the Buddhist dharma from dangers. Their unusual background offers important clues as we ponder their role in the Liu Benzun composition and beyond. Simply put, they are embodiments of the secret knowledge and enlightened wisdom that buddhas and bodhisattvas in the esoteric pantheon shared with them to enable such extraordinary feats. Significantly, for the *vidyārājas* to exercise the awesome power they possess to subjugate any formidable opponents, they must first defeat the demons within themselves, which are often personifications of hindrances such as desire, ignorance, anger, and delusion. Unlike other Buddhist schools, which advocated escape from the defiled world, adherents of esoteric teaching believe that it is critical to embrace imperfections and passions as part of the path toward enlightenment. Hence, some of the *vidyārājas* are believed to have committed horrific deeds or succumbed to cardinal sins in their previous lives. For example, Ucchuṣma, who is doubly represented at the center of the bottom-most level in the Liu Benzun composition as the Fiery Head Wisdom King and as Great Vidyārāja of Impure Traces (fig. 12.10), was once a man full of lustful desires who eventually learned to turn his lustful mind into the fire of wisdom



Figure 12.10 Ucchushma (*left*) and the Great Vidyaraja of Impure Traces (*right*), Large Buddha Bend, Baodingshan, Dazu, Chongqing, 1177–1249. Photograph by the author.

through meditation on different parts of his body.²⁴ As a *vidyārāja*, he wields his power by consuming filth and destroying it with the fire within him. This cleansing capability made Ucchuṣma and the written spells associated with him popular among those who carried out healing rituals to combat diseases such as *gu* poisoning or plagues caused by soldiers who had lost their lives on the battlefield.²⁵ As discussed earlier, in leading up to his first austerity Liu Benzun relied on the spells of Mahāchakravajra to defeat demons that brought about epidemics in Sichuan.

It is beyond the scope of the present study to delve into detail about the *vidyārājas* and their connection to Buddhist medicine. But there is one important lesson from this discussion on their marginality that illuminates the broader topic of ecological interdependence: to connect with other species, it is essential to be at the right place in order to recognize what is in common between us and them. Our example at Baodingshan has shown that cave temples were precisely the ideal kind of setting for Buddhist devotees to reach modalities of perception and imagination that would lead them see the world from the perspective of the other, even that of the most despicable beings, be they *gu* poison or the coronavirus. To see beyond the duality of self and other is a hallmark in esoteric teaching and Mahāyāna Buddhism in general. If we were to look for a provocative comparison in modern genetics, it would be something similar to what Hayles calls “species-in-biosymbiosis,” an idea that recognizes the ways in which different species interpenetrate, for example in the human biome.²⁶ The imagined engagement of the *vidyārājas* with disease-spreading demons and other malevolent spirits thus offers a heady challenge to reconsider human and nonhuman agencies. It can help reset the way nonhuman actors beyond the familiar categories of animals, plants, and nonliving natural elements are construed. Instead of casting them simply as existential threats to humans—a negative characterization prompted by recent advances in artificial intelligence, automation, and biotechnology, the perspectives of premodern Dazu bring greater flexibility to imagining these forces, such that they are no longer seen in stark opposition to but as having the potential of reconciling with and even transforming into their counterpoint.

NOTES

1. Hayles, “Novel Corona.”

2. For discussion on sacred mountains and their unique features, see Hargett, *Stairway to Heaven*, 12–14.

3. Howard, *Summit of Treasures*, 147.

4. *Ibid.*, 160.

5. To be precise, the group of ten *vidyārājas* are located in the Large Buddha Bend at Baodingshan. A group of eight *vidyārājas* can be found at another location at Baodingshan called the Small Buddha Bend.
6. For a concise introduction to Liu's teaching, see Howard, *Summit of Treasures*, 99–108.
7. The earliest extant version, titled *The Biography of Liu Benzun of the Tang*, was written by the monk Zujue of Meishan (1087–1150) in 1140. It was originally inscribed on a stone stele erected at Liu's tomb in Shousheng Monastery in Mimeng, a suburb south of today's Chengdu. The version preserved at Baodingshan was likely made by Zhao Zhifeng and his followers at the turn of thirteenth century. The text has been transcribed and annotated in Chen Mingguang, "Chongxin xiaobu Song ke."
8. For a more detailed discussion of the narrative and related pictorial representations, see Lee, *Temples in the Cliffsides*, 63–88.
9. Raoul Birnbaum (*Healing Buddha*, 34) has noted that self-sacrifice is in fact a prerequisite for attaining healing powers as articulated in the *Lotus Sūtra*.
10. Chen Mingguang, "Chongxin xiaobu Song ke."
11. *Qingjing fashen pilushena xindi famen chengjiu yiqie tuoluoni sanzong xidi*, T18.780a.
12. Chen Mingguang, "Chongxin xiaobu Song ke."
13. *Damiao jingang da ganlu junnu li yanman chisheng fo ding jing*, T19.340c.
14. For more detailed discussions of this motif, see Howard, *Summit of Treasures*, 6–10; and Teiser, *Reinventing the Wheel*, 221–238.
15. Instructions for constructing the Wheel of Reincarnation as a didactic tool are given in Vinaya scriptures such as Yijing's translation, *Genbenshuo yiqie youbu pinaiye*, T23.811a–b. Cited in Howard, *Summit of Treasures*, 6.
16. Sadakata, *Buddhist Cosmology*, 41.
17. See Lee, "Landscape," 244–246.
18. Robson, "Monastic Spaces and Sacred Traces," 48–59.
19. Shapiro, "Territory, Landscape, Garden."
20. Decaroli, *Image Problems*, 162.
21. Translation of inscription based on Howard, *Summit of Treasures*, 56.
22. Dazu shike yishu bowuguan, *Dazu shike mingwenlu*, 194, 195, 197, 200, and 203.
23. The other four locations in Baodingshan's surrounding area that feature images of protective deities are Longtoushan and Sanyuandong to the east, and Pusabao and Yangjiapo to the west.
24. *Lengyan jing*, T19.127a–b; cited and translated in Yang, "Devouring Impurities," 7–8.
25. Yang, "Devouring Impurities," 160–168.
26. Hayles, "Novel Corona."

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CHAPTER 13

Mountains, Waters, and Dharmakāya

Kūkai's Irrigation Projects

Ryūichi Abé

One of the most celebrated achievements of the monk Kūkai (774–835) was his restoration in 821 of the reservoir Mannōike in Sanuki Province (present-day Kagawa Prefecture). Mannō Lake remains the largest irrigation reservoir in Japan today (fig. 13.1).¹ It was the scale of the act's beneficence that triggered the transformation of Kūkai from a mere historical figure into the stuff of legend, the most famous Buddhist saint throughout many centuries of Japanese history. However, modern scholars who have studied Kūkai's work of Mannōike have described it as a "public" work and have separated it from his Buddhist accomplishments.²

In this chapter I argue that Kūkai's Mannōike restoration was a significantly "Buddhist" as well as "public" work. To that end, I first look at the historical context in which Kūkai was appointed by the imperial court as the administrator of the reservoir restoration in 821. Second, I outline Kūkai's Buddhist worldview by focusing on the following cosmological concerns: the material world; the world of sentient beings; Dharmakāya, the ultimate truth in Kūkai's Esoteric Buddhist system that permeates both worlds; and the relationships between these three. Third, with those relationships in mind as the theoretical background, I introduce Kūkai's two essays that express his reading of the mountains and waters in Japan, one on a natural lake and the other on an artificial lake–reservoir. In these two essays, Kūkai grounds his appreciation of natural beauty on foundational Buddhist cosmology and its Esoteric Buddhist variations.³ I hope these three points explain why Kūkai accepted the task of



Figure 13.1 Aerial view of Mannōike, 2019. The reservoir functions not only as a source of irrigation but also as a major attraction for recreationists and sightseers. Reproduced by permission of Mannō City.

restoring Mannō Lake and how he was able to complete the work that presented itself as a particularly challenging hydroengineering endeavor. Fourth and in conclusion, I illustrate how in Kūkai's view of the natural world, his aesthetic concerns were profoundly intertwined with inspiring and mobilizing people for a large-scale hydraulic project.

Kūkai and Mannō Lake

Kūkai (774–835) was born in Byōbugaura in Sanuki Province, or Zentūji City, in Kagawa Prefecture on Shikoku Island in present-day Japan. He belonged to a prominent local aristocratic clan. Mannōike is located about five miles southeast of Zentūji, the temple founded on the site of his birth. He must have been familiar with the geography there from his childhood days. At eighteen, he began his career as an elite student at the National Confucian Academy (*Daigaku*) in the capital. By the age of twenty-four, however, he grew disillusioned with the education at his school whose sole purpose was to train court officials. He then privately took Buddhist vows, joined groups of Buddhist mountain practitioners, and in the following years devoted himself to ascetic practices in the mountains of the Yamato, Kii, and Shikoku regions. When he was thirty years old, Kūkai joined the Japanese diplomatic mission to Tang China in order to study Buddhism there. In the Tang capital of Changan, Kūkai met an eminent Esoteric Buddhist master, Huiguo (746–805), in the Qinglongsi (Blue Dragon Temple) monastery. From Huiguo he received the transmission of both the Matrix Maṇḍala and

Diamond Maṇḍala systems of Esoteric Buddhism. Huiguo passed away only four months after he completed his Dharma transmission to Kūkai. In 806, when he was thirty-four years old, Kūkai returned to Japan.⁴

When Emperor Saga (786–842, r. 809–823) rose to the throne, Kūkai finally received the court's permission to spread Esoteric Buddhism as its Dharma transmission master. However, Saga was primarily interested in Kūkai for his firsthand knowledge of Chinese calligraphy and poetry and not for his Buddhism.⁵ For example, in 814 Saga ordered Kūkai to reside in the Ministry of Central Administration (*Nakatsukasashō*) in the court. Saga's aim was to have his young courtiers study advanced compositional and calligraphic skills under Kūkai in order to improve their abilities to produce official documents in literary Chinese.⁶ In this way Kūkai's mastery of Chinese literature and calligraphy became widely known among the early Heian courtiers and aristocrats.

As stated above, and in contrast to the popular Shingon sectarian claim that Saga was the most powerful supporter of Kūkai's Esoteric Buddhism, Emperor Saga was actually interested only in what Kūkai had learned in China in the arts of poetry and calligraphy. This would seem to support those scholars who have argued that Kūkai's restoration of Mannō Lake was a non-Buddhist, public work. That is, Saga appointed Kūkai to the reservoir restoration because of his knowledge of advanced hydraulic technologies that were available on the continent. True, Kūkai and his diplomatic emissaries relied on the Grand Canal for a large part of their inland travels between the coastal regions of southeastern China and Changan.⁷ And Kūkai may well have had chances to learn about the most up-to-date hydroengineering at the Tang court. However, a careful review of the historical context suggests a different picture, one in which Esoteric Buddhism was intrinsically intertwined with his reservoir project.

Between the years 701 and 704, the governor of Sanuki Province, Lord Michimori, built a large reservoir and named it Mannōike, "The Lake That Quenches the Thirst of Myriads." The reservoir functioned efficiently as a major source of irrigation for rice cultivation in a region of fertile soil but extremely hot and dry weather during the summer months. An earth-filled gravity dam was built in a narrow valley in which the Kanaoka River transitions from the Asan mountain range in the north to the plains of Marugame that spread south to the coast of the Japanese Mediterranean Sea. In 818, a major storm destroyed the Mannōike dam. In 820, Emperor Saga's court ordered the rebuilding of the dam. However, they found the task challenging, and the work of rebuilding the dam stalled.⁸

In 821, the Sanuki provincial government made an appeal to the court requesting that Kūkai be commissioned to restore the reservoir. Kūkai designed the dam to be not simply taller and wider than the original structure (which is

estimated to have been about twenty meters high and eighty meters wide) but also equipped with multilevel drains and aqueducts. Furthermore, he was able to build this robust and refined dam within a short period of time, about three months.⁹ The whole text of the provincial government's petition to the court reads as follows:

Since last year we began the work of rebuilding the dam at Mannōike. However, the work needed is extensive, and the number of people whom we have been able to conscript is too small for the task. The restoration remains far from complete. The monk Kūkai was born in this region. He meditates in the mountains and befriends even birds and animals in the wild. He traveled to foreign lands to study the Buddhist Dharma. He departed our country empty-handed but brought home many fruits from across the seas. Therefore, both lay and ordained people worship him sincerely. When commoners see him even from afar, they rush to him and crowd around him. They come out like clouds rising over the mountains, and they gather around him as if a busy market suddenly appeared. Although he lives in the capital now, people of our region lovingly revere Kūkai as if he were their own parent. Whenever he returns to his homeland, even without properly putting their shoes on their feet, people hurriedly come out of their houses and fervently welcome him. Therefore, I beseech that your majesty's court appoint Kūkai as the administrator for the restoration of the reservoir. We request that your office approve our petition.¹⁰

Throughout the petition, the Sanuki provincial government emphasizes Kūkai's local popularity to mobilize large numbers of people as the reason for the court to make Kūkai the administrator for the restoration. They also explain why Kūkai was unusually popular. First, he was born and grew up in Sanuki Province. Second, he had been renowned as a master of meditative practices in the wild and therefore was familiar with the geography and natural environment of the region. Even birds and animals befriend him in the mountains; likewise, people of the region flocked around him and followed him whenever Kūkai made a homecoming. Third, having traveled to Tang China to study Buddhism, he returned to Japan with much new knowledge. It must be noted, however, that the petition here makes no specific mention of his familiarity with the Chinese hydraulic technology. In short, the petition characterizes Kūkai as a charismatic Buddhist figure who was regarded as the local hero of Sanuki Province.

In the following sections, I show how Kūkai's Buddhist ideas of the natural world and its relationship to humans inspired him to take up the task of restoring Mannō Lake and enabled him to successfully mobilize people to accomplish that task.

The Buddhist View of the Material World and Its Relationship to Sentient Beings

In the first chapter of the *Ten Stages of Abiding Mind According to the Teaching of the Esoteric Buddhist Maṇḍalas* (*Himitsu mandara jūjūshinron*), Kūkai's magnum opus that he composed in 830 in response to a request by Emperor Junna (786–840, r. 823–833), he details his understanding of the natural world, or “mountains and waters” (J. *sansui*, Ch. *shanshui*), the words typically used for the natural world in religious, literary, and historical texts in premodern East Asia. Having squarely grounded himself in the pan-Buddhist cosmology discussed in core scriptures, such as Vasubandhu's *Abhidharmakośa*, Kūkai understands the world as made up of two separate categories: sentient beings (J. *ujō seken*, Ch. *youqing shijian*, Skt. *sattvaloka*) and the material world that supports sentient beings. The “mountains and waters” are the material world, or, literally, the “vessel world” (J. *ki seken*, Ch. *qi shijian*, Skt. *bhājanaloka*) that serves as the “vessel” or “container” to support all sorts of sentient beings in that world.¹¹

Kūkai begins by outlining the Buddhist cosmological idea of galaxies. In the Buddhist “small galaxy,” one counts one thousand world-systems; when one thousand small galaxies come together, they form a “middle galaxy”; and the aggregate of one thousand middle galaxies gives rise to a great chiliocosm. The Buddhist scriptural literature has no system to calculate the vastness of the universe beyond “chiliocosm.” Yet even a chiliocosm cannot exhaust the infinitude of the Buddhist universe. All the countless world-systems that float like dust particles in the empty space of the universe have an identical structure: each of them looks like a gigantic wedding cake (fig. 13.2).¹² This “wedding cake” structure is the material world, the vessel that supports the sentient beings in that world-system.

At the base of each of these wedding-cake-shaped worlds is the “wind realm,” a vast drum-shaped structure whose circumference is 10^{59} *yojanas* and height is 1,600,000 *yojanas*.¹³ On the top of the wind realm rises the “water realm,” another but smaller drum-shaped structure with a diameter of 1,203,450 *yojanas* and a height of 800,000 *yojanas*. On the top of the water realm one finds the “metal realm” that is also drum-shaped and has the same diameter as the water realm. However, the metal realm's height is given as 320,000 *yojanas*. It therefore has less than one-fourth of the thickness of the water realm. The rim of the metal realm surface forms “Iron Circle Mountains” that contain the primordial oceanic water on the surface of the world-system. In the center of the top surface of the metal realm is Mount Sumeru, the cosmic mountain whose square base measures 80,000 *yojanas* across. The physical part of Sumeru is 80,000 *yojanas* high; then the mountain continues to soar high into the nonmaterial realm of emptiness and becomes nontangible for humans.

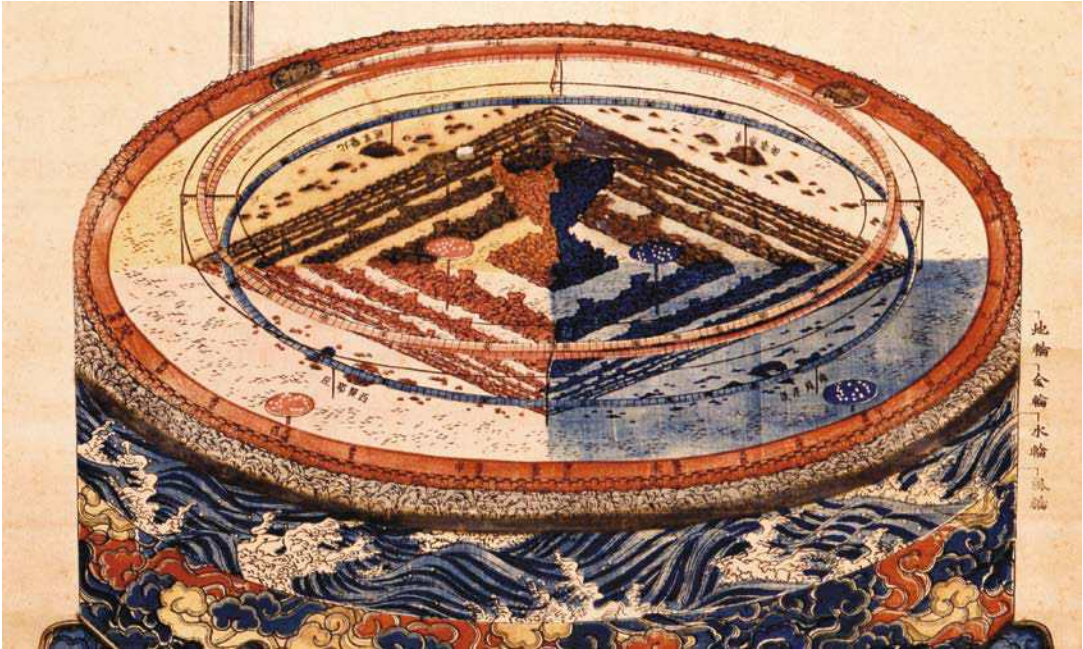


Figure 13.2 Detail of Entsū (1754–1834), *The Model of the Sumeru-Centered Buddhist World-System*, 1813. Woodblock print with hand coloring.

The sun, moon, and constellations circle around the middle part of Sumeru and move around it. At the base of Sumeru are seven concentric picture-frame-shaped square mountain ranges that surround it. They are much lower than Sumeru, and their interstices are filled with water, forming concentric square freshwater lakes. A vast saltwater sea occupies all the expansive space between the seventh (outermost) square mountain range, the Nimiṇdhara Mountains around Mount Sumeru in the center, and the Iron Circle Mountains at the outer periphery of the world. Amid this cosmic ocean, on the four sides of Sumeru, are the four great continents of East, South, West, and North. These four continents, together with the hells underneath each of them, Mount Sumeru, and its surrounding mountains and waters, are the areas where all sorts of sentient beings reside in the Buddhist “wedding cake” model of the world. The higher their habitat, the more superior in their spiritual and moral qualities the sentient beings become. Sumeru and its surrounding mountains are typically identified as realms of gods; humans and animals live on the four continents, and hell dwellers occupy the realms below ground.¹⁴ The closer one gets to Sumeru, the center of the world, the more sublime and beautiful the landscape grows.

Buddhist sources refer to our world-system, in which Śākyamuni Buddha rose to preach the Dharma, as Sahā (J. *Shaba*, Ch. *Suopo*). In the Sahā World, the continent in the south, Jambudvīpa, is where India and other parts of Asia are located—the areas where the Buddha’s Dharma has spread and prospered.

Thus, this continent receives much attention in scriptural descriptions of its geography and inhabitants.¹⁵

According to the *Abhidharmakośa*, each of these wedding-cake-shaped worlds cyclically transforms itself through four phases of change: forming, abiding, declining, and cessation. During the cessation phase, a world-system simply exists as empty space. It takes twenty *kalpas*, or Buddhist eons, for each of the four phases to be completed. When the declining phase is about to end, there occur great cosmic fires, floods, and other disasters. Starting with Sumeru, the most sublime portion of the world, the surrounding mountains and lakes, the ocean, and the four continents disappear one after another. By the time the hellish realms beneath the continents disappear at last, all sentient beings in the world, heavenly beings, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell dwellers also cease to be. Then the entire world, including the gigantic water and wind realms that support the system, vanishes. At that time, the material world, the “vessel world” for supporting sentient beings, loses its *raison d’être* and its phase of cessation begins.¹⁶

All the sentient beings who have lived in that world are transformed into karmic energies. Based on their karmic orientations, they move forward in their transmigratory processes and travel to different places in the universe where the new world-systems are about to form. That is, when a new world-system is about to rise at a location in the universe, various karmic energies from countless ceasing world-systems in other parts of the universe begin to gather at the location of that rising world-system. Because these karmic energies share the common traits that destine them to be reborn as sentient beings in that world-system—henceforth, referred to as World-System X—they are called “common karma” (J. *kyōgō*, Ch. *gongye*, Skt. *sādhāraṇa-karman*). Then these karmic energies draw each other into a gigantic cosmic whirlwind, which in turn gives rise to the drum-shaped “wind realm,” the foundation of World-System X that has just begun its phase of “forming.”¹⁷

After ten *kalpas*, the billowing swirl of winds on the top surface of the wind realm begins to solidify and transforms itself into raging circles of water. This gives rise to the “water realm” of World-System X. Next, on the top surface of the water realm, the violently whirling waves collide with each other until they turn into solid matter. Thus the “metal realm” is formed. In this way all sorts of material elements of World-System X, including the cosmic oceans, four great continents, surrounding mountains and lakes, and Sumeru, the cosmic mountain, come into existence in order to support sentient beings. Then all the sentient beings originally from distant world-systems that went into their cessation phase complete their transmigrations into and populate World-System X. In short, both the material world and the sentient beings of the Buddhist world-system are made of the same “common karma.” That is why the material world in Buddhist cosmology is referred to as the “vessel world” supporting sentient beings there. The material world is prefigured

from its inception to symbiotically support particular sentient beings and serve as the habitat for those who are karmically destined to be born and live in that world.¹⁸

Kūkai's Esoteric Buddhist Reinterpretation of the Material World: The Aesthetics of the Dharmakāya's Permeation

How is it possible for karmic energies to transform themselves into different materials to construct a world-system? The *Abhidharmakośa* and its analogue commentaries—the most essential theoretical texts for the Buddhist worldview that have been studied across different schools and by many generations of scholars in East Asia—answer this question by elucidating the working of the “augmentative power” (J. *zōjōriki*, Ch. *zengshangli*, Skt. *adipātya*) of the common karma. This power combines the four great elements of the universe to create “atoms” (J. *gokumi*, Ch. *jiwei*, Skt. *paramāṇu*).¹⁹ The four great elements—earth, water, fire, and wind—are not identical with the physical phenomena of earth, water, fire and wind. Rather, they represent four different qualities and functions of karmic energies. Earth represents solidness and solidifying function; water, immersion and embracing or “bringing all sorts of things together”; fire, heat and maturing; and wind, flux and development. When the augmentative power of common karma pushes these four great elements against each other, they give rise to atoms. Each atom is a combination of different intensities of the four great elements. Thus, unlike modern physics, Buddhists think of each atom as unique. When seven atoms of unique qualities find mutual affinity, they come together (again, because of the augmentative power) and form a molecule (J. *mijin*, Ch. *weichen*, Skt. *aṇu*). Molecules are considered large enough to be tangible and therefore serve as building blocks of all sorts of matter in the Buddhist universe.²⁰

It is this “augmentative power” that constantly aligns the four great elements with each other and that changes atomic and molecular structures in the process of developing a Buddhist world-system: the wind realm gives rise to the water realm; the metal realm comes out of the water realm; and then mountains and waters and all things in the world come into existence. Soils, for example, are principally composed of the earth element. However, the different combinations they form with the three other great elements make soils vary in accordance with their geographic locations and geological situations.

Thus far, Kūkai in his *Ten Abiding Stages* faithfully follows the arguments developed in the *Abhidharmakośa* and its analogue commentarial literature. For example, he offers the following explanation for the primordial formation of mountains and waters: “All the mountains and oceans are made up of the augmentative power of karma. It first gives rise to great clouds and showers down

raindrops as if they were iron wheel shafts falling from the sky. They pile up high to shape up mountains and carve out the earth to make oceans.”²¹ However, in the last part of chapter 1 of his *Ten Abiding Stages*, Kūkai adds a particularly Esoteric Buddhist variation to these foundational Buddhist cosmological views in order to elucidate the universal permeation of the cosmic Buddha, the Dharmakāya. Basing his variation on a range of Esoteric Buddhist scriptures, Kūkai adds “space” as the fifth great element of the universe to the four great elements of the exoteric Buddhist cosmology, earth, water, fire, and wind. He states, “What gives rise to the five great elements? They all derive from the karma of sentient beings.”²² While he remains faithful to the traditional Buddhist literature in viewing the relationship between karma, the great elements of the universe, and the formation of the material world, Kūkai’s addition of space as the fifth great element changes the dynamics between sentient beings and the material world.

Space represents differentiation (spacing) as its karmic quality, and differentiating things as its karmic function. Space gives rise to the identity or uniqueness of any chosen thing among all things through differentiation, that is, identity deriving from a thing’s differences in relation to all other things. In other words, space obviates the need for an intrinsic essence that would make each thing unique. Obviously, space also stands for the Buddhist truth of emptiness (of intrinsic essence or “self”) and of dependent co-origination (of all things in terms of their mutual and differentiating relations). Thus, in Kūkai’s poetic vision of the wedding-cake-shaped Buddhist model of the world-system, even before the wind realm comes into existence, the invisible yet gigantic drum-shaped “space” realm is imagined to be born as the support of the wind realm, water realm, metal realm, Sumeru, and all the mountains and waters of the world.²³ The space realm of emptiness is the transducer by means of which the energies of common karma manifest their augmentative power in order to give rise to all material existences.

Based on the addition of space, in the later chapters of the *Ten Abiding Stages*, Kūkai asserts that these five great elements constitute the Dharmakāya’s body. By colliding with each other, the five great elements create all things in the world. The Dharmakāya is the creator of the world, and the five great elements are its creative force. At the same time, however, all things in the world are also made up of the five great elements. Therefore, they too are the manifestation of the Dharmakāya. In this sense, Kūkai calls all things in the world the “emanation bodies of differentiating wisdom of the Dharmakāya” (*J. shabetuchi-shin*).²⁴ The creating force and created things in the universe form a nondual relationship demonstrating the perfect permeation of Dharmakāya’s body. In short, while in exoteric Buddhist schools, the Dharmakāya is understood as an abstract, transcendental, intangible reality of emptiness; in Kūkai’s Esoteric Buddhism, the Dharmakāya—representing the same reality of emptiness but as a process of differentiation—is understood as tangible and even organic. Its presence is felt as the permeation throughout the universe of the five

different kinds of karmic energies and also as all the things that are none other than the Dharmakāya's living bodies of the differentiating wisdom.

The five great elements constantly interact with each other to make all sorts of changes in the world; yet the world as a whole sustains its natural equilibrium. While constantly changing each other's interfusion, the five elements as a whole maintain their harmonious, balanced relationship. That is, the entirety of the universe is the Dharmakaya's body in its harmonious cosmic meditation. Each and every thing in the natural world is a part of the Dharmakāya's cosmic body in meditation; like constituting elements in human body, each part works only in relationship to other parts of the Dharmakāya's body. In other words, everything in the world manifests its ultimate reality and contributes to maintaining the cosmic harmony only when its presence is understood as being derived from its difference from all other things, that is, as the Dharmakāya's "bodies of differentiating wisdom."²⁵

It must be noticed that this way of imagining the entirety of the universe as a sacred body weakens or even effaces the distinction between the sentient beings and material "vessel" world that sustains them. Kūkai thus moves on from the Dharmakāya's cosmic body to yet another poetic image: the entirety of the universe as the Dharmakāya's cosmic palace (*J. hokkaigū*).²⁶ This is obviously the most expansive, grandiose, and splendid palace of all the palaces, the vision of which serves as the root inspiration for mandalic art productions in Kūkai's Esoteric Buddhist tradition, the visions in which the Dharma King is surrounded by his buddha and bodhisattva courtiers in concentric and geometric-patterned chambers.²⁷ Even the palaces of Brahmā in the highest region of Sumeru, not to mention the palaces of most powerful human kings, do not compare to the Dharmakāya's palace. Like the cosmic body's constituent parts working together, all things, events, and actions that make up this cosmic palace—the architectural structures and their ornamentation, furniture, lights, art, music, dance, trees, bushes, flowers, and ponds, for example—glorify each other. Kūkai compares the mutual glorification of all things in the palace to the huge transparent jewels of the jewel nets that wrap around Indra's celestial palace, the famous metaphor of the emptiness representing the philosophy of the Flower Garland school. Each jewel's individuality derives from the reflections in that jewel of all other jewels in the network. In the same way, each and every thing in the Dharmakāya's cosmic palace brilliantly manifests the truth of emptiness.²⁸

Seen from this perspective, a pine tree in a mountain, for example, acquires its identity from its difference with all other things. It is *not* a grass, *not* a bush, *not* a hardwood tree. It is intrinsically dependent on things that are not this tree—the soil that gives nutrition to its roots, the mountain's water system, the sun and its movement, the winds that travel through mountains and valleys, the climate system, and so on—that all nurture, sustain, and determine how it grows and what shape it takes. Like a gem in the Indra's jewel net, a pine tree

reflects within itself all other things in its surrounding as the differences from the pine tree. It is these differences that create the pine tree's uniqueness, its own identity. It thus manifests eloquently the Buddhist truth of emptiness. The healthier and more vigorous the tree, reflecting its harmonious yet differentiating interrelationship with other things, the more capable of beautifying its surroundings it becomes. The tree's natural beauty celebrates its dependent co-originating relationship with all other things. It withers and dies when it loses its interdependent relationship with other things. Thus, the tree ceases its celebration of natural beauty; and yet in the very process of its withering and dying, the tree demonstrates the Buddhist truth of emptiness in the sense of the ephemerality of "things"—when "things" are viewed conventionally only as isolated, self-standing things.

In sum, in Kūkai's poetic vision of the universe as the Dharmakāya's cosmic palace, even nonsentient things of the material world, such as mountains, waters, and trees, are able to work like buddhas and bodhisattvas. As emanated bodies of Dharmakāya's differentiating wisdom, they manifest their virtuous qualities and workings most brilliantly when they are able to adorn each other with their own natural splendor. The beauty of nature is intrinsically linked to the permeation throughout the world of the ultimate truth in the form of Dharmakāya's bodily presence and palatial expansion.

Kūkai on Japanese "Mountains and Waters"

Although Kūkai did not leave any writings about Mannō Lake or his experience of restoring it, there are two essays by him, one on a natural lake, and the other on an artificial lake, that illustrate his Buddhist understanding of the waters in a local geographical context. Both were prepared as inscription texts for steles that were erected at the lakes. Both texts are celebrated as among the finest examples of Kūkai's compositions in the classically ornate parallel prose of the Six Dynasties.²⁹

His first essay is titled "Introduction to and Laudatory Prose and Poem for the Monk Shōdō and His Practice in the Mountains and Waters" (*Shamon Shōdō sanzui wo hemegurite genju wo migaku no hi narabi ni jo*).³⁰ Kūkai composed this work in 814 at the request of a certain scholar-official named Iyo of the Shimotsuke Provincial Governor's Office. Shōdō (735–817) was a monk celebrated for his mountain asceticism and a local hero of Shimotsuke Province (corresponding largely to the present-day Tochigi Prefecture), which at the time constituted the northeastern frontier of Japan. He was particularly known for his success in climbing Futara Mountain (presently known as Nantaizan at Nikkō) in 782 and turning the mountain and its surrounding areas of wilderness into the ground for religious practices. Shōdō's sacred land includes the three lakes to the south, west, and north of the mountain (fig. 13.3). The South Lake (presently, Lake



Figure 13.3 Futara Mountain (Nantaizan) and the South Lake (Chūzenjiko) in Nikkō, 2017. Reproduced by permission of the Tochigi Prefecture Travel Bureau.

Chūzenji) is particularly renowned for its vastness and splendid beauty. Shōdō built a temple (presently, Chūzenji) on the shore of the lake in 784.³¹

Although there are no records that suggest Kūkai knew Shōdō personally, in the essay, Kūkai states that he had been befriended by Iyo. Iyo seems to have chosen Kūkai for composing Shōdō's eulogy because Kūkai was well known as an expert of mountain practices and also for his talent for producing belles lettres.

Kūkai opens the essay by stating that in India, the Buddha and bodhisattvas resided on Eagle Peak and other sacred mountains to deliver their Dharma teachings, and that lakes in the mountains, such as Anavatapta, the legendary Himalayan lake celebrated for the purity of its water, have been attracting gods and sacred beings, such as Dragon Kings, to benefit living beings with their water supply. Turning his attention to the land of Japan, Kūkai states that in Shimotsuke Province is Mount Futara, which soars high as if to reach the Milky Way. Thus, Futara and Mount Sumeru are good friends; and the lower mountain ranges surrounding Futara are like the Iron Circle Mountains and other mountain ranges that surround Sumeru.³²

Kūkai then turns to a biography of Shōdō's early years in Shimotsuke and his two failed attempts to climb Futara. On the third month of the second year of Ten'ō (in the Japanese calendar year that corresponds to 782), Shōdō made the following vow at the base of the mountain: "I pledge that I will bring up all the Buddhist scriptures I have copied and Buddhist icons I have produced to the top of the mountain. I will make [a] sincere offering to them at the mountaintop in order to pacify the powerful yet violent gods of the mountain, benefiting all sentient beings. I beseech all benevolent gods to protect me, dragon kings to chase away fogs and mists, and mountain sprites to guide my way

to the summit. Unless and until I reach the mountaintop, I will never attain my enlightenment.”³³ Having made this pledge, Shōdō began his climb when white snow covered the land, and reached the steep cliffs in the middle of the mountain when all the trees began to shine with their freshly green leaves. However, he was then exhausted from his climb and could not go farther. After he rested for two nights and regained his energy, he was able to see the summit for the first time. Then, finally, he reached the summit. Having stayed there for twenty-one days, he was able to complete all the ritual offerings and fulfilled his original pledge.

Kūkai then describes the beauty of the panoramic view that Shōdō enjoyed from the mountaintop: Futara is comparable to Sumeru in its grandeur; the mountains surrounding Futara are like the cosmic mountain ranges circling Sumeru; and the three lakes to the south, west, and north sides lie on a flat land between Futara and its circle mountains—these lakes are comparable to the four sides of the six-fold square freshwater ocean around Sumeru. In short, Kūkai resorts to a topological metaphor of the Sumeru-centered Buddhist cosmology in order to praise the sublime beauty of Futara and its surroundings. By means of this metaphorical comparison, Kūkai succeeds in eulogizing Shōdō’s superhuman accomplishment of Buddhist pacification of Futara’s wilderness. Shōdō’s work is measured in the cosmological scale and given a cosmic significance.

Implicit here is the basic Buddhist idea that both mountains and waters came into existence simultaneously by means of an identical process. As we saw earlier, according to the *Abhidharmakośa*, when the primordial torrential rain falls on earth so intensely it seems as if iron wheel shafts are dropping vertically from the sky, it gouges out the ground and makes lakes and oceans. At the same time, the raindrops compress themselves so tightly they pile up to engender mountains. In short, both mountains and waters are cogenerative, deriving from the augmentative power of common karma.

In other words, the unsurpassed beauty of Futara Mountain and its surrounding lakes result from the superlative quality of the common karma that gives rise to this particular landscape in a manner replicating the topology of Mount Sumeru and its cosmic environs. This in turn explains why the beauty of the land attracts gods—and only a few spiritually gifted humans like Shōdō who seek communication with gods via their Buddhist practices—to Futara and its lakes.

In his discussion of Futara’s natural beauty, and to justify Shōdō’s choice of the site on the lakeside to build his temple, Kūkai details the beauty of South Lake:

South of the mountain is a great lake. When it reflects Futara Mountain and all other mountains around it within itself, complete with exquisite views of all the rocks and trees, silvery snow in winter, and golden flowers in

summer on the mountains, it enhances the beauty of all the mountains. . . . The mirror of the lake is utterly selfless. Therefore, it holds together all myriad forms of the world within itself. . . . Observing the perfectly round moon in the lake, practitioners realize the mirror-like wisdom of Bodhisattva Samantabhadra; looking up to the sun of radiant wisdom in the sky, they understand that all-pervading enlightenment is already in themselves.³⁴

Kūkai suggests here that South Lake is capable of “bringing together” within the lake water’s reflections a number of elements of Mount Futara and its natural environment because the lake is replete with the karmic function of the great element water—which, as we saw in the previous section, acts to “bring together myriad different things.” Citing this ability of the lake’s water as evidence, Kūkai asserts that South Lake itself manifests the “mirror-like wisdom,” one of the five great wisdoms of enlightenment of the Dharmakāya Buddha, the light of which glorifies the Buddha’s cosmic palace. It is the wisdom of seeing things as they really are, the wisdom personified by Bodhisattva Samantabhadra.³⁵ All the different things of the world, when reflected together on the great mirror of South Lake, manifest their true nature as the Dharmakāya’s differentiated bodies and demonstrates the Dharmakāya’s permeation of the world.

Therefore, meditating on the lake’s water and the round moon in it guides practitioners toward enlightenment. And observing the sun—the major celestial metaphor for the Dharmakāya, especially its personification as Mahāvairocana (Great Radiating One) Buddha—that illuminates equally with its rays all things on Mount Futara and its surroundings, practitioners realize that they too are endowed with the auspicious rays of enlightenment that permeate all things. Kūkai’s discussion here brings readers’ associations back to Samantabhadra, because in the bodhisattva’s name, the word *samanta* means “all-permeating,” and the world *bhadra* indicates “auspiciousness.” Kūkai thus doubly connects the bodhisattva with the great element water’s karmic function of bringing myriad different things together, on the one hand, and South Lake’s ability to encapsulate all the natural elements on Mount Futara and its surroundings in its reflections, on the other. In this way, Kūkai justifies and praises Shōdō’s choice of this lakeside venue with a splendidly beautiful landscape for founding a temple and practicing Buddhism.

Kūkai also pays attention to the sounds of South Lake. About the water birds that fly down from the mountain to visit the lake, he states, “White cranes dance on the beach; mandarin ducks play with waves. Their flapping wings echo like bells, their chirping turns into the sounds of jade flutes.” He then continues, “Winds caressing trees on the mountain slopes are lute players, waves rushing into rocky shores on the base of the mountain are drummers. These sounds surpass all the notes of the five musical scales and turn themselves into heavenly music.” Here again Kūkai underscores the mutually complementary

relationship between the mountain and the lake in integrating all sorts of different natural sounds into a sublime heavenly music. His attention to the sounds of South Lake is inspired by his vision of the entirety of the universe as the Dharmakāya's cosmic palace with its interior permeated by most sublime heavenly music.³⁶

In the last section of his essay, Kūkai states that Emperor Kanmu (737–806, r. 781–806) recognized Shōdō's work of spreading the Dharma in northern Japan and appointed him to the post of provincial master of Kōzuke (roughly corresponding to present-day Gunma Prefecture). Then Kūkai describes Shōdō's monumental act of performing a rainmaking ritual on Mount Futara in 807 when the nation of Japan suffered a widespread drought: "At the drought, the provincial governor appointed Shōdō for the task of rainmaking. Shōdō immediately climbed Mount Futara and prayed for rain at the mountaintop. Gods gathered around him, Buddhas deepened their compassion in the lake. Sweet rain thoroughly quenched the earth; all the crops rose again to promise a bountiful harvest. It is simply beyond words how sublimely Shōdō's prayer caused all the Buddhas to work on saving beings."³⁷ Kūkai's eulogy here makes it obvious that Shōdō succeeded in his rainmaking ritual because he performed it at Mount Futara, the cosmological replica of Mount Sumeru in the land of Japan, where karmically cogenerated mountains and waters work together to respond to his prayer. The gods who reside on Mount Futara bring rainclouds to the nation; Buddhas' compassion energizes the lake to intensify the karmic energy of its water and pervade the nation with that great element. Kūkai underscores Shōdō's earlier heroic climbing of the mountain and placing Buddhist scriptures and images on its summit as his Buddhist rereading and rewriting of the wilderness. Shōbō made this area of untouched majesty accessible for practicing Buddhism. That, in turn, enabled him to successfully perform a rainmaking ritual at Futara at the time of the nation's crisis.

Kūkai on Constructing a Reservoir

In 822, only a year after Kūkai restored Mannō Lake, the court commanded that a large reservoir be constructed in Kashihara County in Yamato Province. The counselor of the court, Fujiwara no Otsugu (773–843); the governor of Yamato Ki, no Suenari (781–826); and the Kōfukuji monk Shūen (771–835) were appointed administrators for the project. In 825, when the reservoir was completed and named Masudagaike, or Masuda Lake, Emperor Junna ordered Kūkai to compose a prose piece and a poem to be inscribed on a gigantic stele located on a steep hill overlooking the new reservoir.³⁸ I support the claim repeatedly made by foregoing studies that Kūkai advised the work of constructing Masuda Lake

on the following grounds: the construction of Masuda Lake began right after Kūkai completed his restoration of Mannō Lake; Masuda Lake was comparable to Mannō Lake in its scale; like Mannō Lake, Masuda Lake was made by an

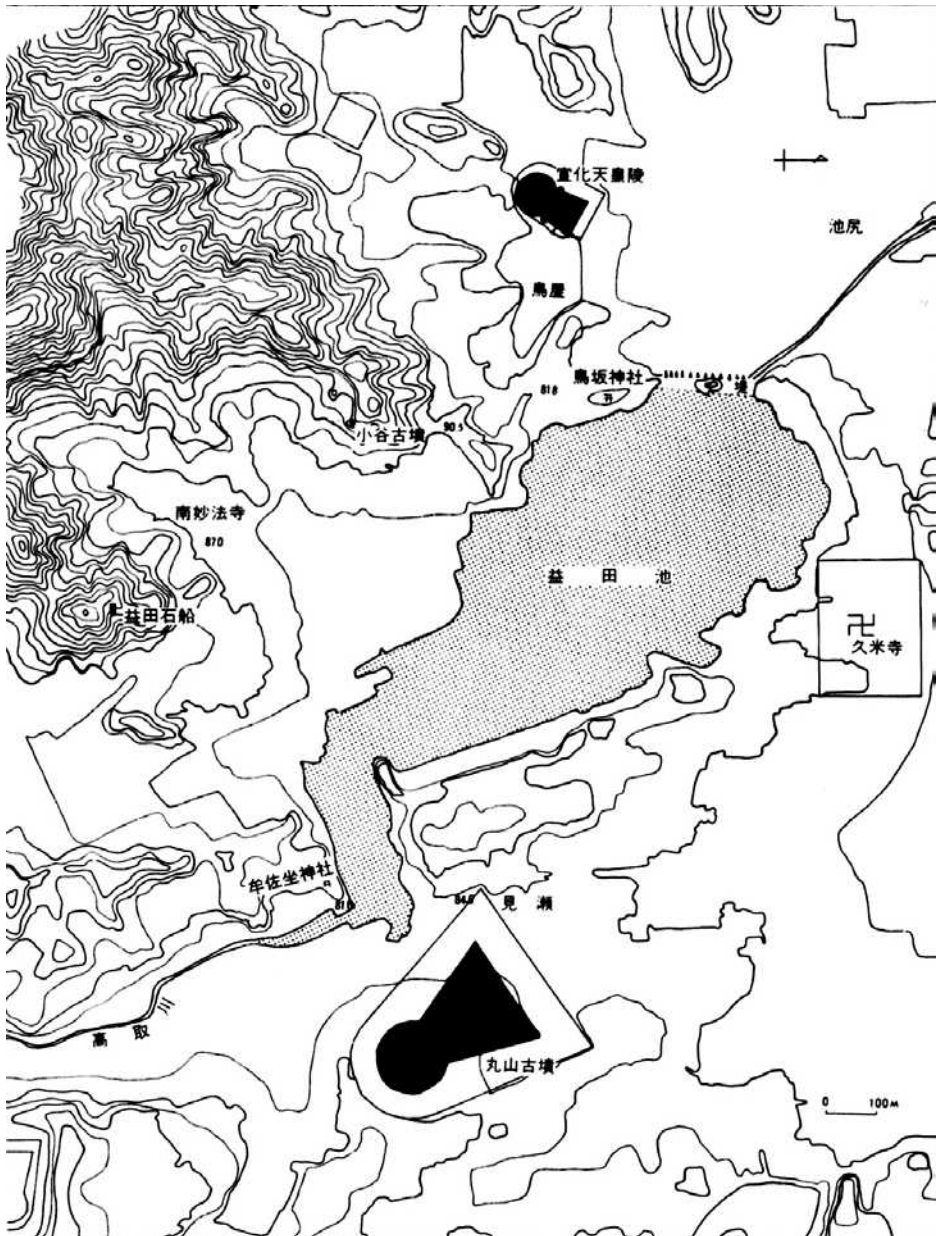


Figure 13.4 The area of the Masuda Lake (in grey) on the current Japanese map of Asuka. A small keyhole shape in black to the west of the lake is the mausoleum of Emperor Senke; the large keyhole shape in black to the east of the lake is Maruyama Kofun, the mausoleum of an ancient unknown ruler. Masuda no Iwafune (益田岩船) is on the hill south of the lake. The ancient Buddhist temple Kumadera (久米寺) is north of the lake. Reproduced by permission of Kashihara City.

earth-filled gravity dam; and Fujiwara no Otsugu was Kūkai's major patron.³⁹ In addition, Shūen was one of Kūkai's most important allies in the Buddhist community, and Kūkai details the construction processes of the reservoir in the stele inscription.⁴⁰

Masuda Lake was located near the ancient temple of Okadera (Ryūgaiji) in Asuka and existed until around 1575 as one of the largest reservoirs in Japan (fig. 13.4). It was renowned for its scenic beauty. It attracted many celebrated *waka* poets, including Sei Shōnagon (fl. 1000), Miya no Koben (fl. 1032–1055), Emperor Juntoku (1197–1244), and Ichijō Kanera (1402–1481). In fact, the word *masudagaike* was adopted and circulated among the circle of poets as *utamakura*, the poetic phrase to evoke Yamato Province, the birthplace of the Yamato dynasty's reign over the land of Japan.⁴¹

Today a huge housing development occupies the area that was once Masuda Lake. Only a part of the original dam remains. A few long wooden aqueducts were recovered from the dam site. The stele was destroyed in the sixteenth century in order to recycle the rock to build the foundation of a castle on the mountain nearby. On a steep slope of a hill overlooking where Masuda Lake was, a huge trapezoid-shaped rock base with curved sides named Masuda no iwafune, or “the Stone Boat of Masuda,” with two deep rectangular holes in the middle of it, the holes into which the bottom tips of the stele slab were inserted, is all that remains on the original site of the stele (fig. 13.5).⁴²



Figure 13.5 Masuda no iwafune, the base stone for the Masuda Lake stele, Kotenseki Database, Waseda University. *Yamato meisho zue* (1791).



Figure 13.6 The opening section of Kūkai's Masuda Lake inscription, a copy of the stele rubbing, Shakamon'in, Kōyasan, National Diet Library, Japan, mid-Heian period. Kikui Rihei, ed., *Masudagaike himeichō* (Tokyo: Seikadō, 1903).

Although the stele for the artificial lake was destroyed in the sixteenth century, a copy of a rubbing of its inscription has been preserved.⁴³ It shows the uniquely eclectic calligraphic style of *zasshotai* (Chi. *Zashuti*) chosen by Kūkai himself for stele inscription (fig. 13.6). Specialists on Japanese calligraphy have praised this work as among the most sublime examples of Kūkai's calligraphic creations. Kūkai was renowned for his mastery of diverse calligraphic styles. In the inscription, he integrates several archaic Chinese calligraphic styles within his *zasshotai* by giving each character a suggestion of water's movement, its fluid, amorphous freedom. It seems not accidental that Kūkai chose this style of characters for exalting Masuda Lake.⁴⁴

Although it is beyond the scope of this chapter to give a detailed analysis of Kūkai's *zasshotai* calligraphy, I believe that he chose this particular application of the *zasshotai* style for this occasion in order to visually present his philosophical, aesthetic, and poetic visions of waters in the context of the Dharmakāya's cosmic permeation, the visions that he literarily expressed in his inscription essay. In place of a full-scale analysis, I suggest the possibility that Buddhist theories of reading aesthetic values in geographical and geological features prefigure the development of a wide range of visual arts in Buddhist societies in East Asia. Kūkai's *zasshotai* calligraphic work can well be understood as a superb example of this approach to the Buddhist aesthetics of the natural world.

In his prose essay "Introduction to and Laudatory Prose and Poem for the Masuda Lake in Yamato Province" (*Yamato no kuni masudagaike hi mei narabi ni jo*), Kūkai points out that although Masuda is an artificial lake, it radiates a beauty comparable to that of the most splendid natural lake:

When [the] Lords of Fujiwara and Ki ordered the work under the Emperor's auspices, several thousands of men and women gathered. Night and day, with countless horses and carts, they piled up earth as if snow accumulating endlessly in a winter storm. The dam rose quickly to the sky as if clouds billowing up from within a valley. . . . The water of the lake embraces the whole heaven; all the surrounding mountains that are shaped like tigers and dragons are reflected in the water upside down. Vast and deep, it is as limpid as a mirror. . . . All sorts of water birds are drawn to the lake's beauty. Their songs fill the air over the water and their dances adorn the shore. Turtles and fish abound in the lake and sport in the water. Brocades of spring flowers and autumn leaves doubled in the lake draw people from far and wide.⁴⁵

Against the background of Kūkai's understanding of Buddhist cosmology, this passage reads as his effort to equate the collective action of the men, women, and animals who took part in piling up earth to create the dam to the "common karmic energy" that engenders mountains, waters, and all in the primordial world. The goodwill of people caused their excellent common karmic work; therefore, the resultant lake is endowed with an unusual beauty ordinarily enjoyed only by sublime natural lakes. Kūkai's description of the mirrorlike quality of Masuda Lake, with its ability to beautify its surroundings accentuated by the cacophony of birds singing and fish playing in the lake, parallels his depiction of Shōdō's South Lake. It seems that Kūkai is suggesting that surrounding mountains and hills, in their power to hold water from overflowing, do the same work as a man-made dam. Therefore, the topology of Masuda Lake stands as an excellent example of complementary work between natural events and human actions, both of which ground themselves in the "common karma" and its augmentative power: "Whether it is a natural lake or man-made lake, there is no difference in its power to irrigate land; redolent with compassion and virtue, the lake spreads wide the Buddha's wisdom; just like rain, it saturates all things with life, just like spring, it leads people to prosperity. . . . With its majesty, Masuda Lake surpasses the celebrated Kunming Lake in China and rivals even the Anavatapta Lake in the Himalayas."⁴⁶ Kūkai here develops his argument for the nondistinction between an artificial lake and natural lake, both of which exhibit exquisite grace. With their beauty serving as evidence of the sublime quality of the common karmic energy that makes up the lakes, they are equally superior in performing their "Buddhist" acts of saving beings by supplying water, the source of their life and well-being. Placed in the framework of the Buddhist cosmology, the statement in the phrase "redolent with compassion and virtue, the lake spreads wide the Buddha's wisdom" should be taken not as a hyperbolic eulogy but as an indication of how Kūkai literally understood the significance of constructing Masuda Lake as it was being completed.

Kūkai boldly states that Masuda Lake is superior to the Kunming Lake in Changan, arguably the most celebrated grand-scale artificial lake in East Asia.⁴⁷ Furthermore he declares that Masuda Lake competes squarely even with the legendary Anavatapta Lake. Paraphrasing the *Abhidharmakośa* and a wide range of foundational Buddhist scriptural sources, Kūkai describes Anavatapta in the first chapter of his *Ten Abiding Stages*.⁴⁸ He states that Anavatapta Lake is located on the north side of the Himalayas; its water is constantly cool and limpid, therefore its name is the “Lake of No Heat-Distress.” The lake serves as the fountainhead of the four great rivers of Jambudvīpa, and therefore as the source of life for all sentient beings on the continent. In the scriptural commentaries that are particularly popular in East Asia, Anavatapta Lake is described as a part of the earth that is none other than an advanced seventh-stage bodhisattva, and the lake manifests itself as a dragon king by the same name, Dragon King Anavatapta, the leader among the eight dragon kings who protect the Dharma.⁴⁹ For Kūkai, although Masuda Lake is a man-made lake, it is not inferior to Anavatapta in its bodhisattva work of quenching the land, saving beings from the suffering of thirst, and promising them the bounty of nature at the autumn harvest.



I hope that the foregoing discussions have made it possible to understand Kūkai’s restoration of Mannō Lake as a superb Buddhist work—on top of being an excellent hydraulic public work of the time. In addition to being an exceptionally charismatic monk in his home region of Sanuki, Kūkai must have been able to mobilize people by giving them his message that restoring Mannō Lake was an important religious work that would bless its participants. Rebuilding the dam at Mannō Lake was like building a temple. In 821 people of the Sanuki region got a chance to work with their local hero in this exemplarily merit-accruing project. These lines of thinking explain why Kūkai was able to attract such a large number of participants to the project and so quickly complete a task of restoration that both the provincial government and the central court found particularly challenging.

In addition to helping local people by securing a source of irrigation, the work also glorified and beautified their land. Through Kūkai’s Buddhist interpretation on the significance of reestablishing a reservoir, the lofty images of Anavatapta Lake or the freshwater lakes surrounding Sumeru suddenly became familiar and relevant to the region. The aesthetic value of the lake is of central importance in Kūkai’s thought because the lake’s beauty is the testimonial for the ideal symbiotic relationship between the human and the nonhuman: the surrounding mountains and hills work together with the man-made dam in holding water for irrigation; the resultant lake exalts the scene by reflecting the mountains and its vegetation, doubling their seasonal beauty; and water birds and water-dwelling animals further accentuate the lake’s scenic attraction.

All these processes stand as proof that Kūkai carried out his reservoir construction and restoration to replicate the Buddhist cosmological creation of primordial mountains and waters that prepare the material world to be a suitable habitat for sentient beings, following the idea that the common karmic energies of transmigrating beings transform themselves into both the material “vessel” world and into all sentient beings who colonize that world. In other words, in Kūkai’s Buddhist vision, successfully completing an irrigation project required not only a sufficient workforce and a certain amount of hydraulic technology. More importantly, it needed the rightly motivated participants and their appropriate “common karmic” energies, which resulted in beautifying not only the lake but also everything in its natural environs. This aesthetic valuation of the material world is the means by which geographic and geological features of the land turn into the indicators of the Dharmakāya Buddha’s permeation, his emanation bodies (i.e., all sentient and nonsentient existences in a world system) that make up that Buddha’s boundless cosmic palace.

To reiterate, according to Kūkai, all things in the universe, both sentient and nonsentient, are equally the Dharmakāya Buddha’s manifestations. There is one remaining question: What makes it justifiable for Kūkai, then, to single out and prioritize mountains and lakes over other geographic features? In one of his works he states that although the Dharmakāya, as vast as empty space, is the ultimate reality, it would not enable sentient beings to observe its physical presence as a “Buddha.” The infinite Dharmakāya Buddha does not allow people to see the Buddha’s individual face and, as a result, does not help rouse them in their faith. Therefore, Kūkai argues, all the images of buddhas and bodhisattvas are revealed as expedient means to guide beings.⁵⁰ In the same way, all the written texts can be understood as material manifestations of the Dharmakāya. However, esoteric Buddhist scriptures distinguish themselves because they describe the ways to read elements of sentient and nonsentient realms as manifestations of the Dharmakāya. Then it can be argued that the essays of Kūkai discussed in this chapter identify particularly grandiose mountains and scenic lakes as effective pointers to the Dharmakāya’s presence, pointers that bring to the fore the Buddhist worldview in the geographical and geological features of localities.

Kūkai’s effort to see in the beauty of the material world the presence of the Dharmakāya—and by extension the cosmic Buddha’s innumerable buddha and bodhisattva emanations—may have wide-ranging parallel developments in Buddhist literary and art traditions throughout East Asia: in the poems of the great Tang dynasty poet Wang Wei, in which his depiction of natural beauty and Buddhist teaching converge, in the Song and Yuan paintings of the White-Robed Guanyin who manifests herself sitting on rocky summits and immersing herself in the beams of the full moon, and in poems of the medieval Japanese monk Saigyō that unreservedly praise the short-lasting beauty of cherry blossoms in the mountains and valleys of Yoshino immediately come

to mind. It took diverse local, cultural, and historical variations for Buddhists to become aware of and then discover the deep connections between the beauty of the material world and the Buddhist teachings. The discussions presented here suggest that the Buddhist worldview and its theory of karma can well be the common threads that run through these diverse developments.

NOTES

Abbreviations

NSNK = Kuroita Nobuo and Morita Tei, eds. *Nihon shiryō nihon kōki*. Tokyo: Shūeisha, 2003.
T = *Taishō shinshū daizōkyō* volume number, page number, register, and line number(s).
TKDZ = Kōbō Daishi chosaku kenkyūkai, ed. *Teihon Kōbō Daishi zenshū*. 11 vols. Kōyasan: Kōyasan daigaku mikkyō bunka kenkyūjo, 1996–1997.

1. The present-day Mannōike occupies the area of 142 hectares, and its perimeter is 20 kilometers. With its dam that is 155 meters wide and 32 meters high, the reservoir irrigates 4,600 hectares of agricultural land. Its source is the Kanakura River. For a description of Mannōike's hydraulic function and its history of maintenance from 1950s, see Tsuji, "Sengo Kagawa."
2. See, for example, Watanabe and Miyasaka, *Shamon Kūkai*, 170–174. Watanabe and Miyasaka's book is the standard for the modern Kūkai biography representing the Shingon school's sectarian reading of his life. Yet they discuss Kūkai's restoration of Mannōike as the exemplar of his "social work." See also Wakiya and Watanabe, "Chiiki kassei-ka," 1033–1034; and Kameda, *Nihon kodai chisuishi*.
3. For an example of a study that treats Buddhist philosophy's approach to natural beauty, see Eckel, "Is There a Buddhist Philosophy of Nature?" See also Swearer, "An Assessment of Buddhist Eco-Philosophy." However, these foregoing studies primarily concern Buddhism and natural beauty from the point of view of contemporary ecology and have not addressed the Buddhist cosmological ideas that this author sees as the foundation for the Buddhist understanding of natural beauty.
4. For Kūkai's biography, see Hakeda, *Kūkai*, 13–60. See also Abé, *Weaving*, 2–23, 71–76, 114–117. For a history of Zentsūji, see Matsubara, "Zentsūji."
5. For Saga and Chinese culture, especially Chinese literature, see Kitayama et al., *Nihon kodai*.
6. TKDZ, 6:251; 7:112–113.
7. In his liturgy written in 821 for the memorial service of Fujiwana no Kadonomaro, who served as the Japanese ambassador to Tang China and to whom Kūkai was an attendant on their way to Changan, Kūkai states that Kadonomaro's embassy traveled from Fuzhou to Changan on land and by way of "three waterways," namely, the Yangtze, the Grand Canal (Tongjiqiu and Shanyangdu), and the Yellow River. See TKDZ, 8:110–111. For Kūkai's travel routes in Tang China, see Takagi, *Kūkai*, 34–50. For an updated history of Grand Canal and its technological innovations, see Tan, *Technical History*.

8. NSNK, 798. The early history of Mannōike is described in a number of disparate and fragmentary primary sources most of which derive from periods much later than Kūkai's day. The dam was destroyed in the late Heian period and was not rebuilt until the early Tokugawa period. For a rigorous comparison of these sources for authenticity and reconstruction of a reliable history of Mannōike, see Terauchi, "Kōbō daishi."
9. For a computer-aided attempt to reconstruct Kūkai's rebuilding of the Mannōike dam and his innovations for setting the dam drain and aqueducts, see Ōbayashigumi purojekuto chimu, "Mannōike." The court appointed Kūkai as the administrator for restoring Mannō Lake on the twenty-seventh day, fifth month of Kōnin 12 (821). On the seventh day, ninth month of the same year, he already returned to Takaosanji, the temple of his residence near the capital, and performed a grand mass there. *TKDZ*, 8:108–110.
10. NSNK, 798. Unless otherwise noted, all the quotes in this chapter from Asian language primary sources are my translations. Paragraph breaks in the quote are mine.
11. *TKDZ*, 2:12–13. The corresponding discussion of the "vessel world" can be found in the following section of *Apidamo jushelun* T29.57a, the Chinese translation of the *Abhidharmakośabhāṣyam*.
12. However, despite their identical structure, these world-systems differ from each other because the "common karma" of the sentient beings in each of these worlds is unique. According to the *Vimalakīrti Sūtra*, for example, in some world-systems, scent serves as the language of sentient beings, and in others, lights, colors, Bodhi-trees, and waters are their languages. T14.552a–553c.
13. Based on a passage in the *Abhidharmakośa* and its commentarial sources, Hirakawa (*Gusharon*, 124, 129–132) calculates one *yojana* as a distance just short of eight kilometers. Following discussions on Buddhist numerical units in *Jingang borejing zanshu* (T33.143c) and *Jingang bore boluomijing poquzhe buhuai jiaminglun* (T25.889b), I have translated the word *asōgi* (Ch. *asengqi*; Skt. *asamkhyā*) as 10⁵⁹.
14. *TKBZ*, 2:12–16. T29.57a–58a.
15. *TKBZ*, 2:12–16. Kūkai here references the discussion of the continent in the following scriptural sources: *Qishijing* (T1.311c), *Dazhidulun* (T25.105b), *Yujia shidelun* (T30.287b), *Shunzheng lilun* (T29.516).
16. T29.62b–63a.
17. T29.57a. Also see Kūkai's paraphrased discussion in *TKDZ*, 2:13–14. For a detailed discussion of "common karma" and its role in engendering the "vessel" world, see *Apidamo dapiposhalun*, T27.106c–107a. The Sanskrit text of this section is also useful in understanding the role of karma in forming the material world, an aspect of karma that is often overlooked in modern Buddhist studies. See Pradhan, *Abhidharmakośabhāṣyam*, 158–160.
18. T29.63a–64a. For Kūkai's adoption of this idea, see *TKDZ*, 2:13.
19. The *Abhidharmakośa* states separately that the augmentative power creates all things in the material world, and that the four great elements give rise to the atoms and then molecules. However, other Abhidharma texts expound these points and specifically talk about the augmentative power as the sources of the four great elements and as the cause for the simultaneous rising of the great elements' functions and the atoms. See, for example, *Apidamo shunzheng lilun*, T29.444c; and *Dasheng apidamo zajijun*, T31.770a.

20. T29.3b–c, 8c–9a, 18b–19a, 57a, 57b–c, 59a. For a detailed discussion of the relationship between the four great elements and the Buddhist atoms and molecules, see *Apidamo dapiposhalun*, T27.633c, 702a.
21. TKDZ, 2:13. Kūkai here paraphrases the discussion of the genesis of a world-system in the *Abhidharmakośa*, T29.57a.
22. TKDZ, 2:13. For a discussion of the five great elements in the Esoteric Buddhist context, see *Dabei kongzhi jingang dajiao wang yigui jing*, T18.596a–598a. Also see Abé, *Weaving*, 281–282.
23. TKDZ, 2:13.
24. TKDZ, 2:316.
25. TKDZ, 2:316–319.
26. TKDZ, 2:311, 317.
27. TKDZ, 2:307–315; 4:255–267; 5:21.
28. TKDZ, 2:280, 283, 291.
29. For the Six Dynasties prose style that was popular during Kūkai’s days in Japan, see Egan, “Prose Style.”
30. See TKDZ, 8:21–27. The most reliable text of this essay is not the stele inscription (that suffers from lacunae and mistakes in copied characters) but the one included in fascicle two of *Henjō hakki seireishū* (TKDZ, 8:1–216), collected essays and letters of Kūkai compiled by his disciple Shinzei (800–860) shortly after Kūkai’s death. This essay by Kūkai serves as the primary historical record of Shōdō and his Buddhist activities.
31. In the precinct of the Futarasan Shinto shrine on the shore of the South Lake, there stands a stele that is said to be the original stele erected for Shōdō in the early ninth century. However, the inscription became worn by the eighteenth century and was replaced by a copy inscribed on a bronze plate that was inserted on the stele. The bronze plate inscription became worn and is currently preserved in the shrine’s museum. For a historical study of the inscription, see Suda Tetsuo, “Futarasan.”
32. For an overview of an extensive inclusion of the Buddhist worldview in premodern Japanese cartographical knowledge, see Moerman, “Locating Japan.”
33. TKDZ, 8:23.
34. TKDZ, 8:23–25.
35. TKDZ, 2:317–318. The five great wisdoms are the wisdoms of perfect nature of the world, of great mirror, of equanimity, of observation, and of action. Also see Hakeda, *Kūkai*, 83–86.
36. According to Kūkai, natural sounds in the wilderness turn into heavenly music because they are none other than the sounds of mantras uttered naturally by all the buddhas and bodhisattvas in the cosmic palace, that, in turn, is the Dharmakāya’s cosmic preaching. See TKDZ, 2:307–312.
37. TKDZ, 8:25.
38. Kūkai’s essay for Masuda Lake stele inscription is the major source of information on the construction of the reservoir. TKDZ, 8:27–31. Also see NSNK, 822.
39. For Kūkai’s involvement in constructing Masuda Lake, see, for example, Takagi, *Kūkai*, 232–225. Also see Ōgushi, “Yamato.”
40. Sectarian sources of the Shingon school wrongly claim that the monk who was appointed to the Masuda Lake construction was Kūkai’s disciple Shin’en. Kūkai in his

inscription refers to the monk as “En risshi,” the Vinaya Master En. However, Shūen was the only Vinaya Master of the court whose name carried the word “En” that time. For Shūen and Kūkai, see Abé, *Weaving*, 40, 56, 63, 205, 239–240, 310, 345.

41. For Masuda Lake and *waka* poets, see Yamanouchi, “Yūshi naishinnōke”; and Ōgushi, “Yamato,” 453.

42. See Ōgushi, “Yamato,” 453–455.

43. See Komai, *Kūkai no shoron*, 248–252.

44. For Kūkai’s mastery of a wide range of calligraphic styles, including the *zasshotai*, see Komai, *Kūkai no shoron*, 219–288. For calligraphic studies of the stele inscription, see Suda, “Masudagaike.” Kadoya Atsushi made brief observations on Kūkai’s *zasshotai*, but from the point of view of later Japanese development of Shintō-Buddhist amalgamation. See Kadoya, “Myth, Rites, and Icons,” 274–276.

45. The complete text of Kūkai’s laudatory essay and poem is included in fascicle two of *Henjō hakki seireishū*. TKDZ, 8:27–29.

46. TKDZ, 8:29.

47. Here Kūkai is referring to the artificial lake built by the Han emperor Wu on the west end of Changan, modeled after the grand natural lake in Yunnan. Unlike the natural lake in Yunnan, the Kunming Lake in Changan was well known among the Heian courtiers. For the history of the construction of the Kunming Lake by Emperor Wu of the Han dynasty and its reception, especially its influence on the literary and visual art productions, in Heian Japan, see Ri, “Kantō chōan”; and Izumi, “Konmeichizu.”

48. TKDZ, 2:18. For Anavatapta Lake in the context of East Asian Buddhist cartographic imagination, see Park, “Buddhist Woodblock-Printed Map.”

49. See, for example, *Yiqiejing yinyi* (T54.464a), *Dafangguangfo huayanjing shu* (T35.359b), *Miaofa lianhuaqing xuanzan* (T34.675c–676a).

50. TKDZ, 4:269–278.

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Glossary

Acuoye Guanyin 阿嵯耶觀音

Anning 安寧

Anyue 安岳

Ayangbai 阿央/映白

Ban Chao 班超

Baojue Wuzhou 寶覺務周

Baozhi 寶誌

Beishan 北山

Bishan Temple 碧山寺

Boshenwahei 博什瓦黑

Budong mingwang 不動明王

Bukkoku rekishōhen 仏国歴象編

Buzhi mingwang 步擲明王

Changlu 長蘆

Chanyuan qinggui 禪苑清規

Cao Xun 曹勛

Changshou wang 長壽王

chi zhai 持齋

Chongqing shi 重慶市

Daolin 道林

Da Tang xiyuji 大唐西域記

Dali 大理

Dalun mingwang 大輪明王

Damiao jingang da ganlu junnuli

yanman chisheng foding jing 大妙金

剛大甘露軍拏利焰鬘熾盛佛頂經

Dazu qu 大足區

Dong Zhongyong 董仲永

Dongming Huiji 東明慧日

Daoxuan 道宣

Daxiao mingwang 大笑明王

Du Chong 杜充

Du Guangting 杜光庭

Du Wan 杜綰

Empress Liu 劉后

Enbudai tsuketari nichikanzu 閻浮提

附日宮圖

Fadeng 法燈

fahong 發洪

Fahua si 法華寺

Famen si 法門寺

Feilaifeng 飛來峰

Feng Yingjing 馮應京

Foguo ji 佛國記

Fohui zhi ta 佛會之塔

Fohuisi 佛會寺

foshi 佛事

Fozu tongji 佛祖統紀

Fumon Entsū 普門円通

Ganlu Monastery 甘露寺

Geluofeng 閣邏鳳

Genshunbō Jūkai 源春房重懷

Gepi 閣陂

goiseki 御遺跡

gokumi 極微

Gotenjiku-zu 五天竺國

Gozan Jissatsu Zu 五山十刹圖

guaishi 怪石

guanding 灌頂

Guanfo sanmei hai jing 觀佛三昧海經

guangji huasheng lu, da kai fangbian
men 廣集化生路、大開方便門
Guangzhao Yingfu 廣照應夫
Guojia wenwuju 國家文物局

Haihui ba mingwang sizhong huaxian
gezan 海會八明王四種化現歌贊
Hanshan Deqing 憨山德清
Heihui 黑惠
hijiri no egan 聖慧眼
Himitsu mandara jujushinron 秘密曼
荼羅十住心論
hokkaigū 法界宮
Hōtan 鳳潭
Huang Tingjian 黃庭堅
Huili 慧立
Huili 慧理

Jiangsanshi mingwang 降三世明王
jiao 蛟
Jing ren sundong zhu zunxiang ji
zhefa kan ta qianhou songbo peizai
ji 警人損動諸尊像及折伐龕塔前後
松柏栽培記
jingang baota lianhua tounang 金剛
寶塔蓮花頭囊
Jingang shen 金剛神
Jinshan Monastery 金山寺
Jōgyō 常曉

Kaku'a 覺阿
kan tang ta 龕堂塔
kejing 刻經
kezō sekai 華藏世界
ki seken 器世間
kyōgō 共業

Lancang 瀾滄
Li Deyu 李德裕
ling 靈
Lingbi 靈璧
Lingjiu Chan yuan 靈鷲禪院

Linqing 麟慶
Liu Rongxi 劉榮喜
Liuzu zun mingwang 六足尊明王
Longwang Miao 龍王廟
Luhe District 六合區
Luohan wan 羅漢灣

Mannōike 萬農池/滿濃池
Matou mingwang 馬頭明王
Mi Defang 米德昉
mijin 微塵
mingwang 明王
moya 摩崖

Nakatsukasashō 中務省
Nansenbushū 南瞻部州
Nansenbushū bankoku shōka no
zu 南瞻部州萬國掌菓之圖
Nanzhao 南詔
Nanzhao tuzhuan 南詔圖傳
nianfo hui 念佛會
Ningzong 寧宗

qimo huayang 起模畫樣
qi 氣
Qinglin dong 青林洞
qingpingguan 清平宮
qiuwang 酋望
quanqing 勸請

Sanchao Beimeng huibian 三朝北盟
會編
sanshi xinian 三時繫念
Sengqie of Sizhou 泗州僧伽
Shaba 娑婆
shabetuchi-shin 差別智身
Shadengjing 沙登箐
shanmen 山門
Shamon Shōdō sansui wo hemegurite
genju wo migaku no hi narabi ni
jo 沙門勝道歷山水研瑩玄珠碑并序
Shanxi 山西

Shao Bowen 邵伯溫
sheng di 勝地
 Shengde 盛德
shengmu 聖母
 Shensha shen^a 參沙神
 Shensha shen^b 深沙神
shi 勢
 Shibaoshan 石寶山
Shijia fangzhi 釋迦方誌
shijie 世界
 Shizhongshan 石鐘山
 Shizhong si 石鐘寺
 Shizhuanshan 石篆山
 Shiziguan 獅子關
 Shu Hai 豎亥
shuilu hui 水陸會
shuilu zhai 水陸齋
shuimo yang 水磨樣
 Songhua 松花
 Sun Simiao 孫思邈

 Tai Zhang 太章
 Taihu 太湖
Taishaku mō 帝釋綱
Tenjiku yochizu 天竺輿地圖
 Tiejin shen 鐵金剛
Tongyong qiqing yigui 通用啟請儀軌

ujō seken 有情世間

 Wan'an Bridge of Luoyang River 洛陽江萬安橋
 Wang Anshi 王安石
 Wang Xiangzhi 王象之
 Wase 挖色
 Wen 文
 Wen Weijian 文惟簡
 Wenying 文瑩
 Wofoyuan 臥佛院
woyou (J. gayū) 臥遊
wu 物
 Wufang fo 五方佛

Wujin Zudeng 無盡祖燈
 Wunengsheng mingwang 無能勝明王

 Xiatang Huiyuan 瞎堂慧遠
xipinai 西平乃
xiu shan'gen 修善根
xiuxing 修行
 Xuanzang 玄奘
 Xuanzheng yuan 宣政院

Yamato no kuni masudagaike
hi mei narabi ni jo 大和州益田池碑銘并序
 Yan Xun 嚴遜
 Yang Lianzhenjia 楊璉真伽
yao bai 遙拜
 Yijing 義淨
 Yimouxun 異牟尋
 Yishan Yining 一山一寧
 Yuantong Faxiu 圓通法秀
Yudi jisheng 輿地紀勝
 Yungang 雲崗
Yunlin shipu 雲林石譜
 Yuru dong 玉乳洞

zao po 鑿破
zasshotai 雜書體
 Zeng Gong 曾鞏
zhang 丈
 Zhang Bang 張傍
 Zhang Banglong 張傍龍
 Zhang Lejinqu 張樂盡求
 Zhang Luopi 張羅疋
 Zhang Pibang 張疋傍
 Zhang Qian 張騫
Zhendan 晨旦
 Zheng Hui 鄭回
 Zhenzong 真宗
 Zhipan 志磐
zhong fudi 種福地
zhong futian 種福田

Zimu dian 子母殿

zōjōriki 増上力

Zongze 宗蹟

Zontō 存統

Zu 圖

Zufeng ru Changlusi 阻風入長蘆寺

zuo fo shi 作佛事

Zuo fo xingxiang jing 作佛形像經

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Index

- Abhidharmakośa*, 68n41, 116, 122–125, 285–291, 293–294, 303n19
- actor-network theory, 197, 221
- aesthetics, 8, 18, 23, 31–37, 98, 107–109, 288–295, 298, 300–301
- affect, 3, 90–91, 96, 102, 262, 264
- affordances, 9, 33–35, 59–60, 94–95, 109, 163–164, 166, 178, 186–187, 196–198, 221, 246–247, 250–256; gendered, 196–200, 205–214, 254–256. *See also* agency
- agency, 9–10, 135, 156, 163, 166, 196–198, 214n7, 221, 232–235, 236n2, 236n7; performative, 197. *See also* affordances
- agriculture, 164, 176, 178, 180, 183. *See also* crops
- Amitābha, 61–62, 95, 97, 103–105, 151–152, 203, 205, 212, 216n41, 266
- animals, 63–64, 116, 119, 121, 128, 147, 204; buffalo, 146; bull, 146; crane, 294; deer, 155, 255; dog, 63; elephant, 72–73, 116, 146, 154, 251, 257n39; frog, 124, 129n12; goat, 249–255; jackal, 63; lion, 116, 141, 203–205, 208–209; *makara* (crocodile), 146; mandarin duck, 294; monkey, 94–95, 102, 107, 110n9; ram, 146; snake, 142; stag, 146; vulture, 63. *See also* birds
- Anthropocene, 4, 14–16, 24, 38–40
- anthropocentrism, 6, 18, 11n3, 156, 197–198
- architecture, 135–136, 139–152, 158n28, 159n50, 220, 290; architectonic form, 102–107; concealing images, 238n31; in relation to trees, 228–231
- arhat (*luohan*), 95, 97, 99–102, 107, 110n23, 215nn28–29, 222–226, 231, 238n31
- astronomy, 32–33, 120, 122–124, 253
- Bennett, Jane, 197, 200, 221, 236n2
- Bhagavad Gīta*, 58
- binaries: East-West, 15–17, 21; human-nonhuman, 6, 59–62, 157, 197, 220–221, 262; micro-macro, 98, 102; mundane-divine, 59–60; object-subject, 196; sentient-insentient, 6, 25, 28–29, 36, 198
- birds: catching fleas, 129n12; dancing on beaches, 294; devouring flesh, 63–64; echoing like bells, 294; playing in waves, 294; preaching the Dharma, 36; sounding like flutes, 294
- bridges, 165, 171
- Bodhidharma, 163, 166–168, 170
- bodhisattvas, 9–10, 35, 63, 66, 122, 195, 215n29; Avalokiteśvara/Guanyin, 56–57, 67n11, 78–81,

- 84, 99, 150–152, 159n35, 204–206, 212–213, 215n28, 225, 266, 301; innumerable, 62; Kṣitigarbha, 215n28, 222, 274; Mahāsthāmaprāpta, 266; Maitreya, 37, 79–81, 95, 97, 101–107, 150–152, 203, 205, 222–223, 229, 233, 236n9; Mañjuśrī, 79–81, 150, 222, 266; Śākyamuni's superiority to, 60–63; Samantabhadra, 222, 270, 294; Tārā, 79–81, 150
- body, 55–67, 198; as corporeal code, 55–56, 64, 66, 253–254; divine, 58–59, 196, 253–254; lithic, 93, 98, 100; as measure, 129n13; relation to artworks, 70, 97–107; relation to landscape, 70, 78–84, 96; sacrificed, 65, 115, 265–266. *See also* genitalia; kinesthetics
- Buddhaghosa, 245–256
- Budai. *See under* bodhisattvas, Maitreya
- calligraphy, 283, 298, 305n44
- cartography. *See* maps
- caves, 94–102, 113, 119, 133–158, 198, 195–214
- Chakrabarty, Dipesh, 11n12, 14
- Chan [J. Zen] Buddhism, 15–19, 26, 28, 41n16, 45n132, 95, 163–194
- Chinese philosophy, 18–21, 40, 119, 222
- cities, 115, 163–168, 178–186, 203–204, 265, 271
- climate, 8, 136–139, 156, 196
- climate change, 4, 30; Little Ice Age, 135
- clouds, 152, 155–156, 207, 211, 228–230, 234, 237n25, 284, 288–289, 299
- conservation, 238n31; for aesthetic reasons, 22; for state or institutional advantage, 22–26; to protect life, 26
- cosmology, 3–5, 26–27, 35–36, 57–67, 121–123, 128, 135, 139–148, 159n50, 172–173, 255, 263, 285–288, 293–295; correlative, 27, 165, 172
- crops and foodstuffs, 178–181, 183, 185–187; millet, 119, 122; rice, 251, 255, 283
- Daoism and Daoists, 4, 18–21, 26, 233, 237n19; unable to tame floodwaters, 165, 176
- dams, 149, 283–284, 295–300. *See also under* lakes, artificial
- Deccan, 133–139, 152–154, 158n10
- deep ecology, 17–21; critical responses to, 19–21, 31
- demons, 82–84; 141–142, 147, 154–156, 260, 263, 265–266, 277–278
- dhāraṇī*, 86n20, 200, 232–234, 265
- Dharmakāya. *Universally immanent*
- disease, 263, 266, 278
- donors. *See* patronage
- dragons, 164–165, 168–177, 207–208, 292, 299–300; and draconyms, 172
- drought, 147, 176, 295
- Earth, 8, 27, 31–37, 59–60, 113–128. *See also* planetarity
- earthquakes. *See* seismic activity
- eco-Buddhism, 6, 20–21, 27–28
- ecocriticism, 6
- ecophilosophy, 31
- ecosystems, 4, 135, 138, 290–291

Ellorā, 133–157, 204
 Emerson, Ralph Waldo, 6
 empire, ideologies of, 107–109, 133–135
 emptiness, 36, 69n42, 119, 285, 289–291
 engineering, 10, 136, 164, 169–174, 186–187, 282–283; Buddhist, 165. *See also* hydrology
 environmental humanities, 6, 38–40
 environmentalism, 9, 14–17, 164; religions and, 38–40; and Romanticism, 4; and transcendentalism, 4, 16
 entanglement (and the entwined), 5–6, 166, 187, 196–198, 254, 282; material and conceptual, 164, 166, 187
 epidemics. *See* disease
 epistemology, 8, 116, 120, 165; of vision, 122
 erosion, 92, 94, 96, 137, 163, 169–172
 Esoteric Buddhism, 35–36, 198–199, 206, 210–214, 260–278, 281–302. *See also* tantrism
 Europe, provincializing of, 121–122
 expedient means, 212–213, 301

 famine, 64, 266
 Faxian, 73, 119
fengshui. *See* geomancy
 five phases (*wuxing*). *See under* cosmology, correlative
 floods, 129n12, 135, 137, 148, 163–177, 180–182, 187, 191n71, 190n48, 252, 287
 flowers, 37, 121, 145, 204, 209, 219, 238n33, 249–250, 252, 301; lotus, 35, 61–62, 99, 104, 146–147, 207
 forests, 4, 24–30, 40, 42n51, 98, 134, 146–147, 221–222; deforestation, 22–25, 28–29, 248; growing over ruins, 248; planting of, 226–231
 fractals, 70–78
 fruit, 118–120, 228–231, 250–252, 284

 Gandhāra, 71–72
 gardens, 3, 23, 98, 149, 156, 248, 250. *See also* parks
gāthā, 167, 179. *See also* poetry
 gazetteers (local histories), 7, 94, 108, 165–167, 169, 171, 174–175, 178, 180–182, 188n5, 188n17, 263
 Gell, Alfred, 197. *See also* agency
 gender, 141–147, 195–214
 genitalia, 139, 141, 145–148, 206, 211–213, 216n46, 266
 geoaesthetics, 8–10, 30–40, 59, 70–71, 107–109, 113, 120, 163, 178, 219–220, 261–262, 272
 geoglyphs, 70
 geology, 8, 15, 59–60, 66, 90–95, 107–109, 135–139, 148, 152–156
 geomancy, 26–27, 33, 40, 82–84, 271
 geomorphology, 4, 128, 135, 153
 geophilosophy, 31–32
 Ghosh, Amitav, 11n2, 11n12, 36–39
 Gibson, James. *See* affordances
 gorges, 146, 149; Three Gorges, 168. *See also* valleys
 Grapard, Allan, 31, 35–37
 Grand Canal, 283, 302n7
 Greece and Rome, comparisons with, 15–16, 21, 33, 55–59, 248
 haptic. *See* kinesthetics

- Haraway, Donna. *See* sympoiesis
- healing, 263–266, 277–278. *See also* medicine
- hells, 252, 270, 274–276, 286–287
- Hinduism, 4, 39, 56, 58, 133–162, 198, 268
- horticulture, 228–230, 238n33
- humanism, 6, 15, 23
- Huayan [J. Kegon], 6, 118, 121. *See also* Indra's Net
- hydroaesthetics, 135
- hydrology, 23–24, 135–139, 148–149, 165, 169, 282–284, 297, 301
- hyperobjects, 9, 59, 66
- icons. *See* sculpture
- iconography, 10, 71, 91–93, 95–96, 141–148, 150–152, 157, 159n32, 188n6, 206–213
- imaginaire* (e.g., environmental, arboreal), 10, 135, 152–153, 169–171, 173, 245–246, 255–256, 290
- impermanence, 180–181, 287–290. *See also* emptiness
- India: in the East Asian imagination, 94–97, 126–127, 292; European maps of, 126–127; Indo-centrism, 122
- Indra's Net, 121, 290–291. *See also* Huayan
- infrastructure, 183, 197; hydrological, 169–175, 282–283; industrial, 163, 182–186; transportation, 164, 179, 203. *See also* engineering
- Ingold, Timothy, 34–36, 199
- innumerable: mustard grass leaves as metaphor for, 119; sand as metaphor for, 59, 61–62, 65, 69n42
- insects, 63, 119
- iron, 169–176, 285–286, 292–293
- islands, 23, 116, 119–120, 126, 172, 190n50, 282
- Jainism, 4, 43n80, 133–136, 156–157, 248, 268
- Jambudvīpa, 3–4, 65, 116–128, 129n26, 286–287, 300
- jātaka*, 61–65, 115, 154, 251–255
- Jetavana, 128, 247–250
- jewels. *See* precious stones; Indra's Net
- karma, 4, 73, 117, 122, 172–173, 186, 198–199, 205, 212, 234, 260, 269–270, 287–295, 299–301
- karst. *See under* topography, karst
- Kegon. *See* Huayan
- kinesthetics, 97–107, 116. *See also* body
- Knappett, Carl, 197, 221
- Kūkai, 35–36, 281–306
- lakes, 4, 28, 84, 113, 116, 137, 293; Anavatapta, 116, 121, 126–128, 292, 299–300, 305n48; artificial, 10, 23, 291, 298–300; Er, 204; Kunming, 300; Mannō and Masuda, 281–306; South Lake of Mount Futara, 291–295; West Lake, 23, 90, 95, 108. *See also* ponds
- land art, 8, 32
- landscape, 32, 36–37, 70–85, 96–97, 133–157, 164, 196–197, 204, 220–

221, 226, 228, 262–263; admiration of, 231, 293–295; as agent, 235; devotional, 128; and mindscape, 36–37; and ritual, 210–211, 237n19. *See also* topography; Deccan

Latour, Bruno, 11n2, 11n12, 197, 221, 236n6. *See also* actor-network theory

Lumbini, 247, 249–250

luohan. *See* arhat

Mahākāla, 204

Maitreya. *See under* bodhisattvas, Maitreya

maṇḍala, 37, 107–109, 149–151, 282–283

maps, 10, 70, 85n2, 90, 113–129

Māra, 154, 252–254

marginality, 19, 116–117, 126, 263, 201–204, 271–278

measure, units of, 61–67, 129n13, 170, 229, 231, 250, 270, 285, 287, 303n13

medicine, 30, 222–225, 278. *See also* healing; Medicine Buddha

Medicine Buddha, 205, 238n37

mines, 104, 203, 215n22, 215n32

monasteries, monastic spaces, 133–157, 163–187, 203, 219, 226; destruction of, 177, 180–182, 191n71; reconstruction of, 168, 180–186, 191n71

monsoon, 135–139, 145, 148–149, 152, 156

Morton, Timothy, 4–6, 9. *See also* hyperobjects

mountains, 33, 153, 156, 195–200; as metaphors for temples, 133–135; Baoding, 261–278; Cakravāḍa,

65; Feilaifeng, 90–109; flesh, 60, 63–67; Futara, 292; Himalaya, 59, 133–135, 152, 201, 292, 299–300; Kailāśa, 141–144, 154–155; Kinpu, 198, 214n11; Kōya, 198; Lanka, 120; Lanfeng, 199; Langshan, 199; Pamir, 119; Potalaka, 120; sacred, 22, 26; Shibao, 195–214, 215n20; Shizhuan, 219–235; Sumeru/Meru, 3, 57–59, 65, 121–123, 285–295, 300; Vulture Peak, 63–65, 94–95, 102, 104, 107, 109, 120, 128, 292; Wutai, 108; Yugandhara, 65. *See also* orography

Muir, John, 6

multiplication, 61–64; as visual rhetoric, 57

murals, 154, 203

nāgas, 84, 147, 254; and nāginis, 147. *Entangled with dragons*

naturalism, 20, 99–100

networks, 71, 77–78, 121, 179, 196–200. *See also* Indra's Net

niches, 95–107, 155, 201–213, 221–230; funerary, 199

nirvāṇa, 66, 73, 92–93, 115, 128, 249, 257n20

oceans. *See* seas

ontology, 3–6, 8, 220

Orientalism, 4–6, 16–17

orography, 96–97. *See also* mountains

pagoda. *See* stūpas

painting, 3, 16–17, 23, 79–85, 90, 108, 114–117, 120, 167, 198, 228, 237n24, 301

- parks, 3, 247–255; industrial, 182–186; national, 36–37; sculpture, 226. *See also* gardens; Jetavana; Lumbinī
- patronage, 72–73, 95, 102–107, 110n12, 110n23, 133–135, 157, 166, 168–169, 182, 195, 197, 199, 205, 221, 226, 237n12, 283, 295–297; by women, 168–169, 205
- perception, 34–37, 117–119, 270–271, 196–198, 200, 262–263
- practices: practicescapes, 199, 211; yogic, 142–144, 147–148. *See also* ritual
- periodization, 7, 15, 24
- poetry, 7, 16–17, 23, 29, 37, 94, 176, 179–180, 283, 291, 295, 297–299, 300–301. *See also* *gāthā*
- ponds, 28, 91, 137, 149
- precious metals, 104, 116, 157n1, 189n28, 216n39, 254, 272, 304n31
- precious stones, 116, 121, 128, 142, 151–152, 253, 290–291; jade, 91, 95, 168–169, 172, 294
- print, 118–128, 129n26, 171, 173–174, 238n43, 286
- pilgrimage, 73, 115, 117, 119, 128, 133, 156, 160n61, 165–166, 168, 175, 176, 179, 187, 245. *See also* Faxian; Xuanzang; Yijing
- place, 196; as created by relics, 73–74; gendering, 195, 213–214; making of, 90–91, 107–109, 115; in relation to space, 71, 73, 107, 146, 214n1, 246. *See also* space
- planetarity, 5, 8–10, 11n12, 14–16, 20, 30, 38, 222–225. *See also* Earth
- plants, 22, 25–29, 36, 226, 235, 252, 271, 278; bamboo, 122, 226, 248–249, 254
- play, 144–145; ludic, 231, 238n34–35
- posthumanism, 59
- pollution, 18, 27–28, 183–184
- Purāṇas*, 141, 144, 155
- Pure Land, 121–122, 232, 234, 238n37–38; scriptures, 238n37; practices (e.g., *nianfo*), 186, 232. *See also* Amitābha
- rain and rainmaking, 135–138, 145, 148–149, 165, 172, 176–177, 186, 234, 288–289, 295
- Ray, Sugata, 135, 196. *See also* geoaesthetics
- relics, 71, 73–78, 85n17, 116, 173, 188n3, 189n28, 196, 236n8
- reliefs, 71–78, 81, 100–101, 103–105, 222. *See also* sculpture
- reservoirs, 135, 137, 145. *See also* lakes, artificial
- rivers, 3, 22, 28, 70, 113, 137, 153, 163–187; Ganges, 61, 65, 148; Godavari, 137; goddesses of, 148, 152; Heihui, 203; Indus, 116; of Jambudvīpa, 116, 121, 128, 300; Meikong (Lancang), 203; as metaphor, 179–180; monsoons, and, 135–139; Oxus, 116; Śītā, 116; Velgaṅgā, 137; Yangzi, 163–187, 302n7; Yellow, 190n48, 191n82, 302n7
- ritual, 4, 8, 83–84, 86n20, 117, 135, 145, 152, 165, 188n14, 197–199, 210–211, 213, 219–235, 265–271, 278, 293, 295; geoaesthetics of, 219–220; and landscape, 196,

210–211; and royal authority, 206;
Water-Land, 226, 235, 237n16

rock. *See* stone

Saha-lokadhātu (Sāha world), 60, 65,
93, 286

Śakyamuni Buddha, 3, 60–63, 66,
72–73, 83–84, 104–105, 117, 128,
150, 215n28, 216n38, 222–223,
227, 229, 233

sand: god of the deep (*shenshashen*),
174–177, 182; grains of, 61, 65;
like silver plate, 254; as silt, 169

scale, 9–10, 27, 32–33, 35–36, 55–67,
70, 73–78, 81, 84–85, 98, 102,
109, 113, 116, 120, 124–125, 141,
151–152, 249–250; scale critique,
11n12; nonhuman, 36, 55–69, 119

sculpture, 56, 78–82, 136, 165,
174–175, 181–182, 187, 227n34,
292; moving under own volition,
72–73; radiating light, 82–83;
rock-cut, 4, 9–10, 90–109, 139–152,
195–214, 219–235, 260–278. *See*
also niches; reliefs

seas, 3, 59, 65–66, 113, 122, 153, 155,
210–211, 285–289

sedimentation, 163, 170–172, 178–
179, 186; visual effect of, 91–93

seeds, 119, 122, 231, 250–251. *See also*
agriculture; horticulture

seismic activity, 152–156, 159n40

senses, or sensory experience, 3,
116, 274. *See also* perception

shores and beaches, 64, 118, 126,
163–172, 179, 181, 283, 292, 294,
299, 304n31

signs, signifiers, symbols, 32–35, 66,
69n42, 86n29, 109, 133–135, 148,

166, 172–173, 179, 188n14, 245,
256n2, 263, 274, 276, 289. *See also*
body as corporeal code

soteriology, 60, 62, 121, 139–148,
154, 199, 212–213, 233–234, 295,
299–300

space, 36, 62–64, 113–128, 136, 139,
148–149; karmic function of, 286;
movement through, 71–73; ritual
and geological, 157. *See also* place

statues. *See* sculpture

steles, 167, 226–235, 237n12, 65,
295–298, 304n31. *See also* stone
inscriptions

streams, 37, 94, 101, 137–139, 146,
149, 157

stone, 33, 90–109, 113, 135, 173, 183–
185, 196–214, 220–221, 233–234;
basalt, 136; conceptions of, 238n45;
eternality of, 228; limestone, 94,
97, 102, 106, 109; lithification, 199;
porosity of, 98, 106, 137; sandstone,
155, 203, 221–222, 262–263, 272;
as stele, 221, 226–231, 297–298;
strange (*guaishi*), 98

stone inscriptions, 92–93, 95, 103–
105, 110n23, 173, 220; smoothed
cliff face (*moya*), 95. *See also* steles

storms, 33, 138, 155, 173, 252, 283,
299

stūpas, 73–78, 81, 84, 85n17, 107–108,
116, 151–152, 165, 173, 205,
216n36, 221, 226, 228–230, 255

sūtras, 60–67, 128, 265, 232;
Avataṃsaka, 121, 124, 186;
Brahmajāla, 249; carved in
stone, 92–93; *Diamond*, 69n42;
Karuṇapūṇḍarīka, 59–67;
Lotus Sūtra, 37, 66–67, 279n9;
Mahāparinirvāṇa, 153; *Ocean-Like*

Samādhi of the Visualization of the Buddha, 72; Pure Land, 238n37–38; *Rāhulovāda*, 249; *Shoulengyan*, 279n24; *Uṣṇīṣavijayā Dhāraṇī*, 232–234; *Vimalakīrtinirdeśa*, 303n12
sympoiesis, 6, 11n5, 278; in Buddhist sense, as cogenerative, 293, 300

tantrism, 96, 157, 189n33, 236n1

Tenjiku, Five Regions of, 113–128

text and image, relationship of, 115–116, 167, 265

temporality, 64–66, 113, 116–117, 219–220, 226–231, 234–235, 249, 287; anachronisms, 206; botanic, 229–231

trade, 28, 157, 203

trees, 10, 11n1, 22, 113, 153, 155, 197, 220; banyan, 248–253, 254; bodhi, 77, 128, 159n40, 245–256; celestial, 249; *champaka*, 254; cypress, 228–231, 248; groves of, 128, 134, 183, 226, 245–249; heritage, 171, 247–251; jambu, 116, 128, 250; mango, 247–250; neem, 246–248, 250, 254; pine, 22, 146–127, 228–231, 248, 290–291; pipal, 248, 251–252; as ritual agents, 228–231; *sal/śāla*, 115, 249–251, 257n20; as shelter, 250–255; as teachers, 36; as timber, 4, 22, 24, 28–29, 177, 180–181, 230, 272, 297. *See also* forest

Tripiṭaka, 119, 177

topography, 27, 34–35, 90–97, 115, 122–124, 126, 149, 188n14; cosmic, 139–148; karst, 96. *See also* landscape

topology, 10, 293, 299

toponyms, 115, 120–121, 126, 128. *See also* place

Vairocana, 121, 149, 199, 206, 209, 211–212, 216n38, 222–223, 229, 233, 265–266, 270, 294

valleys, 37, 94, 141, 149, 221–222, 233–234, 261–262, 272, 283, 299, 301

Vasubandhu. *See* *Abhidharmakośa vidyārājas*, 106–107, 204, 206, 209–211, 216nn39–40, 260–280

violence, 163, 165, 177–178, 180–181, 261–262

vision, 120–122, 129n12, 139; bifocality, 116; Buddhist, 117–119, 121; visibility, 263–271. *See also* perception

warfare. *See* violence

water, 14, 65, 79, 94, 118, 133–157, 220. *See also* hydrology

waterfalls, 37, 137–139, 145, 148–149, 156–157

wilderness, 143–144, 248; idea of, 16, 23

wind, 35, 153, 173, 176, 220, 232–234, 238n43, 263, 273–274, 285–291, 294

wood, 24–26, 57, 172, 180–181, 214n13, 272; sandalwood, 72–73, 82–83. *See also* trees

woodcut. *See* print

Xuanzang, 10, 73, 90, 113–128, 175

Yijing (Book of Changes), 200

Yijing (pilgrim), 120

yin and yang. *See* cosmology

Zhang, Ling, 11n13, 191n82